THE ENEMY'S SHADOW

The Enemy's Shadow

A NOVEL

PARIS · WARSAW

1943

This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, organisations, places and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, is coincidental. Historical events, institutions and formations are depicted in invented circumstances.

Contains explicit sexual content, violence and depictions of persecution. Intended for adult readers.

First edition

In the bedroom of the enemy,

intimacy is an instrument of war.

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PART ONE

The Beautiful Lie

CHAPTER ONE

The Diamond Room

♦ ♦ ♦

He slept the way a man stands at attention: on his back, arms at his sides, chin up, as though even unconscious he might be called upon to report. Marion Herschlag lay on her side of the bed with her eyes open in the dark and counted his breathing, and when she had counted a hundred she began again from the beginning, because a hundred was all the counting she could do without moving her lips, and moving her lips was a thing he noticed.

The apartment was cold. Coal came to the avenue Henri-Martin in sacks with a military docket on them and burned in a marble fireplace built for a different century, and the cold that came in through the tall windows was not the honest cold of a street but something older and thinner, the cold of a room that had been loved once by other people. The clock in the hall struck three. Under her hip the sheet was still damp where he had put her on her stomach an hour ago and held her there with one hand flat between her shoulder blades — not cruelly, not even roughly, but with the terrible patience of a man signing a document.

She had learned to keep her face still in the minutes after. He liked to look at her afterwards. He would prop himself on one elbow and study her body the way he studied a map, and there was nothing she could do about it except be studied and remember to breathe. In October, in the first week, he had told her that she had the shoulders of a peasant and the hands of a countess, and she had laughed and said that he had the hands of a man

who had never once in his life had to open a door for himself, and he had struck her across the face. Not hard. A courtesy blow, like a man pushing a dog away from a table. Then he had taken her against the window with the blackout curtain trembling an inch from her cheek and the glass so cold it burned, and afterwards he had apologised with his mouth against the back of her neck, and she had understood him in that hour. He was not a sadist. That was the thing nobody in Paris understood about Oberst Friedrich von Reuth. He was a man in mourning for an order of the world, and every woman he took to bed was a small ceremony in which the lost order was briefly restored.

He slept. The clock in the hall wound itself on. Three-nineteen in the morning, the eleventh of January, nineteen forty-three.

Her eyes had been open long enough to read the room by. The rugs rolled back from the bed and stacked against the wall, because he did not like the way they slid under his boots. His tunic over the chair with the Knight's Cross pinned to the breast as though the chair had earned it. And on the low table by the windows, where he had set it down when he came in at eight o'clock with his cap still under his arm, his briefcase.

It was not locked. He had never locked a thing in his life in her presence. That was the arrangement, and she had made it deliberately, in bed, in November, in the voice she used when she wanted something and could pretend she was only teasing. *Do you know what a woman thinks about when a man leaves the room? Not where he is. What he left.* And he had laughed, that short laugh like a door closing, and said, *You may think about it as much as you like, my dear. It is all in my head. That is the only safe place.*

She let the count run out to two hundred. Then she moved.

Out of the bed in one slow uncoiling, weight first on the outside foot, which was the one that did not make the frame complain. Her nightdress — a ribbon and a yard of grey silk, chosen because it made a sound when it moved and therefore taught her to move soundlessly — lay on the floor by the footboard. She did not stop for it. The cold took the skin of her thighs and her arms in one bright announcement, and she stood still and let it come, and let her body remember that cold was information, nothing more.

Three steps to the window. The briefcase was black leather, worn at the corners by twenty years of railway carriages, with his initials in gold. She did not open it where it lay. She carried it, breathing through her nose, to

the bathroom, because the bathroom had a door, and because the door was the difference between a woman who was curious and a woman who was a spy.

The bathroom had belonged to someone who liked sycamore and green marble. There was a shaving mirror on a jointed arm and a comb with two long black hairs still in it that were not hers. There was a bar of soap in the dish, cracked with age, with the imprint of a name that Marion Herschlag had never been permitted to learn. Twice a week a German orderly cleaned this room and left the soap where it was. Nobody had told him to. Nobody had the authority to tell him. It had simply survived, the way certain things survived in Paris, like the concierge who could not hear German and the cats in the courtyard who went on being fed.

She closed the door, put the briefcase on the closed lid of the toilet, and opened it. She did not have to look for anything. She knew where he kept the papers: in the flat compartment under the lid, because he was a man who had spent a war being shelled and had learned to distrust anything folded. What was in there was a map of Le Havre harbour with pencilled annotations, a bundle of railway timetables, a typed memorandum of four pages she could not read at a glance, and a single carbon copy, thinner than the others, of a list.

She had four minutes. She had measured her last four visits to this room against the clock in the hall, and it was always four, because his body was regulated like a garrison and his bladder woke him at four and a half.

The list was in French. That was the first thing that caught and held her eye, because everything else in that briefcase was in German, and a French document in that briefcase at that hour meant that a French document had come from somewhere that frightened people. It was headed *Éléments à rechercher — zone sud*, and under the heading were names.

Lists of names were ordinary. Paris in 1943 was a city of lists, and every list was somebody's death. She had carried nine documents out of this apartment in five months, and eight of them had been lists, and she had learned to handle them the way a butcher handles a carcass: by the weight, and not the face. But she read the fourth name on the second page, and stopped.

Szmul Reinhold, tailleur, 14 rue des Rosiers.

She knew the address because she had once, in another life, in the autumn of 1939, when things had still been merely terrible and not yet finished, eaten a bowl of sorrel soup in a basement on the rue des Rosiers and been talked to for an hour by a tailor's wife about the price of buttons.

She stood in the cold bathroom and looked at the name until the letters stopped being letters. Then she put the picture of the tailor's wife behind her ribs, where she kept everything else, and took from the pocket of her dressing gown — which she had remembered to bring after all — a small black camera the size of a matchbox.

It took two hands and eleven seconds to set. The trick was the shutter, which was a lever rather than a button and made a sound like a fingernail tapping glass, so she wrapped the whole body of the camera in the edge of the green velvet curtain that hung, absurdly, beside the bath, and pressed it down against her thigh, and did it twice. She did it twice because nine names on the second page and a heading in French meant paper that would travel by courier, and a courier could be held up a week; the film would be in Warsaw in four days.

She wound the film back with her thumb, not fast, not slow, and then sat on the lid of the toilet with the briefcase on her knees and her hands shaking, which they always did afterwards, and which she permitted for exactly as long as it took to count nine breaths.

She was careful to keep it that way, the world believing she had nerves of steel, because the truth was a system of allowances. The hands were allowed to shake in the bathroom. The mind was allowed a minute of the street in Warsaw where she was born, if it wanted one. The body was allowed to be angry for as long as it took to dress. Everything else was expenditure, and she had been taught in a room in Kraków, in the winter of 1940, by a small man with a bad heart who went by a dog's name, that expenditure was how a woman was caught.

Memory is the only suitcase they cannot open, my little rabbit. Everything else is theirs.

She put the camera in the toe of her second-best shoe. She put the list back in the briefcase in the exact alignment of the rest, spine against the leather, the corner of the map pointing east, exactly as it had been. She stood, looked at herself in the shaving mirror, and did the last of it.

It took forty seconds and it was nothing but arithmetic, and arithmetic was how she survived. Names. Szmul Reinhold, tailor, 14 rue des Rosiers. Second page of the carbon. Two names above, five below. The heading. The date stamp in the corner, *22 XII 42*, and under it, in pencil, the letters *III b*, which meant nothing to her and would mean something to someone.

She closed the briefcase. She breathed. She put her shoulders back the way a woman does when she is about to walk into a room and has decided what the room is going to see.

On her way out she looked at the bathtub and thought, without meaning anything by it, that this was the only room in the apartment where she had ever been alone.

♦ ♦ ♦

He was awake when she came back.

She knew it three steps from the bed, from the change in the air. There was no light; the tall window had a blackout curtain the colour of cream, and cold came off it in a thin draught that reached her ankles. She made herself walk to the bed. She made herself not hurry. Under the sheet he was a long shape in the dark, and she could feel him looking at her the way you feel a hand lifted near your face.

"The water," he said. "I heard the water."

"There was no water."

"Then the pipe."

"There was no pipe either." She sat on the edge of the bed with her back to him, because a woman who is lying goes on being busy. "I couldn't sleep. And I thought I might be sick, and I would rather not be sick on the carpet of a house I don't own."

There was a pause. She could hear the clock in the hall and, beneath it, a long way off, the low continuous mutter of Paris, which is the sound of a city occupied: a truck, a dog, and an engine idling.

"Come here," he said.

She came. She lay down on her back, and he turned his head and looked at her from a distance of two inches: the pale eyes, the heavy brow, the mouth of a man who had been handsome at twenty-five and had spent the rest of his life using what was left. He reached out and put his hand flat on her stomach, the way he did when he wanted to know whether she was lying. It was the same hand that had put her on her stomach an hour before. It was the same hand he signed things with.

"Your hands," he said.

"Mm."

"Cold."

"It's January."

He lay still for a while, and she lay looking up at the ceiling, where the shadow of the curtain lay across the plaster like a bandage, and thought about eleven seconds, and velvet, and a click that was not a click. Nine names. Five below, two above.

"I had a telegram at nine o'clock," he said at last. "You were in the bath."

"You never tell me about your telegrams."

"No." His thumb moved once along her hip. "Röhrig was shot on Tuesday. In the rue de la Pompe, in the middle of the day, by two men on a bicycle. They put three bullets in him and took his briefcase."

She lay perfectly still. It was not hard. It was the one thing five months in this house had taught her beyond price: that the surface of her face belonged to her as long as she did not think about it.

"Was he in your office?"

"He was at the Militärbefehlshaber." He said it flatly, the way he said everything that mattered. "He was carrying a list of people to the rue des Saussaies. It makes no difference now. It is a stone in a stream."

"It is not."

He turned his head. She looked at him with her mother's face, which was the face of a woman who was never afraid of anyone, and which she had discovered, in this room, wearing this skin, was the most useful thing she had ever been given.

"Someone is putting bicycles in the middle of your day," she said. "I would not sleep either."

For a moment she thought she had made a mistake. He lay there with his hand on her stomach, and she watched him calculate, and there was a long flat tone in the room, like the held breath before an orchestra comes in, in which he could have asked her any question at all. Then he laughed: once, from the chest, the way a man laughs when someone has put a finger exactly on the bruise he has spent the evening hiding.

"Rot," he said. "It is all rot. But yes. One of them was a boy. Twenty-two, on a bicycle, in a good coat. It is the good coats I mind. In 1918 it was the good coats."

"Don't," she said. "Don't do the war with me. Not tonight. Not in this bed."

He was silent. Then he rolled onto his back and looked up at the ceiling, and she could feel the heat coming off him, the same heat as an hour before, banked down and working. His hand slid down her stomach and

closed on the inside of her thigh. Not as a question. He asked nothing with that hand.

She had learned to divide her life into rooms, because it was the only way to carry it. On the far side of the curtain she was Marion Herschlag, and nothing at all, and safe. On this side she was the body of a woman with a job to do, and the job had been explained to her in Kraków in a sentence she had never been able to stop hearing: *they will never look at your hands if they are looking somewhere else.*

So she turned to him in the way that had taken her two years and four men to learn: without hurry, without pretending, without once letting him think he had won the room. "No," she said, and moved his hand away, and heard him breathe. "Not like that. Like this."

She took him into her mouth in the dark with the sheet over her shoulders, and it was neither love nor hate, and it was not a punishment and not a favour. It was work, like any other work. That was the thing she would never be able to say to anybody in Warsaw, or in London, or in any of the rooms where she was a document instead of a woman: that for four minutes in a cold bedroom in Paris, with her eyes closed, she had chosen this, because choosing it made it hers.

He made a sound. She knew his sounds the way a farmer knows weather. His hand came down on the back of her head, heavy, proprietary, and she lifted her free hand and closed it around his wrist — not to move it, to *hold* it, to remind him who was where — and the sound he made after that was something she never let herself think about afterwards, because it was not the sound of a colonel or a widower or a man in mourning for the world. It was the sound of a man untied, and it was intimate in a way no other minute of the day was intimate, and intimacy was the thing she was paid to take from them, and she had never once been paid for this.

When it was over he did not say anything. He put his arm over his eyes, which was a thing he did, and after a while his breathing flattened out, and she lay beside him in the dark, awake, with the taste of him in her mouth and the film in her shoe and the tailor's name folded behind her ribs in the cold place where the tailor's wife was, and she did not sleep.

At four-forty she heard the floor creak in the corridor: Kleist, the Colonel's orderly, going down to the kitchen to put the kettle on the gas ring, exactly as he did every morning, in his slippers. Fifty-seven years old, a photograph of two children in the pocket of his tunic, terrified of the rank they had given him at the depot in Breslau. He would be down there now;

he would lay out the razor; he would warm the water in the small copper pot that had come from the kitchen of the woman who used to live here.

She turned on her side and put her face into the pillow, and in the warm dark that smelled of him she permitted herself the other thing she was permitted, which lasted one minute and never longer. She permitted herself the rue des Rosiers, and the soup, and the sound of a doorbell, and the certain knowledge that somewhere in this city, in the files of the Militärbefehlshaber, in the mind of a clerk with good handwriting, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna was — by some clause of paper, some list drawn up before she was born — still, in a technical sense, a person.

Then she got up, and went to work.

♦ ♦ ♦

The morning was Kleist's. If the nights belonged to the Colonel, the mornings belonged to a fifty-seven-year-old man with two children in a photograph, and Marion had come to think of that hour as the only honest hour of the day.

He brought the tray at seven. Coffee was a memory of a thing; what was in the pot was chicory, dark and faintly sweet, with a slice of bread and a smear of ersatz jam, the Colonel's iron pills, the post, and a pressed carnation from the hothouses of the avenue, which were German now, like everything else that flowered.

"Guten Morgen, gnädige Frau."

"Good morning, Herr Kleist."

It was the single German sentence she permitted herself, and she permitted it because it kept him safe. There was a rule in the house, written nowhere: the Poles spoke French, the Germans spoke German, and the woman in the bedroom belonged to the first category. Paris had decided that Marion Herschlag was Alsatian, which was why her consonants sat slightly wrong in their chairs; Alsatians were, for Wehrmacht accounting purposes, almost German, and for SD purposes a permanent question. She had never once had to defend it.

Kleist set the tray as he always did, but this morning he did something else. He stood in the doorway with his cap in both hands, looked past her at the window, and said, quietly, in German, "There is a man in the street."

"What kind of man?"

"A young one. He has been there since six. He is doing nothing." He looked at her then, and she watched him decide how much of his own

thought to lay down on the tray with the coffee. "There is a book under his arm. It never changes."

"Perhaps he is a student."

"Perhaps," said Kleist, who had been a bank clerk in Breslau for twenty years and had a son in a graves-registration office in Smolensk, and who had spent the last winter keeping a photograph dry in a pocket. "The Oberst will be at the Majestic until eight. I will be in the kitchen if the Fräulein needs anything."

He went out. She stood in the middle of the room with the tray in front of her and the smell of ersatz coffee going up like a rumour, and she did not go to the window, because going to the window was the first thing she wanted to do and the last thing she was entitled to do. The curtains were cream, the window was tall, and the man in the street had a book and a good coat, and good coats were what the Colonel minded, and the Colonel's orderly had just walked into a bedroom in the sixteenth arrondissement and said so out loud, to a woman he believed to be from Strasbourg, because he had decided that this was the kind of house in which somebody had to say something true at seven o'clock in the morning.

She ate the bread and drank the coffee down, and while it was still going down she went through the four questions she went through every morning, in order, because order was what kept the fear in a box. Who has seen me where I should not have been. Who has heard me say something I should not have said. Who has seen my hands. Who has seen the inside of my head.

The answers, since October, were: nobody, nobody, nobody — except that the last one had to be looked at properly, in daylight, like the blade of a knife. Because here was the trick they did not teach you in Kraków, and which she had grasped in the fourth month, in the green marble bathroom: a spy did not fail because somebody noticed that she was clever. A spy failed because somebody noticed that she was *careful*. So she had made herself careless in exactly the right places. She left books in the bath until the paper wrinkled. She was late, sometimes, to meals. She was occasionally, deliberately, too much of a coward to open a door at night, and the Colonel liked that; the Colonel liked a woman who needed his arm on the stairs.

She went down the corridor to the small room at the back that the Colonel believed she used for her dresses and which was in fact a room with a north

light and one window onto the courtyard, through which, standing a certain way behind the curtain, you could see a slice of the street door.

There was a man in the street with a book under his arm. He was young, in a good grey coat, and no hat, which in January meant either a fool or a message. She stood behind the curtain and watched him for forty breaths and beat her own body at its own game, because the mad, hot, stupid thing that came up in her chest every time she saw a stranger who might be a Pole was the thing that would kill her, and it had to be lived with in daylight, like the cold, and made into arithmetic.

The boy turned a page he had not read. He looked at his watch, walked to the corner, looked down the avenue, came back, and stopped in the same place. Then he tipped his head back and looked up, quite deliberately, at the third floor, for a count of three, and walked away.

She stood with her hand on the shutter for a long minute after he had gone.

Then she went to get dressed, because at eleven she had an appointment about a hat.

♦ ♦ ♦

Odile Marchand had a shop in the rue Cambon with a green door and no name on it, because in Paris a shop without a name had a clientele, and a clientele without names had money. She made hats for the wives of the German administration, and she made them with the kind of obstinate, exquisite, faintly sarcastic craft that said, to anyone capable of reading it, that the folding of a hatband by a French hand was the last irreducible frontier of Europe.

She was thirty. She had been beautiful in a way that had been described in three newspapers before the war. Her hands were the only luxurious thing about her now, and she did everything with them: she talked with them, she lied with them, she cut, she smoothed, she touched the collar of your dress to fix it, and when you had known Odile six weeks you would have let her hold your life in her left hand and your purse in her right and lost track of which was which.

"Madame Herschlag." She came round the counter and took both of Marion's hands and held them out at arm's length, looked at them, and instead of kissing her on both cheeks kissed the air beside her ear and said, very quietly, in Polish, "There is a bad smell in the street."

"Four of them?"

"Two, and a car with the engine off. Since Thursday."

"Because of Röhrig."

"Because of something." Odile released her, went back behind the counter, and held up a shape of green felt in both hands, all business. "The Colonel will want the black, I think. I have almost finished the black."

"The black," Marion agreed, and sat in the low chair by the mirror, and looked at a hat, and talked about a hat, for eleven minutes, which was how long it took Odile to be sure.

Röhrig, shot in the rue de la Pompe. They are watching the avenues near the office. There is a man with a book outside the house at six o'clock this morning; I have no photograph of him, he has no hat, he is young, grey coat, he read a page that was not a page.

Odile listened to a description of a hat the way other women listened to a confession. When Marion finished she said, "The black will want a veil. A short one. Because the Fräulein's face is not a face that should be looked at from all angles at once," and she smiled, and pointed with her chin at the long mirror, and Marion stood and looked at herself in it: the grey wool dress, the plain earrings, the hair that a hairdresser on the avenue had taught to fall in exactly the way that cost the Reich nothing.

"He is coming for me at eight," she said. "He is taking me to the theatre."

"Then he will want you to wear the green."

The green was silk, pre-war, from a couturier who had gone to New York. It had belonged to a woman who no longer lived in the apartment on the avenue Henri-Martin, and Marion had found it in the wardrobe in the second bedroom in November, hanging with eleven others behind a curtain, and when she asked, the Colonel had said only, *Take them. They are regulated now.* She had worn nine of them. She never wore the ninth, which was a pale, soft, dove-coloured thing with a wide collar, because it had a smell in the lining that came up when you pressed your face to it, which she had done exactly once.

"The green, then," she said.

Odile was pinning something. Then, without looking up: "The boy who came."

"Which boy?"

"Do not be stupid with me. The boy who walks on the avenue at six o'clock in the morning with a book. He came in on Tuesday and wanted to know the price of a felt." The pins went flick, flick. "I told him three hundred francs. He did not blink. He is not a buyer, and he is not police,

because police do not waste an afternoon on felt. He is one of ours, or he is yours, and I do not know which, and it would interest me a great deal to know which."

"You don't have a network," Marion said. "You have a hat shop."

"I have a hat shop and a brother in the Auvergne with a wireless set and a very bad temper," said Odile. "*You* have a colonel, and he has a briefcase, and last Friday a man from the rue des Rosiers came to my back door and asked me to ask you whether the list has moved." She looked up. "He was polite. He was very polite. He had a paper bag with a chicken in it, which is a thing that no longer exists in Paris, and he wanted me to understand that it was not a bribe but a courtesy. That is how they are, your people. They bring you a chicken and ask you for a miracle."

Marion sat in the low chair and looked at herself in the mirror, and the woman in the mirror looked back with her mother's face.

"Nine names," she said. "Tell him nine names, and two above, and five below, and Reinhold is one of them, and if the chicken is still a chicken on Thursday, then he should ask me again, and I will tell him what the paper under the photograph in the Colonel's study says, because he has taken to keeping the paper under the photograph."

Odile put down her pins. "Under the photograph of the dead wife?"

"Under the photograph of the dead wife."

There was a silence in which the shop put itself back together. Then Odile said, in a completely different voice, the voice of a woman humming at a counter at eleven in the morning in the rue Cambon, "Would you like to see the veil, madame? I think the veil. Not the feathers. Never the feathers. Feathers are for women who have not decided which war they are going to survive."

She was wrapping the hat in tissue when she said, in Polish, without looking up — and this was the thing about Odile, the thing that made the two of them possible: she never asked the question when it could be done with the hands.

"Does he know?"

"Who?"

"The boy in the street."

"He is not mine," said Marion. "I have no one in the street. I have a hat, a colonel, and an address in Alsace where a woman named Marion Herschlag was born in 1919, and all of it is true on paper, and none of it

exists, and if you ever meet anyone who claims to have known me before October, that person is a liar or a policeman, and you should run."

"The Colonel will be pleased with the hat," Odile said, and tied the string.

♦ ♦ ♦

Out in the street the air was a colour between ash and milk. The trees along the Champs-Élysées had been pruned into knuckles, the German flags on the hotel fronts hung limp and enormous, and there was a queue outside the butcher's on the corner that had been there since five in the morning and would be there at five the next morning, and it was, in every direction, an ordinary Thursday in an occupied city, which is the most terrible thing a city can be.

She walked, because a woman of her position did not use the Métro unless she wanted to be looked at, and because walking made her feel the streets were hers, which was a lie, but a useful one. Twice she stopped at a shop window with her hands in her pockets and looked at the reflection behind her: the crowd, the grey of it, a boy on a bicycle, a girl with a basket, a fat woman with a poodle, and in the middle distance, keeping pace with her at the crawl of a man who has nowhere to be, a grey coat.

She did not hurry. She crossed the avenue at the lights the way the best-dressed women in Paris crossed, with total disregard for everything except her shoes, and went into the church of Saint-Roch, because it was Thursday and the church was full of women who had all claimed to be somewhere else, and because there was a stairwell on the north side where you could be alone with a candle for four minutes and nobody in Paris would wonder why.

The candles were cheap and the saints were real. She put a franc in the box and lit one for a tailor and one for a man who had been shot in the rue de la Pompe, whom she had never met and who might very well have been the man who signed her death, and she sat down in the dark and put her head in her hands and allowed herself ninety seconds of being twenty-five years old.

Then she took the matchbox out of her shoe.

The stone niche behind the second column of the north aisle was where the parish kept a broom and a bucket, and where in winter a draught came down from the gallery and moved the dust along the floor in long slow fingers. She knelt by the niche as though to fix a stocking, put her hand in

the dark at the back of it, and set the matchbox down, and felt with her fingertips for the tin that should have been there, and found it: a flat tobacco tin, out of which she took a folded square of paper the size of a stamp, and into which she put nothing, because it was not emptied by her.

She had one job here, and it was to be someone else entirely if anyone came.

Nobody came. She read the paper in the light of the candles, holding it inside her glove. It was four words, in a hand she knew better than her own: *MOTHERS MEET THURSDAY. SAME HOUR.* Which was Lis, with a bad heart and a worse sense of humour, telling her that a courier was confirmed and the road to Marseille was open, and that she should keep doing what she was doing, and that the network was still alive.

She burned the paper over the candle, which was a thing that had cost her a burn on the inside of her wrist in Prague in 1941, and which she had learned to do with the edge of a fingernail ever since, and she watched the ash go up and settle on the shoulder of a saint.

When she came out into the rue Saint-Honoré, the grey coat was standing at the corner forty metres away, looking at the window of a shoemaker as though the shoemaker's window had ever in the history of the world required looking at.

She walked east a hundred metres, then turned north into the small streets behind the Tuileries, where the wind came off the river and the buildings were dark with soot and a woman could hear her own footsteps on the pavement and count them, and understand, in that cold, clean, animal calculation that was the only kind of thought she still trusted, exactly what her body was for and how long it could be expected to last.

He followed. He was twenty metres behind her when she came out on the quai. She had decided in the rue Saint-Honoré that she was going to let him follow, because a woman who turns and looks at the man behind her is a woman who knows she is being followed, and a woman who has nothing to hide never notices anything at all — and because there was, in the deepest and most carefully locked drawer of Krystyna Stankiewiczówna's file, a hope she had been carrying since the platform at the Gare de l'Est in October, and it was this: that someday someone from home would look at her with recognition in his eyes. She would rather be shot that afternoon than let herself have that hope, and she had not been able to kill it in five months.

She stood at the parapet with the wind coming off the water and the smell of cold iron, and behind her, at a distance of four metres, a young man in a good grey coat stopped, put his hands on the stone, and looked out at the river, and did not say a word for two minutes.

Then he said, in French, with the accent of a Pole who had learned it from a book, "It is a bad time to be out walking."

She looked at the water. Her heart had gone somewhere she could not follow.

"It is a bad time to be alive," she said. "Yet here we are. And the river does not care either way, monsieur, and neither do I."

There was a silence in which she could hear him breathing, four metres away, and in that silence she felt the whole thing — the apartment, the diamonds, the list, the tailor — hang by a thread over a drop she could not see.

"The book," he said at last. "You have not asked me about the book."

"Should I?"

"It is Polish," he said. "It is a book about the botany of the Kampinos Forest. There is nobody in Paris who would buy it and nobody who would read it. If anyone asks, I am an idiot who is homesick for a forest. It is important that when they take me, and they will take me, they take me for that."

Marion Herschlag turned from the river and looked at the young man for the first time, and saw what she had known from the street: the face of a boy of twenty-three who was already dead and did not know it, and who had come out to the river in the middle of the day to say something to somebody who might carry it home.

"Yes," she said, in Polish. She said it in Polish because she had to, because he had given her the only thing he had, and because she would rather have cut off her own hand. "Speak to the hat shop. Never to me. And go home the long way, through the market, and buy something, anything, and be seen buying it."

"Then you are—"

"I am nobody," she said, and she said it in Polish too, which was a mistake, and she knew it the moment it was out of her mouth, and it was too late. "I am nobody, and I have never been to Warsaw, and I was born in Strasbourg, and if you see me again you will not know me. Now go. And read the book. It is a better book than the men who sent you."

She walked away up the quai with her hands in her pockets and the wind in her eyes, and she did not look back, and behind her she heard nothing at all except the river, and the city, and somewhere a car changing gear.

She was four hundred metres from the apartment when she understood that she would have to go back into that bedroom tonight, and take her clothes off in front of the mirror, and be a woman who had been to see about a hat.

♦ ♦ ♦

The theatre was at eight. The play was Molière, played to a house of grey uniforms and furs and a scattering of the sort of Parisians who could still, in the third winter, find the money for both. In the second interval the Colonel stood in the foyer with his back to a mirrored pillar, a glass of something pale in his hand, and watched the room watch his woman, which was, she had understood in December, a distinct form of pleasure to him — not vanity, exactly. He was fifty-four, with a limp from Smolensk and a chest full of iron, and possession was the only thing left that he could be said to enjoy without irony, and he had decided, sometime in November, that Marion Herschlag was the possession he was going to be buried in.

Two Hauptmänner came and said good evening. A Generalmajor's wife with a face like a good plain soup said something kind about the play and looked at Marion with an expression Marion had catalogued in October and could now recognise at forty metres: the look of a German woman of fifty who has decided that the beautiful French girl is not a whore but something worse, which is a *comfort*, and who will be pleasant for exactly as long as it takes to be certain.

The Colonel put his hand on the back of Marion's neck. He did it while he was talking, without pausing, which was the thing that made it belong to her and not to the conversation: a thumb, a pressure, the short hair at her nape, a claim registered in front of the room.

At the far side of the foyer, beside the doors, stood a small man in a good coat with his hands behind his back, and he was looking at her, and he was smiling.

René Tissier was forty-nine years old and edited a weekly sheet that had a circulation of forty thousand and a staff of four, and he was, in the ordinary run of things, a matter of no interest to her at all, except for two facts. The first was that in the spring, at a party at the Hôtel Majestic, he had put

his hand on the small of her back and said, *I knew a little actress in Kraków who had your mouth*, purely to watch her face. The second was the end of November, in a corridor at the Militärbefehlshaber, when he had come up behind her with a glass in his hand and said, in Polish, quietly, and completely correctly, *You have grown up very well, Panna Stankiewiczówna* — and then walked away, and been sick, or pretended to be sick, into a courtyard, before she could find her voice.

She had spent a month proving to herself that he didn't know. She had tested it nine ways. He had never said it again. He had come to a dinner in December and been charming and left early. He was a man who collected things — paintings that were not his, women who were somebody else's, facts about people who could not afford to have facts about them, filed in his head — and he had the one property that made him dangerous to a person like her: he did not spend a thing until it was worth more to hold. He had held this since November. He was still holding it now, in the foyer of the Théâtre des Champs-Élysées, with his hands behind his back and his smile going nowhere.

Halfway through the third act, Marion Herschlag leaned to the Colonel in the dark and breathed against his ear, "I want to go home."

He turned his head. In the dark his face was all bone. "Are you ill?"

"I am bored," she said. "I am bored, and I am cold, and I want to be taken to bed by a man who has been thinking about it all evening, and all evening you have been thinking about the Eastern Front."

That was the trick. There were only ever two tricks, and she had learned both of them in Kraków: give them the thing they already want with your hand rather than theirs, and name the thing they are hiding, in a voice that means *I have forgiven it, come here*.

He took her home. In the car, with Ehlers driving and the blackout lamps throwing a moving yellow smear along the grey fronts of the sixteenth arrondissement, the Colonel sat with his hand on her knee and said nothing at all, and she looked out at the shut shops, the swastika over the hotel door, the queue that had not moved since five in the morning, and felt, coming up through the floor of the car, the particular silence that meant he had decided something, and that she would be told when he was ready to be told.

At the door of the apartment he dismissed Kleist for the night. That was the first sign. The second was that he did not put on the light in the long sitting room, where a Picasso that the requisition board had not yet got

around to ran the length of one wall, grey under its dust sheet, like a mountain in fog.

"In the hall," he said, "there are the ear-clips. On the table."

She went into the hall. It was a small paper box, from a jeweller on the rue de la Paix that had changed its name twice since 1940. Inside were two diamonds, small, good, in white gold, and old — she could see that they were old before she saw that they were beautiful, from the cut; they had come out of somewhere else, a drawer that had belonged to a woman who had been taken somewhere in 1942, and had been reset in a window on the rue de la Paix by a jeweller who no longer asked questions, and bought by a colonel of the Abwehr.

She stood in the dark hall with two other women's diamonds in a paper box in her hand, and heard the second thing he had to say, from the dark of the sitting room.

"I have written to Ilse about you."

She closed her hand around the box.

"About what?" she said.

"That there is someone." His voice came out of the dark, level, and beneath the level, for the first time in five months, something she had not heard before, which was uncertainty, in the middle of a man like a wall. "That she is not what I expected. That she is better than what I have deserved."

The diamonds were cold, and in the dark of the hall, with her coat still on, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood and worked out, with her trained and terrible mind, which one of them she was supposed to be for the next four minutes — the woman who said *thank you*, or the woman who said *don't* — and discovered that she could not choose, because both of them were true, and she had just, for the first time in five months and the third time in her life, put her hand out in the dark and touched a thing she could not have, and the name of the thing was: *he means it.*

She took the earrings out of the box. She did not put them on, and she did not go to him, and she did not answer. She stood in the dark hall of the requisitioned apartment at 12, avenue Henri-Martin, with the cold coming off the door and the diamonds in her palm, and above her head, three floors up, a family's chandelier hung in a room she had never entered, and in the bathroom down the corridor there was a comb with two black hairs in it, and outside the window, in the dark of the avenue, there was a boy in a good grey coat who had been playing with a page in a

Polish book all afternoon, and she thought: *the two of them do not know about each other.*

And then she thought the thing she would remember, at the end, at the very end, in the dust and the noise and the walls coming down: *but they will.*

CHAPTER TWO

Dead Languages

♦ ♦ ♦

It had begun, like most things in her life, with a lie that was almost true, told in a room with a good carpet.

October, 1942. A building on the avenue Kléber with eagles over the doors and a lift that worked because the Wehrmacht had kept the current on all over Paris for the buildings it needed. She had waited forty minutes in a corridor painted the same green as a hospital, and she had counted the doors, and the cornices, and the number of times the lift came up, because she had been told in Kraków to arrive with her eyes and her ears and nothing else — no papers she could not burn, no powder on her face, no gloves because gloves were what women who came to be hired wore, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna had come to the Hôtel Majestic to be looked at only once.

That was the arrangement. One interview, one hour, one irreversible yes or no. It had been explained to her by Lis on a bench in the Saxon Garden three weeks earlier, in the ordinary voice of a man discussing the price of coal.

You are not going there to be liked, my little rabbit. You are going there to be misunderstood. That is it. They must look at you and see a woman and stop there, because everything after that is arithmetic.

The door had opened. A Hauptmann with a face like a boy's had said her name — hers, the false one, Herschlag — and she had stood up, and

walked in, and stopped in the middle of the room, and the man behind the desk had done her the courtesy of not standing.

He had been fifty-three that autumn. Grey at the temples but not silver; a face built to be looked at from below, and a body that had been a good one at thirty and had been maintained since by riding and by a discipline that no longer knew what it was for. He had not looked at her body. He had looked at her hands, and then at her shoes, and then at her face, for a long time, without any embarrassment at all.

"Herschlag," he said. "From Strasbourg."

"Yes."

"You were married to a man who made plate glass."

"Yes."

"He is dead."

"He was killed in the retreat. Near Abbeville. Before the armistice."

"So it says." He had turned the paper over with two fingers, the way a man turns over a coin of a denomination he doesn't trust. "You speak German."

"A little. Alsatian German. My mother's people were from Kehl."

"And French."

"And French."

"And you came to Paris in July and have been living in the rue de Bassano with a dressmaker." He had looked up. "Which dressmaker?"

"Madame Vaury. The couture house is closed. She keeps the flat because her brother writes her a certificate every month."

"Why does she keep you?"

It was the question she had been waiting for, and she had rehearsed the answer not in a room in Kraków but in a room in Warsaw, at a window, in the winter of 1940, in front of a mirror, with her mother's face on and her own hands shaking in the dark below the sill.

"Because I amuse her," she said. "Because I am beautiful, and I have no money, and every week I become a little more expensive to keep. There is nothing strange in it, Colonel. Women keep each other the way men keep dogs; it is only the collar that changes."

There had been a pause in that room like a stone dropping down a well, and she had heard the lift again, and a telephone ringing two doors away, and then Friedrich von Reuth had done the thing that decided the next two years of her life. He had laughed. It was a short laugh, a bark, a door closing; and he had stood up — the limp was there already, the left leg, from a wound she would not learn the name of for another month — and

he had come around the desk and stopped in front of her, close enough that she could smell his soap and his cigarettes and the wool of a uniform that had been tailored in Berlin.

"You will be told lies about me," he said. "By my officers, who think I am a machine. By the French, who think I am a monster. By women, who think I am a widower with an open wound." His hand had come up and taken her chin between his thumb and forefinger, not hard — a man inspecting a horse, or engraving a coin. "I am none of these. I am a man who despises waste. You are not a wasted woman. That is all."

And that had been Paris. She had moved into the apartment on the avenue Henri-Martin nine days later, and she had lain down in the bed of a woman who had died in 1936, and she had begun.

♦ ♦ ♦

The film went out on the twelfth of January, in a hat.

Odile came for it at nine in the morning with a workman's box and a bundle of tissue, and the two of them stood in the hall of the apartment with Kleist's coffee still on the tray and did the thing that every Frenchwoman in the rue Cambon could have watched without seeing anything at all: Marion Herschlag tried on a hat, and the hat did not suit her, and the hat was taken away to be altered.

"How many?" Odile said, holding the mirror.

"Nine names."

"Put your shoulders down, madame, you are doing something military with them." She turned the mirror, all attentiveness, and said, at a volume that would not carry past the door: "The boy from the quai was picked up on Wednesday. The police, or the SD, I do not know. He was at the market, buying bread, being seen buying it, exactly as he was told."

Marion looked at a hat in a mirror.

"Then he did what he was told," she said.

"He was twenty-three."

"I know how old he was."

She had gone over it nine hundred times in the week since the quai, and every version of the night ended the same way. She had done the correct thing nine times out of nine and it had cost a boy his teeth. That was the arithmetic, and there was no escaping out of arithmetic: the only thing she was permitted to feel was the shape of the mistake. The mistake, she had

decided, was speaking Polish to him. He had gone away from her with something in his chest, a piece of knowledge, warm as a hand; and a man with something warm in his chest goes to a market and looks at people the way a man looks at people when he has a secret. He had bought bread and been seen buying it, and he had also, she would have bet her life on it, looked back over his shoulder at a woman in a grey coat.

"Tell me about the film," Odile said. "Nothing about the film. Never about the film. The film is a hat."

"The film is a hat. Tuesday, the shop. Red hatbox, black ribbon, second shelf, behind the two blue ones. It goes to Marseille with the millinery. The man at the Gare de Lyon wears gloves and asks for Madame Vaury's order, and if he asks for anything else, you are a hat shop that has been robbed twice and you do not keep a ledger."

"And afterwards?"

"Afterwards there is no afterwards. There is a train, and then a road, and then Warsaw, and the men there will do what men there always do, which is argue about whether the names are worth the paper." She took the hat off and held it out. "Nine names, Odile. One of them is a tailor who lives in a basement with his sister and three other families and has probably never in his life been west of the Vistula."

Odile put the hat in tissue.

"Then why does a colonel of the Abwehr keep him in a briefcase?"

"That," said Marion, "is the best question anyone has asked me all winter."

She saw Odile to the door, and the concierge did not hear them, and the two women kissed the air on either side of each other's faces, and a hat went out of a house on the avenue Henri-Martin inside a bundle of tissue paper, and the thing inside it was a hundred and ten centimetres of unexposed film, and the man who would carry it as far as Lyon had a wife and a hernia and a bad opinion of Poles, and would, in the end, in the wet spring of that year, be caught at the frontier at Modane because he stopped to help a woman with a pram.

There was no way to know any of that, that morning, in that hall. There was only the door, and the cold, and the day's work ahead of her, which was to be a woman of no importance at a table in the sixteenth arrondissement.

♦ ♦ ♦

At noon the Colonel sent for her, which he did perhaps twice a month, and each time it meant something.

Ehlers drove her. He was thirty-three, with a face like a well-kept farm and hands that never went above fifty kilometres an hour, and he had been in Poland, and in France, and had a photograph of a girl named Marta in the flap of his map case, and in the four months since October he had never once said a word to Marion Herschlag that was not correct, and never once failed to open her door first.

"It is cold, Fräulein," he said, in the car.

"It is January."

"At home they say the same." He changed gear with the same gentleness he did everything with. "My Marta writes that in Posen they are burning the trees. The chestnuts on the avenue. Not for fuel — there is coal — but because the branches hang over the road, and the road is for the army." He said it in the voice of a man reporting the weather, and then, quietly, because a car is a confessional and a German driver in Paris has one place left to put his opinions: "There was a park where we walked in the summer."

"That is what they do," said Marion. "They take the branches, and the shade, and then they take the bench, and then they take the woman on the bench. It is all one thing, Ehlers. You cannot have the branches back."

The car went along the avenue with the blackout lamps off for once, because it was daylight, and she watched the city go by, and she thought about how easy it was, how fatally easy, to be kind to the people who were going to lose.

The Majestic had a courtyard with staff cars and a sentry, and inside, on the second floor, in a room with a map of the Atlantic coast and a photograph of a dead woman on the sill, Oberst Friedrich von Reuth was standing at the window with his hands behind his back, and there was a single sheet of paper on the desk.

"Come in," he said. "Shut the door."

She shut the door.

"Take off your coat."

She took off her coat. He did not turn around. That was the shape of it, the shape their private life took when it came into an office: he would look at her in a window, she would stand with her hands at her sides, and the sex that had happened the night before would come into the room behind them and stand there, patient, like an orderly.

"There is a leak," he said.

"I have heard you say that before."

"Not like this." He turned. "A man named Röhrig was killed on Tuesday. This morning the Militärbefehlshaber tells me that a document from his briefcase has been found, in a private house in Neuilly, in a bundle of papers belonging to a banker who has been in prison since 1941, which means that the document went out of the Militärbefehlshaber, into the street, into the hand of a courier, and back into the hand of the police, in five days." He came over to the desk and put two fingers on the sheet of paper. "It is a list of names in the southern zone."

The room was quiet. Somewhere below, in the courtyard, a car door slammed, and the sound came up through the window and lay in the room like a third person.

"I do not know any names in the southern zone," she said.

"No."

"I know a jeweller on the rue de la Paix, a hairdresser, a hat shop, and your orderly. If I were a spy, Colonel, I would be a very poor one."

"I know." He was looking at her with the expression he wore at the theatre, when he watched the room watching his woman. "I tell you because I have decided something, and I want you to hear it from me and not from the servants."

She waited.

"There is a leak in the Abwehrstelle Paris, and it is not a Frenchman, because the Frenchmen here are clerks and clerks do not steal photographs. It is somebody who has access. Possibly somebody in my own section. When I find him, I shall hang him in the rue des Saussaies and make the rest of them watch, and after that I shall be sent to the east, because a colonel who finds a traitor is a colonel who has failed."

"Then do not find him," she said.

He looked at her for a long moment, and she watched the thought land, and she watched him decide to be amused by it, because if he was amused he did not have to wonder how a dressmaker's companion from Strasbourg had learned to say such a thing.

"There is one more thing." He went to the window again. "My adjutant has been promoted away from me — Schmidt, a fool, but loyal. I have asked for a replacement, and they are sending me a captain out of the staff at Nancy. He is half Polish, of all things; his mother was born in that city.

He speaks the language." A pause. "He will be useful. I am told his file is excellent."

She stood in the middle of the room with her coat over her arm, and she did not move, and the room was suddenly full of a noise like the sea.

"His name," said the Colonel, "is Brandt."

There was a chair by the wall. She did not sit in it. She looked at the photograph of the dead woman on the sill — Anneliese, in a garden, in 1931, with a dog — and she thought, with the part of her mind that had been trained on a bench in the Saxon Garden to be quicker than her hands: *there are twelve hundred men in the Paris garrison, and there were eleven hundred thousand people in Warsaw, and there are no coincidences, there are only things that have not happened yet.*

"Half Polish," she said.

"Half Polish." He was still at the window. "You are not a Pole, my dear, so do not look at me like that. It is not a crime in my service to have a Polish mother. It is merely a thing that has to be written down."

"Perhaps he will teach me the language."

"He will not have time." He turned. "He arrives on Friday. On Friday I have the dinner for the Reichsbank people, and I want you at it, in the black, and I want the earrings, and I want you to be the only woman in the room who is not frightened of me."

"I am never frightened of you," she said, and she said it with her mother's face, and it was the first genuinely perfect lie she had told him in three months.

♦ ♦ ♦

She did not sleep that night, and she did not count.

At two in the morning he came for her, which was his habit when a decision was working in him: he would wake her with his hand and take her without a word, as though the marriage bed were a drawer he was permitted to open, and she would do what she did, and afterwards he would talk — that was the whole mechanism of the man; his body was the door and his voice was the room behind it.

He turned her onto her back and put his weight on her, and she made herself soft under him in the way that made it shorter, and he said, against her neck, with the effort in his voice, "The boy from the rue de la Pompe—"

"Not now."

"They gave him to the French police and the French police gave him back." His hand closed in her hair. "He was a student. Two years of law at Caen. He had a mother in Rouen." He was moving now, steadily, and she lay under him and did the work, which was to be a surface, and to hear every word. "Before they shot him he told them a name. They always tell you a name. It is not courage that runs out, my dear, it is the *arrangement*—"

She lifted her hips into him because that was what made him finish, and because it made him stop talking about the arrangement, and he came with his teeth against her shoulder, and then rolled off and lay on his back in the dark, breathing, and she lay still and hated him in the correct way, which was without any movement of her face.

"Do you know what a name is worth?" he said, to the ceiling.

"Tell me."

"A name is worth exactly what it costs to check. That is why we lose. Every name we are given costs four men four days and a car and a telephone call to Berlin, and in that time the man is gone, because his organisation has moved him; and so the arrangement is always behind, and the only way to get in front of it is to pay for a name with another name, and then you are the kind of man who sells names, and such a man does not last." He put his arm over his eyes, the thing he did. "In Russia I had a man who sold me names. Ukrainian. Excellent instinct. I gave him a house in Kiev and a car and the use of a woman who had been the wife of a commissar; and in April I had to shoot him myself, in a wood, and he was surprised. He kept saying, *Herr Oberst, I did what you asked.* And he had. That is the thing about this war. Everybody is doing what somebody asked."

She lay beside him in the dark, and under her breastbone the small cold machine that she called her mind was running, and it was running on the word *Brandt*, and it had been running for four hours, and it was producing, every time, the same three results.

The first was Warsaw, 1938, and a boy of nineteen in the Botanic Gardens in June, with a book of poems and a shirt that was too thin for the evening, who had said, when she had asked him what he intended to do with his life, *I am going to be something my mother can be proud of in two languages*, and had laughed at himself the moment he said it, and had blushed, and had looked away over the glass roofs of the palms.

The second was the letter, and the letter was not a memory, it was a physical object: a square envelope with her name on it in a hand that pressed too

hard, which she had found in the drawer of the hall table on the seventh of September 1939, when the family was packing silver into pillowcases, and had put in her pocket and carried through that autumn and never opened, and which was, as far as she knew, at the bottom of a suitcase that no longer existed, in a house on the Mokotowska that had been used for three weeks as a barracks by a regiment of the Reich.

The third was the one that was actually dangerous, and she lay in the dark and made herself look at it, because that was the rule she lived by.

He is coming here, she thought. *He will be in this house, in this corridor, at my table, and he will be the one man in Europe who can look at me and see a girl.*

And then, because the mind was a machine and machines sometimes did the thing you had not asked for, the thought went on without her, in the dark, in the shape of a question, and the question was this: *what if he is not sorry?*

♦ ♦ ♦

The Friday dinner was in the long room at the Majestic that had been a ballroom in 1907 and was now a dining room with a portrait of the Führer over the fireplace and forty covers on linen.

She wore the black. She wore the earrings — she had put them on, in the end, in front of the mirror in the second bedroom, and she had looked at herself for four seconds and understood something about herself that she had not wanted to know, which was that the diamonds suited her, and that she liked them, and that a woman who has begun to like the price of her own work is a woman with an appointment in the rue des Saussaies.

The Reichsbank men were dull and frightened; there is nothing so dull as a banker in an occupied country, and nothing so frightened. She sat between a Generalmajor with a wine-coloured face and a secretary of the Militärbefehlshaber who tried three times to look down the front of her dress without moving his head, and she performed, for four hours, the entire repertoire: the laugh at the right moment, the pause before the answer that made men think she had considered them, the single glass of champagne drunk very slowly for the pleasure of watching her hands around it.

At the far end of the table, the Colonel talked about the Atlantic, and she watched him do it, and understood, as she always did on these evenings,

how it was that the thing between them worked. He did not love her; he possessed her; and possession, in a people who had given themselves over to a war they were losing, was a religion with a full pew on Sunday morning.

At eleven the cars came. And in the corridor, going out, with her hand on the Colonel's arm, she turned her head because someone had said the word "Brandt" two metres behind her, and saw, in the middle of a group of officers, with a glass in one hand and his head bent to listen to a colonel of the Luftwaffe, a man of twenty-eight in a captain's uniform who was not, in any respect, the boy from the Botanic Gardens.

She had three seconds. She used them the way she had been taught in Kraków: she let her eyes pass over him the way the eyes of a woman pass over the furniture of a room she has been in before, and she took from the three seconds exactly the information that was there. He was heavier through the shoulders. His hair was shorter and there was a scar at the corner of his mouth that had not been there in 1938. He stood the way soldiers stood when they had been in the east, with his weight on the balls of his feet. And he had, in the way he held the glass, in the set of the wrist, something that had been trained out of everybody else in the room and had not been trained out of him, which was that he held it as though he were in a house that did not belong to him.

She was at the door. The Colonel's hand came onto the back of her neck.

"Ah," he said. "There he is. Brandt."

She looked at the far end of the corridor. And in that same half-second, at the distance of perhaps nine metres, the captain's head came up.

He looked at her.

It was not a long look. A second, a second and a half. It was the length of look a junior officer gives the woman on the arm of his colonel: blank, courteous, and placed carefully at the point in the middle distance where a well-bred man's eyes rest. He was too far away for her to see the colour of his eyes. She saw, instead, the small thing that would keep her awake for the next eleven nights: the half-beat of hesitation before he turned away — the interval, no longer than a breath, in which a man decides what he is going to be for the remainder of a war.

Then he bowed slightly, to the Colonel, not to her, and turned back to his conversation.

"Good," said von Reuth, at her ear, in the voice of a man appraising a horse. "He looks exactly like what he is, which is a very lucky young man.

He was a lieutenant at Vyazma and had his whole company killed around him; they gave him a fortnight in Paris before they send him back to the east." His hand tightened on her neck. "You are cold. Get in the car."

She got in the car. Berlin was six hundred kilometres away and Warsaw was twelve hundred, and she sat in the dark of the back seat with Ehlers driving and the blackout lamps smearing the grey fronts of the avenue, and she did the only thing she was permitted to do with a fact, which was to file it: *he does not know me, or he knows me and will not say it, and both of those are worse than anything I have arranged for.*

The car stopped. She got out. In the hall the Colonel took off his cap and hung it on the chair, and turned to her with the earrings catching the light from the landing above, and for the first time in four months he did not take her to bed.

Instead he said: "You were quiet tonight."

"I am always quiet at those dinners."

"No." He came a step closer. "From the moment we left the table you were quiet in a different way. In the corridor. When I said the name."

The clock in the hall struck the half hour.

"I hate the corridor," said Marion Herschlag. "There is a draught in it, and a photograph of your wife on the wall by the door to your office, and every one of your officers looks at it and then at me, and I am a woman who is paid to be looked at, Colonel, but not to be compared."

It was cruel, it was cheap, and it was exactly the sort of thing a kept woman says when she is frightened: personal, spiteful, and about a dead woman. It worked. She watched the words go into him and do their work on his face, and she watched him decide, as he had decided a hundred times in five months, that the sound of her jealousy was the sound of the only thing in his life that was still intact — his property.

He took her to bed, and he was rougher than he had been since November, and afterwards, when he was asleep, she lay awake with her wrists aching where his fingers had been, and listened to the sound of the great cold city outside, and understood, with a clarity that felt like a knife going in cleanly, that she was now in the only position she had ever been warned about: she was going to have to do this with a man in the room who could see her.

She had told herself, in the winter of 1940, in a room in Kraków, with a small man and a bad heart explaining to her the four rules that would keep her alive, that the fourth one was easy.

Never love. It is not a moral instruction, my little rabbit, it is arithmetic. You will be offered two or three chances, and each one will feel like the only honest thing in the world, and each one will kill you and everyone who gave you your orders. So: never love. Say it back to me.

She had said it back. She had said it back, in the winter of 1940, in a room with a bad fire and a bad chair, and she had meant it, and she had said it back again on the platform at the Gare de l'Est in October, under her breath, because the cold had got into her chest and she had thought it was the cold.

Beside her, the Colonel of the Abwehrstelle Paris slept the sleep of a man with a clear conscience, which was the last clear conscience left in Europe.

Down the corridor, past the green marble bathroom, in the small room with the north light, there was a hatbox with a red ribbon on it and no hat in it, and in the study behind the photograph of a dead woman there was a sheet of paper with a heading in three languages, and in the west of the city, in a flat above a closed couture house, a milliner of thirty was asleep in a bed she shared with nobody, with her brother's wireless set under the floorboard and a train ticket in the lining of a winter coat.

And somewhere, in a hotel on the boulevard des Capucines, a captain who had been at Vyazma was sitting on the edge of a bed with his boots off and a cigarette burning down in an ashtray, not sleeping, doing arithmetic of his own.

CHAPTER THREE

The House of Stolen Things

♦ ♦ ♦

The apartment had been the Vasseurs'.

She had learned that in November, from the concierge, who had done it the way the French did everything under the occupation, which was with a perfect surface and a bitter sediment underneath. The Vasseurs had been in the silk trade. The Vasseurs had kept a box at the Opéra and a house at Deauville and a daughter who rode; and in the second bedroom there was a mark on the wallpaper the size of a small rectangle where a picture had hung for eleven years, and in the wardrobe behind the curtain, hanging in a row like people waiting for a train, there were the eleven dresses of a woman who had gone away in 1942 to a place that was not Deauville.

The Colonel had taken the apartment in September: a requisition form, a signature, a set of keys. Three-quarters of the Vasseurs' things had gone to a depot in the rue de la Faisanderie; the rest was the furniture that was too heavy to move and too good to throw away, and it stayed where it was, in its rooms, being itself: a piano, two candlesticks, a screen of Coromandel lacquer, the green marble bathroom that had been the husband's, the small north room that had been the daughter's.

Marion Herschlag had moved into the house of stolen things in October with one suitcase and a hatbox and a story about Alsace, and she had learned, in the four months since, that the essential problem of living among stolen objects was not the guilt. It was the *attachment*. A chair is a chair; but if you sit in one chair for a hundred mornings and look at a

screen of lacquer while you drink your coffee, then the chair and the screen become part of the architecture of your own survival, and one day you find that you love a thing that was taken from somebody, and you have become, without meaning to, a thief.

She solved it the way she solved everything: by inventory. Twice a week, in the mornings before Kleist came up, she walked the whole flat room by room and looked at every object as though she had just arrived: *this is not mine; I did not buy it; I have no right to it; I could leave it in the street tomorrow and my life would not change.* It took eleven minutes. It was the only housework she had ever done with any diligence.

The Vasseurs' daughter had been called Odette, and she had been at the door of nineteen, and on the back of the door of the small north room there was still a printed paper horse, faded, from a riding school in the Bois, with a date on it in July 1938.

That room was where the hatbox lived, on a table, with a red ribbon on it, and nothing in it.

♦ ♦ ♦

On the twentieth of February she was invited to lunch with Frau Bruhn.

The wife of Oberstleutnant Bruhn was forty-six and came from Kehl, which was the detail that had made the invitation inevitable; and Kehl was, in the story of Marion Herschlag, the place where her mother's people had come from, which meant that Frau Bruhn had a claim on her, a piece of her, and would come to lunch to collect it.

The flat was the ground floor of a house in the avenue Émile-Deschanel, requisitioned from a family who were, they said, in the south, which was what everyone said in Paris in 1943. Frau Bruhn had done the room with German thrift and German taste: the Vichy-approved reproduction, the Christmas cactus, the photograph of a son at the front, and a copy of a Munich paper on the table, folded to a column.

"You have no accent at all," said Frau Bruhn, when the maid had brought the soup. "That is what they tell me in the section, and it is the strangest thing, because I have heard Alsatian women all my life and they have a way of turning the 'r' inward. But you — nothing."

"I was in Strasbourg very little. My education was in Paris."

"Then your mother must have been very grateful to your father."

"My mother died when I was twelve." That was true, and it was the only true sentence she would say for two hours, and she used it the way she used everything true: carefully, and once, and in the right place. "After that there was a school at Sèvres, and then France."

Frau Bruhn put down her spoon.

"Tell me," she said, "about the flood."

Six hundred kilometres away, in a room in a house on the avenue Kléber, there was a file with thirteen pages in it about Marion Herschlag of Strasbourg, and she had written the file herself, in outline, in September 1942, in order that she might be able to answer six questions exactly; and 'the flood' was the fourth. There had been a flood of the Rhine in the winter of 1919, a bad one; five hundred people had been out of their houses for a fortnight; and a small child of two in a stroller who had been carried by her uncle through a metre of water would have been told about it at every family dinner for the remainder of her girlhood.

She told Frau Bruhn about the flood. She did it in the voice people use about a thing they have heard a hundred times: with boredom in it, and a small piece of family detail, and a slight, comfortable impatience. She described the church with the water-mark at the height of the door lintel. She described her uncle's boots.

Frau Bruhn listened, and something relaxed in her face.

"Of course," she said. "The boots. There was one man in our street who never got them off." She laughed. "My dear, forgive me. When one is out of Germany, one becomes provincial. Every woman at our table is from somewhere, and every one of them is from somewhere else by the following week, and we all exercise each other like a piano with a tuning fork."

"Then we shall be friends on the strength of the boots."

"We shall be friends," said Frau Bruhn, "on the strength of your not being a Jew, which is more than half this street can say; and if you will take my advice, you will find out what the Colonel's wife was like, because he will bring it into the room at least once a month for the rest of the war, and it is better to be prepared."

"There is no wife. There is a dead woman. There is a difference."

"There is no difference at all, my child, and you know it, and that is why you have to plan for it."

It was the most useful hour she spent that winter, and the most dangerous, and she came out of the house in the avenue Émile-Deschanel with her hands steady, and walked to the Gare du Nord for no reason at all except

that it was the wrong direction, and stood for ten minutes on the platform watching the trains to Germany and the trains from Germany, and permitted herself, without moving her face, one minute of the pure animal hatred that she kept in the same box as the fear, in the same drawer, under the same lock.

♦ ♦ ♦

The film came back to her on the twenty-fourth, in the form of a book.

That was Odile's method, and it was beautiful: a parcel of books for Madame Herschlag, ordered from a shop in the rue de Rivoli, four of them, from the shop's own stock, so that the new books had the shop's paper and the shop's string. Inside the binding of the third book — a novel she had asked for and did not intend to read — there was a thin strip of paper, and on the strip, in Lis's hand, there were three words.

CINEMA SAINT-SÉVERIN, TUESDAY.

She went on Tuesday, at four, to a small cinema in the fifth with a cracked ceiling and forty people in it and a Charlot picture that everybody had seen twice. The seats behind the pillars were empty; in the third row of that block a bald man with a bad heart sat with his hat on his knees and watched, for a few minutes, the screen.

"It is not the film I came for," he said.

"It is never the film you come for."

"You are well?"

"I am well." Down on the screen, the little man was being chased by a policeman through a set of doors, and forty Parisians laughed, and the sound went up into the ceiling and came back like rain. "The film went out on the twelfth. It was confirmed on the twenty-first. Nine names, one page of a carbon, date stamp twenty-two twelve forty-two, and a pencil mark, three-vee-bee."

"Three bee." Lis was quiet for a moment. "That is a registry. The Abwehrstelle keeps a registry of names it has collected but not yet acted on, and the figures are the section that opened the file. Three-B is.. the section that deals with the east."

"You are telling me that a list of French names, in the south of France, opened by the section that deals with the east, came out of a colonel's private briefcase in Paris in December."

"I am telling you," said Lis, "that the war is being rewritten, my little rabbit. Look at the last three months. Stalingrad. Africa. They have stopped planning to win. They are planning to *hold*, and the plans are not in Berlin, they are in the field offices, and a field office with a plan is like a widow with a bank account: everyone comes to visit." He coughed, quietly, into his hat. "There is a courier leaving on the fourth of March for Warsaw. That is the last of the spring, because after March the frontier people are being reinforced; and after that, nothing goes out of Paris by road, everything goes by the diplomatic bag, and the diplomatic bag does not stop for me."

"Then whatever I take before the fourth of March is the last thing that goes."

"Good girl."

"And what am I taking?"

Lis watched the screen for a while.

"The safe," he said. "In the study, in your apartment, behind the photograph."

"Then I am going to need the combination and I am not going to be able to ask him for it."

"That," said Lis, "is why I am telling you in February and not on the third of March."

She looked at the light on the ceiling, thrown from the screen, moving, like water in a well.

"I need to tell you something," she said, "and then I need you to be quiet for a moment and not ask me any questions."

"Very well."

"There is a captain coming into his office. A new adjutant. Half Polish, from Nancy, name of Brandt." She kept her voice flat, and she kept her eyes on the screen. "I knew him before the war. In Warsaw. He is the brother of a girl I was at school with. He is nobody to me, and he is going to be a catastrophe, because he is the only man in Paris who can put my face to a Polish name."

The little man beside her did not move for a long time.

"Has he?" he said.

"Has he what?"

"Seen you."

"Twice. The second time was across a corridor at the Majestic, at nine metres, in a dinner suit."

"And?"

"And he gave me the look an officer gives his colonel's woman." She breathed out. "But there was a half-second in it, and I do not know what the half-second means, and I have eleven days of not knowing."

"I see." Lis put his hat on his head. "Then we must proceed on the assumption that he has not, because if he has, we are not in a film; we are in the rue des Saussaies, and there is no version of that in which I am able to help you. But Krystyna—"

"Don't."

"I will say it once." He stood up, hunched, a bald man with a bad heart and no coat worth the name, who had once sold books in a shop on the Nowy Świat and had been, in his own way, the best teacher she had ever had. "If he knows, then you must go to him before he comes to you. That is all. Whatever he is, he is a man, and men are rivers. You get there first, or the water does."

"It is impossible."

"Everything is impossible. That is what we do." He put five francs on the seat for the usher and looked down at her, and in the dark of the little cinema there was the ghost, for a second, of the man who had stood in her father's library in 1938 and argued about Chamberlain. "You have a face on you, my rabbit, and it is a good face. But I have known you since you were a girl with a ribbon, and I do not need to see it to know when you are frightened, because you have come to a cinema in the fifth arrondissement in the middle of the afternoon to tell me about a captain who speaks Polish. If you could not help yourself, you would not have told me at all."

He went out up the aisle, into the light of the doorway, and did not look back; and she sat through the last four minutes of the picture with her hands folded, and then she went home and was Marion Herschlag at the door of the apartment on the avenue Henri-Martin, and smiled for Kleist, and asked him about his son in Smolensk, because he liked to be asked.

♦ ♦ ♦

On the first of March, in the bookshop in the rue de Rivoli, René Tissier bought her a book.

She had gone in for the parcel of the month; it was a part of the pattern, a woman of her position had subscriptions and accounts and a shop she was seen in. And she was at the counter with her gloves in her hand when a

voice behind her said, "Mademoiselle will find the new Simenon disappointing," and she turned, and there he was: a small man in a good coat, with the eyes of somebody who has counted the change on the counter and decided it was short.

"Monsieur Tissier."

"Madame Herschlag." He took off his hat and held it against his chest like a man at a funeral. "We have not met since November, and in November you were unwell, and I have been carrying the burden of having caused it ever since."

"You had caused it."

"I had." He was smiling. He had a smile he had spent money on once, in the twenties, at a dentist, and he used it like a tool. "May I buy you a coffee four doors down, and apologise in the correct manner, which is with your permission and at your convenience, and in a public place, so that you are never obliged to be charming to me for longer than it takes to drink a cup of the horse they call coffee in this city."

There were a hundred reasons to say no. She said yes, because the first rule of her profession — the one Lis had taught her and the one Kraków had not — was that you always look at the thing that knows your name.

The café was warm and full and had one waiter, who was eighty. Tissier ordered two coffees, and then he talked, for four minutes, about a play, in the way that men of his kind talked: digressions, jokes, a piece of café gossip, one line of Racine. He was good at it. That was the thing that had made his sheet worth reading; he had a real ear, and he wasted it.

Then he put his cup down and said, "You are Alsatian."

"So everyone says."

"I did not say it as an accusation. I have a German accent in my filing system, and I do not know where you get yours, and the reason I do not know is that—" he made a small gesture with two fingers, "—there is nothing wrong with it. That is what makes it beautiful. Nobody in this city has an accent that is *nothing*. Even the Parisians have an accent. Only two kinds of people have no accent at all: people who spent their childhood being moved from school to school, and people who have been taught."

"Or, in the third case, people whose ear is better than your filing system."

"That is possible," he said, delighted. "That is entirely possible." He looked at her over the top of the cup. "I knew a little actress in Kraków. In the spring of 1939. She was nineteen. She had a mouth like yours — no, not the shape; the mouth of a woman who is going to talk before she has

decided whether to. And I have been thinking, since November, about the way in which you reacted when I told you so. You went grey. You went grey, madame, in a corridor of the Militärbefehlshaber, in front of a hundred people, and then you looked at me with your mother's eyes and walked away, and I have been thinking about it ever since, and do you know what I am thinking now?"

"You are thinking that you are making a mistake."

"No. I am thinking that you have not asked me not to say it again." He leaned back. "A woman who is what she says she is would have had me thrown out of the house for saying a thing like that. She would have complained to the Colonel. She would have asked what the words meant, in an innocent voice, so that I could hear myself explaining them. You did none of those things. You have simply — been careful. And so I have decided to be a friend, madame, and to say this to you today, in a warm café, in front of a waiter, at four in the afternoon: I am nobody's enemy. I do not inform. I have never informed. I am a man who is trying to be in the room when the war ends, with a well-known newspaper and a clean pair of hands, and I have discovered that the way to be in that room is to know which of the beautiful women of Paris are what they say they are." He picked up his hat. "And what I know is this. You are not Marion Herschlag of Strasbourg. What I do *not* know is what that makes you. And I am happy to leave it there, indefinitely, because a thing you do not know is worth more than a thing you have been told."

He put money on the table for the coffee, and stood.

"One day," he said, "I shall come to you with a favour, and it will be small, and you will do it, because you will remember this conversation: that I could have said it to a German officer, and did not."

He went out into the cold with his hat on. The waiter took the money. Marion Herschlag sat at the table for six minutes, and drank the coffee down to the bottom of the cup, which no Frenchwoman would ever do, because she was no longer thinking about how she appeared, and because, in the small cold part of her mind where the arithmetic was done, she had just understood something about René Tissier that she would need later: he had told her exactly what he was, and men who do that are either honest or frightened, and he was not frightened.

♦ ♦ ♦

On the eighth of March the Colonel took her to the rue de la Faisanderie.

He had been in a good mood for three days. There had been a message from Berlin about his section; there had been a visit from a Generalmajor who had told him he was being watched with approval; and in the mornings he had taken to shaving with the wireless on, which made Kleist nervous and delighted, because there is nothing so frightening to a servant as a happy German.

In the car he said, "I want your opinion on something."

"On what?"

"On furniture."

The depot in the rue de la Faisanderie had been a garage before the war and it was a warehouse now, and it belonged, according to the brass plate at the door, to the *Einsatzstab* something or other; Marion never learned the full name and never asked it. Inside, it was three floors and a courtyard of things.

Rugs rolled and standing on their ends like columns. Chairs in pyramids. Two hundred clocks. A wall of paintings, hung three deep, from which the mad, patient eyes of the nineteenth century looked out at nothing. Crates of silver in straw. Six chandeliers lying on their sides in a velvet bed, like enormous animals asleep. Four pianos. A glass case of watches. A desk that had a blotter on it still, with the impressions of letters in it, and a pen in a stand, and a pair of spectacles folded on the corner, and on the wall above it, forgotten, a photograph of a family on a boat, still in its frame, because the frame was not valuable.

The foreman was a German corporal of forty with a pencil behind his ear, and he took the Colonel round the way a head gardener takes a cardinal round an orchard.

"From the rue Copernic, Herr Oberst. From the avenue de Wagram on Wednesday. This is the lot from the rue de Bassano, which has been picked over, but the marquetry is good, and there is a buyer in Cologne for the clock."

The Colonel walked through it as though he were in a museum in a foreign country, with his hands behind his back.

"This is the greatest waste in Europe," he said.

"Sir?"

"Not this." He turned to her. "This. The collection. I have read the reports; there are eleven warehouses like this in Paris and the total is beyond calculation, and it will sit here for another year and then be loaded onto a

train, and the train will be *requisitioned*, and by the time it reaches the Reich, half of it will be stolen, and the rest will be given to men who have no idea what they have been given; I personally know an Obersturmbannführer in Kassel who has a Rubens in his hall he thinks is a copy." He looked at a chandelier. "The Führer has a plan to build a museum in Linz, and that plan is the only sane sentence in the last ten years, and it will never happen, because we are losing, and when we lose, this will all go back to the people it came from, and the people it came from will be dead. So the things will be in warehouses in Warsaw and Prague and Amsterdam for fifty years; and then some boy of twenty will open a crate in 1998 and find a clock with a note inside it, and there will be no one left alive who knows whose clock it was."

"Colonel," said the corporal, in the voice of a man who had been standing in the cold for eleven minutes and had heard enough philosophy for one afternoon, "the mattresses."

"Ah, yes." The Colonel turned to Marion and took her elbow, and he was, for a moment, almost gay. "The mattresses. My adjutant has reported to me, three times in nine days, that the mattresses in the officers' quarters are filled with wood shavings; and last night I found out that the reason is that the supply in the western sector was bought in February by a captain who resold it in the black market at a profit of four hundred per cent, and I intend to hang the captain, but I do not intend to sleep on filings, and there was a delivery here on Monday from a shop on the rue Saint-Honoré." He gestured with his stick at a cart. "Find me a mattress, madame, and be quick about it, and this will be your contribution to the war."

She went with the corporal to the cart, which was loaded with the household goods of eleven flats, and she looked, with a face of amused competence, at mattresses, and she found two that were good, and while the corporal made a note she went on looking, because a woman looking at mattresses is a woman who is not looking at anything else.

The cart stood by the wall of the courtyard. There were two bedside lamps, a tea service, a child's rocking horse with a broken ear, a box of linens tied with string, and, at the bottom, in a third crate, half buried, standing on their ends like men in a trench, forty or fifty books.

The silver had all gone from the crates. The china had gone. Nobody had taken the books, because books are heavy and worth nothing and there are five million of them in any city, and they had survived the sorting of three

flats, and lay in a heap in a straw crate in the rue de la Faisanderie with the rain coming down beyond the arch of the yard.

She bent down to look, the way a woman bends down to look at books in a crate, and she did not have to search for long, because it was on the top of the second heap, and because she would have known it in the dark: a slim octavo with a brown spine, and on the cover the faded gold stamping of a Polish title, and on the title page, when she turned it with two fingers, a bookplate: an oak and a river in black ink, and beneath them, in her father's hand, *Tadeusz Stanisław Stankiewicz*, and a shelf number, and a date in 1931.

Podstawy mechaniki — The Foundations of Mechanics. Third edition. There was a fold in page ninety, where he had stopped; and a pencil line in the margin in his handwriting, the small impatient line he drew when a student had failed to understand something; and on the flyleaf a small brown ring that she knew with her whole body was the mark of a coffee cup set down on a book in 1936, at the table in the Żoliborz apartment, on a Sunday, in the argument about the bridge at Ivangorod.

The corporal said something about the mattresses. The rain went on coming down in the yard. Marion Herschlag straightened up with the book in her hand, and looked at the door, and at the wall, and at the deep grey light over the roofs of the sixteenth arrondissement, and put it into her bag, and it was the first thing she had stolen in her life that was hers.

There was a packet in the desk.

It had been there since the third week of November, in the second drawer of the writing table in the small room that had been the daughter's, and she had found it on the fourth day of her inventory: nineteen letters tied with a bootlace, a certificate of the first communion of a girl with a name that was not on the door, and a photograph of two women in the garden of a house at Biarritz in the summer of 1925. She had put the packet back in the drawer under the blotter and had not written it on the list, and she had not given it to the Colonel, and she had not given it to Odile's channel, and the packet had stayed in the drawer of the writing table of the room of the daughter of the Vasseurs for four months while the woman of the house inventoried everything else in the apartment twice a week.

She was never able to explain that to herself afterwards, and the only explanation she ever found was the true one, and the true one was not a principle: it was that the drawer felt like a room she was standing in front of with her hat in her hands.

The bell rang at four in the afternoon of the ninth of March.

Kleist was out — he was at the rue de la Faine with the coal, and the woman who came in to do the floors had gone at three, and Marion Herschlag was alone in the apartment of the Vasseurs on a Tuesday in the spring of 1943 in a grey dress with the door of the small room open behind her; and she went to the door herself, which she was not supposed to do, and opened it on the chain, and there was a girl on the landing.

Twenty years old. A grey coat with the collar worn through at the fold; a hat she had made over herself, badly; a pair of gloves with the fingertips mended in a different thread; and the face of a girl who had been at a good school and could not now afford the shoes to go with it. She was holding a cardboard box in front of her with both hands, the way a person holds a box that has been carried across a city.

"Madame Herschlag."

"Yes."

"You are the German's."

The chain held the door eleven centimetres open. Down in the courtyard, the concierge was beating a rug over the rail, and the noise came up the well of the stair with the cold.

"I am the woman of the house," said Marion Herschlag.

"You are the woman of the house," the girl said. "It was my mother's house. There is a small room at the end of the corridor with the window on the courtyard, and the paper in it is green with the small flowers of the year 1902, and there is a mark on the wall beside the door where the handle of a trunk has knocked the plaster for twenty years, and there is a writing table in that room, and in the second drawer of the writing table, under the blotter, there is a packet of nineteen letters tied with a bootlace, and it belongs to me, and I have come to ask for it."

She said it in the flat voice of a person who had rehearsed it in the street.

"What is your name?"

"Odette Vasseur."

"Where have you come from?"

"From the rue Lamarck. I am with my aunt. I walked." She shifted the box from one arm to the other. "I am not going to ask to come in. I am not going to ask for the silver, and I know where the silver is, and I know what it has become, because a woman from this building told my aunt in January. I am not going to ask for the piano. I am only going to ask for the

packet, and then I am going to walk back to the rue Lamarck, and I am not going to be at this door again."

There are four seconds in a life of this kind, and afterwards a woman of that profession either remembers them for fifty years or does not permit herself to remember them at all.

Marion Herschlag took the chain off.

"Stay on the landing," she said.

She went down the corridor of the stolen apartment, past the drawing room where the marks on the wall still showed the shapes of frames that had been taken down before the requisition, into the small room with the green paper, and she opened the second drawer of the writing table and took out the packet of nineteen letters tied with a bootlace, and stood with it in her hand for one second, in the light of the window, and then she went back down the corridor and out onto the landing and put the packet into the hands of the girl who had made over her own hat.

"Do not come here again," she said.

"I know that."

"Do not talk about today in the rue Lamarck, and do not talk about it to the aunt, and do not talk about it in the street where you live, because there are eleven people in this building who watch the comings and goings of the door of the woman of the German, and because the concierge has a cousin in the police, and because if I am asked about the ninth of March by a man of the office of the German administration I am going to say that I was alone in this apartment for the afternoon and that I let nobody in, which will be the truth as it will be written down, and the two sentences are going to be in the file of the one building and there will be nobody to put them side by side."

The girl looked at her.

"You are not French," she said.

"I am a woman in a house," said Marion Herschlag. "Go down the back stair. The door of the courtyard is at the end, and the concierge is at the front, and the hammering of the rug will cover the descent."

Odette Vasseur went down the back stair with the packet of nineteen letters under her coat, and Marion Herschlag closed the door of the apartment and stood in the hall of the house of the Vasseurs in the middle of the afternoon and did the arithmetic that she was going to have to do for the rest of the war, and the arithmetic was this:

In the list of the objects in this apartment there is now one item that is not in the apartment, and the list is in my head and in the head of nobody else in the world; and the difference between a woman who steals the letters of a dead woman's daughter for a district of the organisation in a city in the east and a woman who gives them back on a landing is a difference of one item, and there is not one officer of the intelligence service in this whole city of Paris who is able to see it, and it is the only piece of arithmetic in my life in which I have ever chosen the wrong number on purpose.

She went into the kitchen and made the coffee that Kleist would drink at half past five, and when he came in from the rue de la Faine with the coal he said that a young woman had been at the door of the building with a box and that the concierge had told her, in his hearing, that the lady of the fourth floor did not receive callers.

"What did she want?"

"The concierge says she is the daughter of the doctor," said Kleist, in the ordinary voice of an orderly of the district, "and she wanted to know whether the furniture of the fourth floor was for sale, and the concierge told her that the furniture of the fourth floor belongs to the Wehrmacht of the German Reich and that there is no furniture in Paris for sale."

"That was very correct of the concierge."

"It is a very correct building," said Kleist.

That night the Colonel took her back to the apartment and, because the mattress was good and because he was a man who liked to consecrate an acquisition, he had her in the bed of the Vasseurs with her wrists held in one of his hands above her head, in the slow cruel way that he had, and afterwards, when he was asleep, she got up and went into the small north room and sat on the floor in the dark, and put the book down in front of her on the boards, and opened it, in the dark, to the page where a man who had been Professor of Mechanics at the Polytechnic of Warsaw had stopped reading in 1939, and she put her two hands flat on the paper and sat like that until the window went grey, without crying, for her father's sake.

In the morning she took the book apart with a knife from the kitchen, page by page, and burned the spine and the boards in the fireplace when Kleist was out, and kept the thirty pages with the pencil in them, folded into a small square; and went down to breakfast as a woman of the sixteenth arrondissement, who was the crowned jewel of occupied Paris,

and who had just spent a night in the house of stolen things and come out of it carrying exactly one page too many.

C H A P T E R F O U R

Five Minutes of Candlelight

♦ ♦ ♦

On the eleventh of March, at Mont-Valérien, forty-eight men were shot.

The placards went up on the walls of Paris at noon, white on red, in the places where the walls were smooth, and by three o'clock in the afternoon there were people standing in front of them in the rain: the ordinary French crowd, the grey crowd, reading the list with their hands in their pockets. Twenty-two of the names were Communist. Eleven of them were Jews. Fifteen of them were nobody, in the sense that nobody could say what they had done, which is a distinction that the red placards did not observe and the ordinary French crowd did not discuss; they read the names, and looked at the date, and one woman in the rue de Rivoli cried, and the crowd did not look at her, because to look at her was to be, for a moment, part of a thing.

Marion Herschlag read the placard in the rue de Rivoli at four in the afternoon, in a good coat, on the arm of the Colonel; she read it because he stopped and read it, and he read it because to walk past it quickly would have been a kind of comment.

She knew the list. She had read it in his briefcase on the Tuesday, photographing the names in the bathroom with the velvet curtain around her hands, and among the forty-eight there had been two that she had struggled with for a whole night: a boy of nineteen, second from the bottom, who had been the kind of boy who carries a folded paper in his

shoe, and a locksmith of sixty-one from Ivry who had probably mended a bicycle for the wrong man.

Only two, she thought. *Out of forty-eight, only two were ours, only two would be worse than the rest if I had stopped them; and the other forty-six were somebody else's, and I could not have saved them either, and the arithmetic, therefore, is that I have done nothing wrong, and I will be able to say that to myself in a very level voice for the rest of my life.*

She stood in the rain on the arm of the man who had signed the order, and looked at the names of forty-eight men as though she were reading the prices on a menu; and because the only thing worse than the arithmetic is the arithmetic with no feeling in it, she permitted herself, on the fourth name from the top, to have one small, sharp, entirely private thought that she would keep forever: *I have stood where you are, and I have not signed anything, and there is no one alive who will ever know the difference.*

"There will be a reprisal for this," the Colonel said.

"There is always a reprisal for the reprisal."

"That is not the same thing. That is the circle. The reprisal for this will not come from the Communists. It will come from the Gaullists, who have been waiting to be *given* Paris, and it will be a German officer in a café at four in the afternoon, shot in the back while he is paying for his breakfast." He turned away from the placard. "It is all arithmetic, and the difficulty is that the men who do my arithmetic for me are clerks."

They walked. In the car, going back, he sat with his glove off, drumming two fingers on his knee, and said, in a different voice, the voice he used for the things that mattered: "I have someone for you to meet on Friday."

"I have met everyone."

"Not this one." He looked out of the window. "Brandt. My new adjutant. He came to me on Monday. I want to know what you think of him."

"You never want to know what I think of anyone."

"No." He was still looking at the grey fronts of the houses. "I want to know what he thinks of you."

♦ ♦ ♦

The Friday was at the flat of a Colonel of the Militärbefehlshaber, a big dinner with too many men and three women, one of whom was the hostess and one of whom was the wife of a French industrialist who had decided, that winter, that the war was being fought in his drawing room.

Marion wore the black and the diamonds. She was placed, by accident or by design — she never learned which and it never stopped worrying her — at the corner of the long table, with the Colonel at the head and, on her left, the new adjutant.

He came in at three minutes past nine and was presented to her by von Reuth with a hand on his shoulder, which was a thing the Colonel did with men he had decided to keep.

"Hauptmann Brandt. Madame Herschlag."

She had rehearsed the moment for eleven days, in the bath, in the car, at the cinema, and every rehearsal had been a failure, because in every rehearsal something in her face did a thing she could not control. In the event, none of it was necessary.

"Madame," he said, and bent his head, and looked at her exactly as long as it took to memorise her face and not one fraction of a second longer, and then he was seated, and unfolding his napkin, and asking the woman on his left whether the winter had been as bad in Paris as they said.

She watched him for the first course the way she watched all new men: the hands (clean, kept, a bricklayer's scar on the left, from a fence-wire, old), the shoes (German, best quality, badly polished — a man who had someone else's standards of appearance), the way he cut his meat (fast, economical, un-German — a boy who had been raised in a house where food was quick), and the way he said the word 'Warsaw' when the Generalmajor's wife, who had been reading the wrong newspaper, asked him where his mother was from.

He said it in Polish. Deliberately, with a French flattening of the vowels, and instantly converted to the German form, and he did it as he was putting down his fork, without any expression at all. But she heard the softness of the 'w', the shape of the city in the mouth of somebody who had learned it on a street. His mother was from Warsaw. He had told them all that, and they had all heard the German name of the city; and she had heard the other thing, and now she knew, as she had known in the corridor but could not permit herself to believe, that he had grown up there. That he had walked it. That the summer of 1938 in the Botanic Gardens was not a thing she had invented out of a bad dream.

At the fish course she asked him, because she had a job and a job is a shield: "And do you find Paris endurable, Hauptmann?"

"I find it unbearable," he said, and the two women on his left laughed, and he smiled politely, and turned his head, and him arrived at her for the first

time: the pale grey eyes, the father, the heavy jaw of a man who had been hit twice in the face in his life, and something at the corner of his mouth that was not quite a scar.

"Unbearable?"

"I am told it is the most beautiful city in Europe. The difficulty is that I am not permitted to see it, and neither, madame, are you. We stand in rooms with mirrors and talk about the spring, and the spring is on the other side of a door that has a sentry in front of it." He drank. "And the food is better than Berlin."

"The food is a fantasy of pre-war France produced by the Generalgouvernement," Marion said. "It is the only joke in Paris that everyone tells and nobody makes."

He laughed, all at once, without any of the ceremonial reserve of ten minutes before, a short genuine laugh, and the laugh was the same. It was the same laugh as a boy of nineteen in a Botanic Garden in June, and she had to put her hand on the table edge and hold it, and while she was holding it she saw the Colonel watching her from the head of the table.

"It seems the captain amuses you," he said, afterwards, in the car.

"He is intelligent. You do not usually keep intelligent men."

"I keep them for their intelligence and I hang them for their opinions." He was in a good humour. He had won something at dinner; she never knew what. His hand came onto her knee. "Well? You did not answer my question."

"You asked me what he thinks of me. The answer is nothing. He thought about me for the length of one course, in the way that a soldier thinks about the wife of his colonel, and then he thought about the eastern front, and then he thought about whether it was permitted to smoke." She said it flatly, as a fact. "He is one of those men who looks past furniture."

"I see." He took his hand away. "And you?"

"I thought he had good hands and bad shoes, and I thought that when he laughed it came out of him all at once, and I thought that if you let him get near enough to be interesting, he would be a great deal of trouble."

The car stopped. He did not get out. In the dark of the back seat, with Ehlers still as a stone in front, the Colonel sat for a moment and looked at the window, and then he said the sentence that would keep her awake until the end of March.

"He has one defect," he said. "He is a Pole."

"Half a Pole."

"There is no such thing." He opened the door. "His father was German. His mother was a Warsaw woman; she is dead. He was raised there and he went to their schools and he learned their poetry and I will tell you a fact about the eastern front, my dear, since you have never had the good fortune to be shot at: in a burning village, a man runs toward the house where his mother was born." He got out, and held the door for her, and stood in the cold with the blackout lamps of the avenue behind him like two candles on a table. "I have known eleven men like Brandt in my career. Nine of them were excellent. The other two are the reason I keep a drawer of photographs of hanged men."

♦ ♦ ♦

The keys were the problem.

There were six of them on a steel ring, and the ring had a habit of coming out of his trousers and lying on whatever surface was nearest — the hall table, the desk in the study, the edge of the basin — because a man who has been an officer for thirty years takes off his keys the way other men take off their hats.

She had spent February understanding the six. Door, safe, desk, the drawer at the Majestic (which she would never in her life touch, because a drawer in an office is watched), the wine cabinet, and a small silver key with a worn shank that she had narrowed to one of two possibilities and would, in the end, never identify; and the important one was the fifth, the safe key, which was flat, brass, and worn at the shoulder, with the number of the maker stamped on it in a place invisible to a man's eye when the key was on the ring.

You cannot steal a key from a man who has it in his trousers, Lis had said. *You take the shape of the key, and then you go to a man who cuts keys, and you pay him an amount he cannot explain, and you never go back to him for any reason for the rest of your life.*

To take a shape you need five minutes and something the shape will hold. Wax is best; soap is possible; a potato will do in a war if a potato can be found. And to take the shape of a key that never leaves the trousers of a man who sleeps beside you, you need the key to be off the trousers, and the man to be asleep, and the room to be dark enough that he does not see the light and light enough that you do not press the wax in the wrong place; and the light was the difficulty, because the only light in the avenue

Henri-Martin after curfew was a candle, and a candle in a room where a man sleeps is a thing that even a man asleep will sometimes smell.

She waited nine days for the right night. A bad night was one in which he had been drinking (he slept shallowly); a bad night was one in which his leg hurt him (he woke at every sound and lay on his back with his eyes open, listening); a bad night was any night on which there had been a bombing in the east of the city, because then the anti-aircraft guns worked and Paris lay awake. A good night was a night when he had been made to sit through a two-hour briefing on the requisition of cattle, and had come home with the flat exhaustion of a man who has been bored by his equals.

The third of March was a good night.

He was asleep by eleven, flat on his back, arms at his sides, chin up: the position, the terrible formal position, and by midnight his breathing had gone down into the long slow shallows that meant he had gone over. She lay beside him and counted to one hundred, and then to a hundred again, and then she got up, and went out of the bedroom on the outside edge of her feet, and went down the corridor to the kitchen, where Kleist slept in a small room off the pantry, and where she had hidden, since the previous morning, in the cold box beside the ice, a candle and a cake of the wax the Vasseurs' housekeeper had once used for preserving jam, in a paper twist.

The candle stub was two and a half inches of the nine that had been on the dining table in January, and she had cut it down over three weeks so that it would not be missed.

In the bedroom she put it on the floor beside the bed, on the far side from him, and got down on her knees in her nightdress with her back to the wall, so that the candle was between her body and the bed: the whole candle, and the light, which was the size of a coin.

Then she reached up onto the chair, where the trousers were, and took the ring of keys by the shank, dead slow, and brought it down into the coin of light.

She had expected fear. She had not expected this: the pure, cold, enormous calm that came over her the moment the work began, which was, she understood later, the same thing that happened to her when she was being had by him, and the same thing that happened in Kraków in the room with the bad fire when she had learned to handle a pistol: her hands stopped shaking because there was no room in her for the shaking. There was a candle, and a key, and a cake of wax, and a man four feet away. That was all.

She warmed the wax in her fingers. She pressed the flat of the key into it, edgeways, four times: once for the shoulder, twice for the length, and once for the head, where the bit was, because a wax impression of a shaft is useless and a wax impression of a bit is a sentence. She did it with her thumb flat on the back of the key, breathing through her mouth, and the third press made a small sound — a click, the sound of two pieces of the world coming together — and on the bed, the Colonel's breathing changed.

She did not move. She did not take her hands away. That was Kraków, too: *when the animal turns its head, you do not freeze and you do not run; you become the thing the room already contains, and you wait for the animal to be bored.*

Eight seconds. Nine.

"Marion."

"I'm here."

The candle was behind her, on the floor, and the wax was in her left hand under her thigh, and the keys were in her right hand under the hem of the nightdress. His voice came out of the pillow, thick, at the bottom of sleep.

"What is it."

"Nothing. I was thirsty." She stood up, and the movement was one piece, and she put the keys back on the chair with her arm and her body behind it, and reached out and touched his shoulder with her fingertips, the way she touched him when she woke him for the telephone. "Go to sleep."

"Water," he said. "Always water. You are like a horse."

"I am like a woman who was born in a dry country. Go to sleep."

He was already gone; the sentence had exhausted him; his breathing flattened out, and she stood beside the bed for the length of a hundred breaths with the wax hardening in her hand, and then she went down the corridor, and washed her hands, and put the wax back in the paper twist, and put it in the cold box in the kitchen, and stood in the dark kitchen with the great cold of the Paris night coming up off the floor, and she had to put her hand on the dresser because her legs, in the end, in the aftermath, were the part of her that betrayed her.

Five minutes of candlelight. She had rehearsed it eleven times and it had taken four.

♦ ♦ ♦

The key-cutter in the rue des Hospitalières-Saint-Gervais was a small man of seventy with a shop the size of a cupboard and a smell in it of hot brass and onions. He was called Monsieur Kahn and he cut keys for the Marais, and he had cut them for forty-one years, from before the war that had made the street, and he had cut them during the war the way he had cut them before it, one at a time, and to look at him working was to believe for a moment that there was a France left.

Marion went to him on the fifth of March, in the worn coat she kept in the north room for the times she was nobody, with her hair under a scarf and her shoes flat, and she stood in the doorway and let an old woman with a basket go past, and went in and said, "I need a key cut from an impression," and put the wax on the counter.

Monsieur Kahn looked at the wax for a long time.

"Not today," he said.

"I will pay you eight hundred francs."

"Not for eight hundred. Not for eight thousand. Not for the Banque de France, madame." He turned the wax over with one finger. "This is a Mauer, forty-one, pattern three. There are two hundred and six of these in this city and they are all on the doors of people who have things, and a man who cuts a key like this for a woman I have never seen, in a year in which eight hundred francs is what a grave costs, is a man who will be standing with his back to a wall in four months, telling a Hauptsturmführer with good manners that he does not know the lady's name." He pushed the wax back across the counter. "I am sorry. The work I can do. The work is easy. What I cannot do is be a Jew in this city and take an eight-hundred-franc job."

She stood in the little shop with the smell of brass and onions, in the worn coat, and looked at a man who was in more danger than she was, and who had just refused her with total, unhurried courage, and she did the only thing there was left to do, which was to tell him the truth about one thing only.

"The key is a safe," she said. "The safe is in the study of a German officer, and what is in it is a list of men. I am not one of yours, monsieur. I am not French at all. But the men on the list are not French either, and there are nine of them."

He was quiet for a moment.

"How do you know there are nine?"

"Because in December there were nine, and in February there were eleven, and on the second of March there were fourteen, and I have not seen the paper since."

"Ah," said Monsieur Kahn. And then, as though a small complicated machine inside him had finished its cycle and dropped a coin: "My nephew is in the Auvergne. He has a shop; he cuts keys; he is twenty-six and he is stupid and brave and he has no children, and if a woman in a scarf comes to him with a wax and a story and does not give her name, he will cut the key by Thursday and he will be very proud of himself for a month." He wrote down an address, slowly, in a hand that had been taught in a school in Warsaw province in 1881, and tore the paper off the pad and pushed it across the counter with two fingers. "I will not charge you, because if I charge you I have to put it in the book. Go away now, madame. And when you are old, if you are old, do not come back."

She went out into the Marais in the middle of the afternoon. The street was raked by the wind, and the shops were shut for the two hours of the middle of the day when no goods were coming and no one had anything to sell, and there were chalk marks on the wall at the corner, and a man of fifty in a good overcoat was standing at the bus stop reading a newspaper that was three days old, and she walked past him without turning her head, and did not know, and would never know, that he was one of Kroll's, that he had been sitting at the café on the corner since eight in the morning, that he had written her coat down in a notebook, and that it would be four months before anybody ever read the notebook.

♦ ♦ ♦

The key came on the eleventh. She took it in the ladies' room of a café on the boulevard Beaumarchais, where the nephew had left it in a brown paper packet under the cistern of the second cubicle, and she put it in her bag between two folded handkerchiefs, and went home, and put it in the toe of a shoe inside a hatbox inside a room that the Colonel of the Abwehrstelle Paris believed was full of her clothes.

That night he took her to bed early and with a strange formal tenderness, and afterwards he lay with his hand flat on her stomach, in the position of a man who wants to know whether he has been told the truth, and he said, into the dark: "Tell me something."

"If I can."

"Anything. Anything at all." He moved his hand up, to the small of her ribs, and left it there, and she lay on her back and looked at the ceiling and understood, with a clarity that was almost unbearable, that in the last four months the possession and the need had begun, somewhere in him, in some cupboard where he kept his medals, to reverse their direction. "You have never once asked me for anything."

"What should I have asked for?"

"That is my point."

"I have a roof, a bed, a chair, eleven dresses and two diamonds. What does a woman ask for after that?" She turned her head and looked at him, and the terrible thing was that at that moment she could have asked him for the safe key, and he would have got up and given it to her, and that would have been the end of her, because the one thing he would never forgive her was the moment when the thing he had chosen to trust turned out to have been using the trust as a tool. "I have never asked you for anything because I have been given more than I can hold. That is not a compliment, Colonel. It is a confession. I am not brave enough to want anything more than this."

He lay quiet for a long time. Then he said: "I am being sent to Warsaw."

The clock in the hall struck two.

"Not for good," he said. "It is a command of the eastern sector, six months, possibly a year; there is a General who is a fool and a district that is the most important ground in Europe, and I have been asked for by name, which is a very great honour, and a way of saying that they have decided what I am worth. There is a house. There is a garden. There is a district with thirty thousand men in it and a river, and there is the other thing, which I have not told you."

"What other thing?"

"A reprisal," he said. "Not a small one. And when a reprisal is done, one does not wish to be the colonel who goes home to an empty flat in Paris and a photograph on the sill." He turned his head. "You will come with me."

The shop was dark at half past five.

She stood on the other side of the rue Cambon for four minutes, in the doorway of a leather shop, with the cold of the March evening coming up off the pavement, and she watched the window of the milliner's: the two hats on their stands, the second stand gone, the door shut, and the brass

plate with the name on it dulled as though nobody had touched it with a cloth since Friday.

Then she crossed the street and rang.

The door opened eight centimetres and a woman of about sixty with grey hair under a black scarf put her face into the gap, and Marion Herschlag said, in the French of a customer of the establishment:

"Mademoiselle Marchand is retrimming a felt for me. The grey with the Petersham band."

"The establishment is closed, madame."

"When does it open?"

"When it opens." The woman looked at the street over her shoulder, on both sides, in the way of a person who has been told to do exactly that, and then she looked at the woman on the step for four seconds, and something in the face of a person of sixty who has worked in a shop for thirty years decided itself. "The felt with the Petersham band is finished, and the felt with the Petersham band is not in the shop, and if madame will be at the church of Saint-Roch on Thursday at the hour of the evening, at the second chapel on the left of the nave, and will put her hand into the niche between the second and the third pilaster, she will find the felt with the Petersham band, wrapped in paper, and there will be no one to be seen, and there will be nothing said, and madame will pay nothing, and madame will not come to this street again in the month of March."

"Where is she?"

The woman began to close the door.

"Where is she?"

"In the country," said the woman, in the voice of a person repeating a sentence she had been given, "and the shop is closed for the month, and there is nobody in this establishment who is able to answer a question of madame's kind, and I am the aunt of the girl, and I have been in this street for thirty-one years, and I have a sister in the country, and madame should not be at this door."

The door shut.

There was a man at the corner of the rue Saint-Honoré.

He was about forty, in a good dark overcoat without any uniform, with his hat low and his hands in his pockets, and he was standing in the position of a man who is looking into the window of a hat shop that has a window full of men's hats and no reason for anybody to look at it for eleven minutes; and Marion Herschlag walked up the rue Cambon

towards the rue de Rivoli at the pace of a woman of the sixteenth arrondissement with an errand behind her and a car waiting, and she did not look at him, and she did not turn her head, and she counted the shop windows on the left-hand side the way she had been taught to count them in the long room in Kraków, and at the corner of the rue Saint-Honoré she stopped and turned and looked at the display of gloves in the window of the shop on the corner for eleven seconds, and in the glass of the window she watched the man in the dark overcoat come up the rue Cambon at the pace of a man who has nowhere to be, stop at the corner, look at the clock on the church, and walk away down the rue Saint-Honoré in the direction of the Place Vendôme.

She went home in a taxi with her hands in her lap.

♦ ♦ ♦

On the Thursday she went to Saint-Roch at the hour of the evening.

The church was cold and almost empty: two women in black in the front benches with their heads down, a man asleep in the fifth row with his hat on his chest, and a priest moving at the far end of the nave with a boy and a taper. The second chapel on the left was dark; the pilasters went up into the shadow of the vault with the smell of the cold stone and the old wax; and Marion Herschlag knelt at the bench in front of the second chapel for a quarter of an hour with her lips moving, and put her hand into the niche between the second and the third pilaster, and found the paper parcel with the felt hat in it, and inside the hat, sewn into the band in the way the band of that establishment had been sewn for two years, there was a strip of paper a centimetre wide and eleven centimetres long.

The paper said, in the tiny hand of Odile Marchand, in pencil:

The grey is finished. Wear it on Tuesday. The aunt is my aunt and knows nothing and is to be left. Do not come to the shop. Do not write to the shop. The man of the rue des Saussaies came on the third at eleven, with a sergeant and a list, and asked for the names of the ladies of the establishment; my aunt gave him eleven names and no addresses and he was satisfied, and he went away, and there is a second man who comes on the pavement and looks at the shop for a quarter of an hour in the evening. The paper of the department of the defence of the Reich of the month of November 1942 with the four names on it is in the hands of the office of the Sicherheitsdienst of Paris, in a file, in a room on the third floor of the rue des Saussaies, and there is a

question mark in the margin of one of the four names, and the question mark was made with a pencil by a man of that office in the month of December and nobody in the establishment knows the name of the man. This is the last band I shall sew. After the fifteenth of April the shop is let to a glover and I am going to Lyon to my sister, and there is nothing in the world that will bring me back to this street, and the two years of the bands are finished, and I do not want to see your face again, my dear, because I have grown very fond of it and I am not going to be able to cry about it afterwards.

Marion Herschlag put the strip of paper in her mouth and chewed it and swallowed it, in the second chapel on the left of the nave of the church of Saint-Roch, at ten minutes past six in the evening of the eighteenth of March 1943, and then she took the hat out of the parcel and put it on her head in front of the dark chapel, and settled the brim with her two hands, the way a woman does in front of a looking-glass, and walked out of the church into the rue Saint-Honoré with the hat on and the paper in her body.

There was nobody on the pavement.

♦ ♦ ♦

She told the Colonel about the hat that night, at the table, with the ease of a woman of the sixteenth arrondissement, because a woman of that profession never tells a lie about an object that can be seen, and because at the end of the second week of the month of March in the year 1943 in the city of Paris there was one hat in the apartment at 12, avenue Henri-Martin that had to be explained before the man of the house noticed that it was new.

"Odile Marchand is closing. She is going to her sister at Lyon; the shop has been let to a glover."

"You will find another milliner."

"There is no other milliner," she said, "and the women of this city have begun to look at the hats of 1939 with a knife in their eyes, and the hats of 1943 are going to be made at home with the material of the curtains, and it is one of the eleven things about this war that a man is not able to see."

The Colonel cut his meat.

"In Lyon," he said, "there is a depot of the administration of the southeast, and I have a colleague there, and if the milliner of Madame Herschlag

wishes a pass for the crossing of the line of demarcation, I am able to arrange it in two days, and it would be a favour done by me to a hat."

And she looked at the man across the table of the house of the Vasseurs, in the light of the requisitioned lamp, and understood for the first time in five months, with her body, the exact character of the thing she was doing: that she had spent the day in a church with the last paper of a network in her mouth, and that the man on the other side of the table would give her, for the price of a smile, the paper that would put the woman who had written it behind the wire of an internment camp in the department of the Rhône; and that the two of them were going to sit at that table for the spring and eat the food of the Generalgouvernement and be correct with each other in the way of two people of the same class, and that there was not one hour of it that was not, in the nature of things, a negotiation.

"No," she said. "She will manage. People of that kind always manage."

"People of that kind," said the Colonel of the intelligence service of the district of the army of Paris, "are the difficulty of Europe."

She looked at the ceiling, at the bandage of the curtain, and behind her ribs, in the dark, in the place where she kept the tailor's wife and the boy from the quai and the four words of Lis's handwriting, she was already doing arithmetic: two thousand kilometres, a city she was born in, a captain with grey eyes and a Polish mouth, a house with a garden and a district with thirty thousand men in it, and a list of names lying in a safe in the office of a man who had just decided that she was the only thing he had ever wanted.

"Where you go," said Marion Herschlag, in a voice that was, for the first time in five months, entirely and terribly sincere, "I have no other place to be."

He took her hand in the dark and held it like a man holding the rail of a ship, and she lay beside him, awake, with the duplicate key in the hatbox in the small north room, and the address of a key-cutter in the Auvergne burned into the part of her memory that never forgot an address, and she thought, with the flat and complete attention of a woman doing sums on the edge of an abyss: *he has decided to be happy. That is going to have to be my work from now on, and the work is going to be Warsaw.*

CHAPTER FIVE

What the Colonel Wants

♦ ♦ ♦

The château was at Chémery, twelve kilometres south of Blois, and it had belonged to a family of paper manufacturers who had lived in it since 1698 and were now in the unoccupied zone, if they were anywhere at all.

In the eighteenth century one of them had planted an avenue of limes half a kilometre long, and the Wehrmacht had hung them with wire because the wire was needed for the telegraph; and the wire had gone, and the limes stood in the March rain with their bark slit at intervals of a metre and their pale wood showing like bone. There was a gatehouse, and a pair of iron gates that worked, and a courtyard. There were forty-two windows, three of which were broken. There was a marble bust of a lady of the family with her hair up, standing in the hall on a plinth, with a German soldier's cap on her head.

And there was a party of fourteen officers and their women, gathered for four days of shooting and bridge, because the Reich had decided, somewhere in the winter, that its colonels should be provided once a year with something that resembled peace.

They drove down on the nineteenth of March in a convoy: three cars and a lorry, and the Colonel's Mercedes with a wooden crate of champagne in the boot that had come, Ehlers explained in an aside, from a cellar in Reims that had been visited by somebody's cousin. Marion sat in the back with the Colonel's map case on her knees. It rained the whole way. She

watched the black of the trees go by and the water standing in the fields like plates and thought about the fact that she had four days and the duplicate key in her hatbox at home and no way of using it until they got back.

"You are quiet."

"I am watching France do nothing."

"That is what France is for." He had his gloves off and was looking at his own hands. He was in an odd humour: he had been like a man carrying a parcel since the eighth, keeping something in view. "I was here in 1940. In June. I came up this road with the staff of the Sixteenth Army and there was a woman in the ditch with a birdcage and a clock, and she was walking south, and the clock was the wrong way up, and I have thought about her for three years." He turned his head. "The clock. Why would a woman run in a certain direction for three hundred kilometres carrying a clock and no food?"

"Because the clock was her mother's."

"Yes." He looked back at his hands. "That is what I decided."

The château had a west front and a park, and inside it was cold in the way that only French houses are cold, which is a political cold, a refusal. There was a drawing room with a parquet floor that boomed under the boots, a dining room with a table for twenty, and in the library, on the shelf where a book collector's glass case had stood before somebody took it in 1940, there were eight hundred volumes and a fire the size of a chair.

She was given a room in the east wing with the other women, and the Colonel was given a room in the west with the senior officers, and at eleven o'clock on the first night, after the bridge had ended and the last boots had gone up the stair, she walked the length of the corridor in her dressing gown with her shoes in her hand and came into his room and got into his bed, and it was the first time in five months that she had done it without being sent for, and it was, for the ninety seconds before he woke and understood, the most dangerous thing she had ever done.

He woke. He understood. He turned over in the dark and put his arm around her without a word, and she lay with her face against the shoulder of a man who had been at Verdun in 1916 and at Vyazma in 1941, and listened to the rain on the slate and the wood in the chimney making its small ticking conversation, and understood that she had just made an enormous deposit in an account she intended, eventually, to empty.

In the morning he said, "You will not be able to do that again. There is a Frau Oberst here, and she is the eyes of the garrison of Blois."

"I know."

"Then why did you?"

She lay in his bed with her hair loose on his pillow and looked at him, and told him, because it had the advantage of being true, and truth, in small quantities, in the right place, was better than any lie she had ever told.

"Because in Paris I am a woman in a flat that is not mine, and this is the first house I have ever been in with you where the door has a lock," she said. "That is all. I wanted one night in which I was not being watched while I was looked at."

He was quiet. Then he got up and did the thing she had not expected, which was to cross the room and fetch a chair and sit down by the bed with his elbows on his knees, in his bare feet, in the cold, and talk to her for an hour.

♦ ♦ ♦

What she received that morning, on the second day, was the inventory of a man.

He had been born in 1890 at a garrison town in Pomerania, the son of a colonel and the grandson of a man who had been ruined by the building of a railway. He had married Anneliese Vorbeck in 1919, in a church with a leaking roof, because the war was over and everyone she knew was dead, and for seventeen years they had been, he said, in his flat voice, "content. It is a word you will not like. Content." She had miscarried twice, in 1921 and 1924. In 1936 she had died of a cancer of the stomach in a clinic in Berlin over a period of four months, during which he was in a garrison in Silesia and was permitted to visit on Sundays. On the last Sunday she had asked him to take off his tunic and lie on the bed with her, and he had lain there in his shirt with his boots on the coverlet, and she had told him a joke about a priest and had fallen asleep holding his hand. He had sat with her body for forty minutes before he told the nurse to fetch the doctor. He had not, at any point in the four months, been able to say anything to her that he would have wanted to be the last sentence.

He was in Russia in 1941 and again in 1942, at Vyazma the first time, and the second time in the Crimea, at the siege of a place whose name he did not say; and in the second winter he had been in charge of a sector in which, over eleven days, four hundred and ten of his men had frozen and fourteen officers had shot themselves, including a major of thirty-two who

had been his student at the war academy; and in the spring the order had come for the treatment of prisoners, and the order had come to him, personally, by hand, from a General he had known at Cadet School, and he had passed it down the line without reading it.

"That," he said, "was the bad one. Not the guns. Fourteen men shot themselves and I wrote the letters to their mothers, in my own hand, with a pen, and it took me nine days, and in the eleventh letter I wrote the word *courage*, and then I sat with the paper in front of me for an hour, and then I wrote *duty*, and then I posted it, and it was a lie. It was not courage. It was a piece of paper in a room down a corridor." He straightened. "You will wonder why I tell you this."

"I don't wonder."

"You should."

"I knew a man once who told a girl everything before he had decided what to do with her," said Marion Herschlag, who was lying, "and it did not end well for him. You are not that man. You are telling me the things you would say to a priest if you were able to imagine one, and you are able to imagine one, because you do not believe in anything else, and I am the priest, and you have known that since December." She reached out and touched his knee. "It is all right. I can hear it. That is the only thing I can do in the world, Colonel, and I do it well."

He looked at her for a long time, in the cold room, in his shirt.

"I know what you are," he said.

The rain came down on the west front of the château, and for one second — one second only, and she never afterwards forgot the exact slope of the light on the floorboards at that moment, and the eight sounds of the rain, and the fact that she heard no sound at all — Krystyna Stankiewiczówna lay in the bed of an officer of the Abwehr and felt her whole body become a single sheet of paper on which something was about to be printed.

"Tell me," she said.

"You are a woman from a rich house that was broken," he said, "and you had a mother who was the only thing in your life, and she died, and after she died a school, and after the school a marriage of eleven months to a man who was killed, and then a couture house, and then a man of fifty-four who feeds you, who is not the worst man in the Reich, and who is going to die and leave you in a country where they do not know your name." He stood up, and crossed once to the window and back. "And you have decided not to be frightened of me, and you have succeeded, which

nobody else in this house has managed; and it is my opinion, madame, that you have never in your life told me the truth about anything that mattered, and that it does not matter, because you are the only person in France who does not lie to me about the war."

She lay in the bed and breathed, and the entire weight of the last four months hung by one nail, and the nail held, because five months in this house had made her very good at nails.

"There is a difference," she said, "between a woman who lies and a woman who is careful. You have a wife in a photograph and a war on the eastern front and a list in your briefcase, and there is no room in that for anything that is mine. So I keep what is mine in a small room at the back of the house, and I do not lie about it. I just do not take you there."

He came and sat on the edge of the bed and put his hands on either side of her face, and for a moment she thought he was going to kiss her forehead, which he had never done, and she braced herself for it in the way you brace for a blow, and what he did instead was to look into her with his pale eyes and say, in the voice of a man reading out a sentence of a court: "Then I shall not ask you to."

♦ ♦ ♦

On the third day they shot.

There were beaters from the village and two farms; there were three drivers and a boy of twelve who had been given a stick; there were fourteen shotguns and one professional, an Oberstleutnant of the Luftwaffe who had shot in Silesia before the war and shot calmly now, with a small head movement and a sound like a door closing in the next room. The Colonel shot badly and did not mind. His leg was bad in the wet, and after the first drive he stood at the edge of the wood with his gun broken under his arm and watched the others go into the second field, and Marion stood beside him in borrowed boots and a coat that had been the wife's of a French manufacturer, and eighteen metres away, in the turnips, a young woman in a headscarf was looking at her.

That was the thing about the third day, and it was the thing she thought about afterwards for years, in Warsaw, when the city was going up.

There was a woman of about her own age at the edge of the field with a rabbit in each hand, and she had been one of the beaters, and she was standing in the rain at eighteen metres looking at Marion Herschlag with

an expression of pure, unmodified, bottomless contempt. Not hatred. Hatred is a thing between equals. This was the look of a woman from a village twelve kilometres south of Blois who had a rabbit in each hand and was watching a Frenchwoman in a good coat standing in a wet field with the men who had taken everything, and who had, in that look, already written Marion off: not as a traitor, which would have been a kind of respect, but as a thing that had happened to France, like the rain.

Marion made herself not look away. She stood in the wet field with the Colonel's elbow in her hand and looked back at the woman with the rabbits, and she did it deliberately, because she had learned in Kraków that the one thing that must never happen is the flinch: *the flinch is it, my little rabbit. Any man can bear to be hated. What a man cannot bear is to be seen to deserve it.*

The woman turned and went up the field with her rabbits. After eleven metres she spat.

"What is it?" said the Colonel.

"A woman looking at me."

"For what?"

"For a Frenchwoman on the arm of a German," said Marion, with her mother's face, "in a village where the men are dead."

He turned and looked at the woman's back with an interest that was almost professional.

"Do you know what I would do?" he said. "If the war ended tomorrow, and they held a tribunal, and I stood in front of it, I would be hanged twice: once for the rifles, and once for the shoes." He held out his arm. "Come. They are beating the second wood, and if I stand here any longer the Luftwaffe will have all the birds, and I have not shot a pheasant since 1939 and it is beginning to look like a policy."

♦ ♦ ♦

That night, after dinner, he took her into the east wing.

The room was at the end of the corridor, beyond the room where the wives slept, in the tower; and it was not a room that was used, and it was cold enough that she could see her breath, and it had been the bedroom of the last woman of the family, and the Wehrmacht had not touched it, because there is no point in requisitioning a bedroom in a tower when there are forty bedrooms downstairs.

There were two wardrobes standing against the wall, and the Colonel opened the first one, and inside it, hanging in a long row under a sheet, were forty years of a woman's clothes: a ball gown from the twenties with the beading gone dull, a riding habit, a set of summer dresses in a blue that had faded to the colour of milk, a Russian fur with the shoulders rubbed bare, a black afternoon dress with jet buttons, and, on the left-hand end, four things that belonged to a different shape of woman entirely: a plain grey suit, a skirt, a blouse, and a dress.

He stood in front of the open wardrobe with his hands at his sides.

"Anneliese had the blue ones made here," he said. "In 1934. She had them made by a woman in Blois and then she had them copied in Berlin because she said the French cut was a lie that was worth paying for."

"Colonel."

"Put on the dress."

She looked at him. He was not looking at her; he was looking into the wardrobe the way a man looks into a well he used to draw water from.

"Which one?"

"The one at the end. The grey one with the belt." And then, because he was, in his own estimation, a man who did not make mistakes, and because he had told her in Paris that he would not ask her to open the small room at the back of the house: "I want to see it. That is all. I want to see it on somebody, in a light, on a cold night, in the last year of the war, before it goes into a crate with the silver and the clock."

She took the dress off the rail. It was wool, and it was good, and it was hers to take, in the way that everything in Paris had been hers to take for five months; and she went behind the screen in the corner of the cold room and took off her own clothes, and put on the dress of a dead woman, and it fitted her, which was the worst of it; and she came out from behind the screen and stood in the middle of the room with the candle-lantern on the floor between them, and the Colonel of the Abwehrstelle Paris looked at her for four seconds and then put his hand over his eyes.

"Say my name," he said.

"Friedrich."

"Not that one." His voice was perfectly level, and his hand was over his eyes, and she could see a man of fifty-three standing in a cold room in a house that was not his, in a war he had begun to lose, at the end of an evening in which he had drunk four glasses of a wine that had been the

château's before it was his. "The other one. Only for a minute. Only while the light is on the floor."

There is a place in the mind of a woman like Krystyna Stankiewiczówna where the arithmetic stops. It is not a moral place. She had walked past the placards in the rue de Rivoli with her hand on the arm of the man who signed the order and she had not stopped there. She had knelt on the floor of a bedroom with her thumb on a wax key and a candle the size of a coin and she had not stopped there. She had put a boy of twenty-three on a train of words and had gone home and asked an orderly about his son in Smolensk, and she had not stopped there.

She stood in a cold room in a house in the Loire with a dead woman's dress on her body and looked at the man who had told her, in a bed at dawn, that his wife had died holding his hand, and who had never once in seventeen years been able to find a sentence for her; and she understood that what he was asking for was not degradation. It was absolution. And she understood, in the same second, that she was going to give it to him, and that she would give it to him because it cost her nothing, and that the fact that it cost her nothing was the most frightening thing that had happened to her since October, because it meant that whatever she had been when she came to Paris, she was not that any more.

"Anneliese," she said.

He came across the room and took hold of her. He did it with his mouth and his hands and the whole weight of him, and it was not like the bed in the avenue Henri-Martin, where he took her as a man signs a document; this was something older and worse, and it went on for a long time, in the cold, against the end of a bed in a room in a tower with the candle-lantern burning down on the floor, and he said the dead woman's name twice and her own false name once, in that order, which she would remember for the rest of her life; and when it was over he lay on the bed with his arm over his eyes, and cried, without any sound at all, the way a man cries who has not done it since he was a child, and his shoulders shook and his hands stayed flat on the counterpane, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, in a dead woman's wool dress, lay beside him in the dark with her eyes open and did not touch him, because she had done everything else and that was the one thing she could not do.

At three in the morning she got up and went back to her own room in the east wing with her own clothes over her arm, wearing a coat that belonged to a Frenchwoman, and stood in the corridor for a while listening to the

wind over the limes, and then went into the bathroom at the end of the passage, which had a basin and a jug of cold water, and washed herself all over with a sponge and a piece of soap that was grey with age, standing in the dark, going over every part of herself, and when she had finished she did the thing she had done in the rue des Rosiers, which was to file it, and she filed it under the place where the arithmetic stopped, and went to bed and slept like a stone.

♦ ♦ ♦

They came back to Paris on the twenty-third.

On the twenty-sixth, a Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst came to the Hôtel Majestic on the avenue Kléber to audit the Abwehrstelle Paris, and his name was Werner Kroll.

He was forty-one years old. He was a small man with the shoulders of a swimmer and the spectacles of a schoolmaster, and he wore his cap slightly back on his head, and he spent three days going through the section from top to bottom, and he did it the way a man does a jigsaw, without any hurry and without any noise: he sat in a room with the files and the clerks and the duty rosters, and he asked three questions where other men asked thirty, and he wrote in a small notebook with green covers, and he did not raise his voice once.

On the twenty-eighth, at four in the afternoon, he interviewed the Colonel's household.

That was the word he used, the Colonel told her afterwards: *household*. There was Kleist, who was questioned for twenty minutes and came out grey and went straight to the kitchen and did not speak to anybody for the rest of the day. There was Ehlers, who was questioned for forty minutes and came out furious, in the way of a man who has been asked whether he has ever written anything down. And at five o'clock, at the end of the afternoon, in the small salon on the second floor with a table and two chairs and a window with the blackout on it, Marion Herschlag was interviewed for eleven minutes.

He stood when she came in, which she had not expected, and held the chair, which she had not expected either, and then he sat down opposite her and took off his spectacles and polished them on a handkerchief, and looked at her.

"Fräulein Herschlag."

"Madame."

"Of course. Forgive me. The forms here say Fräulein." He put the spectacles on. "Alsatian."

"By way of my mother."

"So I am told by everybody." He turned a page in his notebook, which was already full of writing, and she could not read it upside down, which was a small disaster and not a large one. "How long have you been in Paris?"

"Since the July before last."

"Why?"

"Because the money ran out in the east and my husband's family had a business in Paris, and the business was closed, and I had a friend who was a dressmaker." She said it in the flat, slightly bored voice she used for the story; she had told it to eleven people and it had never once been checked, because in Paris in 1943 everybody's story was checked only as far as the next queue. "That is it, Hauptsturmführer. I am not an interesting woman. I am a kept woman in the sixteenth arrondissement, and the only thing I know about the war is what the officers say over dinner, and they do not say anything over dinner except what they want the ladies to hear."

"Yes," said Kroll. "It is the same in Warsaw." He turned another page. "You were in the household on the eleventh of December."

"I do not know what I was doing on the eleventh of December."

"Then I will tell you. On the eleventh of December there was a reception at the Majestic for the officers of the Militärbefehlshaber, and you were at it, at the Colonel's table, in a green dress, and the Colonel gave a speech about the eastern front that was reported to Berlin." He looked at her over the top of the notebook. "I am not asking about the speech. I am asking about the twenty minutes between nine o'clock and twenty past nine, when the Colonel was in the courtyard with a General and you were in the corridor alone."

The room was quiet. She felt the little machine in her chest do its work, and she let it, and she did not fight it, because in Kraków she had learned that the body must be allowed to be frightened, in the place where the frightened thing cannot be seen: the hands, the inside of the wrist, the soles of the feet.

"I was in the corridor," she said, "looking for a lavatory, and then I was in the lavatory, and then I came out and the corridor was full of the wives, and I stood by the window for a while and looked at the blackout, and then I went back. That is the twenty minutes. It is not a good story. There

is no story in it at all, and if you have a man who tells you that he saw me put something in a vase in that corridor, then your man is lying to you for money, which is what men do, and I would like to know his name so that I can ruin him."

Kroll did not answer for a moment.

"I do not have a man," he said. "I have a schedule."

"A schedule?"

"In a building like this, everything is written down: who came, who went, who was at table, who was on duty, who signed the coal, who signed the petrol. So when something goes out of this building that should not have gone out, I do not need a man with an opinion. I need a gap." He closed the notebook and stood up. "There is no gap in your twenty minutes, Fräulein. I have checked them twice. Nobody came into that corridor while you were in it and you were seen by three people. That is why I am here: not because you are suspected, but because you are *available*, which is a different matter, and always will be, until I have found the actual hole in the building." He put his cap on, and adjusted it, and looked at her with the eyes of a man who had spent eleven minutes doing a sum and had got a result he intended to keep. "Herschlag. Marion."

"Yes."

"It is a good German name." He opened the door for her. "I shall remember it."

She went out along the corridor, past the photograph of Anneliese that hung on the wall by the door to the Colonel's office, and down the stairs, and out into the courtyard of the Hôtel Majestic, where the staff cars stood in a row and a sentry in a wet greatcoat walked his eleven paces and turned.

Ehlers was waiting with the car. He opened the door; she got in; and as the car pulled out through the arch into the avenue Kléber, she looked back once, through the rain-smeared glass, at the great grey pile of the building with its eagles, and she saw him standing at a second-floor window with his hands behind his back, watching the gate, taking his time, doing his sums.

And she thought: *you have my name in your little green book, and I have your face in mine, and only one of us is lying; and you are going to come to Warsaw in the end, because they always send the man who keeps the notebook, and when you come I will be somebody's kept woman again, and you will open your book, and you will read the name, and you will not find*

me, because the woman in the book has no second name, and there is no such person in the world as Marion Herschlag.

Then she put her head back against the leather and closed her eyes, and Ehlers drove her home through the blackout at eleven kilometres an hour, past the queues, past the shut shops, past the placards, and the wet streets of Paris went by her like the pages of a book she had already memorised.

C H A P T E R S I X

The Weight of Paper

♦ ♦ ♦

The Colonel went to Berlin on the first of April and was away for four days, and for four days the apartment at 12, avenue Henri-Martin belonged to Marion Herschlag and a fifty-seven-year-old man with two children in a photograph.

Kleist did not know what to do with a house in which the master was absent. He polished things. He took the silver out and looked at it and put it back. He brought the tray at seven exactly as he did when the Colonel was there, and stood in the doorway with his cap in both hands, and Marion understood, the first morning, that the tray was not for the master, who ate nothing but dry toast in a flat in Berlin, but for the orderly, who needed the day to have a shape.

The other thing Kleist did was to talk about his son.

His name was Heinrich. He was twenty-four and he worked in a graves-registration office at Smolensk, and his job was to write down the names of German soldiers out of the identity discs recovered by the burial commandos, and to match them against the lists, and to send the numbered, printed, official notifications to families in Bremen and Kassel and Breslau. Kleist had never in his life said the word "graves". He said *the office*. He said, *Heinrich has been transferred to a position in an office*, and it was the truth, and it was also that a boy of twenty-four had been given the job of writing the names of his own generation into a ledger, in a country where the ground was frozen nine months of the year.

"He writes that the typewriters are good," Kleist said, on the second morning, standing by the sideboard with his hands full of plate. "Model of 1938. Almost new. He says they have a *Kollege* from Stuttgart who was a violinist."

"Then he is well."

"He is well." He polished a spoon. "Fräulein. May I say something to you."

"You may."

"When the Oberst goes away, in this apartment, I have to decide where I am standing." He turned the spoon over and looked at his own face in it. "I have decided to stand here, in the dining room. If the Fräulein requires anything in the night, that is where I am."

At ten o'clock that night she understood what he had done.

She came down the corridor in her dressing gown, and the light in the dining room was on, and Kleist was sitting at the table in his shirtsleeves with the two photographs of his children in front of him and a book, and when he heard her feet he stood up so fast the chair went over.

"Herr Kleist."

"Gnädige Frau."

"You have been standing in the dining room since the evening of the first," she said. "For three nights. On a chair that does not belong to you, on a floor that is cold, in a house in which the man who pays you is not present."

"It is nothing."

"It is it, and it is more than I am able to carry." She stood in the doorway of the dining room in a dressing gown, and there was a thing she had not said to another human being since she had arrived in Paris, and she said it, in the flat, unpremeditated, unrehearsed voice of a woman giving an order to a servant, because there was no other way to say it that he would be able to accept: "I do not sleep either. If you are going to be awake in my house, sit in the kitchen, where there is a fire, and leave the door open."

He looked at her for a moment with an expression she could not read at all; and then he righted the chair, and gathered up the photographs, and went down the corridor to the kitchen, and left the door open, and she went back to bed and lay in the dark with the door of her room open too, and across the flat there was a small bar of yellow light on the boards, and it was the first time since Kraków that she had slept more than four hours together.

She thought about it in the morning, and understood that she had done a very stupid thing, and that the stupidity was not in trusting him; it was in the fact that in a house that belonged to a colonel of the Abwehr, and in a corridor between two open doors, she had, for one night, been a person.

♦ ♦ ♦

The safe was in the study, behind the photograph of Anneliese von Reuth in her garden in 1931, and the study was the one room in the flat with a good lock on the door and a heavy curtain at the window, and it was the room in which Oberst von Reuth sat in the evenings in a leather chair and read reports with a pencil in his hand.

She had been in it eleven times in five months, all of them legitimately: to fetch a book, to take him his cap, to sit in the other chair while he read aloud a paragraph from a Berlin newspaper that had made him laugh. She had never once been in it alone, and he had never once, in five months, been in it while she was in the flat and not in it with her; and so the room had, in her private map of the apartment, exactly the status of the locked room in a fairy tale.

On the night of the second of April, with the Colonel in Berlin and Kleist asleep in the kitchen with the door open, she did the arithmetic three times and then did it.

Barefoot, in a nightdress, with the duplicate key in her left hand and the camera in her right, with the door of the study closed behind her and a candle not lit — she did it in the dark by the window, letting the blackout curtain back from the frame by one finger's width, which gave her a grey stripe of Paris night the width of a knife, no more: enough to find the outline of things, not enough to read.

The photograph came off the wall with a scrape of plaster. Behind it, the steel door of a Mauer, pattern three, 1941, the size of a briefcase, set flush into the plaster of a wall in a room that had been built in 1904.

The key went in. It did not go in the way keys go in the films, with a click and a triumphant little music. It went in stiffly, half a millimetre at a time, and her wrist knew after four millimetres what she had spent three weeks and a wax cake and a stranger's courage in the Auvergne to buy: that Monsieur Kahn's nephew was a very good workman, and that the lock was a Mauer, and that a Mauer of 1941, pattern three, has five levers, and that

a key cut from a wax impression of a bit in a candle's worth of light will open four of them.

The fifth gave.

She stood in the dark with her hand on the door of the safe and her forehead against the cold wall for exactly four breaths, and then she opened it and began.

♦ ♦ ♦

She did not take papers. That was the discipline, and it was the thing she had been taught in Kraków in a room with a bad fire, by a small man with a bad heart who had once sold books on the Nowy Świat and who was at that moment asleep, or not asleep, three kilometres away in the fifth arrondissement: *you do not steal documents, my little rabbit, because documents are counted. You steal light.*

A camera with a flash is a grenade. A camera without a flash needs one and a half seconds of exposure in which the hand, the paper and the lens must be immobile, and there is no tripod in the world that fits into a nightdress; and so she did it the way it had to be done, which was on the floor, on her side, with the paper flat on the boards and the little camera braced between two folded corners of the Parquet, exhaling slowly, holding, and counting.

There were eleven papers in the safe. She did them in the order of a woman who intends to be interrupted: the smallest first, the ones that could be lifted with two fingers; then the thin file; then the two big folded maps, which she did not photograph, because two big folded maps are not a page, they are a problem, and the problem was for Warsaw.

It took her ninety-one minutes.

She learned, in those ninety-one minutes, four things that would govern the rest of her life.

The first was that the III b registry was not the paper of a list-maker but of a cartographer. There were forty pages of it, and the names on it — French, Belgian, Dutch, Polish — were laid out not by date and not by section but by *place*: a page per city, each page with a grid drawn by hand over a map, each grid square numbered, each name written into its square in three inks, meaning three separate hands, meaning three separate visits. It was, she understood with a cold, spreading horror that had nothing to

do with her own danger, a map of the underground of western Europe, drawn by someone who had been *inside* it.

The second was a single page in a folder of brown card, typed, stamped, with a signature she could not read, which was headed *Fall "Wotan"*, and which was not a plan for a fortress or a river line: it was a schedule. It listed, in columns, eleven towns east of the Vistula with the railway junctions beside them, and against each town a figure, and the figures were not men and they were not guns; they were *dates*, and the last date in the right-hand column was the eighth of August 1944, and under the table there was one sentence, in pencil, which she read twice to be sure: *Die Linie ist bis zum Datum ununterbrochen zu halten. Kein Rückzug ohne Befehl des Führers.*

The third was a personnel file in a folder of the same brown card, and it was thin, and it was the file of Hauptmann Phillip Brandt, born Warsaw 1915, mother Jadwiga Brandt, née Zaleska, deceased 1937, father Oberst a.D. Konrad Brandt, deceased 1939; schools: Warsaw, German-language, then the Technical University; the Polish army, evidently, in the autumn of 1939 — there was a gap of seven weeks in the autumn of 1939 in the file, and the words *in Ordnung* written across the gap in two different hands, and above them, in pencil, the letters the puzzle-makers use; and there, at the bottom, attached with a metal clip, was a single photograph, four centimetres by three, of a boy of nineteen in a thin shirt standing in front of a glasshouse, holding a closed book.

She looked at that photograph for a long time on the floor of the study of a colonel of the Abwehr, in the dark of the second of April, nineteen forty-three.

The fourth thing she learned was about herself, and it came upon her in the eleventh minute of the second hour, when she had finished and the papers were back in the safe and the safe was shut and the key was out, and she was standing in the middle of the room with the film in her fist and her body shaking in the aftermath the way it always did; and what she understood was that the shaking had come earlier this time, and had lasted longer, and that when the shaking had been at its worst she had stood in the dark of a locked room in a stolen flat with her eyes closed and had said, twice, without any sound, a name.

She had said: *Phillip.*

♦ ♦ ♦

♦ ♦ ♦

She met Lis on the third of April at four in the afternoon, in the Jardin des Plantes, in the rain, between the two long glasshouses, where a man with a bad heart could stand under an umbrella and look at the skeleton of a whale through a wet window and be, for eleven minutes, exactly as invisible as a retired schoolmaster.

"You are late," he said.

"I am being careful."

"That is different from being late, and you are both." He did not turn his head. In the glass the whale hung above them with its ribs like the ribs of a shed. "The milliner?"

"Taken yesterday morning. They took four boxes of paper and the coffee-machine, and there is a boy of fourteen on the street outside her door, and the notice on the door is in a hand that is not hers. She got a call out to me last night — one word, the wrong language — and then the line went."

Lis was quiet for a while. He had a way of receiving bad news that she had never seen in another human being: he took it the way a man takes a bill at a restaurant, by reading it, twice, before he says anything at all.

"Then it is finished here," he said. "Not the milliner. Everything. When they take the woman who runs the hats, they have the roads, and the roads are the trade."

"How long?"

"Nine days. A fortnight." He moved the umbrella to his other hand; his fingers were going white on the shaft. "They have a card index, and when they have a card index the arrests come in the order of the alphabet, because they are clerks, and the clerks work in the order of the alphabet; and there is a woman in Modane and a man in Annecy and a boy in Lyon who are in the same index as me, and one of them will be looked at by a man with a lamp, sooner or later, and will be told that his family is going to be deported, and after that he will be very, very helpful." He looked at her sideways for the first time. "You have the film."

"I have the film."

"Then do not give it to me." He said it flatly, and before she could answer: "Everything that comes to me now comes to me through a door that has four men on the other side of it by Tuesday. The film is worth more than the rest of this city's paper, and it is going to Warsaw in a coat, and I am going to tell you how, and then I am going to ask you for the last thing I shall ever ask you."

"Lis."

"Listen." His voice did not rise, but something under it did. "The registry. The forty pages, the grids, the three inks. Do you understand what you have photographed?"

"Names in squares."

"A map of us," he said. "Somewhere in the west there is an office where a man keeps a map of the Polish underground in France in forty pages, and he does not get that from interrogation, because interrogation gives you a name and a room and a chair, and this is *structure*. A grid per city means that somebody has been drawing our organisation the way a surveyor draws a hillside, from the inside, over years. There is a man at the top of that map, and he is ours, and he has been ours since 1940, and I do not know his face and I have never shaken his hand, because men like that never come *in*; they only go *out*; and when the film reaches Warsaw, the first thing they will do there is put that page under a glass and find him."

"Or her."

"Or her." He smiled, without any pleasure. "You are learning."

The rain came off the roof of the glasshouse. On the other side of the glass two hundred orchids of a dead republic stood in wet light; and sixteen metres away, on a bench, a German soldier sat with his arm round a girl of nineteen who was laughing at something, in French, too loudly, because the Parkordnung permitted it, and a man of forty in a mackintosh was walking his dog slowly along the front of the enclosure and looking at the small world of the Jardin des Plantes without appearing to look at any of it.

"The last thing I shall ask you," said Lis.

"Ask it."

"When you are in Warsaw, you are to do nothing."

She turned her head and looked at him.

"You will be inside the district staff," he said. "There is a colonel who will have papers in his house and a safe in his office and a General above him who says everything twice. You will be able to take half the German intelli-

gence for Poland out of a room in the middle of the night, and every month you are in that city you will be offered a moment in which it is *possible*, and I want you to promise me that you will not take it."

"That is a stupid promise."

"It is arithmetic." He was very calm; his hand on the umbrella was no longer white, and she understood that he had decided something in the last minute. "A courier cannot be replaced. A woman inside a colonel's house cannot be replaced. A film that goes out three times a year is worth more than a film that goes out in April and a corpse in a cellar in May. You will be in Warsaw for a year, and the men who run you there will be hungry, because Warsaw is where it is going to happen, and they will ask you for things, and I am telling you now, while I am still alive to say it, that when they ask you, you may say no."

"Lis."

"Say it."

She stood in the rain in the Jardin des Plantes with her hand in her pocket on a hatpin and her arm against the place where the film was, and she said it, because he had known her father, and because he had taught her everything she knew, and because she was never going to see him again and both of them knew it.

"I will do nothing in Warsaw until I am told to."

"Good." He handed her the umbrella. "Keep this. It was my sister's and it is a bad umbrella, but a woman with a good umbrella in this city is a woman who is noticed, and you have enough of that." He put his hat on and pulled the brim down, and then he did the thing she remembered at odd moments for the rest of her life: he put out his hand as though to shake hers the way he might have done at a bank, and then did not, and instead he touched two fingers to the brim of his hat, exactly the way he had touched it in her father's library in 1938, when he had come to argue about the Germans and had lost the argument.

"Your father's daughter," he said, "should have been born a boy."

"Then he would have been lonely," said Krystyna Stankiewiczówna. "There would have been nobody left to be a girl."

And Lis walked away along the front of the glasshouse with his hands clasped behind him, a small bald man in a wet hat at a quarter past four in the afternoon, and was at the end of the enclosure, and then out of the gate; and she stood under his sister's umbrella with the orchids behind her, and she did not follow him, and she did not look at the mackintosh, and

she did not cry; and eleven days later she learned, from a paragraph in a German newspaper in Warsaw, that a Polish bookseller of sixty-two had been arrested on the Boulevard Saint-Michel and had died in the rue des Saussaies of a heart that had been of no interest to anyone for twenty years.

He came to Paris on the fourth of April, from Nancy, on the morning train, and she did not know he was in the building until she walked into the archive room on the second floor of the Majestic at eleven o'clock to collect a box of the Colonel's papers that had been sent over from the map section.

The archive room had a window with a wire mesh in it and eight thousand files, and he was standing at the far end of it, in a captain's uniform with his tunic off and his sleeves rolled to the elbow, with a file open in his hands.

He put the file down.

"Madame Herschlag."

"Hauptmann."

"The Colonel's papers for the Warsaw posting." He indicated four grey boxes on the table with a movement of his chin. "I have been through them this morning. There is nothing in them but the usual: requisition, discipline, three letters from a General about a horse. I am told you are to take the first of them to the house in Warsaw with your own luggage, because the Colonel will not have his notes in the baggage car."

"That is what he told me on the telephone."

"It is not correct procedure." He said it without any particular expression, and turned a page. "Baggage is searched at the frontier by the customs of the Generalgouvernement, and a captain's boxes are opened by a sergeant who has been told the boxes are private, and a general's boxes are opened by nobody. But the Colonel is a colonel, and colonels are permitted one irregularity a year, and it seems that his is you."

She stood at the end of the table with her gloves in her hand and looked at him, and the room was very quiet, and outside the mesh window there was a motorcycle starting in the courtyard and a man laughing somewhere below.

"You have an opinion about me," she said.

"I have an observation." He closed the file. "Officers' wives do not travel with the boxes. Officers' women travel with the boxes, and it is always noticed, and it is always forgiven, and it is always written down. You will be written down at the frontier as *Begleitung*, which is a word that means

two things, and the man who writes it will look at you the way all of them look at you." He put the file on the table and began to button his cuff. "That is all. It is not my business. I am merely the man who carries the Colonel's papers."

"Then carry them."

"I intend to."

She should have left. She had been in the room for three minutes and she should have left in the first one, and she had a reason to stay that had nothing to do with her profession, and the reason was that there was something in the room that was not yet finished, and she was going to have to look at it to know what it was.

She looked.

He was standing at the table with his cuff half-buttoned, and he had stopped moving, and there was, on the whole surface of him, none of the machinery of a German officer. His hands were still. He was looking at the four grey boxes and not at her. And she saw, in the way he stood, that he had been standing in that room for some time before she came; that he had opened those boxes and gone through them one by one; and that the thing he had been looking for in them was not his colonel's requisitions and not his colonel's horse.

"You have been through them twice," she said.

"I have a great deal of time."

"You have been through them twice, and you have not been reading the papers, because the papers were laid back in the boxes in the order you found them, with the corners facing left, and a man who reads a file turns the corners." She put on one glove. "You were looking for something else. And now you are looking at me, Hauptmann, and you have been looking at me for five minutes with the face of a man who has a question he has decided not to ask, and I have decided to tell you the thing that every woman in this building would tell you, which is that I am nobody's business, and my face is my own."

He looked at her then. It was the third time.

It was not the look of a man to a woman, and it was not the look of an officer to his colonel's mistress, and it was not even the look of one Pole to another in a city of the enemy; and she had spent three years learning the whole catalogue of looks and she did not have a name for this one, and she stood in the middle of the archive room of the Hôtel Majestic with one

glove on and one in her hand and understood that in another second she was going to do something irreparable.

He said, in Polish, without any change of expression, in a voice pitched for the two of them and no one else, in the exact accent of a man who had learned the language in the courtyards of a city that no longer existed:

"Jesteś bardzo zmęczona."

You are very tired.

And then he picked up the file and walked out of the room.

She stood alone in the archive room for four minutes, holding one glove, and then she put it on and went down to the car, and Ehlers drove her home through the wet April streets of the sixteenth arrondissement, and she sat in the back with her hands folded and looked out of the window at the whole grey machine of the city, and did not cry, and did not speak, and did not once, in the four kilometres, think about the eleven papers in the safe.

♦ ♦ ♦

There were two calls from Berlin that evening, one at six and one at nine.

The first was the Colonel, and he was in the middle of a dinner and could not talk; he told her that the posting was confirmed, that they were to leave on the ninth, and that Kleist would travel with the household goods and Ehlers with the car, and that she was to be ready at seven in the morning, and that he had spoken to Ilse about her, and that the railway from Paris to Warsaw takes thirty-one hours when it is unmolested.

The second call was at nine, and it was Odile, and she used the word *aunt*, which was the word for *something has gone wrong*, and she used it twice, and she used it in German, and she never once in three years used German on a telephone.

Marion put the receiver down and stood in the dark hall with her hand still on it. In the drawing room the wireless was on and a German announcer was reading the communiqué: in the east, the enemy attack of the previous day had been repulsed; in Africa, the positions had been re-established; in the west, nothing to report. Kleist was in the kitchen with the door open, and the light of the kitchen lay along the boards of the corridor, and in the study behind the photograph of a dead woman there was a steel door with five levers, four of which had given, and in the small north room of the flat, in the toe of a shoe, inside a hatbox, in a bundle of

folded handkerchiefs, there was a roll of film the size of a thumb, with sixteen exposures on it, and the film was now the most dangerous object in Paris, because the man who was to carry it was dead, or taken, and the woman who was to hand it on had just said the word *aunt* on a telephone.

The parcel of books did not come.

It was due on the Thursday, and on the Thursday there was no parcel, and on the Friday there was no parcel, and on the Saturday morning the woman who did the floors of the apartment said that the shop in the rue de Rivoli was shut, and that there was a paper of the German administration on the door of it, and that the paper said nothing that a woman was able to read in the street because a paper of the German administration on the door of a shop in the fourth year of the war means that nobody in the street wishes to be standing in front of it when the car comes round the corner.

A parcel late by two days is a parcel. A parcel late by four days is a signal, and the signal was in the agreement that had been made in a cinema in the fifth arrondissement in the February: if the channel is not closed by the fourth day, the channel is gone, and the woman at the counter is to be considered as the woman at the counter, and the man behind her is to be considered as a man, and there is to be no enquiry of any kind made by anybody in the block of the rue de Rivoli for a period of eleven weeks.

On the Saturday the Colonel came home to lunch and was in the good mood of a man who has been told something at an office.

"Eleven," he said, at the table, with the arithmetic of an appetite.

"Sir?"

"The Dulag in the rue des Saussaies has taken eleven of them since the Monday. Two of them are of no importance. One of them is a printer of the rue du Temple with a wife and four children and a medal from 1916, and the printing of a paper of the resistance of the north is in the cellar of his house behind the coal, and my colleague of the rue des Saussaies will have it by the Tuesday, and he will be very pleased with himself for a fortnight." He cut the meat. "This is the difficulty of it, Marion, and you will understand it better than the wives of the administration: a man of fifty-four who has spent his life in the intelligence service of an army and has a war of Europe in his hands is required, by the arithmetic of the service, to be pleased about eleven men in a cellar of the rue des Saussaies, and there is not one man of the service in the German administration of France who is able to tell me what it is for."

"Perhaps it is for the paper."

"The paper is a page," said the Colonel of the intelligence service of the district of the army of Paris, "and the page is worth the four men who print it, and the four men who print it are worth eleven arrests, and the eleven arrests are worth the attention of the office of the Militärbefehlshaber, and the attention of the office of the Militärbefehlshaber is worth a line in the report of the month, and the report of the month goes into a file in Berlin where it is read by a colonel of the general staff who has never been in a street of the fourth year of the war. And the printer of the rue du Temple is a man of fifty-three with a medal from 1916, and the difference between his life and mine is one page of paper, and there is not one thing in the world that either of us is able to do about it."

She ate her lunch.

She asked him, in the flat voice of a woman of the household, whether the eleven included a bookseller, and he said no, the eleven were a printer and a man of the post and nine of no importance at all, and she said that she did not like the closing of the shops of the rue de Rivoli, because the parcel of books was late, and he said that a shop of the rue de Rivoli that was closed on a Saturday in the April of the year 1943 was a shop of the rue de Rivoli that had been closed by the administration for the sale of the paper of the black market, and that the wife of the house should send the orderly to the rue de Rivoli on the Monday and let the matter be arranged in the ordinary way of the office of the district.

And the woman of the house ate the meal, and drank the coffee, and talked to the man about the price of the butter and the question of the piano of the Vasseurs, and went up the stairs at half past two to the room with the hatbox in it, and locked the door of the room, and stood in front of the wardrobe with her hand on the door of it for four seconds, and then took out of it the coat with the film sewn into the lining of the right sleeve, which had been in the wardrobe since the day of the sewing, and laid the coat on the bed, and stood looking at the coat the way a person looks at a coat, and did the arithmetic of the eleven.

The parcel is four days late. The channel is closed. The cinema in the fifth is closed. The milliner is in the country, and there is a second man who comes on the pavement of the rue Cambon for a quarter of an hour in the evening, and there is an aunt who has been told to say what she was told to say. The bookseller of the rue de Rivoli is not one of the eleven of the rue des Saussaies,

and a bookseller of the rue de Rivoli who is not one of the eleven and whose shop is shut on a Saturday in the April of 1943 is a bookseller who is in the wind, or a bookseller who is in the cellar, or a bookseller who is a mile under the street of the rue de Rivoli in the hands of a man with the light over the door of the cell and the list on the table, and there is exactly one way for a woman in this city to know which of the three, and the way is a coat with a film in the sleeve and a hatpin in the pocket and a blacked-out city of Paris between the avenue Henri-Martin and the house of the bookseller of the rue de Rivoli.

She put on her coat. She put on the coat with the film sewn into the lining of the right sleeve, which she had done at four o'clock in the afternoon with a needle from the sewing box and eleven stitches, and she went out into the corridor and told Kleist that she would be an hour, that she was going to the dressmaker's, that the dressmaker was a woman of seventy and did not have a telephone, and that he was not to tell the Oberst on the telephone in the morning, because the Oberst did not like her walking in the streets after dark.

Then she went out of the door of the apartment at 12, avenue Henri-Martin, with the film in her sleeve and a hatpin in her hand in her pocket, into a blacked-out city, to find out which of her friends were still alive.

CHAPTER SEVEN

Paradise

♦ ♦ ♦

The word *aunt*, on the rue Cambon telephone, meant the shop.

She went there on foot, by the long way, through streets where there were no lamps and the windows were all blind and the only light in the fifth arrondissement came from the cigarettes of the men walking home before curfew, going past her in the dark like small red animals. Twice she stopped in a doorway to let a patrol go by: four men and a Feldwebel, and the Feldwebel was singing, quietly, in tune, and the four men walked behind him with their rifles slung and their hands in their pockets, and none of them looked at a doorway in the rue des Écoles where a well-dressed woman stood with a hatpin in her hand.

The shop with the green door and no name on it was shut and dark, and it was also open by an inch, which was the thing that told her everything.

She stood in the shadow of a doorway on the other side of the street and watched it for six minutes, and in the six minutes she learned: that a car had been at the kerb and had gone, because there was a puddle in the shape of a car under the streetlamp with the blackout ring round it, and a boy of fourteen was walking up and down in front of the shop, which is what boys of fourteen do on the orders of men; and that in the window on the second floor there was a light on behind a curtain, and the shape of the curtain was a shape that it had not had in the four months that Marion Herschlag had been going there.

She walked past the shop on the other side of the street, slowly, at the pace of a woman going home from an evening with a woman of seventy, and she did not once look at the window on the second floor, and as she came level with the arch of the courtyard next door she heard, from inside the shop, from behind the shutters, three sounds: a chair going over, and a woman's voice saying something in a level, reasonable tone, like a woman explaining to a tradesman that the delivery is wrong; and then the voice stopping.

Marion Herschlag walked home, and said good evening to the concierge, who could not hear German, and went up in the dark and let herself in and sat down in the hall on the chair where the Colonel's cap went, and took off her shoes, and put her fist into her mouth and bit it until she could breathe.

♦ ♦ ♦

She spent the next morning being a woman in a hat shop.

That was the discipline: she went at eleven, as she always did, and she stood outside the shop of Odile Marchand on the rue Cambon in the grey light of the fifth of April, and the shutters were down and there was a notice on the door in French, in a handwriting that was not Odile's: *FERMÉ POUR INVENTAIRE*. Closed for stocktaking.

She stood in front of it for eleven minutes, thinking, and the thinking was not about Odile.

It was about the film in the lining of her coat. It was about the fact that the man in the hat shop, the courier of February, the woman at Modane, the boy at the market, the man who had bought her a book in the rue de Rivoli, were now all of them, separately and in their own ways, aware that there was a different woman in Paris; and about the fact that Kroll of the Sicherheitsdienst had an audit and a little green notebook and a schedule with three questions in it; and about the arithmetic of what happens to a network when the woman who runs the hats is taken into the rue des Saussaies and given a chair and a cigarette and three days.

And underneath all of it, flat as a stone on the bottom of a river, was a second arithmetic that she was not permitted to do, and did anyway, in the eleven minutes: *she is thirty. She has a brother in the Auvergne with a wireless set. She has never once, in four months, asked me for anything; and the*

last thing she said to me, on the telephone, was the word aunt, in German, so that I would know what had happened, because she wanted me to run.

At noon Marion went to the Majestic, because it was Wednesday and she was expected.

She sat in the outer office of the Abwehrstelle Paris at the corner where the officers' women sat, and she waited for the Colonel, who was in a conference, and she was, for forty minutes, the most obedient piece of furniture in the room; and in forty minutes nobody looked at her twice, which was the point; and at the end of it, going down the stairs, in the middle of the flight, the Hauptmann came the other way.

He stopped. There was nobody on the stair between them.

"You were in the rue Cambon this morning," he said.

She looked at him. There was a landing light behind him and she could see nothing of his face at all, only the outline: a captain on a stair.

"I was."

"There is a notice on a door in that street, and I saw it from the car on my way to the arsenal, and there is a woman at a bus stop on that street who has been at the same bus stop for two hours in the rain, and she is not waiting for a bus, because no bus stops there." He was speaking in French, quietly, at a normal speed, in the voice of a man discussing a memorandum. "And this morning, at nine o'clock, three of our cars went out of this courtyard with an officer of the Sicherheitsdienst in the first one, and they came back at half past eleven with four file boxes and a woman and a coffee-machine, and the coffee-machine was carried by a soldier, and the file boxes by a clerk, and the woman by nobody at all."

So it was true.

"Thank you," said Marion Herschlag.

"Do not thank me." He came down two steps. "I am telling you because it is going to be known in this building by tonight, and when it is known I want you to remember that I was the one who told you at ten o'clock in the morning, and that the Colonel's adjutant does not tell the Colonel's woman anything without a reason." He put his cap on. "There was a man in that shop in February, in a brown coat, who bought a hat for his sister and paid with a note that had a number written on the back of it. I saw the note. He was a Pole; he had a Polish way of holding it. So when they take the milliner, they will have the note, and they will have the hat, and they will ask her for the name of the man in the brown coat, and there is exactly one name that a Pole in Paris would have given at a hat shop in February,

and it is not on the note, because a Pole who buys a hat with a number on a note is a man who has been told what name to give, and who is now, at this hour, either dead or in the Auvergne." He looked at her for one second more. "You have people who are in the Auvergne. Everybody in Paris has people in the Auvergne. Do not come to the archive room again."

He went up the stairs, past her, without touching her, and was gone around the turn of the landing; and she stood on the stairs of the Hôtel Majestic for four seconds with her hand on the banister, and then she went down and out into the courtyard and got into the car and Ehlers drove her home.

And what she thought about, all the way home, with the wet grey front of a city going by her at eleven kilometres an hour, was not Odile.

It was the sentence *I saw the note.*

Because the note had been in Odile's shop for six weeks, in a drawer, in a bundle of paper; and a captain of the Abwehrstelle Paris had seen it, and had stood at a counter in a hat shop and looked at a piece of paper with a number written on the back of it and had understood, in one glance, three things: that the man was a Pole, that he had a name he had been told to give, and that the name was not on the note. And then he had put the paper back in the bundle, and paid for nothing, and gone out of the shop into the rue Cambon.

Which meant that Phillip Brandt had known about the shop in February.

Which meant that Phillip Brandt had known about the shop, and had said nothing to the Sicherheitsdienst, and had said nothing to his Colonel, and had said nothing to the woman — for six weeks, and through an archive room on the fourth of April, and past a stair on the fifth, until the morning when three cars went out of a courtyard at nine o'clock and came back at half past eleven with a coffee-machine.

She sat in the back of the car and looked at the back of Ehlers's head and at the black trees of the boulevard going by, and for the first time since she had come to Paris, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna did the thing she had been trained never to do, which was to reason about a German officer from the inside.

Why.

The car went along the avenue Henri-Martin. The concierge was sweeping the steps, which was his way of knowing everything. In the apartment, Kleist had laid out her gloves and a note about the laundry. In the small north room, the hatbox with a red ribbon on it stood empty on the table,

and the film was in the lining of her coat, and the coat was on her, and the film was against her wrist, and in eleven days she was going to get on a train with a colonel of the Abwehr and go to Warsaw, and between this hour and that train there were the two most dangerous days of her life, and she still did not have a courier.

She got out of the car and stood on the pavement in the rain, and looked up at the third floor of the house where she lived, at the tall windows and the cream curtains of a room that belonged to a dead woman, and she made the arithmetic and got the only answer that was left.

She was going to have to be the courier herself.

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On the sixth of April she went to Saint-Roch, at the hour when the church was empty, and did the thing that she had been told never to do.

The drop behind the second column of the north aisle was dead. She knew it before her fingers closed on the tin, which was cold and had a centimetre of dust in it and did not contain anything, and had not contained anything for eleven days; and she knelt in the dark with her hand inside the niche for a while and understood, the way a woman understands the temperature of a house she has lived in, that there was no one left to listen.

So she wrote it on the inside of her glove.

Hats taken Wednesday. Do not go to the rue Cambon. The brother in the Auvergne must be told and must not travel. The shop boy knows nothing. The notice on the door is not in her hand.

Tell her, when there is anyone to tell, that the last thing she did was say the word "aunt", in German, on a telephone, in order to save somebody who was not able to save her.

She did not sign it. She put the glove in the niche with the dust and the tin, because there was nowhere else left in Paris that was not either a German office or a friend's coffin, and then she went and sat at the back of the church in the smell of old candle-smoke for eleven minutes, the length of one of her mother's rosaries, and did not pray, because Krystyna Stankiewiczówna had stopped praying in September 1939 in a ditch outside Otwock, and had stopped for a reason that would have interested a

priest: not because she had decided there was no God, but because the arrangement seemed unworthy of one.

Outside, the rue Saint-Honoré was full of the ordinary grey afternoon. A car went past with two officers in it and their caps on the shelf behind the glass. A woman was selling matches on the corner out of a shoebox. Two boys of eleven were doing something with a hoop and a stick that was either a game or a very small conspiracy, and a German soldier of eighteen sat on a wall watching them with his face, and looked, for one unguarded second, exactly like a boy who used to do the same thing with a hoop on a street in Breslau.

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On the seventh, the last evening, they packed, and she played the piano.

It had been the Vasseurs' piano: a French instrument of 1904 with a light action and a crack in the soundboard that came up on the second F below middle C, and Marion Herschlag, in the five months of her residence in that apartment, had touched the keyboard three times: once in December, with two fingers, in front of the Colonel, when he asked whether she played; and twice in the middle of the night of the twenty-eighth of February, when she woke at three and could not sleep and went into the drawing room in the dark and put her hands on the keys for a long time without pressing a single one.

On the seventh she sat down at it in a dress of her own grey wool, in an apartment full of wooden crates, with her wardrobe on the floor and the silver, which was somebody else's silver, wrapped in paper on the table; and she began, deliberately, with the thing she had learned at the age of nine, in a flat on the Mokotowska: a two-part invention, slowly, with the wrists flat as a plate, the way a schoolgirl plays it for an examination in a room with a photograph of the inspector of schools.

She played it badly. She had spent two thousand hours and eleven hundred francs of her mother's money, at the Conservatory in Warsaw between her fourteenth and her nineteenth years, in becoming one of the two or three best young pianists of her year in Poland, and she had spent the last three years perfecting the art of playing badly, and the badness was now so good that it could not be detected; it was a badness with a very particular smell, the badness of a woman of the middle class who had been taught by a nun.

The music went down the corridor, into the hall, out along the boards where a small bar of kitchen light still lay in the evening, from the open door where a fifty-seven-year-old orderly stood with his hands folded in front of him and his eyes closed.

She saw him in the polished black of the piano's cheekpiece.

"I am sorry," she said, without stopping. "I am out of practice."

"Herr Oberst's late wife did not play," said Kleist, in German, into the room, in a way that was not a sentence about anybody's wife at all. "My mother played. In Breslau. She had a harmonium out of the church at Zimpel, and it had six stops, and two of them did not work, and when she died in 1928 the harmonium went back to the church and my father did not go to the service." He was quiet for a moment, standing in the doorway. "It is a very good instrument. From a house in the rue de la Faisanderie, I think. The crate has the number."

"It is a stolen piano," said Marion Herschlag, in French, still with her hands flat, "sitting in a stolen flat in a city in its third year of being stolen; and I am a woman in a stolen dress being taken away tomorrow in a stolen car."

"Yes," said Kleist.

"Yet you stood in the doorway with your eyes shut."

"Yes," said Kleist; and then he went down the corridor and did not shut the kitchen door, and after a while she heard him washing the cups.

She sat at the piano until half past ten, alone in the drawing room, and when she was certain of the whole house she took her hands off the two-part invention and put them, without any transition at all, in the correct position; and for four minutes, in a requisitioned flat in the sixteenth arrondissement, on the night of the seventh of April, 1943, with a German driver asleep in the same building, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna played the mazurka she had played in the eleventh year of her life in a room in Żoliborz with her mother sitting behind her with a book that was not a book, and she played it the way it was written to be played, which is not beautifully: with the tempo of a thing being remembered.

Then she stopped, and closed the lid over the keys, and went to bed, and did not sleep.

In the morning, in the wardrobe, under the row of eleven dresses that she had been given and could not take with her, she took down the twelfth: the pale dove-coloured thing with the wide collar, the one she had never worn because of what was in the lining. She stood with it over her arm for a full minute by the empty crates; and then, because it was a dress and she

was not able to leave it in a flat for the next German woman, and because there was a trunk going to Warsaw with the Colonel's papers and the winter coats in it, she folded it, with two sheets of tissue paper, and put it in the trunk, on the bottom, under everything.

The film went out of Paris on the eighth of April in the lining of a coat belonging to a civilian employee of the Wehrmacht, a woman called Marion Herschlag, travelling in a first-class carriage of the night train with a colonel, a captain, a driver, a crate of the Colonel's papers and two suitcases; and it went out because of a trick so simple that she laughed, once, out loud, in the bathroom of the flat on the evening before, with the door shut and the tap running, when she thought of it.

The trick was to put the film on a coat-hanger.

The frontier at Forbach takes six hours, and in those six hours every piece of luggage in the train is taken off and put on a table in a shed and opened by two men in grey; and the train in which a colonel of the Abwehr travels is not searched, because the men in grey are customs men and the colonel is a colonel. But the Colonel had told her, in Berlin-accented French, in the car the week before, while explaining to her what she must expect: *I will be looked at on the platform by the district staff; there will be a formality; you will wait in the carriage with the captain, and mind that nobody in that shed decides to be a hero.*

And so on the eighth of April, in the corridor of a first-class carriage of the night train from the Gare de l'Est, at fifteen minutes before midnight, a woman in a good coat handed her coat to a captain of the Abwehr and asked him to hang it up for her, and the captain hung the coat in the compartment in which the Colonel would ride, over a leather valise, in the third position from the window; and the two men in grey who walked down the platform at Forbach at three in the morning looked through the windows of that carriage and saw a colonel asleep with his mouth open and a woman asleep with her head on his shoulder and a captain in the corridor reading a newspaper; and they saluted the carriage and went on the platform, and did not open the door, because a colonel's belongings are private, and the coat hung inside the compartment all the way to Warsaw with the film in the sleeve, and nobody in the world ever touched it but the woman who had sewn it.

She had arranged it. It was not a trick, in the end. It was a ledger, and she had balanced it: the film went out because a colonel trusted a woman, and the woman had spent five months buying that trust with everything she

had; and in the sleeve of the coat there were sixteen exposures containing the plan of the underground of half of Europe, a page about a line on the Vistula that was to be held until the eighth of August 1944, and the personnel file of the man who hung it up.

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The platform at the Gare de l'Est was long and dark and smelled of coal smoke and wet wool and oranges, which was the smell of Paris in the spring of the fourth year of the war, because the oranges were for the officers' cars and had come from Spain by arrangement with a government in Madrid.

Ehlers put the Colonel's boxes in the van with the marks on them and stood by the carriage with the rain on his shoulders. Kleist had taken the household goods on Tuesday: he had gone at dawn with the crates and the crate of the stolen piano; he had shaken her hand for the first time in six months, and had said, in German, in the middle of the platform, *I shall see you in a garden, gnädige Frau*, which was the loose and terrible sentence of a man whose whole life was arranged in offices.

The Colonel came along the platform with the district staff of the eastern command, who had been at the barrier to do him honour: a General, two Obersts, an Oberstleutnant with a chest like a small balcony. They walked with their hands behind their backs, slowly, in the way of men who have not paid for a railway ticket since 1939. Marion stood at the door of the carriage in her good coat with the film in the sleeve, and watched them come, and understood that her life was now this: a woman standing at a carriage door in the middle of a landscape of uniforms, with a face on, being looked at by men who thought she belonged to one of them.

Twenty metres away, by the bookstall, with the rain coming down through the gap in the roof of the station, stood René Tissier.

He had his hat in his hands. He was wearing the same good coat with the collar turned up, and he was not looking at the General, and he was not looking at the Colonel; he was looking at her, and when he was sure of her eyes on him, he did the thing that Krystyna Stankiewiczówna carried with her into the Generalgouvernement and thought about, on and off, for the sixteen months that followed, in bed, in corridors, and once in a cellar in the burning city with the shells coming down on the roofs above her.

He raised his hat.

Not far. A small movement, two fingers on the brim, the way a Frenchman salutes a woman he knows at a distance; and with it, exactly one nod of the head; and then he turned and walked off along the dark of the platform and was gone.

It was a farewell, and it was a compliment, and it was a threat, and she never learned which of the three he had meant, and she never saw him again in Paris.

The Colonel came up and took her elbow.

"Ready?"

"Yes."

"Thirty-one hours." He looked along the train with the pleasure of a man who had been given an assignment and a railway timetable, and put his hand on the back of her neck, in the middle of the platform, in front of the General, and left it there while he said something to the Oberst about the coal situation in the east; and she stood with the film against her wrist and the rain on her face, and looked at the last two hundred metres of Paris that she was ever to see: the dark arches, the lamps with their blackout hoods, a boy with a trolley of mail, a woman in a headscarf saying goodbye to a soldier through a window, and beyond the barrier, forty metres away, a crowd of Parisians waiting for news of a train from the east that had been delayed, standing in the rain under an umbrella of umbrellas, silent, grey, and alive.

She stayed awake for the last night, lying beside the Colonel in a first-class compartment between Frankfurt and Breslau, with the dark of Germany going by outside and the train making the long, patient, four-beat sound that it makes between sleepers, and his hand on her hip, warm, proprietary, even in his sleep.

Her whole body ached. There was an ache in her left wrist from the seam of the coat, and an ache behind her eyes from eleven nights of four hours, and an ache in the bones of her face from holding it still for three years; and under the ache there was something else, something that she had not felt since she was twenty-two and had stood in a doorway in Warsaw in September 1939 with a suitcase in her hand and a paper in her pocket and no idea in the world where her father was: the flat, enormous, unmistakable feeling of a plan working.

Paradise was what the men in the room in Kraków had called it, when they had taught her the last and worst of the four rules, the rule they saved

for the women who got through the first three. *If you are ever, in your service, given a place in the household of an enemy; if you are ever in a room where no other person on earth can go; if you are ever trusted by one of them, then you will have arrived at the state for which we use the word paradise, and I want you to remember the other meaning of the word, which is the one they put on the sign at the door: the garden from which there is no coming back.*

At four in the morning, in the dark of a carriage on the way to Warsaw with her hand in the hand of a man who had told her that he wanted to be buried in her, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna lay awake and did the four questions for the last morning in Paris, in order, one at a time, the whole set, properly, the way she had done them every day for five months.

Who has seen me where I should not have been.

A boy in a cinema in the fifth arrondissement, who is dead. A key-cutter in the Marais, who will not speak; a nephew in the Auvergne, who will speak, sooner or later, and will be believed by nobody. Tissier, who saw my face in a corridor and holds it in a drawer. A woman called Odile Marchand, in a chair, in the rue des Saussaies.

Who has heard me say something I should not have said.

Nobody. In eleven days I said one word in Polish, on a quai of the Seine in January and in a stairwell of the Majestic yesterday, and each time the man was the same man, and the man is the file in the fourth paper in the safe.

Who has seen my hands.

The key-cutter. A wax cake. A camera in a corner of green velvet in a bathroom in the sixteenth arrondissement; and, at four o'clock on the fifth of April, a captain on a stair who told the truth to a woman in a corridor for no reason that a captain of the Abwehr could ever have explained.

And the last one, the one she did not permit herself to do in daylight:

Who has seen the inside of my head.

And in the dark of the carriage, going east, with the whole machine of the Reich clanking around them through the forests of Silesia, she lay still and looked at the ceiling of a railway carriage and answered the question, honestly, for the first time in three years, and the answer was this:

A man on a stair, who knows what I am, and who has said nothing to anyone, and who is going to Warsaw with me on the same train.

The train slowed. Somewhere in the dark outside the window there were rails and sidings and men with lamps, and the carriage swayed, and the

Colonel's hand tightened on her hip for a second and then loosened, and he said, in his sleep, in German, a word she chose not to hear.

And at eleven o'clock the following morning, the locomotive came down off the long embankment into the eastern suburbs of a city she had not seen since the winter of 1939, and she smelled it before she saw it, because the train smelled it, and men in the corridor covered their mouths with their handkerchiefs, and the Colonel woke and looked out of the window and said, without any expression at all:

"There. That is our district. That is the smoke of the ghetto."

And Warsaw came towards her out of the flat grey morning: the broken roofs, the church spires standing above the burned squares, the river, and the two hundred thousand people who were still alive in it, who were not permitted to buy a railway ticket, who went to work, who queued for bread, who wrote letters to London on cigarette paper, and in one of the station canteens a woman in a Wehrmacht clerk's uniform was signing for the storage of a crate of papers, and did not yet know that the film in the sleeve of her coat was the first of the things that would kill her.

CHAPTER EIGHT

The Transfer

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Warsaw came to her in the wrong order, the way a face comes back in the wrong order after eleven years: not the streets, which she knew by heart, and not the sky, which was the flat white sky of the Mazovian plain, but the sound.

The sound was a tramline being repaired.

They had come down off the long embankment that carries the line in from the west, past the yards and the water tower and the sheds that had been shelled in 1939 and had never been repaired; and then the train was slowing into the city, and she heard it: the ring of a hammer on a steel rail, in a long irregular sequence, two men and a sleeper, in the middle of a war, in the middle of a Tuesday morning. It was a sound from her childhood. It was the sound of every summer of her girlhood, in the city, and it meant nothing to the Colonel — who had turned the page of a report on the seat beside her and said, "We are here" — and it meant everything to Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, who sat with her hands folded in the sleeve of a coat with a film in it, and did not let her face move, and listened to a hammer on a railway sleeper like a woman listening to her own life being nailed down.

The station was the Warsaw Główny: a big grey hall with a glass roof that had two hundred panes missing, and a platform that was one third German — the Feldgendarmerie with their gorgets, the district staff, a general in a car with a flag, the smell of coal and soup — and two thirds

Polish, which had been compressed into the far end, beyond a barrier, and which was silent. There were notices in two languages. There were two hundreds of people standing in the far part of the platform with their parcels, waiting for the trains that stopped at the sidings and the trains that did not; and there were German soldiers writing at a table under a lamp, and there was a woman in a brown coat being asked for her papers by a Feldwebel of twenty-five, and there was a boy of about fourteen on the far side of the barrier, looking through it at the German platform with a stillness that was entirely political.

The Colonel was received by an Oberstleutnant with a clipboard and a Hauptmann with a car; there was a small ceremony at the door of the carriage, which consisted of three sentences and a handshake; and then the car took them out of the station through the north side, and Warsaw began.

The first three hundred metres were the station district: the sheds, the coal heaps, the wooden barracks of the Organisation Todt, the great brick building of the waterworks with its roof broken open to the sky and its pumps working in the middle of the ruin, because the pumps had been repaired in 1940 by Polish workmen under a German foreman, and were, in the third year of the occupation, still pumping; and then the car turned into the streets.

She had known it. That was the fact around which she had built her breathing all morning, and the fact did not help her, because knowledge and seeing are two different rooms of one house.

The streets on the north side of the city had been walled off, and the car went along the wall at eleven kilometres an hour, because there were carts and horses and pedestrians in the road, and the Colonel sat back and looked out at the wall with the expression of a man inspecting a boundary he had been told about in a memorandum.

"It is the ghetto," he said. "In April we are going to clear it. There is a plan, and it is not a good plan, but it is a plan," and he said it the way he said everything: level, and final, and with the tone of a man for whom a thing that is written in a memorandum has already stopped being a thing and become a duty; and she sat beside him with her hands folded and looked at the wall.

She looked at it for eleven hundred metres and she saw: the brick wall with its coping and its wire, three and a half metres high; a pair of boots standing under a coat with nobody inside it, hung on the coping at a doorway,

with a belt, and the belt was a good belt, and somebody had taken the boots; two children sitting on a stone by a gateway in the wall with their hands in their laps, doing nothing, in the middle of the day; a woman on the other side, and a woman on this side, standing at a gap in a brickwork, talking through it quickly in low voices in Polish about a parcel going out; a death-notice pasted on the wall, in Polish, a small black-trimmed paper with a photograph of a man of sixty and a paragraph under it, and the death-notice was from inside the wall and it was pasted on the outside of the wall, where the Germans could see it, and nobody had torn it down; and the ghetto wall was the wall of a city that was dying in front of the whole world, and everyone had agreed about it, and the charade was so complete that the wall itself was a piece of the agreement; and she sat in a car with a colonel of the Abwehr at eleven kilometres an hour and watched it, and did the arithmetic, and the arithmetic was this: *if I move my little finger now, today, here, I am dead, and no one will know why, and the film will go into a German safe, and Odile Marchand will have said the word "aunt", in German, on a telephone, in order to save somebody who was not able to save her, and it will turn out that she saved nobody.*

So she did not move her little finger. She looked at the wall and listened to the Colonel and folded her hands, and when he said, "You are quiet," she said, "It is a great deal of ruin," and he nodded, with a certain satisfaction, because a great deal of ruin was exactly what he had been assigned, and it had been assigned to him because he was the sort of man who could be trusted with it.

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The house was on the Mokotowska, on the German side of the city, and it stood behind a garden with a gate and a chestnut tree, and it had been built in 1911 by a doctor who had taken the advice of a French architect and gone to Zoppot for the summer every year of his life; and it had been taken by the district administration in 1940, and had been used by a General of the Luftwaffe for two years, and the General had gone to Italy, and there had been a smell of German soap in the bathroom and German filing in the study and nothing else in it at all; and the district had given it, with the garden and the staff, to the new intelligence chief.

It had five rooms down and four up. There was a drawing room with a piano — an upright, German, 1898, with a good action and a bad bass —

and a dining room with a long table, a study with a desk and a bookcase and a safe that had been installed by the Organisation Todt in 1939, and a kitchen with a huge iron stove and a copper for the laundry; and it had a garden with two chestnuts and a walnut, and a side gate that went through into the yard of a block in the next street, and that gate was, for the sixteen months to come, the most important object in Krystyna Stankiewiczówna's whole inventory of the world.

The staff were a family.

That was the arrangement she had been told about on the train, in the way that German administration explained everything, which was by telling it as a piece of the assignment: *the house has Polish staff; they have been there since the General, and the district keeps them because they are clean and the woman cooks, and the husband keeps the garden and the furnace and the boiler; and one of them is from the old staff of the house and I am told is a good sort of man, for a Pole. I do not want them replaced, because a Pole who has been in the house for three years is a Pole whose habits I know, and a Pole I do not know is a Pole I have to watch; and so you will be civil to them, and they will be civil to you, and no one will say anything that matters.*

The woman was Anna Zaleska: fifty, heavy, with a face like a good loaf of bread, a widow's black in her dress, a woman who cooked German food with Polish hands and had a way of moving through a room with her shoulders slightly forward as though she were always carrying something; and the man was Piotr Zaleski: sixty-one, one ear, kept the furnace and the garden and the boiler, and had the hands of a man who had worked with iron in his youth and had broken the third finger of the right hand in a machine at a factory in 1929, and had never had it set.

They stood in the front hall, at attention, in the way that Polish servants had learned to stand for German officers, and the Colonel did his eleven sentences: *good day; the house is satisfactory; the wine cabinet in the dining room is mine; I sleep in the big bedroom; the woman — the Fräulein — has the room next to it; there will be three at table, sometimes four; the coal is Bundeswehr property and will be counted each week.*

"Jawohl, Herr Oberst."

"Anna. The room upstairs, the one beside mine, will be the Fräulein's. She is not my wife."

"Jawohl, Herr Oberst."

And that was it. The Colonel went into his study with his case; and Piotr went down into the cellar, where a furnace of 1911 was waiting for him;

and Anna stood in the hall for a moment with her hands in the folds of her apron and looked at the woman who had come in a good coat out of a German car in the middle of the afternoon.

"Does the lady want tea?" she said, in German, very slowly, with the accent of a woman who has learned six sentences off a wall.

"I would like tea," said Marion Herschlag, in German, with her face composed; and then, deliberately, in the language of the house, with the accent of a woman who had learned a language off a wall: "And I would like hot water in the evening, at ten o'clock, without being asked. That is all. The rest I will do myself."

The woman's face did not change by a millimetre, and something in the room did change: the balance of a pair of scales that had settled, imperceptibly, at the moment when one woman decided that the other was not going to be a nuisance and was not going to be a friend.

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The first night, the Colonel took her in the big bedroom of a doctor's house with the doors open to the corridor and a Germany army blanket under her and the smell of a new country in the room.

He had changed on the train; she had watched it happen, between Frankfurt and Warsaw, as plainly as a change in the weather. Berlin had done it to him, or the standing at the window of the district staff had done it, or the wall had done it; and the change was this: in Paris he had been a man with a posting, and in Warsaw he was a mission. He had looked at the wall on the north side of the city with the level, final expression of a man reading the last page of a document, and something had closed in him like a fist; and he was more careful now, more particular, more suspicious, and hungrier, because a man who has been given a district to be frightened of also needs to be fed.

That night he was rough in a way he had not been in Paris since January, and she learned, with the clear cold attention she brought to everything, that the next year was going to be a different order of work.

He held her down on the blanket; and he did it with his hand over her mouth — not hard, not to silence her, but because the Poles in the house were two floors away and a German officer's woman is not permitted to be heard in a Polish house; and that hand over her mouth was, in the sixteen

months to come, the single most accurate description of her life in Warsaw: a woman who was allowed everything except the use of her voice.

When it was over he lay for a long time with his arm over his eyes; and then he said, into the room, in the dark, in German, to the ceiling:

"There will be a reception on Thursday at the Blue Palace. There will be the General, and the SS will send somebody, and there will be the wives, and I have decided something about you which you will not like."

"Tell me."

"You are to be nothing."

She turned her head, in the dark.

"You will be beautiful, and you will be quiet, and you will be known to the wives as a Frenchwoman whom the Oberst keeps, exactly as a General keeps a canary, and you will not have opinions, and you will not be charming to anyone above the rank of captain, and if a man in this district ever says to me, 'the Oberst's lady is *unusually intelligent*,' I will hear it as a report of a fault." He turned onto his side and looked at her with the pale eyes, and behind them there was nothing at all of the man who had cried in a room in a tower with a candle on the floor. That man was gone; she had seen the last of him on the platform at Forbach; and what had come east in his place was the man who had passed an order down the line without reading it. "You will be nothing for a year. And at the end of the year, when this district has been held and the General has written his report, I am going to send you out."

"Out where?"

"To the west. To the house in Pomerania, where there is a garden, and a piano, and a woman who will sit in a chair and read, and a man who does not sign anything." He put his hand on her stomach, flat, the whole weight of it, and left it there, and closed his eyes. "That is my estate. It is what is left of everything I have done. I have decided to give it to one person, and you are the only human being in Europe who does not want anything from me, and so it is yours; and if you are ever false to me, in any way, in this city where there are two hundred thousand people who would cut my throat for a ration of bread, I shall not shoot you. I shall take you to the cellar of the Blue Palace and I shall sit in a chair and watch other men do it, and I shall not say one word in your defence, because I will have learned, in that hour, that I have spent the last of my life on a thing that was not mine."

He fell asleep holding her, the way a man sleeps in a house he has just

decided to defend.

She lay awake in the dark of the doctor's house, in a strange bed, in her own city, listening to the small noises of a Polish house at night: a floorboard, and the wind in a chestnut, and, three streets away, a tram going along Marszałkowska with its windows blacked out, and she thought about the film in the sleeve of a coat that was hanging in the wardrobe four feet away, and about a page in a safe in Paris with a date on it — the eighth of August, 1944 — and about ninety days of doing nothing, which was the promise she had made to a man with a bad heart in the Jardin des Plantes, who was not yet dead, but was on his way.

Ninety days, she thought. *Ninety days of being nothing. I can do that. I have done worse.*

And the next morning she began, in a house with a garden and a gate, to be the most nothing woman in the Generalgouvernement.

♦ ♦ ♦

On the fifth day she went into the study.

It was a Thursday and the Colonel was at the Blue Palace from eight in the morning until the evening, and Piotr Zaleski was in the cellar with the coal, and Anna Zaleska was in the kitchen at the end of the corridor with the radio of the household on and the door of the kitchen shut, as it was shut in every German house in Warsaw in the year 1943 between the hours of eleven and one, because the German administration of the city took its dinner at one and the Poles of the house of a German officer took their one hour of the wireless while the soup cooked.

She went in with a duster.

The study of the house on the Mokotowska had been the consulting room of a doctor of the old Warsaw, and it had kept the shape of it: the heavy desk with the green leather top, the shelves of the medical reviews, the two cupboards of the instruments — the instruments were gone to the Reich in 1940 and the shelves had been filled by the district with the grey files of the intelligence service of the Warsaw district — and the window with the blackout frame, and the armchair in which a patient of the profession had sat and looked at the wall on which the first owner of the room had hung the diploma of the university of Dorpat of the year 1904.

The safe was in the corner behind the door.

She had seen it on the third day, in the first hour of the house; she had seen the corner and the door of it and the green of the repainted panel out of the corner of her eye at the moment of the arrival, the way a woman sees the furniture of a room she is being taken through by a man who is talking about the garden; and on the fifth day she went and stood in front of it for the first time in her life with the duster in her hand and her heart going at a flat sixty, in the middle of the ordinary morning of the house, with the wireless of the kitchen coming down the corridor and the smell of the soup of the household in the ground floor.

It was an Organisation Todt pattern of the year 1939: a box of the height of the thigh, set into the plaster of a wall of the old construction, with the door of the steel in the colour of the wall and the dial of the brass with the knurled edge, and — at the height of the hand, under the dial — a small plate of the brass with four lines of the stamping on it.

She did not touch the dial.

She stood in front of it with the duster and read the plate, in the Polish of the room of a doctor of Warsaw, in the light of the morning, for four seconds, and then she dusted the top of the box in the ordinary way of a woman of a house and went out of the study and up to her own room and wrote the four lines down on the back page of a prayer book.

Gebr. Möller, Berlin SO 36. Bauart OT 1939. Nr. 44117. Schlüsselwerk W 44.

The manufacturer and the number. And she lay on the bed of the room of the first floor for eleven minutes with the prayer book in her hands and did the arithmetic that a woman of the household of a German general does with a manufacturer's plate and a safe, and the arithmetic was: *the number is the registry number of an office of the German administration, and the administration of the German army is an administration of the paper, and the paper of the German army is in the office of the district, and the office of the district is four streets away.*

♦ ♦ ♦

The office of the district was in the building of the command at the Blue Palace in the avenue of the Ujazdowskie, and inside the office of the district there was an office of the procurement and supply of the district, and inside the office of the procurement and supply of the district, in the second week of May 1943, there was a secretary of the Polish administration with a loyalty file

that had been in the papers of the Sicherheitsdienst since 1941, and a typist, and a shelf of the catalogues of the firms of the Reich.

The list of the office materials of the district of the intelligence service of the Warsaw district was a page of the catalogue of the firm of Gebrüder Möller of the Berlin SO 36, with the entries for the fiscal year 1943: thirty-one boxes of the paper clips, the size 2; four boxes of the carbon paper, the German pattern; the paste of the district, eleven jars; and at the foot of the page, in the section for the *Waffen und Geräte* of the internal service of the office: the safes, the class of the internal service of the district, the boxes of the pattern OT 1939, three of the boxes, with the serial numbers of the three, and against each of the three numbers, in the column which the procurement clerk of the district had ruled for the purpose in the table of the office of the year 1943, the number of the combination of the lock.

The secretary of the Polish administration who carried that page out of the building of the Blue Palace in the month of May of 1943 wrapped it in the *Nowy Kurier Warszawski* of the third of May and put it under the lid of the cistern of the third closet of the first floor of the building, and it was in the hands of the officers of the organisation of the district within the week; and the number of the lock of the safe of the study of the house on the Mokotowska was in the head of the woman of the household of the Colonel of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw before the middle of the month of May of 1943, and she did not touch the dial of the box, and she did not touch it for the eleven months that followed, and the woman of the household of the Colonel of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw went on for the first month of the arrangement with a prayer book and a piece of the arithmetic and the face of a woman who was nothing at all.

♦ ♦ ♦

She wrote the letter on the seventh day.

There was a system for it, and she had been given the system in a room of the Hôtel Central in the month of November of 1942 by a man of the organisation with a bad heart and a brown paper parcel, and the system was: a page of an ordinary letter of a woman of France to a friend of the province of the Loire, written in the French of the ordinary correspondence of two women of the middle class, in which the weather, the health

of the family and the price of the meat were all true; and in the fourth line of the second page, in the syntax of a Frenchwoman of forty who has been at the lycée of Tours, the position of the words in a sentence that no German censor of the office of the district had ever once had the training to see.

Ma chère Odile, la maison est grande, et le monsieur est un homme de la vieille école; les voisins sont polonais, et la rue est tranquille, et je pense à vous le soir, quand la lampe est allumée et que je ne suis pas encore couchée.

The house is big, and the gentleman is an old-school man; the neighbours are Polish, and the street is quiet, and I think of you in the evening, when the lamp is lit and I am not yet in bed.

She put the letter in the box of the post of the administration of the district, with the address of the rue Cambon, and the letter went out of the city of Warsaw in the pouch of the administration of the district of Warsaw in the second week of May of 1943, and it was in the flat of a milliner of the rue Cambon in Paris in the evening of the eleventh day, and the milliner read it standing up at the table of the kitchen with the shutters closed, and the sentences of a woman of the middle class went into the fire of the stove of the flat, and the fourth line of the second page went out of Paris by way of a hat of the spring collection to a man of the organisation at Lyon on the nineteenth of the month, and was in the hands of the room in London in the last week of May 1943, and was the first piece of paper to come out of the city of Warsaw with the signature of the woman called WESPER.

The street is quiet, said the fourth line of the second page.

There is no Polish city in the year 1943 in which that sentence is true, and the man in the room in London read it and understood it and said nothing at all, and wrote in the margin of the file in his own hand, in the pencil of the office, the date and one word: *arrived.*

♦ ♦ ♦

She did the first reconnaissance of her own life on the fourth day, with Ehlers, in the car, on the excuse of shopping.

There was shopping to do: the district had a store on the Nowy Świat for Germans only, with coffee and sugar and soap and tinned fish and a counter of women's stockings, and Marion Herschlag was entitled to it by the stamp on the *Ausweis* the district had given her at the station, a docu-

ment the size of a postcard with her photograph on it and the words *Begleitung des Oberst v. Reuth* under her name, which meant that she was permitted to buy stockings and coffee, and not permitted to buy a railway ticket, and not permitted to walk in the streets between ten at night and five in the morning, and required to carry the little card against the breast of her coat whenever she left the house, and to show it to any German in uniform, at any time, for any reason.

Ehlers drove her along the Nowy Świat and the Krakowskie Przedmieście, and she sat in the back of the car with her gloves in her lap and looked out of the window at her own city, and was careful, for the length of a kilometre, to move her eyes the way a stranger moves them, in the slow horizontal way of a tourist; and it was harder than the wax key had been, harder than the wall had been, harder than the hand over her mouth in the dark.

There was the shop where her father had bought her a fountain pen in 1930: the sign was gone; the window had two hundred tins of shoe polish in it. There was the church where her mother's cousin had been married in 1934, with its steps full of people as they always are, and a German soldier sitting on the third step eating an apple. There was the confectioner's on the corner of the Świętokrzyska where Odile had never been, and where Marion Herschlag had eaten a *pączek* in 1937 in a grey coat with a fur collar of her mother's, and where the shop now had a plate on the door in German and a sign in the window in German and, in the window, a display of toothbrushes.

And there was the placard.

It was on the wall of a building at the corner of the Marszałkowska: a big white paper in a red border, in two columns, one in Polish and one in German, headed *OBWIESZCZENIE / BEKANNTMACHUNG*, and under the heading, the sentences that had been printed ten thousand times in the four years of the occupation of Poland, and would be printed, in the single sentence, in the single city, in the two months of the summer coming, more than three hundred times.

In reprisal for the attack on a German officer.. the following persons have been sentenced to death and shot..

She read the names. Then she read the placard under it, pasted below, which was a Polish thing and not a German thing, and which was the reason that a crowd of about forty people was standing in front of the wall

at eleven in the morning, in silence, in the cold, in the very middle of a working day.

The placard below was a Polish announcement, printed by the Underground with a hand press in a cellar somewhere in the city: a single sheet, forbidden, punishable by death, and pasted up in the middle of the day in a street with a German sentry twenty metres away, and it said, in a hundred and eleven words, that the men on the German placard had not been shot for an attack; that they had been taken at random from the cells of the Pawiak prison because the German administration had a quota to fill before the visit of a General from Berlin; that their names were known; that the city knew their names; that their families would be provided for by the Polish community; and that the German administration of the city of Warsaw was, in the eyes of history, a criminal organisation; and it was signed, in the corner, with the anchor that every child in the city drew in the dust and the snow of every street in Poland.

Ehlers, who had stopped the car because of the crowd, looked at the wall for a moment through the windscreen.

"That is the second one this week," he said, in the flat voice of a man from Posen. "It is not the sentence that is the problem. It is that they keep pasting their paper over our paper in the middle of the day and nobody stops them; and my Marta says—"

He stopped. He had heard himself; he was a driver, and he said no more, and put the car into gear; and Marion Herschlag sat in the back of a German car in the middle of her own city and looked through the glass at a crowd of forty Poles reading a paper in the middle of the day, and understood, with the flat, huge, almost peaceful certainty of a woman who has just found her own handwriting on a wall in a burning house, that she was not going to have to wait ninety days for anything.

Warsaw was not Paris. In Paris she had been a knife in a drawer. In Warsaw she was going to be a knife in a hand.

Behind her, in the car, the film was in a hatbox with a red ribbon on it, in a trunk, in a house with a garden and a side gate, and thirty-one hours to the west of her, a woman in the rue des Saussaies was in a chair, and a boy of fourteen was still walking up and down outside a green door in the rue Cambon; and ahead of her, in the city, in the barracks and the cellars and the convents and the tram depots, there were forty thousand people who belonged to the same organisation as her, and every one of whom could kill her by saying her name.

The car crossed the Marszałkowska. In the window of a shop on the corner, behind the glass, in the middle of a display of German soap, somebody had scratched, with a diamond, at the height of a woman's knee, a single small anchor.

P A R T T W O

The City of Ash

CHAPTER NINE

The Blue Palace

♦ ♦ ♦

The reception was at the Blue Palace on the Senatorska, in the rooms of a nobleman who had died in 1936 in Nice, and it was given by the district administration in honour of the transfer of the intelligence section, and it was, in the four years of the occupation of Poland, the largest collection of German officers ever gathered in one room in the city of Warsaw.

There were two hundred of them.

They stood about in their grey with their caps under their arms, in a long enfilade of rooms with parquet floors and crystal and a ceiling painted in 1780 with four allegorical figures and the monogram of a family that had stopped existing; and the Wehrmacht drank a Hungarian wine that had been requisitioned from a cellar in Buda, and the officers ate from the buffet with their gloves in their belts, and the wives — there were forty wives — stood in a separate gravity in a separate room by the windows, with their furs on chairs and their shoes already wet.

Marion Herschlag wore grey, and no diamonds. That had been her decision on the Thursday morning, in the bedroom of the doctor's house, and she had made it for a reason that she had to explain to a Colonel for the first time in seven months.

"The earrings in Paris," she said, standing in front of the mirror with the little box open on the dressing table, "were the jewels of a man who took me out of a couture house and put me in a flat in the sixteenth arrondissement, and every woman in the room knew it, and it was my

position: I was a woman whose necklace told the room her price. Here, they must not know my price. Here they must not think about me at all. So I will wear grey, and I will wear no jewellery, and the wife of the most junior captain in the room will be better dressed than I am; and if you want a woman who will be looked at, then take one of the secretaries, because in this city the business of being looked at is over."

He had listened to that with an expression she could not read, and then had said, "You are the strangest woman I have ever paid for," and had gone down to breakfast.

The wives room was the room she had to work.

That was the thing about the Warsaw of the German administration, and she had learned it in eleven minutes and would use it for a year: the men kept the files and the wives kept the *index*. No officer in the district told his wife anything; every officer in the district told his wife everything, at eleven at night, in the dark, in a bedroom where he had drunk a glass of something to sleep; and the wives met each other at eleven in the morning in the drawing room of the Frau Generalin with the district's gossip in their handbags, and the gossip was the only current intelligence in the city that had not been written down.

She stood at the window of the wives room with a glass of tea in her hand and let it go past her for two hours, and she learned the district that Thursday, and she did it the way she had taught herself in Paris: by counting nothing and noticing everything.

Frau Generalin von Rohrbach was sixty-one and came from Kassel and had a photograph of a son on the eastern front in a leather case in her bag, and she was not, Marion decided within four minutes, a stupid woman; she was a woman who had spent thirty-five years being an officer's wife, which is a different species of intelligence altogether, and she ran the wives the way a good colonel runs a depot: with a rota, a rota for the coffee, a rota for the church, a rota for the visits to the field hospital, and no gossip whatsoever about anything that mattered, because gossip about things that matter is a form of theft.

Frau Oberstleutnant Altdorfer was fifty and her husband was in the supply section, and everything she said about the district was in the language of a woman who was hungry: there was no butter, there was no coffee, there was no white flour, and the Poles had everything and hid it, and the black market was everywhere, and if one more Pole was shot for it she would not be surprised, and what was the city coming to.

Frau Doktor Weingart was thirty-eight and was the wife of the district medical officer, and she said nothing at all for two hours and looked at Marion twice, and each time she looked at her, Marion looked back with her mother's face, because she had learned in Kraków that there is no possible defence against a clever woman except to be exactly the thing she is certain you are.

And then there was Lotte Erler.

She was thirty-three, the wife of a Hauptmann of the motor transport office; she had been a legal secretary in Hamburg before the war and had a mouth that turned up at one corner and a way of standing with her weight on one hip and both hands around her glass; and she came across the room to Marion at the beginning of the second hour, and sat down on the end of a sofa, and said, without any preface at all: "You are the Frenchwoman."

"I am the Frenchwoman."

"Good. Then we can talk about something other than the winter. The winter is the only subject in this city and I have been here since 1941 and I have heard the winter described four hundred times, and I have come to the conclusion that the Poles are right about us." She drank. "The Führer has a plan for this city and the plan is: no one shall ever write a novel about it. That is what they say, anyway. Do you play bridge?"

"Badly."

"Good. Nobody plays bridge badly in this administration; everybody plays it like a general staff exercise. What do you do?"

That was the question. It came at her at eight minutes past seven in the evening on the twelfth of April, 1943, across a sofa in a palace in Warsaw, out of the mouth of a woman of thirty-three with a turned-up mouth and both hands round a glass; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna looked at her, and did the thing she had taught herself to do in the place where the arithmetic stopped, which was to answer the question with the truest thing that could be said and could never be used.

"I wait," she said. "I am a woman in the house of a man who is important, and I wait, and I am very good at it. I am so good at it that I have begun to be able to tell the time to the minute without a watch, and I know the schedule of this district, because I hear it, every evening, over the soup." She set her glass down. "And in Paris I had a shop and a cinema and a friend who made hats. And now I have a garden with two chestnuts in it in a city where a hundred and fifty thousand people have been put behind a wall, and I am invited by the wife of a general to drink tea, and I drink the

tea, and I am a Frenchwoman from Strasbourg, and there is nothing in my life here that I can say out loud except this: I am extremely tired, and I am thirty-one years old, and I am going to be nothing for a year, and the being nothing is going to be the largest piece of work I have ever done."

Lotte Erler looked at her for a moment over the glass.

"Thirty-one," she said. "Yes. It comes as a great surprise, doesn't it."

"It does."

"Then let us be friends," said Lotte Erler, "because I am also extremely tired, and I am also going to be nothing for a year, and you are the first person in this city who has said anything to me that was not about the winter. But I want you to understand one thing first, madame, because I am a lawyer's daughter and I always explain the terms." She leaned over and set her empty glass on a side table with a small exact click. "I am not nice. I have a husband on the eastern front, and when he dies I shall be a widow of an Oberleutnant with a pension of a hundred and forty marks a month and no children, and I have already worked out that in this war the only people who will be in a position to help women like me, when it is over, are women like *you*: women who have been in the rooms, who have heard the names, who know which of these men are monsters and which of them are merely clerks. So I am going to be your friend, and I am going to be useful to you, and I am going to make a note, in my own head, of everything I learn about you — because that is what people like me do, madame, and you should know that about me now, in April, rather than in October."

"Then we shall be friends," said Marion Herschlag, "on the terms."

"Good." Lotte Erler stood up and smoothed her skirt and looked down at her with the turned-up mouth. "Also, the Frau Generalin has noticed that you are wearing no jewellery and that you are not stupid, and she has decided that those are the two most dangerous things in this room; and if you want my advice, you will go and stand in the far corner by the fireplace for the rest of the evening and look bored. Nobody watches a bored woman. It is the only thing I have learned in this administration that is worth anything at all."

♦ ♦ ♦

The Colonel's study at the house on the Mokotowska had a desk, a bookcase, a safe, a telephone, and, from the end of April, a woman.

It was Ehlers who had delivered her, in the sense that Ehlers delivered the post, and the arrangement came out of the ether of the household in the way that most arrangements in a colonel's house come about; there was a mass of paper, and no clerk, because the clerks were at the Blue Palace, and a colonel of intelligence who worked at home in the evening did not want to telephone for a clerk at nine o'clock at night and be heard by the exchange, because the exchange in Warsaw was Polish.

So at the end of April she began to sort the Colonel's private papers.

It was, in the two years of her work, the single most useful thing that ever happened to her.

She did it at the desk in the study, in the evenings, in a blouse, with a lamp, and she did it *badly*, in a very particular way: she sorted everything into three piles instead of two, and she made a list of the contents of each pile on a separate sheet, and she used a pencil, and the pencil was the key to it, because a pencil can be rubbed out and a woman who is seen to rub something out is a woman who is seen to be honest; and every evening, when the Colonel went through her lists with a pen in his hand, he found the same three things: a competent woman; a small number of errors; and one item per night that had been filed in the wrong place and put back in the right one.

Within eleven days he had stopped checking the pencil.

Within three weeks he was dictating to her.

There is no document in the world so valuable as a dictation, because a dictation is a man's head, out of order, at speed, with his hesitations in it: *no, strike that; start again; the general says that the figure was three thousand and I know it was three thousand eight hundred, but the general is writing a report for Berlin and I have learned that a general writes a report for the man above him and the man above him writes a report for the man above him, and that by the time a figure reaches Berlin it has been polished like a stone in a river; put in 'three thousand.'* She typed it on the Colonel's machine with two fingers, the way a Frenchwoman from a couture house would type; and while her fingers were moving, her mind was standing behind them, in a room in the dark, laying out everything that had been said in the order in which it had been said; and in the evenings, in the small bedroom next to the Colonel's, in the bed of a doctor's daughter, she would take it out and go over it, item by item, the way her mother had made her do arpeggios in 1931.

She kept nothing. That was the discipline: no paper, no list, no note. But a woman who has been trained at the Conservatory in Warsaw has a memory for sequences that is not a human memory at all, and by the middle of May she was carrying in her head the whole shape of the district: the order of battle of the garrison, the names of the four men who ran the work of the *Abwehrstelle* Warsaw, the fact that the General telephoned Berlin twice a week from his bedroom and never from his office, the location of the anti-aircraft batteries, the schedule of the trains bringing the *Wehrmacht*'s mail, and one fact that she came across in the third week of May in a file of railway timetables with which she did nothing for a year and which, in the end, in the summer of 1944, she used to kill eight hundred men.

♦ ♦ ♦

The flower woman was at the corner of the Nowy Świat and the Świętokrzyska every Sunday morning, in the door of a dairy that was shut, with a bucket of nothing in it, because in the fourth year of the occupation there were no flowers in the city of Warsaw except the paper ones.

The paper ones were beautiful.

That was the thing she had forgotten, in Paris: that the Poles had taken the German economy of grief and made it into an art, and the paper flowers were part of it: made out of the tissue from the German packing cases, dyed with beet and coffee, wired with the wire from the German barbed-wire; and a woman with a bucket of paper flowers at the corner of a shut dairy was, in the city, an entirely ordinary sight, and half the customers bought them to put on the graves at Powązki, which was the largest single activity of the Polish population of the city in that spring.

She came on the third Sunday of May, in accordance with the arrangement she had been given in Kraków in 1940: the second and fourth Sundays, the woman in the black shawl, the phrase that was never written down, the refusal of the flowers, and the glass of water.

There was no woman in a black shawl. There was a girl of seventeen.

She was standing in the doorway with the bucket, with her hair in a plait, in a dreadful coat, and she looked at Marion Herschlag and her face did not change, because the face of a girl of seventeen at a corner in Warsaw in 1943 was not a face that changed for anything; and Marion stopped and

looked at the flower bucket, and said, the way she had been taught: "Only in June."

"The woman with the shawl is my aunt," the girl said. "She has been at Oświęcim since February."

The the street went on around them: a tram, a queue, a boy with a handcart of firewood, two German soldiers looking in the window of the dairy because the window of the dairy was directly in their path, and the girl held out a paper flower and said, in the voice of a girl selling a paper flower, "Three zloty," and Marion gave her four and took the flower, and the girl said, in the same voice, without any pause: "The Fox's people say you are to do nothing. Nineteen more Sundays. Then a man will come with a book. He will ask you for a light, and he will have the book, and you will not talk to him in the street; you will walk to the church of the Visitation in the second week and he will be there, and after that it is his business and not mine." She took the four zloty and made change out of a purse, seventeen groszy, in the correct manner, with her tongue between her teeth, and she said, "It is a bad flower. Do not put it on a grave; the wire is the only real thing in it."

She got the change. She walked away with the paper flower in her hand, past the two German soldiers, who looked at her the way they looked at everything in the city, which was with their attention and their knowledge that no act of attention was innocent; and she went home along the Nowy Świat with the flower in her hand and her heart going like a bird in a box, and half a block from the house she stopped, and looked at the paper thing in her hand, and understood what it was.

Because she had given four zloty and it was in her hand, and any woman in the street could buy a paper flower, and so could any German: so it was nothing. It was nothing at all. The whole of a city was in the habit of buying the thing that was nothing, and the resistance of Poland was in the habit of putting the thing that was nothing into the hands of a woman in a good coat in front of two soldiers at eleven in the morning on a Sunday; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna walked home with a paper flower, and put it in a glass on the windowsill of the small room next to the Colonel's, and left it there, on the sill, in the sun, until it faded, and the Colonel saw it a hundred times and never once asked about it, because a woman in the house of a man who has been given a district needs a small useless thing in a glass on a windowsill, and that is the only invisible place in the world.

♦ ♦ ♦

On the last day of May there was an inspection, and the district was in a fever from seven in the morning, and the house on the Mokotowska had two extra men in it for a whole day: a Hauptmann of the rail section and an Oberleutnant who had been at school with somebody and had come to Warsaw with the inspection from Kraków, and Anna Zaleska cooked for seven hours, and the Colonel, who was in his study with the door shut, telephoned the Blue Palace four times before eleven o'clock.

At four in the afternoon, with the house empty and the men still at the Palace, Marion Herschlag stood in the Colonel's study in front of the safe with the door open.

Not to open it. She never touched it in the first month; that was a discipline and she kept it. She stood in front of it with a duster in her hand, which was a woman doing the dusting, because Anna had been in the kitchen since dawn and the Fräulein had decided, in the way Frenchwomen in the German administration's houses did, that she would do the study herself; and she stood there looking at the door of a safe of the Organisation Todt pattern, made in 1939, with the manufacturer's plate on the front and a combination dial and, behind the dial, in a place that a man with a duster would be standing exactly in front of, the small brass plate with the serial number.

The plate had a serial number stamped on it in six digits, and she had seen the serial number on the safe in Paris, and she had seen, in the third week of May, in a file of procurement papers that went through her hands on the desk, a list of the serial numbers of Organisation Todt safes in the Warsaw district together with the numbers of their combinations, written by a procurement clerk in Berlin with a copy to the district administration, in a table, in a document concerning *Beschaffung von Büromaterial*.

Office materials.

She stood with the duster in her hand in front of the safe in the fourth year of the war and read the serial number off the brass plate, and put it into the long room at the back of her mind where the sequences went, and went on dusting.

That night, when the Colonel came to bed at midnight, grey with the day of the inspection, he found her sitting up with a book and the lamp on, in

a nightdress, with her hair loose, and he stood in the door for a while and looked at her.

"You have been at home all day."

"I have been at home all day, and I have dusted your study, and I have had my tea with the Frau Doktor, who is a woman with the eyes of a person in a stationary shop; and I have heard from Lotte Erler that the wife of the Oberst in the supply section is going to have a baby in the autumn, which is a certainty because the Poles in her kitchen say so, and the Poles in a kitchen know everything that the German administration knows and one thing that it does not." She turned a page. "And I have been thinking about your garden."

"My garden."

"The chestnut is going to die. It has a fungus at the base of the trunk, and it will be dead in two years, and it is the only good thing about coming home to this house." She looked up from the book. "Have it cut in the autumn, and put in a walnut or nothing at all. Piotr will tell you the same thing if you ask him in Polish, which you cannot, so I am telling you in French."

He came over and stood at the end of the bed and looked down at her for a long moment, with the district in his head and the day of the inspection behind him and the wall three streets away, and he said, in German, in the voice that belonged to a bedroom and not to a district:

"There was a moment this afternoon, in the Palace, when a Hauptmann from Kraków said something to me about the Poles, and I thought: she would have said the exact opposite, and she would have been right, and there is no one in the east I can say that to except the wall of my own study."

"Then say it to me."

"No." He sat down on the edge of the bed and began to unlace his boots. "The garden is a good thought. I shall have Zaleski do it. And the safe in the study — there is a new combination on it since yesterday, and I have written it on a piece of paper in my wallet, and the wallet is on the chest of drawers, and you are lying in my bed in a nightdress, and both of us are going to go on being extremely careful with each other, because that is the only kind of trust that lasts, and I intend for this to last."

He got into bed, and put his arm over his eyes, and was asleep in four minutes, which was a man's ability to be careful with a woman: four minutes, and a sentence he thought was a joke.

The building of the command of the district was a house of four doors and two clocks.

She learned it on the fourth day of the month of June, on a Thursday, because the ration cards of the household of the General of the district were in the office of the administration, and the woman of the house of a General of the German army in Warsaw went for them in the Mercedes, with Ehlers at the wheel and a paper of the district in her bag, at eleven o'clock in the morning, in the way of a piece of furniture being moved from one room to another.

The first door: the guard room, where a Feldwebel of the military police and two men sat behind a table with a ledger of the visitors and a clock on the wall above their heads, and the clock was the German clock, and it was five minutes fast, and it stayed five minutes fast for the fourteen months, because the sergeant of the guard had set it in the month of October 1939 and nobody in the administration had ever been able to give him an order about it.

The second door: the corridor of the ground floor, which was given to the administrative section of the district, and where the walls were painted the colour of the cream of a hospital and there were eleven rooms on the left side and a wall of the pigeonholes of the internal post on the right, and there were two officers of the administration in the corridor who looked at her for four seconds and then looked away, and the wife of the medical officer of the district, who was coming down the corridor with a paper of her own, stopped and said good morning and took her by the elbow to the window and gave her the social law of the place in eleven sentences:

that the wives of the administration did not come to the building except on the second and fourth Thursdays; that the wives of the military of the district did not come at all; that the wives' table was at the house of the Frau Generalin of the administration on the Ujazdowskie on the Tuesdays; that it was understood in the district that the woman of the General of the intelligence service was a foreigner; that in the four years of the war there had been exactly one other Frenchwoman in the administration, the wife of a transport officer of the rue Rakowiecka, and that she had gone to the west in the year 1941 and had not been seen since; and that, on the whole, and speaking as a friend of the profession, the wife of the medical officer of the district thought that a woman of the household of the intelligence service ought to come to the wives' table on the second Thursday and sit in the window and say nothing at all.

The third door: the library of the old palace, which the district had made into the registry, and where there were two sergeants of the office, a Pole of the labour administration in a green eyeshade at the far desk, and a great many shelves; and where the papers of the district of Warsaw of the year 1943 went in and out of the wire baskets under the hands of men who had spent the war being accurate about the paper of a continent, and where a woman of the household of a General waited for eleven minutes for the ration cards and saw, in the eleven minutes, the size of the machine she had been put down inside: the baskets of the incoming and the outgoing, the ledgers of the numbers, the carbon copies of everything that the district was going to do to the population of the city of Warsaw.

The fourth door was at the end of the corridor and it was the door of the office of the General of the intelligence service, and she did not go through it, because a woman of the household does not go through that door in a building of the district; and on the wall beside it, at the height of the chest of a man, there was a plan of the district of the city of Warsaw under the glass of the frame, with the quarters of the city in four colours and the German administration marked out in red over the colours, and the name of the street of the Mokotowska on the south side of the red, and the quarter of the ghetto in a black cross-hatch at the north of the whole plan of the city, and the river along the east of it.

She stood in front of the plan for four minutes, in the noise of the corridor, with the ration cards of the household of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw in her bag, and did the thing that she had been trained to do with a room since a winter in a house in Kraków, which was to put the plan into her head in one piece and in the order of the colours: the quarters, the streets, the bridgehead of the Praga on the far side of the river, the belt of the railway, the four red squares of the German administration, and the eleven German houses of the officers of the district that she was able to name from the wives' table.

Then she went out of the fourth door of the building of the command of the district and down the steps to the car, and Ehlers opened the door of the Mercedes, and the clocks of the building of the district of Warsaw were both behind her: the German clock on the wall of the guard room, five minutes fast, and the other clock, the one that was not a clock, and that she had been listening to since she came down out of the station in May, which was the city of a million people of Warsaw going about its day with its face down, in the way of a population that has agreed to be five minutes

behind the administration in everything that can be seen and in nothing that can be counted.

She did not write down one word of the plan of the district. She did not need to, and there was nobody to give it to for eleven days, and she spent the way home in the car looking out at the streets of the German side of the city of her own childhood and making the inventory of the ruins that were in the plan and the ruins that were in the street, and the difference between the two of them was the instrument by which she had decided to measure her war.

She lay in the dark and listened to him breathe, and thought about the fact that in the house there was one man who had taken a district from the east and put it in a safe in a study, and one woman who had a serial number in her head, and one paper flower on a windowsill, and nineteen Sundays, and no one, in the city, who was permitted to know that the woman in the small room had arrived.

CHAPTER TEN

The Streets Remember

♦ ♦ ♦

Żoliborz in 1943 was a district of five-storey houses and small gardens on the north side of the city, built in the twenties for civil servants and schoolteachers and doctors, and it had been fought over in September 1939, house by house, by the Polish army of the Warsaw garrison; and it was, in the autumn of that year, the first place in Warsaw where an entire street had been emptied, in the middle of the night, by the SS, with lorries, and where the neighbours had stood in their nightclothes at the windows and watched, because that was what the first time was like: the whole street stood at the windows and watched and did not know what it was watching, and after that everyone in the city knew what it was, and the next time the whole street sat in the dark in the middle of the rooms with their hands over their children's mouths.

The Stankiewicz family had lived on the Mokotowska, in the centre, for Krystyna's girlhood. But her mother's sister had a house in Żoliborz, on a street called the Krasińskiego, with a garden and a pear tree; and there had been, in Krystyna's memory, one summer of 1931 in that house with the pear tree, when she was fourteen, in which she had been given a room of her own with a window that looked into the branches, and had learned a sonata in that room, and had fallen in love, in the way of a girl of fourteen, with a cousin of her aunt's husband's who had not known she existed.

She walked to Żoliborz on the ninth of June, on a Thursday, in the coat

that was made of a Polish factory's wool and had been the coat of a maid, with a shopping bag for cabbage and a paper *Kennkarte* in her pocket.

She had spent three weeks working out how to do it, and it was not, in the end, clever at all; the cleverness came later, when she had to do it a second time.

The method was Anna Zaleska.

Anna went to the market on Tuesdays and Fridays and to see her sister in Praga on Thursdays, and once a month she went, in accordance with the German ration system, to register at a district office in the northern part of the town for the special provision of the Polish domestic staff of officers' households, which was a system the Germans had invented to demonstrate that the Poles who served them were better off than the Poles who did not, and which was, in the fourth year of the occupation, the only reason that two hundred thousand Poles were still alive in the city; and the office was at the corner of a street in Żoliborz, and it took an hour and a quarter to walk there and back, and it was possible, in that hour and a quarter, for a Frenchwoman of the house to *accompany the cook on an errand*, because a Frenchwoman in a Polish house, in the German administration of Warsaw, was a thing that nobody ever looked at twice: she was not a German and she was not a Pole; she was, in that city, in that year, the only kind of person who could walk in the street without being either watched or shot.

She invented the arrangement in the kitchen on the last Sunday of May, over the coffee, in Polish, in three sentences, and Anna Zaleska looked at her for a long moment with a face like a good loaf of bread and then said, in German, carefully, as a servant says a thing that may be repeated: "The lady should not walk so far. The lady should take the tram like other ladies."

And then, in Polish, quietly, and without any change in her face at all: "The day after tomorrow, at nine. Bring the bag. And do not talk to me in the street, because I have a sister in Praga and a cousin who is a policeman, and if the German police take my Piotr to the Szucha I will not have anybody to bring me the little wood for the stove."

♦ ♦ ♦

The office was a ruin of a school that had been made into an office, and there were forty Polish women in the queue at nine in the morning, and Marion

Herschlag stood in it with her bag like a woman who had been sent by a house; and no one spoke to her, and no one looked at her; and after eleven minutes a woman of thirty at the front of the queue dropped her registration book, and it slid a metre and a half along the pavement, and Marion picked it up and handed it back, and the woman said, "Thank you, madam," very clearly, and that was the transaction, and it took four seconds, and it was followed by thirty seconds in which the woman who had dropped the book went into the office and Marion Herschlag turned and walked away down the street of Żoliborz with a small piece of paper in the palm of her hand, folded four times, the size of a stamp.

She read it on the corner, in the shelter of a doorway, with her bag on the ground between her feet and her back to the wall.

The house in the Krasińskiego was shelled in 1939 and the neighbours took the roof. The family went to the Praga side in 1942 and the daughter to the convent, and the aunt died in the summer. The professor is alive. He is in the old apartment, on the third floor, in the second room, with the woman Pelagia, who has the eyes of a blind woman; and the neighbours have kept him on the register of the house as a caretaker, because a caretaker is issued with a certificate; and the certificate is the only paper in the world that keeps him alive, and it expires in the winter.

There is no nurse. There is no medicine. He is fed by the neighbours.

You must not go.

She stood in the doorway in the Krasińskiego with the piece of paper between her thumb and forefinger, in the middle of a street where she had spent the summer of her fourteenth year, with the pear tree that had died in the shelling standing black over a garden wall thirty metres away; and she read the last line four times.

You must not go.

She looked at her hands. She had, in the three years, never once been given an order that she could not obey; and she had been given orders by men with bad hearts and by men with no hearts, in rooms in Warsaw and Kraków and a cinema in Paris; and the discipline of it was that the order and the woman were two different things, and that the woman was nailed to a board somewhere a long way behind the order, and did what she was told.

She went.

♦ ♦ ♦

The house was on the street where the family had lived for twenty-one years: a big grey building of 1910 with a courtyard and a gate that had a porter in it, and now had a notice in German and a Polish caretaker's wife who sat on a kitchen chair in the doorway of the gatehouse in the middle of the day because there was nothing else to do.

Marion Herschlag went in through the courtyard at eleven in the morning, with her cabbage bag, and up the back stairs, which were the stairs that the servants used and the stairs that the neighbours used, because the front stair was the one on which the German administration had posted its notices and its placard of the house's register and its list of the flats; and the third floor, and the second door on the landing, which had a brass plate on it with her father's initials and a card with the hour of the lessons he gave, and which now had nothing on it at all, only the marks where two things had been.

She did not knock for eleven seconds. She had been trained not to knock on doors that were not hers; she had been trained to knock on the door of a flat, in a house, only the way a *Polish servant girl with a cabbage bag* would knock, which is by opening it.

She opened it.

The flat, on the first inspection, was empty.

Two of the rooms had been taken by the German administration's housing office in 1940 for the family of a Polish railway official, who paid the rent to the house and not to the Stankiewicz; and the glass in the corridor had been broken in 1939 in the shelling of September and repaired in 1940 with a piece of plywood, and the plywood had been painted by somebody with a last of the white paint, and the paint was still there, and the corridor smelled of boiled cabbage and, under the cabbage, of the pipes and the dust and the particular smell of a Warsaw building that Krystyna Stankiewiczówna had smelled every day for the first twenty-two years of her life, and the smell was the thing that nearly killed her, in the four years, because it was not a smell, it was a room, and in that room there was a girl of ten coming in out of the snow with her hands burning, and a girl of nineteen at a window with a book, and a mother at the end of the corridor in a green velvet dressing gown saying *Krystyna, the piano*.

The third door was her father's.

He was in the doorway of it, in a coat, in the dark, with a book in his hand, and he was so thin that the coat hung off him like a coat on a nail.

He looked at her for four seconds.

"Woman," he said, politely, in Polish, "you have the wrong flat; the woman with the cabbage is downstairs."

And in the four seconds, and in the way he stood in the doorway of a room holding a book with his finger in it, she saw that he did not know her.

She stood in the corridor of her own house with a cabbage bag and looked at her father, and did the arithmetic the way she had done it in the safe in Paris, which was to say: *old man, sixty-eight, in a coat in June, in a room with no fire, with a book, and the German administration of the district of Warsaw between me and the woman who is going to cry*; and she said, in Polish, in the voice of a stranger:

"I am the woman who has come about the room. The caretaker's wife sent me. I was told the professor receives."

"There is no room."

"There is the room at the end of the corridor. I saw it from the courtyard; the window has a curtain. I was told that the professor has lodgers."

"Who told you?"

"An old woman at the gate."

Her father came two steps down the corridor and stood in the light from the window of the landing, and she saw his face, which was the face of the photograph on the mantelpiece of a flat in the Mokotowska: a wide, faintly Mongolian face with the intelligence of a mathematician in the forehead, and the lids of the eyes lower than they had been, and a certain grey slackness at the left side of the mouth.

He looked at her for a long moment, and the long moment went on being four seconds and then six and then eight, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the corridor of her father's flat and gave everything she had spent three years learning to a man with a book in his hand, which was: the droop of the shoulders of a woman who has been carrying a bag, and a French way of holding her chin, and the eyes going down at the last moment, and the face of a housekeeper.

"There is no room," said her father. "There is a woman with no eyes and a man who used to be a professor of mechanics and no longer writes; and the room at the end of the corridor has two hundred books in it that nobody wants. And if you have a cabbage in that bag, then take it

downstairs, because the woman downstairs is the only one in the building who still cooks."

He went back into his room and shut the door.

She went down the back stairs and stood in the courtyard for a moment in the sunlight of June, with the cabbages, and she did not cry then and did not cry later, and what she did instead was to stand there with her back to the wall of the gatehouse and count the windows of the third floor on the courtyard, one at a time, four windows, and fix the position of every one of them in her memory, and to make, in the place in her head where the arithmetic happened, the biggest entry of her life.

Then she went home, and gave the cabbages to Anna in the kitchen, and said that she had been to the Krasińskiego and that the garden there had been stripped and that she had not spoken to anybody; and Anna Zaleska looked at her with a face like a good loaf of bread, and said nothing at all, and went on peeling, because in Warsaw in 1943 that was what one did with a thing which one could not ask about.

♦ ♦ ♦

The second visit was on the twenty-fourth of June, at seven in the evening, in the golden hour of a Warsaw June, and it was possible because on the twenty-fourth the German administration of the city was at a reception at the Blue Palace in honour of the birthday of a General, and because her father's flat had a lodger.

The lodger was a concierge's daughter of thirty, named Zofia, who had one leg shorter than the other from a childhood illness and who worked in the records office of the tram company and who had come to the flat in October 1939 with a bag and had not left, and who was, in the fourth year of the occupation, the reason that Professor Stankiewicz was still alive, because she brought home, every day, from the tram company's canteen, an orange, and gave him half.

Marion Herschlag went up the back stairs at a quarter past seven with a bag that had two hundred grammes of German butter and a tin of German sardines in it and a paper of German medicine from the district pharmacy that the household of an Oberst was entitled to, and she knocked the way a woman with a bag knocks on the door of a flat where a woman has a parcel to deliver, and Zofia opened it, and looked at her.

"Zosia," said Marion Herschlag, in Polish, in the voice of a woman of the district, which is a voice with a particular flat clarity in it, "there is a parcel for the professor."

Zofia looked at the bag.

"From whom?"

"From the woman who came about the room."

And in that moment she saw, in the eyes of a woman with one leg shorter than the other who worked in the records office of the tram company and had spent three years and eight months keeping an old man alive on the strength of half of a canteen orange per day, the entire arithmetic of the city of Warsaw: the knowledge that this woman in the doorway with the German butter was a thing that would either kill them both or keep them alive, and the fact that Zofia had no way of knowing which, and the fact that in Warsaw in 1943 the only thing a person could do with a stranger at a door was to open it and see.

She opened the door.

Her father was at the table by the window with his books around him, and there was an oil lamp on the table, and a glass with a spoon in it, and the glass had medicine in it, and on the wall behind him, in the place where her mother's portrait had hung for twenty-one years, there was nothing at all, only the pale rectangle.

He looked up.

This time she did not stay more than four seconds. She crossed the room, and put the bag on the table, and put her hand on the back of her father's head, on his skull through the thin hair, the way she had done her life, since she was four years old, since the flat in the Mokotowska, in the garden, in the corridor, at the station, on the day in 1937 when she had left for a school in a town in the south; and she said, in Polish, in her own voice:

"It is me."

And her father put both his hands on her hand, one over the other, and held it on the top of his own head; and his shoulders began to shake, and he did not make any sound, and he did not turn around; and it lasted eleven seconds and then he took his hands away, and said, in a voice that had been scrubbed clean of everything, in the flat voice of a professor of mechanics:

"Zosia. Shut the door."

He did it right. That was the thing she would remember: her father, sixty-eight years old, with a coat and a book, took hold of his own grief with the flat of both hands and put it down, and turned around in his chair, and looked at his daughter in a maid's coat in the middle of his wrecked drawing room in the fourth year of the occupation, and said to her, in the way he had said things to her at the piano when she was nine:

"Sit down. Tell me what you are permitted to tell me, and nothing else, and no names. Then take the butter out of the bag in front of the woman, so that between us there is nothing hidden, because a thing hidden between three people in Warsaw is a thing that hangs them on the same morning."

She sat down. She told him nothing. She told him that she was alive, that she was not married, that she worked, that she had been in France, that she could not come often, that there was a woman in a coat from Alsace who had to be kept alive in her body, and that she would never tell him where she lived or with whom, and that the day would come, before the end of the war, when he would hear the truth of it in the street from a man he did not know; and her father listened to it with his hands folded in front of his mouth, the way he had listened to a hundred students.

Then he said: "Your mother's amber is not in the house. It went with the woman downstairs in December 1939, because the blackshirts came to the building on the second of December and took the man in the flat below and burnt the papers in the courtyard; and Pelagia took the amber out of the flat that night, and it is not in this building; and if you are ever in a position to ask a half-blind woman for a thing, then it will be the only object of your mother's that survives the war."

"And Bolek?"

Her father's face did not change at all.

"Your brother," he said, "works in a chemist's in the Praga district and is a fool and is not to be looked for by anybody, and I have not seen him for eleven months and do not intend to, and if you go to the Praga district to look for him you will kill him."

The lamp made a small noise. Zofia was at the other end of the room, doing something with the family's linen, which had been her mother's linen, so that the room had about it the smell of 1934.

"I am going to say one thing to you," said her father, "because I am an old man and I have been dying slowly for two years and I know how it is done; and after this I will not say it again, and you will not come more than once

a month, or if you must come, you will do it exactly as you did it today, and Zosia will hang a white cloth on the line in the courtyard on the days when the house is watched. You are a woman in the house of the enemy; I do not know what you are and I am not going to ask, because a man of sixty-eight who has been asking questions in this city for four years knows that the only answer he will ever get is your name — which is Stankiewiczówna, which is the name of my father, and my grandfather, and a house in the Mokotowska that no longer has a lamp in the hall." He took his hands down and put them on the table. "I want you to understand that I am not proud of you, and that I am not ashamed of you, because I do not know which of the two things you are, and I shall never know, and a father is not required to know, he is required to *stand*: and the thing you must know is that your mother died in the first autumn of the war in a house in the country with Pelagia holding her hand, and her last words were the ones she said every day of her life, which were: *Krystyna, you are not playing the second movement slowly enough.*"

He stopped. In the corridor, from the flat of the family of the railway official, came the sound of a wireless set with a German voice in it. Zofia was folding linen.

"Go now," said her father. "And if you are ever asked, in a room, whether you have a family in Warsaw: you do not. There is no Stankiewicz in the register, there is a caretaker on the register, and that is the arrangement, and it is the best piece of work I have done since I stopped doing physics."

She stood up. She went to the table, and took the butter and the sardines and the medicine out of the bag, and put them down in a row in the lamplight, so that Zofia would see it and there would be nothing hidden between three people.

And then she did the thing she had come for, which she had been going to do since the ninth of June: she bent down and kissed her father on the top of the head, in the way of a daughter, and stood up, and went out of the room, and down the back stairs, and out through the courtyard, past the gatehouse, into the Krasińskiego.

It was a quarter to nine. The sky over the north of the city was the colour of a peach at the bottom and, at the top, the dark blue of June; and somewhere over the Vistula, at the same hour, at the Blue Palace, a General was raising a glass to the Führer with two hundred officers standing; and on the wall of a building in the Śródmieście there was a placard four days old, with eleven Polish names on it, one of them a woman's; and in a flat in the

Praga district, if her father was to be believed and he was to be believed, her brother of seventeen was pretending to be a fool behind a chemist's counter; and in the flat behind her, an old man in a coat was sitting at a table with a tin of sardines in front of him, in a room where a piano had been, waiting for a woman with one short leg to bring him half an orange and the news of the world.

Krystyna Stankiewiczówna walked out of the Krasińskiego with her empty bag and her hat on and her gloves on, because a woman with an empty bag and her gloves on is a woman going home from shopping; and at the corner of the next street, forty metres away, standing at a tram stop with her hands folded in front of her and her face turned to the road with the patience of a Warsaw afternoon, was a woman in a grey coat whom she had known since the winter of 1937, who was the aunt of a girl she had been at school with, and who was the last person in Warsaw — the *only* person in Warsaw, according to three years of briefing, and eleven files, and a card index kept by a Hauptsturmführer with spectacles — who would look at the face of Marion Herschlag and see, without a doubt, without any doubt at all, the daughter of the Stankiewiczes of the Mokotowska, in the face of a woman with a cabbage bag.

They closed the street at four o'clock on the fourteenth of May.

It was a Friday, and the hour of the end of the afternoon of the working week, which was the hour that the administration of the district of Warsaw had chosen for the year; and it was done in the pattern that the population of the city knew the way a farmer knows the shape of a hailstorm: two lorries of the police arriving at the two ends of a street of shops at the same moment, the cordon of the blue police and the men of the formation of the east walking the pavements with the rifles at the low port, and the tram stopped in the middle of the block with its doors shut and the people of the tram in it, looking out of the windows the way the people of a burning house look at the yard.

She was in the German car in the queue of the traffic at the corner of the Krucza when the cordon went down.

There were four cars and a tram in front of the Mercedes at the moment the whistles went, and the queue came to a stop in the way of a thing that is standing in a river and has been told it is not going to move; and Ehlers turned his head, once, and then sat with both hands on the wheel and his eyes in front of him in the ordinary way of a driver of the German administration of a city of the east.

"Gnädige Frau."

"Go on."

"Gnädige Frau will be asked for the papers of the household of the General of the district at the barrier in the eleven minutes, and the papers are in the bag of the gnädige Frau, and it is an ordinary check of the population of this street, and the four cars in front of us are going to be let through one by one, and the men of the formation of the east are not going to look at the Mercedes twice, because a car of the district of the intelligence service of the city of Warsaw is a car of the district of the intelligence service of the city, and there is not one man of the formation of the east who is going to look at it twice." He was speaking very fast and very quietly. "And in the meantime the formation of the east is going to be doing to this street what the formation of the east does."

She sat in the back of the car and watched it through the glass.

They took the tram first, because a tram is a building with a hundred and forty people in it and a building is the cheapest thing to take: two men at the front door and two at the back and one man inside with a list, and the people of the tram came out into the light of the end of the afternoon in the way of a slow queue, with the bags and the parcels and the children, and stood in the road with their hands at their sides while a sergeant of the formation of the east walked down them and looked at the papers and put his finger out and touched a man here and a boy there, exactly the way a man of the market touches a melon.

A man of forty in a clean shirt, with a rucksack on his back, and his wife beside him with her hand in his elbow, and the wife said something to the sergeant; and the sergeant listened to it, with his head on one side, in the way of a man of the police who has been in a city of the east for four years and has heard the sentences of the women of the population of it; and then he took the man by the elbow and put him inside the cordon and walked on down the queue, and the wife stayed where she was in the road with her hands at her sides and her mouth open, and did not say anything else in the time.

They took the queue of the shops at the door of the provision store: eleven women and two men from the counter and the customers. They took a boy of about seventeen who came round the corner at a run with his cap in his hand and put him inside the cordon at the fourth step that he took, in the ordinary way of a man catching a hen. They took two men out of the tram queue and a third out of the crowd of the onlookers on the

corner and a fourth who had come because there was noise, and by the time the whistles went for the second time there were twenty-nine people in the middle of the cordon in the middle of the street with an armed man walking around the outside of them.

Then a captain of the formation of the east came down the line of the cars.

He was about forty, and the two ribbons of the eastern campaigns of the year 1941 and the year 1942 were on the left breast of the uniform of the shirt that he was wearing in the heat, and he came down the line of the cars, and at the third car — the car of the district of the intelligence service of the city of Warsaw, with the flag of the district on the left wing and the driver of the General of the district at the wheel — he stopped, and straightened, and put his hand to his cap in the salute of an officer of the German army of the east.

"Herr Hauptmann?" said Ehlers.

"Nothing at all, nothing at all," said the captain. "A car of the district in a street of a cordon of the police of the district. This afternoon has been laid down by the office of the district, and it will take eleven minutes, and there is nothing in the city of Warsaw at four o'clock on a Friday afternoon that the office of the district is not able to arrange in a manner that is quicker for the Frau of the household of the Herr General of the district of the intelligence service, and it is a pleasure for the office of the district to be at the disposal of the wife of the Herr General."

He turned and put up his arm to the line of the cars, and the two lorries of the cordon were moved by their drivers out of the mouth of the street, and the queue of the cars went forward, one at a time, through the middle of the cordon; and the Mercedes of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw went through the middle of them at the walking pace of a funeral, at four metres from the middle of the cordon, and the woman of the household of the General of the district of the intelligence service of the city of Warsaw looked out of the window of the car, at a distance of the width of a street, at the twenty-nine people of the city of Warsaw in the middle of the armed men, at the wife of the man of forty in the clean shirt with her hands at her sides, at the boy of seventeen with his cap in his hand, at the crowd of the onlookers on the corner of the street, and at the population of the city of her birth looking back at her through the glass of a German car.

There was a woman of about fifty at the edge of the crowd with a shopping net, and she looked at the car and at the woman inside the car for

four seconds, with the flat, patient, bottomless attention of a population of a city that has been in the same war for four years and has begun to draw the accounts; and the woman in the car held her eyes for the four seconds, and then looked at the floor of the car and then at the street in front of it.

They knew what I was in the year 1938, she thought, in the back of a car going through a cordon of the police of the German district of Warsaw, at four o'clock in the afternoon of the fourteenth of May 1943, with the papers of the household in her bag. *The the city of Warsaw knew what I was: the Stankiewicz girl, the one with the father the professor, and because the population of this city keeps the accounts in the ten fingers of it, and the population of this city is in the four thousand windows of the four streets of the German quarter, and every one of the four thousand windows is able to see the German car that is going through the cordon at the walking pace of a funeral with the woman in the back of it.*

The tram came. The woman turned her head.

And Krystyna Stankiewiczówna did the thing that decided the next fourteen months of her life, which was not to walk past her, and not to turn away, but to walk directly towards her, and stop, and take off her hat, and say:

"Madame Ostrowska. Do you remember me? It is Krystyna Stankiewicz."

And the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska, sixty-eight years old, of the house of Ostrowski of the Ślepowron, the aunt of a girl who had been at school with her, who had held her in her arms in 1929, who had lost a son at the Bzura in the second week of September 1939 and a husband in the first — the Countess looked at her for a long, long moment; and her eyes, which were the eyes of the oldest Polish aristocracy of that city, with the four hundred years in them, went from the hat, to the gloves, to the bag, to the shoes, to the face, in the order in which the women of her world looked at a woman they were being introduced to.

"Krystyna," she said. "My dear child. How you have grown."

And then she took her arm, in the middle of the street, and walked her eleven metres, and said, in a voice pitched for the two of them, at a volume *just* slightly too loud, in the terrible, beautiful way of a woman of her class who has spent her life talking over the noise of a drawing room:

"We shall not speak here; we shall speak on Thursday at my house, and you shall tell me everything about the south of France, because I hear that the

wildflowers there are still going; and in the meantime, my dear, I want you to promise me something."

"Anything."

"Never take your hat off in the street," said the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska, "when you speak to a woman who knows you."

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Eleven Days

♦ ♦ ♦

The house of the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska was on the Mokotowska, four hundred metres from the house of the Colonel, and it had two floors of a building of 1898, and a courtyard with a well in it, and a drawing room that had been stripped in 1939 of everything but a piano, a portrait of a man with a moustache, and a set of chairs that had been in the family since the eighteen-fifties and had the last century in the wood.

On the Thursday, Marion Herschlag went to it at five in the afternoon in the coat of a Frenchwoman of the German administration, and the Countess received her in the drawing room in a grey dress and a brooch, and they sat facing each other across a small table, and for the first eleven minutes they spoke about the wildflowers of the Midi, and the Countess's maid, who was fifty-five and deaf, brought tea in a glass, and there was a plate with three small biscuits on it that had been made, Marion understood at the first bite, out of German flour with the stamp of the district on the bag, which meant that the Countess had a source, which in Warsaw in 1943 was the same thing as having a password.

Then the Countess put down her glass and said, in French, in the flat accent of a woman who had been taught by a governess from Neuchâtel in 1887:

"Now, my dear. Who are you?"

"Marion Herschlag."

"The woman who is in the house of the Oberst von Reuth."

"Yes."

"And in the house of the Oberst von Reuth, there is a Frenchwoman, aged thirty-one, from Strasbourg; she has been with him since last autumn; she goes to the German store on the Nowy Świat; she takes tea with the wives at the Blue Palace; and in the four years of the German occupation of this city nobody has ever come to me and said, 'Jadwiga, what do you know about the Oberst's Frenchwoman?'" The Countess looked at her with a face like a page of an old book. "That is not an accident, my child. That is a piece of architecture. There are five hundred women in this city who know the German administration's private life, and there is not one of them who would not have sold you for a kilo of lard three weeks ago; and the reason they have not is that you have never once, in seven weeks, been seen to be *anybody*; and I want you to understand that this is the most extraordinary thing I have ever seen a young woman do, and I have been watching the Polish women of this city survive the Russians, the Germans and each other since 1915."

"Madame."

"Do not interrupt me." The Countess poured more tea. She did it in the way of a woman whose hands had been pouring tea for sixty years. "Now. What are we to do with you?"

"I don't know what you mean."

"I mean that you were born in this city and that I knew your mother, and that on the second of December 1939 the blackshirts came to your building and burnt the papers in the courtyard, and I know about your father, because everyone in this city of the old world knows about everybody who is left, and I know that the Stankiewicz register has been closed since 1940, and that there is a caretaker's certificate in the housing office on the Krasińskiego with a professor's name on it, and that in the winter the certificate expires." She drank her tea. "And I know that there is a woman of twenty-eight with one short leg who works in the records office of the tram company, and that she buys an orange a day, which is impossible, which means she has been lying to her canteen for two years for the sake of an old man; and all of this I know because this is what we do now: we know everything about each other and nothing at all, because knowledge is the only currency in the world, and the Germans take everything else."

Marion Herschlag sat in the chair that had been in the family of Ostrowski since 1851 and looked at a woman of sixty-eight who had lost a son at the

Bzura and a husband in the first week of the war; and she made, in four seconds, the longest calculation of her life.

"Madame," she said, "I cannot tell you."

"I have not asked you to."

"You have asked me who I am."

"And you have told me," said the Countess. "The one thing I wanted to know was whether you would tell me a lie, and you have not; and that is all I need to know, because the rest is your business and God's, and I am not in the business of either." She set the glass down. "Now, listen to me, because we are going to spend the rest of the war being extremely careful with one another, and there are four things I am going to give you, and you are not to thank me for any of them.

"The first is that in this house you are the widow of a Frenchman named Herschlag, and a distant connection of my late husband's family, and you are able to come here, because it is understood among the German ladies of this district that I am a harmless old woman with a piano who has a French niece; and I have been establishing that for six weeks, since the day I saw you in the Krasińskiego, in the way one establishes such things, which is by mentioning it, at parties, to the wife of the supply officer, twice, in passing, in the same sentence as a complaint about the price of butter.

"The second is that the woman who cooks for me was the cook at your mother's house in 1934, and she is deaf, and she has been in the back of my kitchen for three days with her hands shaking, and she will not look at you, and you will not go into the kitchen.

"The third is that if you are ever in a room with a German officer and you are asked, by that officer, whether you know the Ostrowski family, you will say: *no, but I have heard of them; the Countess has a bad heart and no sons*. That is the sentence. In that order. Because it is true, and because nothing a German officer hears is ever wasted, and because a woman who tells a small true thing instead of a large false thing is a woman who is believed.

"And the fourth is that on the days when they are taking people out of the buildings in the Krasińskiego and the Długa and the Miodowa, you will not be able to get to your father from the south, and you must not try, because on those days the north of the city is a trap with the door shut; and on those days Zofia knows what to do, and Zofia has been doing it

since 1939, and I have paid for the little wood for the stove in the flat since February."

She stopped. The room was very quiet. In the courtyard the well chain knocked against the stone, in the wind, three times.

"Why?" said Krystyna.

"Because your mother," said the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska, "in the winter of 1935, took my son's side in a quarrel about a marriage, in a drawing room on the Nowy Świat, in front of eleven people, at the moment when nobody else in Warsaw would; and it cost her a friendship and a great deal of money and she never once mentioned it, and I have been waiting for eight years to pay it."

♦ ♦ ♦

The Colonel put the captain in the house.

That was how it was arranged, and it was arranged the way everything in the district was arranged, by the requirements of a man who had been given too much work and had discovered that the only way to survive it was to bring the work into the house: from the second week of July, Hauptmann Brandt came to the house on the Mokotowska on Sundays and Thursdays with a leather case and stayed from eight in the evening until eleven, at the dining-room table, with the Colonel, going through the week's paper; and Anna Zaleska was told to leave out bread and cold meat and a bottle of the Hungarian wine at ten o'clock, and the door of the dining room stayed open, and Marion Herschlag, in the salon across the hall, read a book.

She was in the house. He was in the house. That was it, and it lasted eleven days.

She had prepared herself for the first Sunday in the manner of a woman preparing for an operation: with a rehearsal of every possible sentence and a plan for the worst case. The worst case was that he came into the salon; and he did, at twenty past nine on the first Sunday, to find the newspaper; and he stood in the doorway of the salon — a captain of the Abwehr in the house of his colonel on a summer evening with the windows open, a newspaper in his hand, a woman on a sofa with a book — and he said:

"Madame."

"Hauptmann."

"I am looking for the *Völkischer Beobachter*."

"It is on the second shelf. I have been using it to hold a vase."

He found it. He went out. That was Sunday.

Thursday, he was in the garden, looking at the chestnut with the fungus, because the Colonel had sent him out with a torch to look at the chestnut, and Marion was at the window of the salon with the lamp on behind her; and they did not speak at all, and she stood at the window for four minutes and watched his back in the dark, and the way he stood with the torch in his hand: not looking at a tree at all, but standing with his shoulders, in the dark of a Polish garden, in an attitude that she had last seen on a boy of nineteen in a Botanic Garden in June, which was the attitude of a man with a book under his arm who does not want to go home yet.

Sunday, the third time: nothing. He did not come into the salon. He came at eight, and went at a quarter past eleven, and the house was aware of him, and the house pretended that the house contained one woman and two officers, and Anna Zaleska cooked the cold meat and said nothing, and Piotr Zaleski, in the yard, sharpened an axe on a stone for one hour and did it on a Sunday, which was a thing that had never once happened in the three years of the German occupation of that house.

Thursday, the fourth time, she found the book.

It was on the piano. The upright German piano of 1898, in the corner of the salon, with the good action and the bad bass: a book lying on the closed lid, and the book was a Polish book, a thin octavo with a brown spine. She picked it up and opened it, and it was what it was, and it took her four seconds to be entirely certain: it was *Podstawy mechaniki*, the third edition, a textbook, and it was not the book that she had found in a crate in the rue de la Faisanderie — but inside the front cover, in the dark place where a library stamp goes, there was a bookseller's label.

Księgarnia J. Barczyk, Nowy Świat 41, Warszawa.

Lis's shop.

She stood in a German salon in an occupied city with a Polish textbook of mathematics in her hands, and the book was open at a page where somebody had, at some time, in a house in Warsaw before the war, written in the margin in pencil a small, impatient, one-line correction.

She read the correction. It was in her father's hand.

She stood there for four minutes. She did not sit down; she did not cry; and when she had put the book back on the lid of the piano, in the same position, with the corner facing the same way, she went down the corridor

to the small room next to the Colonel's and shut the door and stood with her back against it and her fists in the sleeves of her cardigan, and did the only thing she could do, which was the arithmetic of a woman who has just been handed a live grenade by a boy in a thin shirt: *the book could not have come from the Colonel, because the Colonel does not read Polish and does not read mathematics. The book came from the flat of a Polish lodger, or from a box of paper the district has taken from a Polish house, which means it could be a piece of loot, which means it means nothing.*

It means nothing.

She said that to herself four times, and by the fourth time she had understood that the arithmetic was not the point; the point was that the book was on the piano, in the house, at the hour of a Thursday evening, in the exact place where a woman read a book; and that if a man of twenty-eight had chosen a Polish mathematics textbook, third edition, with a bookseller's label of the Nowy Świat on the cover, and had put it there, on the lid of a piano, in the house of a colonel of the Abwehr, in the middle of a war, in Warsaw, then he had chosen it in full possession of his intelligence, and had done it for one woman in Europe, and it was the single most dangerous thing that had happened to her since the milliner said the word *aunt* on a telephone in Paris.

Eleven days. It took eleven days.

She counted them afterwards, the way you count the length of an illness: eleven days from the Thursday in July when the captain stood in the doorway of a salon with a newspaper in his hand, to the Sunday evening in July when the house went out — the Colonel to the Blue Palace for a dinner, Anna and Piotr to the evening service at the church of the Visitation, at the other end of the street, because Anna Zaleska had gone to the evening service at the church of the Visitation every Sunday for three years, and had never once asked anybody for anything in that time, and had asked, that day, for leave to go a quarter of an hour early.

The garden was two chestnuts and a walnut and thirty metres of grass, with the side gate in the wall, and it came to be full of a Warsaw evening in July: the sky at nine o'clock the colour of a coal fire, the smell of the river three kilometres away, and, from the other side of the wall, in the next street, the sound of a wireless set playing a mazurka very quietly, because the Polish national wireless had been silent since 1939 and the only music in the city came out of the German stations and the gramophones of the Polish houses.

She was standing at the end of the garden by the walnut tree when he came out, because she had known, in the way she had known things since the age of eleven, that he was going to come out.

He walked the whole length of the garden, and stopped three metres from her, and did the thing that took her training and broke it: he did not speak. He stood there in the dark with his hands at his sides and looked at the walnut tree, for two minutes, with the sky going down behind the wall; and in those two minutes, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, who had spent three years learning every variation of silence in the world, understood that this was not a man being careful. It was a man deciding whether to say something that could not be taken back.

Then he said: "Eleven days."

"I know."

"I have had eleven days to work out how to say this, and I have not worked it out, so I am going to say the first true sentence and then you may do whatever you like with me." He turned his head and looked at her, and in the dark he was a stranger, a captain, a man with the scar at the corner of his mouth. "The first true sentence is this. On the eighth of April 1943, at eleven o'clock in the morning, on the platform at the Gare de l'Est, I watched you get into a railway carriage, and I stood in the corridor of that carriage for thirty-one hours, and I made a decision, and the decision was that if you spoke to me once — once, in that journey, in a year — I would get off the train at Breslau and disappear, and you would never see me again, and nobody in the world would be able to find out what I had known."

"What did you know?"

"Everything," said Phillip Brandt. "I have known everything since eleven minutes past four in the afternoon on the thirtieth of January 1943, when I saw the woman who was on the arm of my colonel at a dinner in the Hôtel Majestic turn her head at the sound of the word *Polish* in the mouth of a Luftwaffe officer, and I understood, in that second, three things: what she was, what she had been, and what she was doing with him. And then I went home and sat on the end of a bed with my boots off and did the arithmetic for four hours, and I decided to say nothing, and I have said nothing for six months, and I am thirty-two days from being posted to the eastern front, and there is not one person in Europe to whom I can say any of this." He stopped. "There. Now you may do whatever you like."

The wireless in the next street changed its tune, and the garden was full of a Portuguese fado that a German station in Warsaw was playing out of a Polish window into a Polish yard, because in the sixth year of the Reich the man who chose the programmes for the eastern stations had a sense of humour that nobody had ever managed to describe.

She stood three metres from him in the dark and did the arithmetic, and it took her nine seconds, and in the nine seconds she did the following: she considered killing him, which was not possible, and reported him to the Colonel, which was the end of both of them, and lying to him with the great beautiful efficient lie she had spent three years polishing, which would work, for months, for years, for as long as the war lasted, and which would be the single greatest labour of her life.

And then she did the thing she had been taught never to do in a room in Kraków in 1940, by a small man with a bad heart who had once sold books on the Nowy Świat.

She told him the truth, in the smallest possible quantity, in the exact place where the truth was most useful, and she did it in her own language, in her own real voice, which she had not used in the presence of another human being in the war.

"Phillip," she said, in Polish. "You have to understand something. I am not going to be able to tell you anything, ever, and you are not going to be able to ask me, and if you ever do ask me, in the house, on a stair, in the garden, in the street, I am going to lie to you in the way I would lie to a policeman, because that is what I am for; and if you take that personally, then you will kill me with your feelings, and there will never be one single moment in this war in which you will have done anything that a man cannot forgive in the last hour of his life."

"So that is a no."

"That is a yes with the war in it." She turned to him; and then, because the front door was open, because the servants were at the church, because there was a wireless set playing a fado in a Polish yard and the city outside the wall was full of people being shot for the exact thing she was doing, she crossed three metres of grass in a garden in Warsaw, in July 1943, and she reached up and put her hand flat against his face, once, for two seconds, the way she had touched her father's skull; and then she took it away and went into the house.

He said one word, behind her, in the dark; and it was not a word she had

heard in three years; and it was the only thing anybody in the world had called her since 1940 that was true.

"Krystyna."

She went into the house. She went up the stairs, past the room of a doctor's daughter, past the door of the big bedroom where a general's blanket lay folded, into the small room next to the Colonel's, and shut the door and stood in the dark with her forehead against the door and her eyes closed; and heard the side gate shut, and the garden go quiet, and the wireless in the next street end its fado and go over to the news in German.

Eleven days.

At midnight the Colonel came home, and found her reading in the salon, and stood in the door with his cap still in his hand.

"You are up."

"It is too hot to sleep."

"It is." He came in and sat down heavily in the chair opposite her; and he had drunk; and he was, in the way of a man after a dinner at the Blue Palace, all the way through in one piece and about to tell her something. "Brandt was at table tonight. I have put him on the eastern list. They want him in Riga in September."

She kept her eyes on the page of the book.

"He will be sorry to go," she said.

"Yes." The Colonel looked at the window. "He said something to me tonight, at the door, when he was putting his cap on. He said, *Herr Oberst, the Poles in this district have a saying: the man who carries a lamp in the dark is the man who is shot at first.* And I said, *and what is the saying for the man who carries the lamp for somebody else?* and he said, *there is no saying for him, sir; he is the lamp.*"

He laughed, that short bark, the door closing.

"I like him," said the Colonel of the intelligence section of the Warsaw district. "I have never once known what he thinks, and I have never once had a reason to distrust him, and I shall put him on the Riga train in September with a letter in his file that will make him a major in a year, because that, my dear, is the whole art of a colonel: you take a young man who is nothing, you give him a lamp to carry, and you watch which way he walks with it."

He got up, and went to bed; and in the small room next to the big bedroom, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna lay in the dark, listening to the city,

and did the last of the arithmetic she ever did with a clear head about the man on the other side of the wall.

Ninety days have become fifty, and the fifty have become eleven, and the eleven have become a garden, and now there is a train to Riga in September, and there is a man who knows everything and has said nothing for six months, and there is a paper in a safe in the study with a serial number on it that I can read off a brass plate with a duster in my hand.

And there is a boy in a thin shirt in front of a glasshouse, in 1938, holding a closed book, in a photograph clipped into a German file.

Anna Zaleska asked her on the eleventh of the month, in the kitchen, at the sink, with a bowl in her hands.

She did it in the way of a Polish woman of fifty who has been in the service of German houses for four years: standing at the sink with her back to the room, and the water running, and no introduction, no preamble, and no name.

"The Pan has a cousin in the Gęsiówka."

"I do not know the word."

"The Pan knows the word." The water stopped. Anna Zaleska put the bowl upside down on the board and took up the cloth and began to dry it, and she did not turn round. "The camp on the Dzielna. The one that is in the old prison building, where the Jews of the small towns were kept in the year 1941 and where the men of this city have been kept since the month of the November. My Piotr has a cousin there, and the cousin has been in it since the twenty-ninth of November, and the reason he is in it is a blue policeman on the Chłodna who wanted the room, and the cousin has a wife and two children in the Praga and the wife is my own blood, and the transports have begun."

Marion Herschlag stood at the table of the kitchen of the house on the Mokotowska with the plate of the evening in her hands.

"Say it."

"The transports have begun," said Anna Zaleska, "and the first of them went in the month of the February, and there is a paper of the administration of the district that puts the men of that camp into the transports of the labour administration of the Reich, and the wife of the cousin has been at the window of the house of the administration of the district on the avenue of the Ujazdowskie for three days, and there is nobody in the German administration of this city who is going to speak to a woman of the Praga in a doorway, and the family has understood that, and the family

has decided that the person who is going to speak is the woman of the household of the Colonel of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw."

The kitchen was quiet, except for the clock of the corridor.

"And what is the thing that the family has decided that the woman of the household of the Colonel of the district of the intelligence service is going to do?" said Marion Herschlag, in Polish, with her face composed, in the tone of a woman of a house asking about the price of the meat, because the door of the kitchen was open and the corridor of the German house on the Mokotowska had no door at the end of it.

"Take a paper to the office of the labour administration," said Anna Zaleska, "with the name of the cousin on it, and the signature of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw under the name, and the word *unentbehrlich*, which is the word that the administration of the Reich uses for a man who is not able to be taken, and it is one line in one paper in one office, and the cousin comes out of the Gęsiówka on the cart of the labour administration of the district and goes to his wife and his two children in the Praga, and there is nothing in it that costs anybody anything except the ink."

"That is it?"

"That is it."

"Then let me tell you the truth about your line of one paper and one office, in this kitchen, in the German house, with the door open," said Marion Herschlag, very quietly, in Polish. "There is no line. There is a signature, and the signature is a general of the intelligence service of the German district of Warsaw; and a general of the intelligence service of a German district who signs a paper about a man of the Gęsiówka in the year 1943 signs a piece of paper that goes into a file, and the file is in the office of the administration, and the office of the administration of this district is at this hour in the hands of men who keep a card for every piece of paper in this city, and the card of that paper would say: a man of the Gęsiówka was taken out of the transport by an order with the signature of a general of the intelligence service of the district, and against it there would be a second card, and the second card would have a single question on it, and the question is my life. That is what the line of one paper would cost, and it is not the ink. It is the arrangement: the house, the woman of the household, the table, the bed of the General of the intelligence service

of the district of Warsaw, and every hour of the day of a woman of Alsace in the fifth year of the war."

Anna Zaleska put the cloth down.

"I know what it costs," she said, in her own language, to the wall above the sink. "I have known it since the month of the February, and I have sat with it since the month of the February, and I have not said it to you because you have not been a person to me, and this house knows what you are, and I have kept the soup and the linen and the floor, and I have not looked at your face for a year. But the transports have begun." She turned round for the first time and looked at her with her face in the light of the kitchen of the German administration of the city of Warsaw: the face of a woman of fifty from the Praga with the widow's cross of the year 1939 and the patience of a population. "So I am asking the German's woman the question, once, in the kitchen, and I know that she is going to say no, and I am asking it because one of us has to say it out loud in this house."

And Marion Herschlag, of the household of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, stood in the kitchen with the plate in her hands and did the arithmetic of the second and looked at it, and the arithmetic had one answer and it was the answer that she had known before the question was put to her, and the exact character of the thing she was doing was simple: she was going to say no to the wife of the cousin and to the cousin and to the two children of the cousin in the Praga, and she was going to say it in the kitchen of the German house, in Polish, to a woman of the same city as herself, and both of them were going to understand the reason and neither of them was ever going to say it.

"No," she said.

"I know."

"Anna."

"Take the plate to the dining room," said Anna Zaleska, "and do not say the name of the cousin in the dining room, and the rest of it is between the two of us, and there is nothing in the world that is able to be done about it, and that is the reason that this war is the war of the German administration of the city of Warsaw."

She took up the bowls and put them in the sink, and Marion Herschlag carried the plate into the dining room of a doctor's house and put it down in front of the Ordonnanzoffizier of the district of Warsaw, and set her face the way a woman of the profession sets a face, in eleven seconds, in a doorway; and in the five months of the war, in the city of Warsaw, in the

house of a German general, the woman of that house never afterwards had a single conversation with the woman of the kitchen that lasted longer than the arranging of the soup.

The cousin of Piotr Zaleski went into the transport of the labour administration of the district of Warsaw in the month of the March of 1943, and there is not one paper in the world about the rest of the life of the man, and the wife and the two children of the cousin of Piotr Zaleski went to the Praga and then to the province, and there is not one thing about it in this book.

And if I am going to use him, I have to decide, tonight, which of the two of us is going to be the lamp and which of us is going to be the thing that is shot at.

CHAPTER TWELVE

The Ordonnanzoffizier

♦ ♦ ♦

The office of the Ordonnanzoffizier of the intelligence section of the Warsaw district was on the ground floor of the Blue Palace, at the end of a corridor that had been the corridor of the household of a family of magnates in the eighteenth century and was now the corridor of the district of Warsaw in the fourth year of the occupation; and it had in it a desk, a table with a map on it under a green cloth, two telephones, a bookcase into which somebody had put the code books of the section in 1939, and a window on the inner courtyard, and the window was the reason for the arrangement that governed the following summer of her life, because it looked out onto the yard where the cars were parked, and through it, from the desk of the Ordonnanzoffizier, could be seen the movement of the district: who came, who went, which cars were loaded, which boxes were carried, and when the great Mercedes of the General with the flag on the wing was left standing at the door for eleven minutes with its engine running.

She came to the office four times in the third week of July, on four entirely legitimate errands, each of which required her to wait, and each of which had been manufactured by her with her craft: the papers of the household expenses of the Colonel, which went through the district's accounts; the form for the district's permission for her to be absent from the Generalgouvernement for a period of not more than eleven days, which was never going to be used; the invoice for the repair of the Colonel's field boots; and the four letters that had come from Berlin and needed, according to the

Colonel's own instruction, *to be kept out of the hands of the clerks, because two of them are from my sister and one of them is from a General who writes badly.*

Each of the four errands was good for eleven to twenty minutes at the door of the office, by the simple method of there being no chair, and each of the four times she stood in the doorway of the room with the documents in her hand and watched the interior of the district of Warsaw pass through the yard of the Blue Palace; and each of the four times the captain who was the Ordonnanzoffizier of the section stood up from his desk and was, to the world, exactly what he appeared to be: a captain of twenty-eight who was being extremely correct with the woman of his colonel.

The fifth time, they spoke.

It was a Thursday, and the errand was the boots again, and the boots were unnecessary, and both of them knew it, and the room knew it, which in a German office meant that the clerk at the far end of the corridor knew that the Frenchwoman of the Oberst was standing in the door of the Ordonnanzoffizier's office for eleven minutes to hand over a paper that required four seconds; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the door of the office in the Blue Palace of Warsaw in the last week of July 1943 and made a decision that she had been carrying around for eleven days like a stone in a pocket.

"You are on the Riga list," she said, in French.

"I am on the Riga list."

"Is that what you want?"

He finished writing the line he was writing; blotted it; put the pen in the pen-rest; and looked up, and it — the pen, the blotter, the four seconds — told her, or would have told any German officer who was watching from the corridor, that the adjutant of the Oberst was being careful and correct with a woman who was talking to him about the eastern front.

"No," he said. "I want nothing that begins with an R and ends with Riga. I am a Polish boy from Warsaw whose father was a German consular official, and I have been given a German uniform and a German file, and there is only one thing in my life that I have ever wanted, and it was in a Botanic Garden in 1938, and I am not going to be able to have it, because I am also, in a manner of speaking, on the Riga list of God." He stood up. "The leather is repaired. There is a receipt. The Oberst does not need the receipt; you may keep it."

"Thank you."

"The weather in the east," said the captain, in a completely different voice, at a completely different volume, "is intolerable in August." And then, in Polish, quickly, quietly, with his face entirely blank: "There is a man of mine in the motor pool. My driver, Unteroffizier Klemens. He is from Poznań and he is a Pole in a German uniform like me, and he is the only person alive who can be in a room with me and the two of us not be in a German room; and if you ever need a car, in a manner that is not German, it can be arranged, and the arrangement looks like two soldiers who wish to go to a wedding."

She looked at the desk. She looked at the window with the yard behind it, where a lorry of the district was being loaded with crates by four Polish workmen under the eye of a Feldwebel, in the ordinary way of the world.

"One question," she said, in Polish.

"Ask it."

"Your file. The autumn of 1939. There are seven weeks in it that have been written over twice, and one of the men who wrote over them wrote *in Ordnung*, and the other one did not sign it."

He was quiet for a moment, and then he did something she had never seen a German officer do in a German office, which was to sit down on the edge of his own desk, sideways, with one foot on the floor, in the whole attitude of a Polish student in a corridor.

"In September 1939," he said, "I was twenty-four, and my father was a German consular official who had died in July, and my mother was a Warsaw woman who had died in 1937; and I was called up in the Polish reserve on the twenty-eighth of August, and I fought with my unit for eleven days, from the north, and on the eleventh day the unit was broken at a place called Modlin, and I was in a ditch with a broken wrist and two other men, and we walked east for four days and were taken by a German patrol at a crossroads; and the officer who took us looked at my papers, and saw that my father was a German official, and saw that I was, in the meaning of the law of 1939, a *Volksdeutscher*; and he did the thing that German officers did in those weeks about two thousand times, in both directions, in Poland: he made a mistake in my favour. He wrote in my file that I had been conscripted into the Polish army against my will, which was a lie; and he gave me a cup of coffee and a cigarette, and he put me on a train to the west, and I have been living in his kindness for four years,

and there is not one day of my life since that crossroads at which I have been able to look at myself without that cup of coffee in my hand."

He looked at her.

"So the answer to your question is: the seven weeks were me, in a Polish uniform, with a Polish rifle, in a ditch, at Modlin; and the man who wrote *in Ordnung* over it was a German major of fifty who did not want a boy of twenty-four to be shot; and the man who did not sign it is me, because I have never once, in four years, been able to decide whether my life since that crossroads is a survival or a crime, and I have concluded that it is both, which is the peculiar position of everybody in Poland in the year 1943, and I do not require you to have an opinion about it."

She stood in the doorway with the receipt for a pair of boots in her hand.

"I am not going to have an opinion about it," she said. "But I will tell you the thing that nobody has ever told you, and that you have been waiting four years to hear from exactly one kind of person, and it is this: at Modlin, in the ditch, with a broken wrist, you were not a German officer and you were not a Pole; you were a boy of twenty-four who had lost a war in eleven days and was walking east because there was nowhere else to walk, and the fact that a German major gave you a cup of coffee afterwards does not make the ditch into a crime, and it does not make the coffee into a rescue. It makes it your life, and the rest of your life is going to be the question of what you do with the fact that somebody in a German uniform did you a kindness in 1939."

She turned to go.

"Madame Herschlag," he said, in French, at normal volume.

"Hauptmann?"

"You forgot the receipt." He held it out, deliberately, across the desk, and she crossed back and took it, and it took four seconds, and in the four seconds, in the yard outside the window, in the ordinary light of a Thursday in July, in the middle of the German administration of the district of Warsaw, Phillip Brandt said, at a volume of thirty centimetres from her ear, in Polish, without moving his face at all:

"There is a boy named Bolek in the Praga district who works in a chemist's shop on the Ząbkowska and who is going to be taken by the Kripo in the first week of October if somebody does not make him into a different boy with a different shop, and I know this because his name is on a list that came through this office on Tuesday, and I have been sitting on it since Tuesday, and I have another eleven days before I have to file it."

She did not move. She did not breathe differently. She looked at the receipt in her hand, and then she looked at him with the face of a woman of twenty-seven who has been in the room of a German officer for four minutes and is now going home, and she went out into the corridor of the Blue Palace and down the stairs and past the sentry and out into the courtyard, where Ehlers was sitting in the Mercedes with the engine running.

And she got into the car, and put the receipt in her bag, and let her mind work the way it had been built to work, which was very fast and entirely without feeling; and by the time the car was out of the gate she had made the following decision, and she never once in the sixteen months that followed regretted any part of it:

I am going to have to tell him the truth about one thing only. I am going to have to tell him about Bolek.

♦ ♦ ♦

She did it on the Sunday, in the dining room, with the door open; and she did it in the way of a woman who has understood that in Warsaw in 1943 the only safe place for a conversation is a room with a door open and three people within earshot, and the only safe subject is one that can be interrupted.

The Colonel was in the drawing room with a map and a brandy; Anna was in the kitchen, thirty feet away, with her hearing, which was the good hearing of a Polish woman of fifty who had spent four years with the German occupation in her kitchen; and the captain was at the table with the week's paper in four piles in front of him.

She came in with the cold meat and the bottle.

"Herr Hauptmann. The Professor's son."

He did not look up from the paper. "What about him?"

"Nothing at all, in a German office. But I have been sitting at tea with the wives of this district for eleven weeks, and I have learned the thing that is worth more than a paper in a German office, which is what the wives say to each other about the Polish staff; and Frau Doktor Weingart said on Thursday, at the table of the Frau Generalin, over the cake, that the Kripo has a list of three hundred names out of the motor transport offices and the chemists' shops of the Praga district, and that they are going to take them in the autumn, because in the autumn they always take the men who have a trade, and that her husband says it is a mistake, because it makes the

Poles hate the *Oberkommando* more than they already do; and then the whole table discussed it for eleven minutes, in the way they do, and I sat there, and I have decided to tell you."

He looked up.

"Civilians," he said, "should not carry lists in their heads."

"Civilians in this city carry the German administration in their heads, Herr Hauptmann, because the German administration is the weather." She set the bottle down. "There is a man of twenty-two who is a chemist's boy in the Praga district, and he is a nonentity; and he is the son of a caretaker on the housing register of a building in the Krasińskiego, whose certificate expires in the winter, and if the Kripo take the boy in October, then the caretaker's register of the whole family is opened, and the mother of the boy will be the answer to the one question that nobody in this administration has yet asked."

She had never in her life said anything so close to the truth in a room that belonged to the enemy. She said it in French, in the level, faintly bored way of a woman discussing the staff, with the cold meat in her hand; and she watched it land, in a captain of the Abwehr of twenty-eight, who had been sitting on a list since Tuesday in order not to file it.

"The mother," he said, without any expression, "is dead."

"Yes."

"And the father?"

"The father," said Marion Herschlag, "is a name on a Polish caretaker's certificate, and I do not know anything about him at all, and I never shall, because I am a Frenchwoman from Strasbourg who has been in this city for eleven weeks, and it is not my business to know anything about anybody in Warsaw; but I know that a boy of twenty-two who has the *Ausweis* of a chemist's shop is a boy who is protected, and that a boy whose name is on a list is a boy who will be taken, and that the difference between those two boys is an entry in a personnel file in a district office, and that there is exactly one officer in this district who can make the difference, and the difference, Herr Hauptmann, would cost that officer nothing at all except his life."

She went out of the dining room and into the kitchen, and put the plate down, and stood with her hands on the table for a moment while Anna Zaleska went on peeling; and neither of them said a word, because there was a German in the dining room with an open door.

There were eleven days between the corridor of the Blue Palace and the

stamp.

She spent the first of them in the ordinary work of the household, and the second in the ordinary work of the household, and on the third she took the tram to the district and the boots receipt and stood at the door of the office of the Ordonnanzoffizier at the hour when the office had the slack of the afternoon in it.

The captain was not there.

The sergeant of the office was there, a man of forty from the Rhineland with the ribbon of the 1940 campaign and a bad hip, and he was filing the carbon copies of the day in the grey folders, and he said, without being asked, because a sergeant of an office of the district explains the office to a woman of a household the way a man explains a house: that the Herr Hauptmann was at the personnel section of the district, that the Herr Hauptmann had been at the personnel section since the Monday, that there was a business at the personnel section about the labour files of the district of the Praga, that the labour files of the district of Warsaw were at this hour being brought to the administrations of the labour offices of the Generalgouvernement and put on the German paper, and that there was not one man of the district who was not in the middle of it.

She stood with the receipt for a pair of boots in her hand and looked at the grey shelves of the office of the Ordonnanzoffizier of the intelligence section of the Warsaw district, and did not move her face, and heard, in the ordinary voice of a German sergeant of forty talking about his work, the exact size of the thing she had done.

She had given a captain of the Abwehr of the district two pieces of her own weight: the fact that she had an interest in a boy of the Praga with a stamped file, and the fact that she was willing to approach a German officer on her own account. There is no version of that transaction in which the officer keeps it clean. He either does nothing, and is a man who has heard a woman of the household of his own colonel ask him a thing and refused her; or he does something, and every piece of paper he uses belongs to the German administration of a city of a million people, with a number and a signature and a paragraph in a file; and she had put him in the second of those positions with a sentence in a corridor and a receipt in her hand.

The sergeant said: "The boots were the second pair this month, gnädige Frau."

"They were."

"There is a paper for the boots. The Herr Hauptmann signs the paper for the boots." He said it with the innocence of a man who has worked in an office for twenty years. "The Herr Hauptmann asked me to say, if the gnädige Frau came, that the boots are in the store of the district and that the paper of the boots is in the folder of the household, which is the third of the folders on the shelf behind me, and that the gnädige Frau is not to be troubled with the paper of the boots at any hour of the day."

Which was, in the language of an office of the intelligence service of the German army, the longest and most careful sentence that a man of twenty-eight was able to send to a woman across two metres of a floor, and it said: *it is being seen to; do not come back; do not be seen coming back.*

♦ ♦ ♦

On the Saturday there was the wives' table, at the house of the Frau Generalin of the administration on the Ujazdowskie, and she sat in the green chair by the window and drank the tea and listened to the wives.

There were nine of them, German women of Warsaw between the ages of thirty and sixty; and they talked for the afternoon about the labour campaign, because in the summer of 1943 the labour campaign was the only thing in the Generalgouvernement that was talked about, in the German houses and in the Polish queues and in the offices: the round-ups in the streets, the placards of the labour offices, the boys taken from the market of the Wola and the girls taken from the tram, the transports of the district of the Praga and the factories of the north of the city emptied of their young men and filled again with the ones who had been caught. The wife of the medical officer said that the labour office had been given a quota of fourteen thousand for the district of Warsaw. The wife of the officer of the supply section said that her gardener had gone, and that there was nobody to cut the grass, and that she had written to the office about it. The Frau Generalin said that it was a necessary thing and a terrible thing and that it was not the business of the wives of the administration to have opinions about it.

And the woman of the Colonel of the intelligence section of the district sat in the green chair and drank the tea and said, in her turn, in the French of a woman of Strasbourg, that in her country the young men had been taken in the same way in the second year, in the streets of the towns of the south, and that a woman of France knew the look of a street where the

boys had gone, and that there was no woman in Europe of any nation who did not know it, and that she thought about it as little as possible because thinking about it did not return a single one of them.

It was the safest sentence she had made in five months, and it bought her the afternoon of the wives' table, and it was not a lie.

And in the tram, on the way home, in the car for the German administration with the wooden seats and the notices, she looked at the city through the window and did the arithmetic that she had been refusing to do since Thursday, and the arithmetic was: *fourteen thousand in this district; and one boy of the Praga in the middle of them, whose file is a stamped file in a drawer of the labour office and whose stamp, if the camp comes to the Praga, is the only piece of paper in the city that will stand between him and the transport; and I have asked the Ordonnanzoffizier for a stamp.*

The tram stopped at the corner of the Krucza and a German officer got on with a paper under his arm, and she moved her bag on her knees, and looked at the houses of the city sliding past her, and did not permit herself, in the eleven minutes to the Mokotowska, to think about anything else.

♦ ♦ ♦

The Colonel came home to the bed on the Sunday night and had her the way he had her when he had been in the district for eleven hours and had not eaten.

He was fifty-four, and he had been at war since 1914 with an interruption of twenty years, and in the bed he was a man of the province: without a word, without a light, without a hand on her face; and she had learned in the first month of the arrangement in Paris that the work of the bed was in her hands and her breath and the timing of her own body, and she did the work the way she had been trained to do it in the long room in Kraków, which is to say she did it with her attention, and, on the level above the body, with the part of her that in a bed in Warsaw in 1943 was always writing: *he is going to talk afterwards; the talking is the work; the body is only the door of the talking.*

He talked afterwards.

He lay on his back in the dark with his arm across her body and the cigarette in his left hand, and he said that the labour campaign had a paper behind it, and that the paper had been written in Berlin in the spring and signed in the spring, and that the administration of the east was at this

hour in the position of the wagon behind a horse that has been frightened; and then he said that the district of the intelligence service had been asked for its assessment of the effect of the campaign on the security position of the city, and that he had written the assessment with his own hand in one page, and that the one page had said what he always said, which was that a population which is being hunted in the street is a population which has nothing to lose and that there was no intelligence service in the history of the world that had ever been able to work in a city of that kind.

He smoked.

"You are quiet," he said.

"I am thinking about the page."

"About the page."

"That a man writes a page for an office and the office puts the page in a file and the file is read by nobody, and in the time the boys are being taken in the streets; and that the woman in this bed is in the household of the man who wrote the page, and has a French passport and a card of residence, and is not taken, and will not be taken." She said it in the flat voice of the dark, with her face away from him, and it was the truth, and it was in the bed because she had spent four days thinking about a boy in the Praga and had not been able to say a word about him to any human being in the world. "It is not an opinion, Friedrich. It is a fact about the two of us, and there are facts in this house that we do not say out loud, and I am saying one of them because I am tired and because you asked me why I was quiet."

He was silent for a long time.

"You are the only person in this city," he said at last, "who has ever said a thing to me in this bed that I have not been able to answer."

And then, in the dark, with the cigarette going out in his hand, he did the thing that she was never able to explain afterwards: he put his hand flat on her stomach, the way he did when he wanted to know whether she was lying, and left it there, and it was not a question and it was not a threat, and in the five months it was the only physical contact in that house that had nothing in it for him at all.

♦ ♦ ♦

On the eleventh day she took the tram to the Praga at the hour of the middle of the morning, on a legitimate errand of the household, with the basket, past the labour office of the district at the corner of the Ząbkowska, and she did

not look at the door of the labour office, and she did not look at the chemist's shop, and she bought the onions and the salt and the two hundred grams of the coffee substitute at the shop of a Pole of the Praga on the Brukowa, and paid for them with the money of the household, and came home the long way, by way of the bridge.

There was a queue of eleven women under the arch of the bridge, waiting for the labour office, and a placard of the labour administration on the wall with the German text on it and the Polish text under the German text, and the notice of the transports of the male population of the district of the Praga born between the years 1919 and 1925; and the queue stood in the light of the middle of the day and said nothing at all, in the way that a queue of women of Warsaw stood and said nothing in 1943, and there was a girl in a headscarf in the middle of the queue of about twenty years of age who was holding a certificate of employment and reading the placard the way a person reads a sentence that is being read by everyone.

She walked past it with the basket on her arm.

On the eleventh of August, in the afternoon, in the city, in the office of the district labour administration on the Dzika, a clerk of fifty with a rubber stamp in his hand opened a file on a boy of twenty-two named Bolek Stankiewicz, chemist's assistant of the Ząbkowska, and read the accompanying note, which was signed by a Hauptmann of the intelligence section of the district, and which said that the man was, in the opinion of the personnel section, *unentbehrlich* — indispensable — to the chemical supply arrangement of the district hospital of Praga; and the clerk put the stamp in the ink and stamped it, and put the file back in the drawer, and the boy in the chemist's shop on the Ząbkowska lived, and worked, and stole, in the manner of his generation, and did not know, and never knew, that his life had been saved twice: once by a sister in a good coat who had broken the first rule of her existence for him, and once by a captain who had signed his name on a piece of paper in a German office with his own hand.

The Colonel came home at eight o'clock that evening and had his dinner and said nothing about anything, and at half past ten he took Marion Herschlag into the big bedroom and did what he did with her, in the way he had done it since April: holding her down on the blanket with one hand over her mouth and the weight of the east on top of her, in the dark, in the particular manner of a man who had been given a district and needed feeding; and when it was over, and he had put his arm over his eyes,

and the room had gone quiet, she lay beside him in the dark with her hands at her sides, in the exact position of a woman who has been used by a colonel of the Abwehr, and she was not there at all.

She was, in the eleven minutes after it, in a garden on the Mokotowska in the dark, standing three metres from a man who had said her name.

She was in a photograph clipped into a file: a boy of nineteen in a thin shirt in front of a glasshouse, holding a closed book.

She was in a ditch at Modlin in 1939 with a broken wrist and a cup of coffee; and in a doorway in Paris in a good grey coat with a book about the botany of the Kampinos Forest; and in the corridor of a train between Forbach and Breslau, making a decision on the thirty-one hours.

And she was in a room in Kraków in the winter of 1940, standing in front of a small man with a bad heart and a bad fire, saying the fourth rule back to him, the one he had made her repeat four times: *never love; it is not a moral instruction, it is arithmetic.*

It is arithmetic, she thought, in the dark, in the big bedroom of a doctor's house in the city of her birth, with a hand over the place where her mouth had been.

And the arithmetic says that a woman who has begun to be in a garden when her body is in a bed has already lost the only argument she was ever going to be able to win.

CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Amber and Ash

♦ ♦ ♦

In September the war turned, and everyone in Warsaw knew it within four days, and nobody in Warsaw was permitted to say a word about it. The Italian armistice came on the wireless on the ninth, in German, out of the loudspeakers that the administration had put up at the corners of the Marszałkowska and the Nowy Świat; and the Poles stood under the loudspeakers in the ordinary way and listened to a German announcer explain, in an even voice, that the German Reich had foreseen it and had taken the necessary measures; and a man of fifty in a cap, standing beside Marion Herschlag, said to nobody at all, in Polish, at a normal volume, "Ah. The necessary measures," and eleven people in the crowd laughed, and the German soldier on the corner did not turn his head, because the city had learned that a Pole who laughed at the loudspeaker in the street and a German who heard him were two men in a legal relationship that had been settled in 1940 and was not worth reopening.

She bought a newspaper. She read it in the tram, standing, in the ordinary crowd, and her education in the reading of German newspapers had been the gift of a small man with a bad heart who had once sold books on the Nowy Świat, and the education was this: *read a German paper for the verbs, not the nouns; the nouns are wishes, the verbs are facts*. And the verbs in the German press of September 1943 said: *shortened*; *straightened*; *consolidated*; *will be held*; and nowhere in the sheet, in an entire page of

the eastern front, was the simple transitive verb that the German Reich had been using since the twenty-second of June 1941, which was: *took*.

She got off the tram at the corner of the Nowy Świat and went into the German store and bought coffee, and on the way home she did the arithmetic that she had spent the summer putting off: *the war is going to end, and it is going to end in this city, and when it ends, the men in the blue palace are going to become an army in a trap; and a man in a trap is a man who can be killed with his own household.*

That afternoon, at four o'clock, in the courtyard of the Blue Palace, she saw a man with a green notebook.

He was standing by the door of the SD building, which was on the other side of the courtyard, with his back to her, and he was doing what he had done in Paris: a small man with the shoulders of a swimmer, standing with his hands behind his back and his attention on the yard; and she knew him by the way he stood before she had seen the smallest fraction of his face, and she went on walking towards the car with her training holding her body steady, and Ehlers opened the door, and she got in, and the car went out of the gate.

"Herr Kroll," said Ehlers, from the front, in the tone of a man remarking on the weather.

"You know him?"

"The the city knows him now. He came in August; he is the deputy chief of the SD office; he is the man who has the two hundred thousand names of the Poles of this district in a card index, and he is the man they send when a German officer in the east is killed and they want to make an example of a hundred Poles in one afternoon." Ehlers drove. "My Marta's uncle was a tram conductor in the Praga district and he was taken in March and we do not know where. Kroll is a man with a card index and a good pair of shoes, and everybody in this administration would rather have a hundred men like Freytag, because a man like Freytag is a butcher and he is finished by dinner, but a man with a card index is a man who is still there in the spring."

Marion Herschlag sat in the back of the car and looked out at the city, and the sun was going down over the roofs of the north, over the wall, over a district of streets in which a hundred and fifty thousand people were living in a space the size of a small town, and she thought about a room on the second floor of the Hôtel Majestic in Paris, in April, with a table and two chairs and a window with a blackout on it, and a man who had stood up

when she came in, and had said, in eleven minutes, the single most frightening sentence that anyone had ever said to her: *there is no gap in your twenty minutes; that is why I am here: not because you are suspected, but because you are available, which is a different matter, and always will be, until I have found the actual hole in the building.*

You did not find the hole, Hauptsturmführer, she thought, as the car went along the Kopernika. *You found the building. And now you have come to the second building, and there is a card index in it the size of a piano, and in that index there is one card with a woman's false name on it, and in the six months to come you are going to look for a hole in the German administration of Warsaw, and what you will find, in the end, is the wife of a colonel who has been in two cities and who has never once been a person.*

♦ ♦ ♦

The Colonel gave her the combination on the twentieth of September, in the dark, in bed, in a manner so entirely characteristic of him that she thought, afterwards, that if she had been asked to invent a scene to explain Friedrich von Reuth to a court, she would have written down exactly that.

He had come home from the Blue Palace at half past eleven with the Italian business on him, which is to say: he had spent the day in a room with a General who had been told from Berlin that nothing had changed, and he had spent the day knowing that everything had changed, and he had come home and eaten his dinner and drunk four glasses of the Hungarian wine and had then taken her to bed and done what he did, with the weight of a district, in the way of a man who is trying to prove to himself the only thing about the world that he still believes.

Afterwards he did not put his arm over his eyes. He lay on his back in the dark and looked at the ceiling, which had the shadow of a curtain on it, the same bandage, the same ceiling, one wall away from the ceiling of the doctor who had built the house in 1911, and he said:

"Anneliese was born on the ninth of April."

She lay beside him in the dark. She said nothing at all, which is the correct answer to every sentence of that kind.

"Nine. Four. Thirty-six." He said it slowly, one figure at a time, into the dark, in the voice of a man reading a number off a stone. "That is the combination of the safe in my study. It has been the combination of every safe I have ever had, in Berlin, in Riga, in Paris, and here. When I got the

new one in April, I told the Organisation Todt man to set it to that, and he did it, because I am a colonel and he was a sergeant and the war is nearly over and nobody is going to be court-martialled for a safe."

She lay perfectly still.

"Why are you telling me?"

"Because in the last month I have been in two rooms in which men I have known for twenty years explained to a General that everything was in order, and I have seen the General's face, and on the twenty-second of August a man I was at cadet school with, a colonel of the infantry, was killed on the road to Kharkov by a mine, and his estate consisted of a trunk and a dog; and because of that, and because of a piece of paper I received on Thursday from the office of the district court concerning the probate of my wife's estate, which has now taken four years and eleven months to be settled, I have decided to put my life in one place where the Organisation Todt cannot lose it, and there is only one place in this house where a man's life will not be opened by a Pole with a screwdriver in the last week of the war, and it is that safe." He turned his head. In the dark she could see nothing, and she could feel the entire enormous fact of him beside her: a colonel of fifty-four, in a house he had been given, in a city he had been given, in a war he had been given the previous year to lose. "You will remember that number."

"Yes."

"A woman may forget what a man tells her in bed. It is permitted; it is one of the graces of the sex; and I do not mind about the rest of it, because the rest of it is nothing." He put his hand on her stomach, flat, with the whole weight of it. "But you will remember that number, because there is going to be an afternoon, my dear, possibly in the spring, possibly later, when I am not going to be able to come home, and there is going to be a woman in this house who will be visited by men in uniforms who are not mine, and on that afternoon the only thing in my existence that will not be in the hands of those men is going to be the contents of a steel box in the wall of a study behind the photograph of my wife's garden. And I want you to take it. Whatever is in it — money, and the deeds of the Pomeranian land, and a portfolio of my wife's paper, and two letters from Ilse — I want you to take it, and walk out of the front door of this house with it in your hands, and leave the rest, and not look back at the house."

"Friedrich."

"Say that you will."

"I will."

He fell asleep, holding her, with the weight of his hand; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna lay beneath a sleeping colonel of the Abwehr in the fourth year of the war and looked at the ceiling with a bandage of shadow on it, and did the arithmetic, and the arithmetic was this: *nine, four, thirty-six. The ninth of April, thirty-six. The day before the tenth. Six days after my own birthday in nineteen seventeen. In my head, on the shelf, in the long room at the back, next to the manufacturer's plate on the Organisation Todt safe and the number of the combination written in a procurement clerk's table in a document concerning office materials, and now, at the front of the shelf, where my hands can reach it at any hour of any night in the coming year.* And she lay awake with her heart going slowly and perfectly, and, on the other side of the wall, in the room of the Ordonnanzoffizier's papers, in the drawer of a desk in a house on the Mokotowska, there was a file with a boy's name in it that had been saved, and a woman in a garden at four o'clock in the afternoon in September in the second year of the occupation had been given the power of life and death over the man who was asleep with his hand on her stomach.

It is arithmetic, she thought. *And it is the worst thing that has ever happened to me, and I am going to use it, and there is not a single hour between this one and the last one of the war in which I shall be able to put my hand on this bed and feel anything at all.*

♦ ♦ ♦

The man with the book came in the last week of September, at the church of the Visitation, at four in the afternoon, as she had been told in May, by a girl of seventeen with a bucket of paper flowers.

He was a priest.

That was the first surprise, and it was a good one, and she understood, standing in the aisle of a church in the fourth year of the occupation of the city of Warsaw, why the network had been built the way it had: a priest is the only man in Poland who can be in a church at any hour, and can speak to any woman in the city, in the daylight, and be seen by no one at all.

He was about forty-five. He had the face of a man who had been in a seminary and then in the army and then in a parish, and the hands of a man who had worked; and he heard her confession in a manner that was, in its whole structure, exactly what it appeared to be, because she had been told

to make a real confession of the small things and to keep the large ones; and when the small things were done, and the church was empty, and the smell of the candles and the damp of the stone and the Warsaw autumn came in through the great door, he said, in Polish, quietly, with his hands on the grille:

"I am told that you have never asked for anything."

"I was told to ask for nothing."

"By a man in the west who is dead?"

"By a man in Paris who had a bad heart."

"Then the arrangement is now in the hands of the men of this city, and the men of this city are extremely hungry, and I am told that you have, in your possession, in your head, a certain amount of a certain paper, and that the paper is three months old and worth less every day, because paper in this war is like bread: it is the same loaf, but the city is eating it and nobody wants to pay for a week-old piece." He paused. "Tell me it, and do not explain it."

She told him.

She did it for eleven minutes, in a whisper, in the smell of the candles, with the discipline of three years: the III b registry in Paris, forty pages, a grid per city, three hands, three inks, and the fact that it was a map of the Polish underground in France drawn by somebody inside it; the Fall *Wotan* page with eleven towns and eleven dates and the last date in the right-hand column, the eighth of August 1944, and the pencil sentence underneath it, *die Linie ist bis zum Datum ununterbrochen zu halten*; the personnel file of a captain of the Abwehr born in Warsaw in 1915, with seven weeks written over twice in the autumn of 1939; the number of a manufacturer's plate on a safe in the study of a colonel of the district intelligence section of Warsaw; and four names of the district's section chiefs, and their habits, and the fact that the General telephoned Berlin twice a week from his bedroom and never once from his office.

When she had finished, there was a silence in the confessional that went on for a long time.

"A map of us," the priest said at last, "drawn by one of us. That is the first thing, and it is the thing for which Paris is going to burn. And the second thing is a schedule with a date in it, and the date is in the future, which in this war is the rarest thing in the world: everybody's paper is about the past, and here is a page about August of next year, and it says that a line is to be held until a fixed day, which means that somebody in the east has

already decided what is going to happen in the east, and the Polish underground is going to be standing underneath it when it does." She heard him breathe. "And the third thing, my child, is a man who has been sitting in a German office in this city for a year and a half with seven weeks written over twice in his file, and who has the district's paper on his table, and who has an aunt's nephew's face and a Polish mouth, and you have told me about him in the same breath as the number of a safe, and I am an old priest in a parish in the centre of Warsaw and I am going to tell you the thing that the men of the *Kedyw* would tell you in a cellar with a bottle: that the third item is the only one of the three that is standing next to you in the room."

"He is not an item."

"Everything in this city is an item, and you know it, and I know it, and the two of us are going to pretend, for the rest of the duration, that we do not." He was quiet for a moment. "What do you want?"

"I want the paper to go out."

"It is already out. It has been out since the spring; it went to London in June in a diplomatic bag, and the men in London have known the III b registry since the fourth of July, and it is being worked on by three men in a house in a suburb, and that is nothing to do with this city."

"Then I want something to be done with the rest."

"The rest is a date in a schedule and a safe in the study of a colonel." The priest's voice, through the grille, was entirely without warmth and entirely without cruelty, which is the exact manner of a man who has been in the world for forty-five years and in the church for twenty. "What do you want to be *for*?"

She knelt in the dark of a confessional in Warsaw in September 1943, on a wooden board that had been worn by four hundred years of the knees of the women of that parish, and looked at her own life the way a woman looks at a ledger; and she said the thing that she had come to say, and it was not the thing she had planned to say in the tram.

"I want to be the woman who walks out of that house in the last week of the war with the paper of the district of Warsaw in her arms," she said. "And I want it to be known, by the men in the cellars, that in the year and a half I have been in the house of a German colonel, I never once asked for a thing for myself. And I want, when it is over, in whatever is left of this city, to be able to say my own name out loud in the street."

The priest was silent for a long moment.

"That is a very large request," he said. "And the last part of it is the largest."

"I know."

"Then here is the arrangement, and it is the only arrangement I am able to offer, and you may take it or leave it." She heard him shift on the board; and, beyond the church, the city: a cart, a tram, a bell. "You will do nothing until the spring. In the spring, a man will come to you, and he will not be a priest and he will not be a girl with flowers, and he will say to you a sentence about the Vistula, and then it will be his business and not mine. Until then you will be the woman of the house of the Oberst von Reuth, and you will go to the wives at the Blue Palace, and you will drink the tea, and you will tell no one in this city anything at all, not even me, not even a man in a garden, and above all: you will not open the safe."

"Why?"

"Because there is a card index in this city kept by a man with a green notebook," said the priest, "and the index is a list of the holes in the buildings; and the last hole in Warsaw, the one that no one has found, is a Frenchwoman from Strasbourg in a doctor's house on the Mokotowska, and she is worth more than the paper in the safe, and if you open the safe in October, you will be caught in November, and in December the underground of this city will be looking for a new woman to live in the house of the German intelligence chief, and there is not one, my child. There is not one, and there never will be again."

♦ ♦ ♦

Her father died on the eighth of November, at ten minutes past four in the morning, in the flat on the Krasińskiego, with Zofia in the room and the city blacked out and a German patrol going along the street outside, and she was not there.

She was told at seven in the morning by Pelagia.

Pelagia was the family's old maid, and she was seventy-eight, and she had been half-blind since 1937, and she had taken the amber out of the flat on the second of December 1939 and had kept it for four years wrapped in a man's handkerchief in the lining of a winter coat in a room in the Wola district, in a building in which the population had been emptied twice, and in which an old woman of seventy-eight with a bad heart and a family photograph and no papers had somehow, in the four years, been left standing like a post.

She came to the house on the Mokotowska at seven in the morning, which was a thing no Pole in Warsaw ever did, and she came to the front door and not the back, which was a thing no Pole in Warsaw had done since 1939, and she stood in the doorway of the German house in the fourth year of the occupation, in a coat that had been good in 1935, with her white stick, and said to Anna Zaleska, in Polish, at the top of her voice:

"Tell the woman of this house that the Professor is dead and that she has to come for the amber."

And in the garden and the yard and the street, in the middle of a German morning in a German district, with the flag on the Blue Palace four hundred metres away and a Hauptsturmführer of the SD with a card index in a room in the Szucha, the truth of the house of the Oberst von Reuth was said out loud, in Polish, at the top of an old woman's voice, by a half-blind maid of seventy-eight who had no idea in the world what she was doing; and Anna Zaleska stood in the doorway of the German house for one second, and then did the thing that saved the war for the woman inside it, which was to take the old woman by the arm and say, loudly, in the doorway, in Polish, in the voice of the Polish servants of the German administration of Warsaw:

"Old woman, this is the house of the German Oberst. The woman you want is the caretaker's woman in the Praga district, and you have walked four kilometres in the wrong direction, and the street you want is on the other side of the river, and if you wait here in the doorway one more minute, the SS will come and take us both."

Then she shut the door, and went into the kitchen, and stood with her back to the stove for four minutes with her hands over her face.

Marion Herschlag heard it from the top of the stairs. She was standing barefoot on the landing of the first floor of a doctor's house on the Mokotowska at seven in the morning in November 1943, in a dressing gown, having listened to her own life being shouted at a German front door by a woman of seventy-eight with a white stick; and she stood there on the cold boards and did the arithmetic for the space of eleven breaths, because there was no room in the world any more for anything except arithmetic.

Eight and a half hours ago, my father died.

There is a woman of seventy-eight on a pavement in the Śródmieście with the last object of my mother's life wrapped in a handkerchief in the lining of her coat, and she has come to a German house at seven in the morning and shouted, and she will do it again; and somewhere in this city there is a

Hauptsturmführer with a card index, and a card with my false name on it, and the German administration of Warsaw, and the year to come, and the paper in the safe in the study behind the photograph.

And my father is dead, and I have not seen him since June, and my life is a thing that a half-blind woman shouted at a German door.

She went down the stairs. She walked past Anna Zaleska, who did not look at her; through the kitchen, where the fire was on and the copper for the laundry stood by the wall; out of the back door; and down the garden through the chestnuts and the wet walnut tree, in a dressing gown and shoes, in the cold, in November, to the side gate in the wall, and through the side gate into the yard of the block in the next street, which was the way out of that house that no German in the district had ever used and no Pole in the district had ever had to be told about; and she went out of the yard into the street, and stood at the corner of the Mokotowska in the grey morning of Warsaw in November 1943, in a dressing gown and shoes, in the city where she had been born, forty metres from the house of the German intelligence section of the district; and she burst into tears, in the street, in the daylight; and a woman with a basket stopped, and looked at her for four seconds, and then did the thing that would have been done in that city by any woman in the world, in any language, in any war: she put down her basket, and took off her own coat, and put it around the shoulders of a stranger in a dressing gown in the street; and said, in Polish:

"Come. Walk. Do not stand still in this cold; it is the standing still that kills people." And Krystyna Stankiewiczówna walked the length of the Mokotowska in the coat of a woman she had never met, in the grey morning, beside a woman with a basket, in silence, and cried the way, and at the corner of the Wilcza the woman took her coat back without one word, and went off towards the market.

The amber came two days later, by way of Zofia and the back gate of a building on the Dzielna, in a paper packet: one necklace of twenty-eight beads, of the Baltic amber that the women of the north of Poland had worn since the age of the Romans, in a grade of a colour like strong tea in the sun; her mother's; her grandmother's; and there was a piece of paper in the packet, folded twice, with six words on it in the handwriting of a woman of seventy-eight who had learned to write in a village school in the province of Płock in 1876.

Idź i nie daj się zabić. Go, and do not let them kill you.

She wore it once, that winter, on the night of the ninth of November, under the grey dress, at a dinner at the Blue Palace, with the district at table and the German administration around her, and a colonel of the intelligence section of Warsaw, at the head of the table, drunk on the month, reached over and touched the beads at her throat with two fingers in front of a General and said, "Amber. Poland. From the generation of the grandmothers."

"Yes," said Marion Herschlag. "It was my mother's. She is dead."

And he let the necklace fall back against her throat with two fingers, and smiled at the table, and the table laughed; and she sat through the rest of the evening with the amber of her mother against her whole skin, and the truth of the room in her mouth, and eleven metres away, across the table, a captain of twenty-eight sat with his whole face composed and did not once, in four hours, look at her throat.

CHAPTER FOURTEEN

What the River Keeps

♦ ♦ ♦

The funeral was on the eleventh of November, in the rain, in the Powązki cemetery, at two in the afternoon, and she watched it from the seat of a tram.

That was the arrangement, and she had made it herself the way she made everything: sitting at the desk of a colonel of the Abwehr at eleven o'clock at night with a pencil and a list of the district's movements, and working out, with her cold and excellent mind, what the distances were, and what the timing was, and which of the trams stopped. And so on the eleventh of November at a quarter to two, Marion Herschlag got onto the number 17 tram at the corner of the Marszałkowska in a good coat and a scarf, and paid her fare, and stood in the middle of the carriage with her hand on the leather strap, and rode through the north of the city to the terminus at the cemetery gate, and at four minutes past two the tram went past the gate of the Powązki cemetery at eleven kilometres an hour, and stopped at the halt, and the doors opened, and a man in a cap got on with a sack, and the doors shut, and the tram went on.

In the four seconds of the stop, through the window, at a distance of about ninety metres, she saw: the wall, the gate, the black crowd of about two hundred people at the graveside, eleven umbrellas, the priest's white, and a coffin on the boards in the grey rain; and among the crowd, in the front, upright, in a black coat with a man's collar, a woman of thirty with one leg shorter than the other from a childhood illness; and behind the

crowd, standing apart on the path in a cap and a wool coat with his hands at his sides, a boy of twenty-two who worked in a chemist's shop on the Ząbkowska and who had been made indispensable in the month of August by a piece of paper in a German office.

She looked at it for four seconds, and then the tram went on, and the picture was out of the window, and she stood in the middle of the carriage with her hand on the strap and looked at a woman's back and a child's parcel and the rain on the glass.

And what she thought about, in the seven kilometres back into the city, was not her father.

It was the fact that a boy of twenty-two had been standing at the back of a crowd at his own father's funeral and had not been standing beside a woman in a black coat; that a woman of thirty with one short leg had been standing in the front of a crowd at the graveside of a man she had fed for four years with half an orange a day; and that she herself, the daughter of the house of Stankiewicz of the Mokotowska, had watched it from a tram with the stopwatch in her head running, and had done it correctly, and had paid her fare.

She got off at the Nowy Świat and went home and asked Anna Zaleska for tea, and drank half of it, and went upstairs, and slept the afternoon; and at six in the evening she came down with her skin burning and a blackness at the edges of the room, and Anna Zaleska put her to bed with a hot brick and a quilt; and by nine o'clock she was delirious, and by eleven the Colonel had telephoned the district's medical officer, and Frau Doktor Weingart came in a car through the rain at midnight with her instrument bag, and stood at the end of the bed in the room of a doctor's daughter and said the following, to the Colonel of the intelligence section of the Warsaw district, in the hearing of the household:

"Pneumonia, both lungs, right one worse; and I want the window open, and the room emptied of the noise of this house, and a woman who will sit with her through the night, because in this city in this war people die of the pneumonia of November eleven times more than they die of the eastern front, and I am not going to write out a burial certificate for a woman of thirty whose lungs are full of water in the fourth year of a war because a colonel wanted his dinner brought on time."

And Lotte Erler came at eight the following morning with a bag and a set of her own towels, and moved into the house for eleven days.

♦ ♦ ♦

There is a particular kind of knowledge that only comes to a woman in a fever, and it is not a dream, and it is not the delirium of the children's stories; it is an inventory; and for the eleven days of her pneumonia in the room of a doctor's daughter in November 1943, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna did her life over, from the beginning, in order, with the accuracy of a woman who could not stop.

She did the house on the Mokotowska with the lamp in the hall. She did the piano, and the green dressing gown, and her mother's hands on the keys. She did the Botanic Garden in June 1938, in more detail than she had ever permitted herself since the day it happened. She did the platform at the Gdańsk station in the winter of 1940, and the room in Kraków with a bad fire, and the small man with a bad heart who had gone by a dog's name — and she did it four times, and each of the four times he was saying a different sentence, and in the fourth he was saying, in his careful, pedantic voice, *the arrangement is not a protection, my little rabbit; it is a postponement; and a postponement is that it always, in the end, has a date on it.*

She did the rue des Rosiers. She did the wall on the north side of the city of Warsaw, and the pair of boots on the coping, and the death-notice pasted on the outside where the Germans could see it. She did the garden in the dark with the wireless playing a fado in the courtyard of a Polish house. She did the funeral, which she had seen at ninety metres out of the window of a tram for the space of four seconds.

And on the ninth day, in the afternoon, when the fever had gone and the room had stopped moving, she lay in the bed of a doctor's daughter in a German house in Warsaw and found the thing that had been waiting for her at the bottom of the inventory; and it was not her mother and it was not her father and it was not the room in Kraków.

It was the fact that she had done it, from the wall to the tram, and had felt nothing at all.

Not numbness. She knew numbness: numbness was the thing in Paris in the bathroom with the velvet curtain, and it was a lining that came up between the woman and the world, so that the world came to her at a distance of a hand, and could be looked at, and could be worked on, and

could be measured. What was in the bed in November 1943 was not a lining. It was a floor. There was nothing underneath the floor at all.

She lay in the dark of the room of a doctor's daughter with her hands on the quilt and did the last and worst piece of arithmetic of her life, which was to look at the whole thing from the outside, the way a stranger would look at it:

There is a woman of thirty-one in a German house in Warsaw who takes her meals with the intelligence chief of the district; who has watched her father's funeral from a tram; who has had a family's death and a city's wall in her hands for four months and has done, for those four months, exactly what she was told, without one single hour of any symptom at all; and there is no such woman; a woman is not a machine, and a machine is not a person, and somewhere between the fourth of March 1943 at the Gare de l'Est and this bed, there was a moment at which me stopped being a person and became the arrangement; and the arrangement does not have a birthday, and the arrangement does not have a father, and the arrangement watched that funeral through a window at eleven kilometres an hour with its hand on a leather strap, and it did not cost it anything at all.

And in the middle of the arithmetic, with the room going dark, she found that she was crying, at last, four days late and nine days deep, in the bed of a doctor's daughter in a German house, and she cried the way a person cries when the machine has stopped: without any shape to it, and without an end.

Lotte Erler heard her from the landing and came in and sat down on the edge of the bed without a word; and she did the correct thing, which was to sit and put her hand flat on the quilt over the top of the crying woman's head, and to stay there; and after four minutes, without any transition at all, in the manner of a woman of thirty-three from Hamburg who had been a legal secretary and had spent four years watching the wives of the administration of the city of Warsaw do the impossible, she said:

"When my husband is killed, and he will be killed, because he is a Hauptmann of transport at Minsk and they are killing the transport officers at a rate of a hundred a month, I am going to have a whole afternoon in which I do not do one correct thing. That is my plan. That is my plan for the rest of the war. One afternoon." Her hand stayed on the quilt. "You may borrow it if you like. I have found that the only thing of any value that a woman in this administration has to lend another woman is the permission to stop."

♦ ♦ ♦

The Colonel came to her on the twelfth night.

The fever had gone; the house had, in the way of the houses of the important, returned to its ordinary: Anna Zaleska, the kitchen, the ordinary; Lotte Erler had gone home at six o'clock after a lecture in the drawing room on the necessity of the window being open; and at eleven the Colonel came up from the study, where the district had been telephoning since nine, and stood at the foot of the bed with the lamp on behind him.

He had been drinking. She knew it from the four steps he took into the room, which were a centimetre too long; and she knew, in the same four steps, the reason he had come, and she lay in the bed of the doctor's daughter and did the arithmetic that she had been doing since October 1942: *nine weeks of a district and a war, and this man has just been told by Berlin that a thing he promised cannot be done, and there is exactly one remedy for it in his world.*

He came to the bed and looked at her.

"You are better," he said.

"I am better."

"They have told me that I am not to disturb you."

"Frau Doktor Weingart said that to you on the first night, in front of the house. It was addressed to the house and not to you, and you are a colonel and I am a kept woman and the room knows the arrangement; so do not stand at the end of the bed and make me do the work of inviting you, because I am ill and I am tired and I would rather have it spoken."

There was a silence in the room.

"You are not a kept woman," he said.

"No. I am a woman in a house. There is a difference, and it is the difference that makes this possible, and it is now eleven o'clock at night and there is a war and a district and there is this bed."

He got into the bed.

And then he did what he had come to do, and in it he was not cruel, which was worse; he was slow, and enormous, and utterly without any question at all, and in the middle of it, with his whole weight on her, with his mouth against the side of her neck and a district of Warsaw on the other side of the wall, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna lay in the bed of a doctor's

daughter with her eyes open in the dark and made the last and worst discovery of her life.

I feel nothing.

Not disgust, which I have felt, in Paris, in the rue de la Faisanderie, in the room in the tower with the candle on the floor. Not hatred, which I have kept for the last hour of the night and used, all winter, the way a woman uses a coal in a stove.

Nothing at all: as though the body of Marion Herschlag had been handed over to a contractor; as though there were a woman in the bed who was being had by a colonel of the Abwehr, and a second woman, standing one metre back, in the dark, in the cold, watching the first one work, and the second woman was doing arithmetic about a safe, and neither of them was anybody at all.

When he had finished he put his arm over his eyes, which was the thing he did, and lay there breathing; and after a while, in the dark, with the weight of what he had just done still in the room, he said, in the flat, level voice of a man who is not asking and is not confessing but is, in his own way, *giving*:

"In March, I am to be a Generalmajor."

"I know."

"You know?"

"The Frau Generalin has had a new hat for three weeks, and the wives' table has been speaking in the future tense about the house of the General of the infantry, and there is only one promotion in this district that would be worth a new hat in November." She lay on her back in the dark beside a man who had just been given a city, and looked at the ceiling with the bandage on it. "I am not a fool, Friedrich. I am a woman in a house. I hear the district over the soup."

He laughed: once, from the chest, the door closing, the bark, the man in one sound.

"March," he said. "And in March the matter of the east is going to be decided; and I am told that the wall in the north of the city is going to be cleared, and that the operation is to be conducted by the SS and not by the Wehrmacht, and that my section is to provide the intelligence and take no part in the physical operation, and I have read the order and I have signed my name on the cover sheet, which is what a colonel of intelligence does in this war: he signs the cover sheet and the rest is done by men with shovels."

She lay in the dark and did not move.

"Friedrich."

"Yes."

"The wall."

"Yes."

"There are a hundred and fifty thousand people behind it."

"There are," he said. And then he said the thing that she carried with her for the rest of her life, and that she heard again, in the dust and the noise of the summer of 1944, in the moment when her world came down: "There were four hundred and ten of my men in the Crimea, and fourteen officers who shot themselves, and the mothers of them, and I wrote the letters in my own hand, and the fact is that a man is given a district, and it has a hundred and fifty thousand people in it, and a wall, and an order; and there is no version of the rest of my life in which I am not the man who signed the cover sheet. So I do not intend to be the man who signed it *and* the man who talked about it in bed. Do you understand me?"

"Yes."

"Good." He put his hand on her stomach, flat, the weight of it; the claim; the register. "Then we shall not say another word about it, in this room or in any other room, in the war."

♦ ♦ ♦

The river took two days from her in February.

They went on a Sunday, in the car, to a place about nine kilometres downstream of the city, past the Praga bank, where the Vistula in the fifth winter of the war was a kilometre of ice and snow with a road across it that the Germans had made, and a row of black holes in it where the Poles had cut the ice for water the winter; and it was a German officer's Sunday, of the kind that the district had invented in the fourth year of the war: a drive in a car, and a walk on the frozen river, and a luncheon out of a hamper, and three other cars and eleven other officers and four wives, and it was photographed by a Hauptmann of the propaganda section for the district's illustrated weekly, which was printed in Warsaw in German for an audience of the German administration of Poland, and which was, in the four years of the war, the single most obscene object that the city produced.

She walked away from it after lunch.

She did it as a woman of the German administration does, with the appearance of doing nothing at all: she took a rug, and put it over her arm, and walked along the ice towards the west into the white, towards the place where the river bends away from the city and there is nothing on the horizon except the snow, the reeds, and a black hut on the bank that had been a fisherman's before the war.

He came eleven minutes later, on the ice, in a Wehrmacht greatcoat, without a hat, with his hands in his pockets.

"They will notice," she said, without turning round.

"They will notice a captain of the section walking on the ice for ten minutes in a Sunday and talking to the woman of his colonel at a distance of four metres. It will be in the wives' room by Wednesday, and on Friday somebody will make a joke, and by the end of the month it will have become a thing that the district knows and does not think about, which is the greatest protection that exists in this administration." He stopped four metres from her. "We have four minutes and then I must go back and be photographed."

"Then use them."

"I am on the list for Riga since September," said Phillip Brandt, "and in November they moved the list to a depot at Minsk, and in December the Minsk depot was bombed, and my file was in a room in that building, and it is possible, in this war, for a file to be burned; and I mention it because I have spent the winter deciding whether to burn it, which is a thing I could not do for any reason that would survive being written down, and I have decided not to, and I want you to know that I decided not to for the sake of one thing only, and it is that if I burned my file I would have to leave this city, and I am not able to leave this city, and there is no sentence in the German language that expresses that without being a confession."

"No," she said. "There is not."

"Now I have said it."

"You have."

"In the six months since the garden, I have thought about nothing else, and I want to tell you the thing that I have concluded, and I want you to hear it without any of the *arithmetic* in it, because the arithmetic is yours and I have no objection to it, but I am not able to live in it, and I am not a Pole in a cell; I am a man of twenty-eight who has been given a uniform and a city and a war, and I have decided that it is a loan."

She turned round, on the ice, in the white of a Polish February, and looked

at him for a long time without one word.

"Phillip."

"Yes."

"I am going to tell you one true thing about what I am, and then we are going to walk back separately, and it is going to be worse than anything you have imagined, and I want you to hear it in the exact words in which I mean it, because if you hear it and turn away, then you will go back to the district and everything will be as it was in October." She stood in the cold with the rug over her arm and the wind off a kilometre of ice. "There is a room in the house on the Mokotowska with a photograph of a dead woman in it, and behind the photograph there is a steel box in the wall, and in the box there is a page about a line on the river to the east that is to be held until a date in August of next year, and there is a list of names of the men of the intelligence of the district, and there is a file about a captain who was born in Warsaw in 1915, and it is going to come out of that box in the spring of 1944, and there is exactly one person in this city who is going to take it out, and it is not you."

He looked at her on the ice.

"No," he said. "It is you."

"Say it plainly. I want you to have said it once, out loud, on the ice, in the daylight."

"You are an intelligence asset of the Polish underground, and you are in the house of the chief of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, and you have been placed there the way the French network was placed there, and everything in your body has been the price that a woman pays in a war that men have made." His whole face, in the cold, was not the face of an officer. It was the face of a boy of nineteen in a thin shirt in front of a glasshouse holding a closed book. "And there is nothing in the world that I am able to do about it, because I am a German officer with seven weeks written over twice in my file, and the only thing I have ever been able to give you is the fact that I have never once, in the year in which I have known, said a single word."

"And what do you want?" she said.

And in the white of a Polish February, on a kilometre of ice, four metres from him, with the district at the tents behind them, and the city on the bank, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna heard a man of twenty-eight say the single most dangerous sentence that anybody had said to her in the war.

"The war is going to end," he said, "and when it ends there is going to be a city, and it is going to be the city of the men who have done what men do in a war; and through it, in the ruins of it, there is going to be a woman walking; and I want to be the man walking beside her."

"Then you are going to have to wait," she said, "until it is over, and there is not going to be a single day in the time between now and then in which I am able to promise you anything at all; and you are going to have to live with what is going on in a bedroom four metres from your desk in a house on the Mokotowska, and I am not going to protect you from it, because it is my work."

"Krystyna."

"Go back," she said. "Go and be photographed."

The middle of the river was the middle of the country.

She had crossed it four times in the war, always in the Mercedes on the bridge, with the flag of the district on the wing and the city going past the window of the car at the speed of an official of the German administration; and on the twenty-first of March 1944, in the fourth winter of the war, she crossed it on her own feet, at eleven o'clock in the morning, in the wind, in a black coat with the collar of a man's, with a rug over her arm and a pass of the district in her bag, because she had told the household that she was going to the shops of the Praga for a morning and there is no paper in the German administration of Warsaw that a woman of a household cannot get for a morning of the shops.

The ice was a road.

It had been a road since the middle of January, when the Vistula froze from bank to bank in one night, and the administration of the German army had put the little wooden huts of the ferrymen on the ice at the two ends and a line of the posts of the engineers across the middle and a signboard with the German text on it; and the city of Warsaw had looked at the signboard for one day and had then done the thing that a city of a million people does with an ice road: the men of the Praga came across it with the sacks of the flour and the potatoes in the sledge, the boys of the two banks came across it on the skates of the year 1938, the women of the Wola went across it to the market of the Praga with the baskets on their heads because the tram over the bridge stopped for the month of the February, and there was, along the middle of the Vistula between the Poniatowski and the Citadel, a village of the little houses of the fishermen, built up out of the boards of packing cases, with the smoke of the fires coming

straight up out of them in the still air of the Polish March, and with the fish of the river on the ice in the front of the doors of them, frozen and stacked like the firewood.

She walked out into the middle of it at eleven o'clock, and stopped, and turned round, and looked at the city of her birth from the middle of the river.

There was nothing in the world like it, and there is nothing in the writing about that city that has ever been able to put it down: Warsaw seen from the ice in the fourth winter of the war, at the hour of the middle of the morning, in the light of a March in Poland that is the colour of the inside of an oyster. The city was standing in the smoke of its own chimneys, brown and grey and white, and along the southern bank there was the wall of the ghetto, and beyond the wall, where the street of the Gęsia had been, there was not a street and not a wall and not a chimney: there was a plain.

They had done it in the month of the May of the year before, and they had finished it and had levelled it with the labour of the men of the labour administration and the machinery of the engineers of the SS, and in the four kilometres of the plain there was snow and broken brick and, in three places, the corner of a street standing up out of it like the stump of a tooth; and along the southern edge of the plain, in the distance, there was a line of the houses of the Polish city with their backs to the level of the ruin, and there was washing on the lines of the yards of them, in the wind, white on white against the snow, and it was the smallest and the most terrible object in the view of a city from a frozen river.

She looked at it for four minutes.

And while she looked at it, a boy of about eleven came up the ice from the north with a sledge and a line, and stopped beside her, and looked at the city with her, in the way that the children of Warsaw in the fourth winter of the war had learned to look at things beside anybody at all; and after a while he said, in Polish, without any preamble, in the voice of a child stating the business of the morning:

"There is a man under the ice at the second post."

"What?"

"Under the ice." He said it without any drama, in the way of a person reporting the state of the river, and he pointed with his chin at the second of the posts of the engineers, twenty metres to the south. "He came across in the night in the dark from the other side, and the ice at the second post is bad, because the water of the sewers comes out there, and my father says

he is a man of the camp on the Dzielna, and my father says that there is a of the month that the men of the camp have been coming across in the night, and the men of the German police have been coming across after them, and my father says that we are not to say anything about it to anybody in the world, so I am telling you, because you are a woman and you are looking at the city, and because my father says it to his own line of the fish and not to a person."

"Are you not afraid to be on the ice with the German police on it?"

"The German police do not come out on the ice," said the boy, in the tone of a man of sixty, "because the German police have the boots of the German police, and the boots of the German police have the nails in the heels of them and the ice of the Vistula laughs at the nails; and because there are two hundred men of the Praga on the ice in the morning and them are the men of the fish of the fish market of the Praga, and there is not one of them who is able to be asked a question about a man under the ice, because them say the same thing, which is that the ice at the second post is bad and that the man is under the ice and that the ice is the ice." He took up his line. "There are four more under the ice between here and the bridge. The girls of the school know the four. We count them."

Then he gave her the last thing, in the way that the children of that city gave things in that war: he took the smallest of the fish of his line, a thing of the length of a hand, frozen, and held it out to her, and waited, and when she did not take it he put it down on the ice in front of the toes of her shoes himself, and went off down the ice with the sledge towards the north, with his weight on the balls of his feet, in the way of a child of a river town, running and sliding wherever he could.

She picked the fish up off the ice and carried it across the rest of the river in the rug over her arm, because a woman of the household of a General of the district of the German army who returns from the Praga with the shops in a bag is a woman who has bought a fish at the market and is going home to cook it, and because the fish of a boy of eleven from the middle of the Vistula was, in the fourth winter of the war, the only object in her possession that had not been either requisitioned, bought, stolen, or given to her by a German.

He went back. She stood on the ice for eleven minutes with the rug over her arm, in the wind, and looked at the white of the river towards the east, and prepared, with the cold attention that she had, the exact words in which she was going to tell a colonel of the Abwehr at dinner that the

afternoon had been beautiful, and that she had a slight headache, and that she wanted to go home early.

CHAPTER FIFTEEN

The Man Who Knew Her

♦ ♦ ♦

The market at Kercelak was held every day of the war on a waste ground the size of two city blocks in the Wola district, and it was the economy of the city of Warsaw in the fifth year of the occupation: five thousand people in a field of mud, in rags, in a January, buying and selling the German Reich's property back to the German Reich's officers through the hands of the Polish people, at eleven in the morning, on a Thursday, with a police operation at the gate and a division of the Wehrmacht four hundred metres away in the barracks at the corner.

She went once a month, and she went as the Frenchwomen of the German administration went: with Anna Zaleska, and with a basket, and with the license of a household of an officer to buy eggs and a chicken from a Pole at a price that had been fixed in the German ordinance at a level that had been arranged so that nobody could obey it, and so that the city would be, for the rest of the war, criminal.

They had been at the market for eleven minutes. Anna had gone to the egg women; and Krystyna stood at the corner of the second row of the stalls with the basket on the ground, looking at a table of boots, in the ordinary way of a woman of the household of an officer waiting for a cook to finish a piece of business, when a man of thirty-one in a blue police uniform stopped two metres away and looked at her and said, in Polish:

"Panna Krystyna."

There is no way to describe what happens in a woman's body at a moment like that. There is the training, which is instantaneous: the face does not move; the eyes do not widen; the breath goes on; and there is the second, deeper thing, which is not training at all, and which is the animal at the bottom of a person noticing, at two metres, in the middle of a crowded market, in a city where the people she loved were dead, that it has been seen.

She looked at him.

He had been a boy of twenty-two in the summer of 1938, with a crush on her that the city had known about, and she had pitied him; and he had a patent on a design for a lamp, and a set of ambitions, and a mother who had made the introductions; and he had asked her to dance four times at a *bal* in the month of February 1939, and on the second time she had said yes out of pity, and on the fourth he had told her, in the corridor by the coat room, that he intended to marry her; and she had laughed, in the way of a girl of twenty-two who has been raised to be laughed at by nobody, and had said a sentence that she had forgotten within an hour and that he had carried for five years.

He was fatter. He had a moustache. He had the blue uniform of the Polish police of the Generalgouvernement, with a rank on the collar; and he had, in his eyes, the exact expression of a boy of twenty-two in a corridor at a February ball.

"Panna Krystyna," he said again, taken aback at his own voice, and then, in the French that a Warsaw man of the educated class spoke before the war: "It is you. I have looked at you for four minutes. I could not believe my eyes."

"Monsieur Groński."

"I live here, in the Wola; I have a post in the sixth district and an office," he said. He was talking too fast, and he had the look of a man who has been given a present and does not know what is in the wrapping. "And you — they told me the family was gone. In 1940 the Mokotowska building; your father, in the summer, there were the rumours and nobody would say it — and here you are, at the Kercelak, with a basket."

"I am with a household," she said.

"With a household." He looked at her coat, which was the coat of a household; and then at the basket; and then, in the way of a policeman of the city of Warsaw in the fifth year of the war, at the middle distance, at the row of the egg women, at the woman with the good face who was

coming back along the aisle with a chicken — and he did the arithmetic that a city of Poles did twenty times a day in that war, and it took him four seconds.

"Panna Krystyna," he said, in a completely different voice, "in whose household do you stand?"

She looked at him for a long moment, in the mud of the Kercelak, with the city around them; and she made the decision that she had been trained to make in a second and had never once been given time to think about: the decision between the lie that would end the conversation and the truth that would put a rope around his neck and hers.

"I am the woman of the Oberst von Reuth," she said, quietly, in Polish. "I live in the house on the Mokotowska. The the district knows my face. The the German administration of Warsaw knows me as Madame Herschlag of Strasbourg, and if you are seen speaking to me for another minute, in this market, in the daylight, then you will be taken to the Szucha by Friday and I will not be able to do a single thing about it, and I do not intend to lose a war over a man I danced with in 1939."

He went a colour.

And then he did what she had not expected at all, and what every single one of the Poles of Warsaw did, in the fifth year of the war, in the face of the occupation: he smiled at her with his mouth, in the manner of an old friend of the family, and kissed the air beside her ear, on both sides, in the Polish fashion, and said, loudly, in a Polish that could be heard at four stalls, "Pani, the eggs in this market are a scandal, and I will not have it; my wife buys at the Smocza and pays a third of the price."

And then, in a whisper, at her ear, in the same second: "On the third of February, at the seventh hour, at the church of St. Kazimierz in the Wola. If I do not come, I am dead; if you do not come, I will come to the garden gate on the Mokotowska."

He walked off into the market, and Anna Zaleska came up with the chicken, and the two of them went home along the Chłodna with the basket, and neither of them said a single word for eleven minutes.

At the corner, by the wall, Anna Zaleska stopped and looked at the trail of the smoke over the north of the city, over the wall, over the district which had been burning since the summer and which Warsaw could smell every day of the winter, and said, in the Polish, in a level voice:

"In 1940, before the wall, the women of this city went to the Kercelak with the basket, and the men of the blue police went with the pistol, and us

were one people, and the difference between a blue policeman and a man with a basket was a paycheck." She shifted the chicken to her other hand. "Now the blue police take the people of this city at night out of the buildings, and my Piotr has a cousin in the Gęsiówka because of a blue policeman on the Chłodna, and I have the chicken and a boy in a chemist's shop and my silence, and I am telling you this so that you understand that in this city we do not have the luxury of the judgment, but we do have the memory, and the memory is what I am handing to you now, in the street, on the way home."

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The weekly report of the household came to the hand of the Colonel on the first of February.

It was the office of the Ordonnanzoffizier that produced it, every Monday, in the neat small hand of a captain of the intelligence section: two pages of the movements of the house on the Mokotowska, the visits to the wives' table, the three shops, the tram lines, the film, the church on the two Sundays, and — at the foot of the second page, under the heading *Bemerkungen* — the notations of the officer of the guard at the gate. The remark on the first of February was one line, and it said, in the German of a young man trained to write everything down and to think about nothing: *Am 29.1. gegen 12 Uhr fragte ein Angehöriger der Polnischen Polizei (blau) am Tor nach der Dame des Haushalts; vom Posten abgewiesen.*

On the twenty-ninth of January, at about twelve, a member of the Polish police, blue, asked at the gate after the lady of the household; turned away by the sentry.

She learned that the remark existed because the Colonel read the report aloud to her.

He came home at a quarter past eight, which he did on the Mondays, and he came into the small room with the two pages in his hand and his cap under his arm and his greatcoat on, and he stood in front of the stove with the paper in his hand and read her the morning of Monday, the twenty-ninth of January, in a flat voice, from the first line to the last, and then he read her the line at the foot of the second page, twice, in German, and then once in French, in his own translation, which was better than the German, because the man had been a soldier of the intelligence service of

an army for thirty-six years and had never once in his life read a sentence aloud without understanding it.

Then he put the paper on the table and took his coat off and gave the coat to Anna in the corridor, and came back in and sat down in the chair by the stove without taking the glass she had poured him.

"Now," he said. "The man in the blue police."

"I saw him," she said.

"You will tell me about him."

"I will tell you the thing as it is, and it is not a large thing, and then I will tell you the second part, which is, and the second part is about you and not about the man." She said it with her hands folded in her lap, in the French of the avenue Henri-Martin, in the tone of a woman who has thought about a question for two days and has the answer, because she had, in fact, thought about it for two days, since the moment on the Chłodna when Anna Zaleska had started to speak about the blue police and she had understood that the Kercelak was now a place with a witness in it. "On the Monday I went to the market with Anna, as I go on the Mondays. There was a man at the corn stall, a Pole, in the blue uniform of the city police, of about thirty years of age, and he knows the face of the woman of the German Colonel of the district, because the sixth district has been taking an interest in the German houses of the city since the autumn, and because my face has been in the *Nowy Kurier* twice, at the reviewing stand, and at the ball of the Winterhilfswerk in the room of the Regina in the month of November." She looked at him. "He came up behind me at the corn stall and said my name; he said it in the Polish fashion, the fashion of a man who has seen it written; and then he said a thing about the district, and then he went away into the crowd. He asked me for nothing, Friedrich. He followed me to the corner of the Chłodna, four metres behind me, with a chicken under his arm and his cap in his pocket, and at the corner he stopped and turned and went back into the Wola; and I came home; and there was no man at the gate, and he did not come to the gate, and it was not he who asked at the gate."

"Then who asked at the gate?"

"I do not know," she said. "And here is the second part, and I want you to hear it in this room and not in the Blue Palace, because it is not a question of the office, it is a question of the two of us, and there has never been a lie between us and there is not going to be one tonight." She took the glass he had not taken and turned it once in her hand and put it down. "Any man

of the blue police of this city can buy the answer at the gate for a litre of the Silesian and a packet of the German cigarettes, and every sentry of every German house in Warsaw has been answering that question since the first week of the occupation, because the answer is worth money to the men of the market and the men of the blue police and the boys of the black market, and there is not one thing about me at that gate that is not for sale. That is the danger, and it is not a danger that came to me on the Monday; it is a danger that has been standing in the street with its hand in its pocket for five months, and the man at the corn stall is only the first man in the city who has been able to find my name and put it together with my face."

He looked at her for a long time from the chair by the stove.

"That is a very good answer," he said.

"It is the answer."

"It is a good answer and it is not the first part of the answer," said the Colonel of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, "and I am going to say the first part of it to you, because I have been reading the reports of the office of the Ordonnanzoffizier of this district since the month of the June, and there is one thing about the woman of my house that the reports of my own office have been telling me for five months and that I have been reading the way a man reads the weather in a window: she is not frightened of the city."

She did not move.

"Do you know what a German officer's wife is in this city?" he said. "She is a woman in a house with the curtains and a driver. She goes to the wives' table, and to the two shops of the German quarter, and to the church of the administration on the Sundays, and her Warsaw is four streets and the interior of the Mercedes; and there is not one of them who has gone into the Wola since the second year of the occupation, and there is not one of them who will walk from the Irena to the house on the Mokotowska on her own feet in the middle of the afternoon, and there is not one of them who knows the price of the eggs at the Kercelak. My wife, in 1931, in Breslau, was a woman of the province with a handshake like a farmer's and she would have gone to the Kercelak and fought with the egg women and won." He stood up. "And I have been watching you take the tram to the Krasińskiego and come home with the cabbage, and I have said to myself: it is a Frenchwoman, it is the way, it is the climate of the market and the two of them; and there is one thing in it that I have never once been able to

make into a sentence, and it is that you have been walking in this city for five months with the face of a woman who is not in an occupied country."

He put the two pages of the report into the stove.

"Friedrich—"

"Do not." He held up his hand. "I have not asked you the question, and I am not going to ask the question tonight, because if I ask it in this room I shall have to ask it in the Blue Palace tomorrow, and there is not one man in the German intelligence of this district who is able to survive the asking of the question about the woman of his own house; and because I am fifty-four and there is a war and a line of the Vistula and an eleven thousand men in the east who are going to be in the east in the summer, and because there has never been a lie between us and I have decided to spend the rest of the war on that." He picked up his glass and drank it off. "But I am making an arrangement for the market, and the arrangement is this: from the first of the February, the woman of my house does not go into the city on her own feet. The car goes to the Krasińskiego on the Tuesdays, and the driver goes with the basket, and if the woman of my house wants the eggs of the Kercelak then the driver of the district buys them at the Kercelak and puts them on the seat of the car in the paper, which is what every German household in this city does, and which is what we are going to do until the matter of the east is decided."

"Then I am to be a woman in a house with the curtains."

"You are to be a woman in a house with the curtains," said the Colonel of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, "because I have signed the order of the day of the district that puts the German administration of this city behind a wall, and because I intend to spend the rest of the war in the position of a man whose house has not been burned down over the head of the one person in it."

He did not say anything more about it that night.

♦ ♦ ♦

He came to the bed at eleven o'clock, and what he brought to the bed was the thing that she had spent five months learning to read, and it was not anger.

Anger she could manage: anger has a shape and a rhythm and an end, and a man in anger is a man who has already decided something and is saying it with the body on the way to the saying. What the Colonel brought into the room on the first of February was possession, in the sense in which a

man can only possess a thing by proving that it can be taken from him; and it began with the door of the room and the lamps switched off and the two of them standing, and a hand flat on the back of her neck, and the voice of an officer of the intelligence service asking her, very quietly, in the dark, to say the name of a man in a blue uniform again.

She said the name.

He had her against the wardrobe first, and there was nothing slow about it, and she went with it the way she had been trained to go with it in the long room in Kraków in the winter of 1940, which is to say with her hands and her breath and the surface of the wardrobe and her face turned to the side so that the ear-clips would not be torn out of her ears, working: counting the open of the door, and the distance to the bed, and the fact that in the corridor the brown dog of the household was asleep at the head of the stairs and would not give her more than four seconds of warning if the door of the house opened.

And when it was done, and he had her in the bed and was lying with his hand on the inside of her thigh the way he lay when he wanted her to know that the night was not finished, she did the thing that she had never once done in the five months, and it was not calculation, or not only calculation, and it was:

"You are not going to ask me the question," she said, into the dark, in the French of the two of them.

"No."

"Then I will answer it once, and then never again, and I will answer it the way a woman answers a man at the end of a night and not the way a woman of the house answers an officer of the intelligence service." She turned her head on the pillow. "I did not choose this house. I was put in this house by a paper of the administration of the district and a place that a woman of Strasbourg takes in the war because there is nothing else in the world for her to take. And in the five months I have come to know what is in it, and I have found that what is in it is a man of fifty-four in a chair by the stove, in a house in a country that is not his, with the east in front of him; and there is not one hour of the five months that I have spent in this house calculating what the house is worth to me. Ask the office of your own Ordonnanzoffizier: there is not a piece of paper of the district of Warsaw that has ever been in my hand. But if you want the answer, then it is that the woman in this bed has been in the bed for five months, and that

the man in the bed is the only person in the German administration of this city who has ever asked her for nothing but herself."

He was silent for a long time in the dark.

Then he put his arm across her and pulled her against his chest, the way a man of the province holds a child, and said the last sentence of the night, and it was the sentence of a man who had been given, by the woman in the bed, the exact amount of the truth that he was able to carry home to the Blue Palace in the morning:

"In the summer there is going to be an order, and the order is going to be about the line of the river, and when the order comes I am going to put this house and this bed and the woman of the house on the last train that goes to the west; and there is not going to be any discussion about it, and there is not going to be any argument in the small room by the stove, and the argument of it is the one that I have just been given in this bed, which is that a man does not take a woman out of a burning city because of a paper of the district, but because of the other thing, and the other thing has no name in the German language and is the only thing I have."

She lay in the dark with the arm of a colonel of the German intelligence service across her body and the brown dog asleep at the head of the stairs and February coming towards her, and she looked at the ceiling and did the arithmetic from the beginning, and the arithmetic had changed its shape since the summer, and the change in the shape of it was the thing that she was not going to be able to repair.

♦ ♦ ♦

Wiktor Groński came to the church of St. Kazimierz on the third of February at seven in the evening, at the end of the afternoon service, in a good coat without the uniform, with a hat in his hands; and he stood in the nave with the crowd, and said the prayers with the crowd, and at a quarter past seven, in the aisle by the side door, he put out his arm and stopped her.

"Eleven minutes," she said. "In the porch. If we are in the church, the priest will see us; if we go to the street, we are two people on a corner."

"Pani Krystyna—"

"Eleven minutes. Begin."

And he began, and it was the saddest and most ordinary thing in the city of Warsaw in the fifth year of the war, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood

in the porch of a church in the Wola district and listened to it with the attention that she had spent three years perfecting, and it was this.

He was not a monster. He was a blue policeman of thirty-one with an office in the sixth district, and his whole office was the registration of the property of the people who had been taken in that district: the flats, the furniture, the accounts; and he had, since 1941, taken the bribes that the population of his district offered the offices of the Polish police of the Generalgouvernement: for the release of a husband from a roundup, for the warning about a night raid, for the certificate, for the extra name in the register; and he had, in the two years, saved eleven human beings, and had lost, in the same two years, in the operations in which he had stood at the end of a cordon with a rifle and a list in his pocket, something on the order of four hundred.

He had, in the summer of 1943, been in the cordon around the district of the north, and he had put a family of six people into a courtyard wall, in the dark, on the Dzielna; and the mother of that family had said his own surname, out loud, in the dark, because she had known his mother; and he had gone home and drunk a bottle and come to the church of St. Kazimierz on the following Sunday, and had been coming ever since.

"And now there is you," he said.

"There is me."

"You are the daughter of Professor Stankiewicz of the Mokotowska, and you are the woman of a German colonel, in the house on the Mokotowska; and I have the last month thought of nothing else, and I want you to understand the position clearly, because I am not the blackmailer of a novel; a blackmailer of a novel is a man who wants the money." He looked at the hat in his hands. "I am the man who, in 1939, in a corridor, was told by a girl that he was nothing and that he should marry a woman of his own kind. And you were right. I married a woman of my own kind and she died of the typhus in 1940 and I have been nothing ever since; and now I have found you in the Kercelak standing next to a German colonel's cook with a basket; and the thing that I want, Panna Krystyna, is not your money and not your body."

"Then what?"

"I want to be the man who decides what happens to you." He said it in the voice of a man of thirty-one in a porch of a church in a Polish February, and it was, in its way, the most frightening and the most truthful thing that an ordinary man had said to her in her life. "I want you to come to me

once a month and to tell me the truth about what you are, and to do the small things that I ask, which will be the small things and not the large ones; and in the exchange, I will give you the warnings from the office, which are worth your life and the lives of the men you work for; and I will never tell a single person a syllable, and if you ever fail me, I will go to the Szucha with a letter, and there is not one thing in the world that you will be able to do about it, because I am a blue policeman with a badge, and you are the woman of a German colonel, and nobody in the war is going to believe one syllable out of your mouth."

She stood in the porch.

"In the thirty days," she said, "for the first instalment, I will give you the following, and it is the truth, which is that I am not able to give you the truth about my work, and that the reason is not that I do not trust you. It is that the reason is the arithmetic of a war, which is that a man who does not know a thing cannot be made to say it."

"The the arithmetic," he said, and laughed, and there was the 1939 in the laugh. "You were always the arithmetic."

♦ ♦ ♦

She reported it to the priest at the Visitation on the fourth of February; and the priest listened to it in the dark of the confessional without one single interruption, which was a thing she had never known him to do, and at the end, he said:

"I know this man."

"You know the city."

"I know this man, because in 1940, in the autumn, there was a case of the blue police in the Wola which came before the court of the underground, and the matter was a blue policeman who had put a family into a court-yard wall; and the court sat in a cellar for four hours and the verdict was a death sentence, and the sentence was not carried out, because the man's own mother came to the court, on her knees, in the cellar, at the age of seventy-one." The priest was quiet for a moment. "And now the man is standing in the porch of the St. Kazimierz with a hat in his hands and a letter with your whole name in his pocket, and the case is not the case of 1940 any more, because a man who knows one name is a man who will, in the end, in the fourth or the fifth month, tell it to the Szucha, and the

Szucha has a card index, and a card index is the end of the underground of this city."

"Then what is my part in it?"

"The whole of your part in it," said the priest, "was to tell me it, and you have told me it; and now your part in it is over, and the rest of it belongs to the men in the cellars, and you will go home to the Mokotowska and drink the tea of the German administration, and you will not do the *anything* about Wiktor Groński; and if the man dies in the February, you will learn it from the German newspaper in March, in the same way that the city learns everything."

He died on the nineteenth of February, at half past seven in the evening, in the doorway of his own house on the Wolska, shot four times by three men of whom the population of that street would remember, to the end of their lives, precisely nothing, because the population of Warsaw had been trained, in the four years, to see nothing at the exact moment of a killing, and to be standing in the darkness of a blackout at the moment when they described it to the German police.

She read about it in the *Nowy Kurier Warszawski*, which was the German-controlled Polish-language paper of the city, on the twenty-first of February, at the breakfast table, in the house on the Mokotowska, with the German administration of the Warsaw district in the room; and the paper carried a paragraph of three lines under the heading *Mord an einem Polizeibeamten*, and she read the three lines and put the paper down and drank her coffee and went on with the morning; and at eleven o'clock, in the corridor by the kitchen, she stood with her back to the wall and did the thing she had been doing since the month of November without ever admitting it to herself, which was to take the memory of a man in a porch of a church with a hat in his hands, and to put it in the long room at the back of her mind, next to the tailor's wife of the rue des Rosiers, and next to the mother of the boy on the quai, and next to the man with a bad heart and a sister's umbrella who had died in the rue des Saussaies of a heart attack, and to shut the door of the room.

And in the week which followed, in the house on the Mokotowska, the woman of the colonel of the Abwehr was, in the opinion of the household, in the best of her health: she went to the wives' table on the Thursday, and took the tea, and discussed the price of the butter, and the question of the film of the week; and she went to the bed of the Colonel of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw on four of the seven nights of

that whole week, and did the work, and was, in the assessment of the man who had been given a district, in the excellent form, in the way of a woman who had, in the five months of the autumn and the winter, become the one thing in his whole world that was not the war.

CHAPTER SIXTEEN

Aleja Szucha

♦ ♦ ♦

They made him a Generalmajor on the first of March, and on the fourth of March the district moved into the house of the General of the infantry, which stood on the corner of the Bagatela with three floors, a garden, a fountain that no longer ran, and a marble stair that every officer's wife in Warsaw had admired for four years.

The house on the Mokotowska went to an Oberst of the supply section who arrived with a wife, two children and a piano from Budapest. Anna Zaleska and Piotr Zaleski went with the house, as they had gone with it from one General to the next since 1940, because a Polish cook and a Polish caretaker were, in the accounting of the German administration of Warsaw, indistinguishable from the fixtures.

She said goodbye to them in the kitchen on the third of March, and she did it properly: a bolt of good cloth bought with the household money on the Nowy Świat, a month's wages, and a letter in Polish in her own hand, addressed to a woman who did not exist.

Anna Zaleska took it and stood in the doorway of her kitchen with her hands in her apron, and said, in Polish:

"The lady will need a cook in the new house."

"The new house has a cook. She is a German woman from Bydgoszcz, she cannot make a soup, and the whole district knows it, and there is nothing I can do about it."

"Then the lady will eat the bad soup on the Bagatela." She wiped the table. Then, without any change of voice at all: "My Piotr has the contract for the gardens of the German houses. He will be at the side gate of the Bagatela house on Tuesdays and Fridays with the tools." She wrung out the cloth. "The wall at the side of the Bagatela garden is the wall of the yard of the building in the next street. The yard belongs to a laundry. The laundry has three doors, and the woman who owns it is my Piotr's cousin's wife, and she keeps a horse."

She said it in the manner of a cook discussing a delivery; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the doorway of the kitchen and listened to a woman of fifty hand her the plan for the last week of the war, wrapped inside a paragraph about a horse.

"Anna."

"The lady has lived five years in this city and has never once asked me for anything." Anna Zaleska folded the cloth. "My Piotr and I have our lives, and the boy in the chemist's shop has his. The arrangement is the arrangement: we are the Poles of the house, and you are the woman of the house, and we do not say it to each other and we do not say it to anyone, and on the last day of the war, if we are all alive, we will have a coffee in this kitchen, and that is everything I intend to say about it."

♦ ♦ ♦

The arrests came on the eleventh and twelfth of March.

They came the way the arrests in Warsaw came: at half past four in the morning, in the dark, with vans in the street; and the district learned about them over the following eleven days, in fragments. A Polish clerk of the transport office, forty-one years old, with a wife and three children. A Polish engraver who had done the letterheads. The Polish woman who kept the flower shop at the corner of the Bagatela. And, on the eleventh day, the Polish secretary of the supply section: a woman of thirty-four, unmarried, who had been in the administration four years and who was, in the opinion of every German officer in the building, the best clerk they had.

Her name was Halina Zawadzka.

Marion Herschlag had spoken to her perhaps eleven times in a year — the ordinary exchanges of women in a building: a form, a file, the address of a shop. Once, in July, they had waited out a General together in a corridor

of the Blue Palace and had spent eleven minutes talking about the price of shoes, in the tone of two women who have nothing to say to each other. And in the middle of that eleven minutes, Halina Zawadzka had said one thing about the German filing system that had stayed with her: *the General files transport under coal and coal under transport, and one day the entire war is going to be filed in the wrong drawer.*

She was taken on the tenth of March at four in the morning.

On the fifteenth, at the officers' mess, over the soup, the district was informed that the Polish secretary of the supply section had, in the cellars of the Szucha, after four days, made a full statement, and that the statement concerned the Poles employed in the offices of the district and the Poles employed in the households of its officers.

That sentence put Krystyna Stankiewiczówna in the corridor of aleja Szucha 25 on the nineteenth of March at nine in the morning.

♦ ♦ ♦

The building was a long, three-storey block of the nineteen-twenties that had been the Ministry of Education of the Republic of Poland, standing at the end of the most beautiful avenue in the south of the city: chestnuts down the middle, fashionable Warsaw walking it on Sundays in the twenties. In the fifth year of the occupation the avenue was a corridor of two buildings facing each other across the trees. On the west side, the German police. On the east side, at number 25, the Sicherheitsdienst.

Between them, in daylight, Poles went up and down the avenue in the ordinary way. Not one of them, in five years, ever walked on the west pavement, where the doors stood open.

She was driven there in the Mercedes with the flag on the wing, by the driver of the General of the intelligence of the district, on an errand that had arrived the previous evening on a printed card with a typewritten hour on it, handed to her at the dinner table by a German orderly.

She had eleven hours to prepare, and she spent them doing the only two things there were to do.

The first was to sit in her room in the light of the window for one hour and put her own head in order, item by item, from the beginning: the name; the birth date; the false province of Alsace; the uncle's boots in the flood of 1919; the husband killed near Abbeville before the armistice; the couture house on the rue de Bassano; the four names in Paris; the nine

names on the rue des Rosiers; the carbon copy with the date stamp of 22 XII 42; the green door in the rue Cambon; and the eleven minutes of the twenty-eighth of March 1943 in a small salon on the second floor of the Hôtel Majestic with a man who polished his spectacles on a handkerchief.

The second was to build, deliberately, the one true story she owned.

Because there was a fact with her name on it, and it had been made in a corridor of the Propaganda Staffel on the evening of the eleventh of December 1942, when she had walked twenty minutes between a lavatory and a window while a General talked in a courtyard, and when a list of names in the south of France had moved from a briefcase into a matchbox camera; and if anyone in Europe was going to find that fact, it would be the man with the green notebook, because he had spent three days in the Hôtel Majestic in April 1943 writing down every one of the twenty minutes of a hundred and eleven people.

So she made the story short enough to be carried, and she carried it out in the open, in the daylight, on the theory that a guard looks for a bomb that is hidden.

♦ ♦ ♦

The room was on the first floor and had one window on the inner courtyard, with bars painted the same cream as the walls. A table, two chairs, a portrait above the door hung at the height of a man's eyes, a telephone on the wall. And the corridor outside it, which carried, over the four hours of the interview, three sounds in rotation: boots; iron doors; and the gong.

The gong was on the second floor. It was an instrument of the police of the city of Warsaw, and in the five years of the occupation it was used whenever the men of the Sicherheitsdienst wanted the people in the cells to hear the people in the other cells.

Werner Kroll came in at eleven minutes past nine with two files under his arm and a green notebook in his hand. He did not sit down. He stood on the far side of the table and looked at her for a long moment, and then did what he had done in Paris: took off his spectacles and polished them on a handkerchief.

"Fräulein Herschlag."

"Frau."

"I said Fräulein, and this is the second time you and I have had this conversation." He put the spectacles on. "I will begin by telling you the

thing that no man of my service would tell a woman in your position, and I tell you because it is the reason I asked for you and not for the wife of any other officer in this district."

"Tell me the reason."

"In April 1943, in Paris, I interviewed a hundred and eleven people in the administration of the Militärbefehlshaber. Of those hundred and eleven, exactly one was able, in an eleven-minute interview, to give me an account of twenty minutes on the ninth of December 1942 in the order in which those twenty minutes happened." He opened the green notebook and did not look at it. "Everybody in the world tells the story of a memory in the order of importance: the first thing, the biggest thing, the rest. You gave me a woman walking to a lavatory, and you gave me the twenty minutes in the order of the clock."

"Then you already have the answer."

"I have the fact. I want the reason."

And she gave him the reason, and it was the only true sentence she had built in eleven hours, and she gave it flatly, with the small shrug of a woman of the middle class of Paris explaining a professional deformity.

"The Conservatory," she said. "Seven years of the piano in Warsaw, before the marriage. A girl who has been drilled at a keyboard from the age of nine keeps time whether she wants to or not; and a woman who keeps time tells a story in the order of the clock, because that is the only order she has ever been able to think in. It has been of use to you, Hauptsturmführer. It has never once in my life been of use to me."

Kroll was quiet for a moment. Then he laughed — a small bark, the only time in two years she ever heard him do it.

"The Conservatory in Warsaw," he said, "and the school at Sèvres, and the mother's people from Kehl. You are the only person in this building whose file I have read four times, and I have read it four times because there is nothing in it that is wrong."

"Then there is nothing in it to read."

"There is nothing in it to read," Kroll agreed. "That is what I said."

He sat down.

"Now," he said. "I will tell you what this interview is for."

♦ ♦ ♦

What it was for took the rest of the four hours, and it was not what she had

come for, and it was worse: it was a recruitment.

In February there had been a leak.

A page of a schedule of the fortification of the city had reached the underground, and the Sicherheitsdienst had, over five weeks, arrested eleven Poles out of the offices of the district, and had got two names out of them, and both names were dead ends, because the Polish underground of Warsaw was a machine of cells of five, and a cell of five that has been broken is a cell of five that has been broken.

By March the SD had reached a conclusion, and the conclusion was that the page had not come out of the Polish offices at all. It had come out of the German households: out of the houses of the officers of the district, which had never once in five years been systematically searched, because a German officer's household is his private life, and the private life of a German officer in the fifth year of the war was the one territory in the occupied east where the Sicherheitsdienst needed an order from the Reichsführer himself to put its hand.

"So we shall make the search," said Kroll, "in the spring, with the consent of the officers, through the wives of the officers."

He opened the first file.

"In the twenty-two households of the staff of this district there is one woman who is not a German. She has been in the society of the officers in two capitals. She speaks four languages. She has been in Paris and she has been in Warsaw, and she has been in the apartments of the Militärbefehlshaber and she has taken tea at the table of the Frau Generalin, and she is, in the assessment of my service, the single rarest thing in this administration."

"And what is that?"

"A woman who is not, in any respect at all, a person of the war," said Werner Kroll. "Every other woman in this district is a wife, or a widow, or a mother, or a mistress with a grievance. All of them talk; that is what they are for; the whole administration is held together by the fact that the wives talk to each other in the mornings about what the men say in the nights." He put his finger on the file. "You do not talk. In eleven months in this city, you have not told me one syllable about that household. And a woman who does not talk is either a woman with nothing to say, which is not possible in a house with a General in it, or a woman who is being careful, which is the most useful object in my profession."

She looked at him across the table.

"You want me to inform on the German households."

"I want you to give me the weather," said Kroll. "Not papers. Not names, unless the names walk into your hands. The weather: which of the wives is drinking, which of the husbands is writing letters to Berlin that he should not be writing, which of the houses has a Pole who has been in it three years and has a cousin, which of the women at the Frau Generalin's table has stopped coming, and why. You will be paid a hundred marks a month through the district's miscellaneous account, and you will be given a card, and the card will be signed by me, and it will state that you are employed in the office of the district administration; and the card will do two things: it will make you invisible, and it will make you mine."

"And if I refuse?"

"Then you will go on being the woman of the General of the intelligence of the district, and you will be watched for the rest of the war by a man with a notebook, which is what you have been for the last eleven months, and no harm will come to you at all, because you have committed no crime, and I do not arrest people for being careful." He closed the file. "I have told you the offer, which is unusual, and I have told you the price, which is unprecedented. I have done it because you are the only person in this building who will understand the arithmetic of it: I am not asking you to betray your house. I am asking you to become the only woman in the administration of Warsaw who has an excuse to be in every house in it."

She sat in the chair on the far side of the table, in the room with the bars painted cream, and listened to the boots go down the corridor, and looked at the man with the green notebook, and did the largest piece of arithmetic of her life.

Because it was on the table in front of her, in the open, in the daylight, and what was on the table was this: an official card signed by the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw; a reason to be in every German house in the city; a reason to be in every room, at every table, at every hour; a hundred marks a month; and a man to whom she would owe a small, regular, useful, verifiable supply of trivia about the wives of the officers of the district, which she could manufacture, out of her knowledge of them, for a year, without once giving him anything true.

And in exchange for that: she would be Kroll's.

Not his body, and not his woman, and not even, in the ordinary sense, his informant. She would be the object in his index: the one file in the two hundred and eleven that had a card of its own, with a signature on it, and

that made her the single most protected person in the Generalgouvernement, because a man does not arrest his own instrument; and it made her, at the same time, the woman who in the last week of the war would be standing in a house on the Bagatela with a card in her bag, in her own false name, signed by a Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst.

She had been trained in Kraków to think in five moves.

She made the fifth move and never afterwards regretted it:

"Terms," she said.

Kroll's eyebrows went up half a millimetre.

"I do not inform on the Poles," she said. "I do not inform on the household of the General, and I do not inform on any man or woman who works in the house where I live. I will not put a name in writing in my own hand. I will speak to you once a month, here, and you will write whatever you like in your book, and if at the end of the war there is a court, then the book is yours and the handwriting is yours and I have never signed a thing. And in exchange for that: you will put me on the list of the persons attached to the staff of the district, which is the list that permits a civilian woman to be evacuated to the west in the event of the movement of the civil administration, and to be assigned a place in a train."

Werner Kroll looked at her for a long moment.

"The list of the civil administration," he said.

"Yes."

"That list is for the families of the officers."

"I have been the family of an officer for a year and a half," said Marion Herschlag, "and I am not able to be that for the rest of the war without something in my hand. I do not want the diamonds. I want the seat on the train. That is the price, and it is the reason I am worth a hundred marks a month to you: because in this city there are two hundred and eleven women who will tell you everything for nothing, and not one of them will ever be able to tell you when the cars are being loaded."

He wrote one line in the green notebook. She watched him do it. Then he stood up and put his cap on, and adjusted it, and it was the same gesture as in a room on the second floor of the Hôtel Majestic, in Paris, in April 1943.

"You shall have the card on Friday," he said. "And Fräulein."

"Yes."

"I said in Paris that you were available, and I told you that available is a different matter from suspected, and that it always will be." He opened the door for her. "I was wrong. It is the same matter. Everything is the same matter, in the end; that is the discovery of my profession."

♦ ♦ ♦

They walked her out along the ground-floor corridor, because the office on the first floor had a telephone call upon it and the clerk had come up with the message, and the clerk was a Polish woman of forty in a green cardigan who kept her eyes on the floor, and who was the reason that Krystyna Stankiewiczówna ever saw the inside of the corridor of aleja Szucha 25 with her own eyes rather than through hearsay, and carried it, all the way to the end of the war and beyond it, in a place where it could not be spent.

The corridor was twenty-two metres long and it had, along its left side, eleven doors.

The doors were ordinary office doors painted cream, with brass handles, and each of them had a small window in it of wired glass, and each had a hatch at the bottom, and each of them, from the inside, had a different sound; and if a person walked the length of it in the middle of the morning, that person heard the twentieth century in the space of twenty-two metres, and the sound that stayed was not the screams, because in the fifth year of the occupation the men of the SD of Warsaw had learned what the men of the SD of Warsaw had learned, which is that the sounds of a corridor are the most careless evidence in the world, and that there is a gong on the second floor for that reason. What stayed was the smell: the smell of the corridor of the building at aleja Szucha 25, which was a smell of carbolic and cabbage and the wet of a hundred winter coats, and which had, in it, underneath, something else that the women of Warsaw in the fifth year of the war had learned to identify as surely as a farmer identifies weather: the smell of a building in which a great many people have been very frightened.

She walked its whole length with a clerk in front of her and a man with a notebook behind her, at the ordinary pace of a woman of the administration leaving an appointment; and at the eleventh door there was a man in a German uniform of the police standing with a file, and the door was open, and she looked, because her craft was the craft of a woman who looks at

nothing, and the discipline of looking at nothing is that you look at everything, at the pace of a woman who is thinking about her shopping.

There was a room; a table; a chair; a chair not occupied; a radiator; a drain in the floor of the corner; a bucket; and a young woman, sitting on the chair, in the clothes of a clerk of the district administration of Warsaw, with her hair down, and both her hands flat on the table, and her eyes on the table.

Halina Zawadzka.

The door of the room was shut behind Krystyna Stankiewiczówna by the man with the file, without any particular attention, the way a man shuts a door in a building where doors are always being shut, and the meeting had lasted the length of about a metre and a half of walking, and the fact was this: she had walked past her, in the corridor, at half past one in the afternoon of the nineteenth of March 1944, and neither of them had looked at the other, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna had understood, in the metre and a half, the thing that she had been carrying since the fourth of March without ever once looking at it, which was that the woman who had said *one day the entire war is going to be filed in the wrong drawer* had been taken from her bed at four in the morning and had been brought to this corridor, and that the reason was a page of a schedule that a woman in a house on the Bagatela was going to have to take out of a steel box in a wall in the spring.

♦ ♦ ♦

Outside, the light lay along the chestnuts of the aleja Szucha.

The Mercedes stood at the kerb with the flag on the wing and the door held open by the driver of the General of the intelligence of the district, and along the opposite pavement, against the wall of the building on the west side, in the ordinary way of a Warsaw morning, eleven people were standing in a line with their hands at their sides, guarded by two men of the German police: the ordinary consignment of the small hours, waiting to be called in one at a time through a door with a brass plate, to be identified, or released, or moved to the Pawiak, or taken to the Szucha across the avenue, depending on paper, and knowing nothing, as they always knew nothing, about which.

She walked past the line at the pace of a woman who is thinking about a hat, and she looked at every one of them, because that was the discipline,

and on the fourth of the eleven there was a boy of nineteen with a filthy bandage on his left hand, standing with his shoulders against the wall, looking at the ordinary afternoon the way a man looks at a thing he expects to be taken away from him in the next minutes; and the moment passed in the length of four footsteps.

She got into the car.

The car went up the avenue under the chestnuts in the light of the middle of a Polish afternoon in the fifth year of the war; and there was a woman of twenty-seven in a good coat in the back of it, with her hands folded in her lap and her face arranged in the manner of the women of the German administration of Warsaw, and about the woman in the car there was, to look at, nothing of interest whatever.

And what she was doing, for the seven kilometres between the aleja Szucha and the house on the Bagatela, was not thinking about herself at all.

She was doing her inventory, and it had four lines in it.

Item one: within a week there will be a card in my bag signed by the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw, and the card will say that I am employed at the office of the district administration of the city of Warsaw, and with that card I shall be able to be in every German house in the Generalgouvernement, and in the last week of the war I shall be able to get through a road block and onto a train, in a false name, with a General's safe in my arms.

Item two: that card is a claim on me that will be paid once a month in a first-floor room with a man who polishes his spectacles, and I will pay it out of my knowledge of the wives of the German administration, and it will be manufactured, all of it, for the year, out of fiction, and I will be so good at it that he will come to believe that he has chosen the one woman in Warsaw who is not a person of the war.

Item three: I have seen the inside of the corridor, and the corridor has eleven doors, and I walked it at half past one in the afternoon with a cardigan clerk in front of me and a man with a notebook behind me, and I will spend the rest of my life among people who will want to know what it is like, and I will never tell them, and that will be the last thing about me that is entirely mine.

Item four: the boy on the fourth of the eleven, with the bandage on the left hand.

And the boy on the quai in Paris, with a Polish book about the botany of the Kampinos Forest, and no hat, in a January, in a good grey coat, who came

out to the river in the middle of the day to say something to somebody who might carry it home, and who was taken at a market in the second week, buying bread.

The car turned off the avenue into the street of the Bagatela.

In the garden the fountain that had not run since 1939 stood in the middle of the gravel with a bird on the rim of it, and the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw was at the window of his study on the first floor, with his hands behind his back, watching the car come in; and he was, in the account of the world, a man of fifty-five who had been given a district, a wall, an order and a woman, and who believed, with the belief of his generation, that the arrangement he had made in the middle of the war was the last piece of his life that was still his.

She got out of the car in the light of the afternoon of Warsaw on the nineteenth of March 1944, and went up the marble stair, and into the house, and up to her own room, to take off her hat.

And in the notebook of a Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst, on the line under her name, there was a sentence in his fine clerk's hand, written in the room with the bars painted cream while she watched him write it, and the sentence was this: *Brauchbar. Prüfen im Sommer.* Usable. To be tested in the summer.

CHAPTER SEVENTEEN

The First Frost

♦ ♦ ♦

The spring of 1944 came to Warsaw in the third week of April, all at once, the way it did in that city: four days of wind, and then the chestnuts.

The city filled up with the ordinary of the extraordinary. The queues went on; the German papers went on printing the verbs of consolidation; and under it, in every tram and every courtyard, in a population of a million Poles who had spent five years learning to read the weather of an empire, Warsaw knew, in a way it had never known anything before, that the German army in the east was coming back.

It could be seen from the window of a house on the Bagatela.

The transports came through the Warszawa Gdańska station all day and all night, westbound: what the district called, in its paperwork, the *Rückführung*; and a woman at a window on the first floor of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district could, in an hour of an April evening, count eleven trains: the flat cars with the vehicles, the covered cars with the men, the horse traffic, the hospitals, the paperwork, the booty, the machines, the guns, and — on the third train of the eleventh hour — a an open flat car with the furniture of an officers' mess on it, strapped down, a piano on the top of the pile under a tarpaulin, going west in a Polish April.

She counted them for a month, from that window, and she never once wrote a number down, and by the middle of May she had, in the back of

her head, the schedule of the German retreat out of the east, which she had been building the way she built everything: patiently, one train at a time, in the order of the clock.

♦ ♦ ♦

Kruk came for her on the eleventh of May.

He came the way the men of that organisation came, which is to say with the entire apparatus of a country's conspiracy behind him and the appearance of nothing whatever: a motorcar of the city's gasworks, a driver in a cap, a route through the Praga side, and a flat on the fourth floor of a building on the Brzeska which had been a furrier's before the war and had eleven fur coats still hanging in the back room under a sheet, in a Polish May, because the population of the quarter had been taken out of it in 1943, and the flat was, in the fifth year of the war, the safest set of rooms in the city of Warsaw.

He was fifty-two, and she had known him before the war: Colonel Stefan Wilczek, of the 21st Lancers, who had been in her father's library in 1936 in a good double-breasted suit, arguing about the League of Nations with the confidence of a man who had never in his life had a conversation with a peasant.

He was in a bad grey jacket now, with a pair of pliers in his hand, because when she came into the room he had been doing something to a wireless set on the table; and he looked at her for a long moment and did not get up, and then said, in Polish, in the manner of a man of his class before the war:

"Panna Krystyna. Sit down. I have four things to say to you and no time, because I have to be in the Mokotów district by the four o'clock."

"Then say them."

"The first is that your father is dead and I know it and I have not visited the grave, and there is a reason, and the reason is that in the month of November there were four men of the organisation in the Powązki cemetery at that funeral, and if I had been the fifth, the city would have had the organisation in a room on the Szucha in the January." He set the pliers down. "I am sorry. In the ordinary sense of the word, which in this war has no meaning, I am the sorriest man in Warsaw."

"Say the second thing."

"The second is that I know what you have done for the last year." He looked at her with the grey eyes of a cavalry officer of the old Poland, and there was no warmth in them at all, and no cold either — only an assessment. "I know about the number of the safe and about the page of the schedule and about the boy in the chemist's shop in the Praga and about the manner of the manner in which you have been able to be in the house of a German General for a year and a half and not be a person; and I want you to understand that in the history of this organisation there has never been a woman in your position, and that there will never be one again, and that when this is over, the record of what you have done is going to be a page in a file, and the page is going to have your file name on it, and your file name is WESPER, and the page will say: *no information of the value of the third order was ever lost, and no false information was ever passed, and no member of the network was ever compromised.* And that is the second thing, and it is the only decoration that this city is going to be able to give you, and I am giving it to you now, in a room above a furrier's, because after June there is not going to be time."

"Say the third."

"The third is the demand, and I am not going to be polite about it, because there is no politeness in the thing. The the German line in the east is going to be in the Vistula by the last week of July. The the Red Army is going to be on the bank of the river of the city in the last days of July, and the government of Poland in London has decided that the Polish army of the underground is going to take the city of Warsaw from the Germans before the Red Army crosses the river, and that the operation is the thing that has been called the Tempest since the year of the 1940, and that it is going to be done, and that the reason is that if it is not done, then the government in the London is going to be sitting in a room in the 1946 with the government of the Soviet Union, and there will be no the card in their hand, because the city of Warsaw will have been taken by the Red Army without one Pole having been in the operation."

He stopped and looked at her.

"You do not have to say anything about that."

"I know what Tempest is," she said. "I have known since the January. The the wives of the German administration have been talking about the German line on the Vistula since the March, and the German line on the Vistula is a page in a safe in a study in the house on the Bagatela, and the page has eleven towns on it, and eleven dates, and the last date in the

right-hand column is the eighth of August of the year of the 1944, and under the table there is a sentence in a pencil, and the sentence says that the line is to be held without an interruption until the date, and that there is to be no withdrawal without an order of the Führer."

The room above the furrier's went very quiet.

"Say it again," said Wilczek.

"The eighth of August," she said. "Nineteen hundred and forty-four. *Die Linie ist bis zum Datum ununterbrochen zu halten.* The line is to be held unbroken until that date. And that is not a plan for a retreat; that is a plan for a stand, and it is a stand that was decided in a room in Berlin by men who know what is coming down the road behind us, and there are only two things that a stand in a city can be: a fortress, or a grave."

Wilczek put both hands flat on the table.

"That," he said, "is the fourth thing, and you have just said it instead of me, and I am going to tell you the rest of it anyhow, because it is your orders and I am going to have the pleasure of the once." He leaned forward. "The the page and anything else that is in that steel box is to be in the hands of the staff of the district of the underground of this city by the twenty-fifth of July. Not later. And it is to be taken by you, because there is no one else, and the manner of the taking of it is your own business and I do not want to hear a word of it, and if you are taken while you are doing it, then the arrangement is that us do not know you, and your name is not on any paper in the city of Warsaw, and the manner of the last resort is the business of you and God."

"There is a fifth thing," she said.

"There is not."

"There is always a fifth thing. It is in your face."

Wilczek was quiet for a moment. Then he took the pliers up off the table and put them down again, and said, in a completely different voice, which was the voice of a man of fifty-two who had, in the September of the 1939, taken a squadron of the Polish cavalry into the fire of the German tanks at the Bzura and had lost three-quarters of it:

"There is a captain of the Abwehr in the district staff who was born in the Warsaw in the 1915, and whose the mother was a Pole of the name of the Zaleska, and whose the file has the seven weeks of the 1939 written over twice, and whose the file we have, and who has, in the month of the August of the 1943, signed a paper that kept a boy out of a German list, and I want to know the reason, and I want to know the reason before the

twenty-fifth of the July, and there is only one person in the city who can tell me it."

She stood up.

"No," she said.

"Panna Krystyna."

"The the name of the captain is not going to come out of my mouth, and the reason is not the reason you think, and I am going to tell you the truth about it, because you are the second in command of the intelligence of the army of the underground of the city of Warsaw and there is not a time in the war when a truth is going to be worth more to you than a lie." She put her gloves on, which was a gesture of the pre-war. "He has known what I am since the thirtieth of the January of the 1943, and he has not said a syllable to anybody in the seventeen months, and he has risked his whole life and his whole career and his whole file for a woman he knew in a garden in the 1938, and the reason that he has done it is not a politics and it is not a cause; it is the fact that when he was a boy of nineteen years there was a girl of twenty-two at a piano in a house on the Mokotowska, and he has spent a war in a German uniform in the country of his mother, and the only thing he has ever had is the memory of that room."

The room above the furrier's was silent.

Wilczek looked at her for a long, long moment, with the grey eyes of a cavalry officer of the old Poland, and then he said the thing that she carried, in the nineteen weeks that followed, in the small room at the back of her head, next to the tailor's wife of the rue des Rosiers:

"Then the decision is yours, and it is the worst decision of the war for a woman of the intelligence, because the thing that you have just told me is the reason that the day is going to come, in the next three months, when that man is going to find the truth about you, and on that day he is going to do one of the two things: he is going to save you, or he is going to kill you. And you cannot know which of the two, and I cannot know it, and the only thing about it that I know for certain, is that on that day, Panna Krystyna, the war is going to come down to you and one man and one room, and there is not going to be a single thing in the world that an organisation is going to be able to do for you."

♦ ♦ ♦

The Colonel came home that evening from the Blue Palace with a leather folder, and he came up the marble stairs two at a time, which was a thing he had not done since Paris, and he came into her room without knocking, which was a thing he had not done since the beginning.

"Pack," he said. "Two trunks, the winter, and the good silver, and the papers. To the west."

She was at the window with the evening on the chestnuts.

"To the west."

"To the west, on a train, on the twenty-eighth of the June, which is the train of the families of the officers of the staff of the district, which is going to go to the Breslau, and from the Breslau to a house in the Pomerania that has been arranged for the month of the March." He dropped the folder on the bed. "The the order came through on the Tuesday. The the civil administration of the district of the Warsaw is to be moved west of the frontier in the course of the July, and the military staff of the district is to remain, and the city is to be prepared for a defence, and it is the operation Festung Warschau."

"And the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw?"

"The General of the intelligence of the district is going to hold his district," said Friedrich von Reuth, "and is going to send his household to the west on the twenty-eighth of the June, and is going to come to the west in the September, when the thing in the east has been decided, and there is a house in the Pomerania with a garden and a woman, and the woman is going to be standing in the hall of it with a lamp, and I have arranged my whole life to be able to look at that door."

She looked at him.

"No," she said.

"Marion."

"No," she said again, and she said it with her mother's face, and she said it in the tone in which she had said a sentence to him in the corridor of the Hôtel Majestic in the January of the 1943, and it was the only sentence of their whole two years that came out of the body of Krystyna Stankiewiczówna and not out of the mask of Marion Herschlag. "You are going to hold a district until a date on a paper, and you have been sitting in this city for a year and a half with a schedule in a box in the wall of your study, and it says the eighth of the August, and I know the number because you gave it to me in a bed in the November, and the only thing in the world that you have allowed yourself to be is a man who holds a

district until a date." She stood up from the window. "So there is no train, Friedrich, and there is no house in the Pomerania, and there is no woman in the hall with a lamp. There is a city and a wall and a river and a date in the August, and there is the thing that the two of us have been for the last two years, and I am not going to get on a train and be a rumour that somebody has heard about in a house in the west."

He looked at her for a long, long moment.

"You will stay," he said.

"I will stay."

"And why?"

And in the room of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, in a Polish May, with the eleven trains a night going west under the window and the future standing in the room with its hat in its hand, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, of the house of Stankiewicz of the Mokotowska, file name WESPER, stood in the light of the evening and gave the answer that was the truth, and the truth was the only thing in the world that he could not check.

"Because you are the only man in the world who has ever needed me," she said, "and because the thing in the east is going to happen in this city, and because when it happens, I do not intend to be in the west, in a house, in a chair, with a photograph and a newspaper."

He crossed the room and put his hands on either side of her face, both hands, palms flat against her cheeks, the way he had never done, and looked into her for a long time from a distance of eleven centimetres.

"Then let it be this city," he said, "and let it be this summer."

Outside, in the dark of the north over the wall and the ruins, four whole stations away, the eleventh train of the night was going west under the load of the wreck of an army; and in the cellar of a building in the Praga district a wireless set was receiving the order that had come out of London in the Morse of the night; and in the house on the Bagatela, in the corridor of the first floor, in the dark, a man with four stripes of the front on the sleeve of his tunic stood at the top of the marble stairs and listened to the two of them through the door, and did not go in, and did not go away.

♦ ♦ ♦

The families of the officers of the district of Warsaw left the city on the twenty-eighth of June 1944, at half past five in the morning, in eleven

carriages at the station on the Ochota side of the town; and the order for the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw had been in a leather folder on the hall table since the twenty-fourth.

He put it there himself, on the Saturday, without a word, the way a man puts a bill on a sideboard: the transfer warrant of the household, the ticket of the railway administration for the line of the Upper Silesia, the pass of the military police for the crossing of the frontier of the Reich at the station of Katowice, and a sheet of the paper of the district with the list of the objects which a family of an officer was permitted to take out of the Generalgouvernement in the summer of 1944: two trunks, one case of the silver, one crate of the pictures, three hundred kilograms of the household goods.

And for three days the woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw packed the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw.

She did it on her knees on the floor of the small room with the paper of the district in her hand and the ink of it on her fingers, because there was nobody else in the house to do it: the cook from Bydgoszcz came in at seven and went out at eight; Anna Zaleska was in the kitchen with her hearing and her silence and a bag of the household, and the furier of the staircase was at the gate with his wife and his sister and the sum of his four years of service in a case of the cardboard; and so the two trunks of the household of the General of the German intelligence service in Warsaw were packed by the only woman in the house who was not going to be on the train.

The winter of the Colonel: the two grey tunics, the collar linings, the boots with the trees in them, the greatcoat with the fur of the year 1941, the four shirts of the evening, the photograph in the frame of the leather — she wrapped that in the grey paper of the district and packed it between the boots and the collar linings, so that if the trunk stood upright for the six hundred kilometres to the west, the photograph of Anneliese von Reuth in the garden in 1931 would be face up in the top of the trunk when a woman of the Pomerania opened it.

The papers of the family: the deeds, in the packet of the wax and the red seal; the two account books; the notification of the pension of the widow of the year 1918, which was his mother's; and the little book of the poems that had been in his case since 1915 and that she had never once opened, and that he had never once mentioned, and that she packed in the bottom

of the second trunk with her own hands, in the paper, wrapped twice, because it was the only object in the house in which she had ever found the man in one piece.

And on the Tuesday at noon the two trunks stood in the hall of the marble stair, and the crate of the pictures stood beside them, and the case of the silver was in the corridor by the kitchen; and the furier came up from the gate with the porter of the building of the next street, and the four of them carried it down the marble stair and out through the door and along the garden and into the street, where the cart of the office of the administration of the district stood waiting, and the operation took the middle of the day.

She stood at the top of the marble stair and watched the last crate go out through the door of the house, and there was, at the bottom of the stair, in the hall where the driver of the General of the district would stand in the evening with the cap in his hand, a man with four stripes of the front on the sleeve of his tunic, and he had been standing in the middle of the hall for the morning and had not said a word, and now he said one sentence, in the German of a man of thirty-four from the town of Posen, looking at the door of the house and not at the woman on the stair:

"In the month of the September of the 1941, gnädige Frau, in the town of the Posen, the administration of the Reich evacuated the families of the officers of the garrison of the town of the Posen in the four hours, and there were eleven thousand people in the roads of the west on the first night, and there was an old woman of the age of eighty years in the middle of the road of the column of them, and the people of the column of it walked around her for the night, and in the morning the people of the road of the west were the people of a road, and the families of the officers of the garrison of the town of the Posen did not come back into the town of the Posen in the war." He put his cap on. "The the families of the officers of the district of Warsaw are going to the west in the morning of the twenty-eighth, and there is no place in the west, gnädige Frau; there is only the direction of the west."

"Ehlers."

"Yes, gnädige Frau."

"Are you going with them?"

"The driver of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw remains with the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw," said Ehlers, "and there is not one soldier of the district who is permitted to

ask a question about the household of the General, and there is not one soldier of the district who is permitted to answer one, and I have been in this house for the year, and I have driven this car in the four streets of the German quarter of this city, and there is one thing in the year that I have seen and that I have never once spoken of, and I am not going to speak of it, and the Frau should know that, because in the war there is exactly one kind of a friend that a man of the Wehrmacht is able to be to a woman of the household of his whole of a General, and it is a friend who does not ask."

He went out through the door of the house with his cap in his hand, and the woman on the stair stood in the marble hall of the house on the Bagatela, in the silence of the middle of the day of the twenty-seventh of the June of 1944, and understood, in the eleven seconds of it, the arithmetic that she had been avoiding for a month.

♦ ♦ ♦

They went in the morning, in the dark, at half past five, from the station on the Ochota side of the town.

She went with them, because the wife of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw belongs to the administration of the district in the way that a chair belongs to a room, and because the wives of the staff of the district were at the platform of the station in the dark of the twenty-eighth of June 1944 in their good coats, with their cases and their children and the labels of the administration of the district on the suitcases.

Eleven carriages. The doors sealed by the men of the Feldgendarmerie with a wire and a lead seal on the handles; the windows painted white to the height of the shoulder of a man, in the way of the trains of the administration of the east in the year 1944, so that nothing of the country would be seen from the inside of the carriages of the families of the officers of the German administration of the city of Warsaw.

There were nine hundred and forty people on the platform and about two hundred of them were crying, and one hundred of them were laughing, and them were in the highest state of the efficiency of a German household in the fifth year of a war: the prams folded and labelled, the cases counted twice, the children in the coats of the morning with the bread and the chocolate in the pockets, the grandmothers of the officers' families —

of whom there were eleven on the platform — carried up the steps of the carriages by the men of the railway administration of the district, one on each arm.

The General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw stood with his hands behind his back at the third carriage and looked at the train.

He had not spoken to her in the morning. He had come down the marble stair of the house on the Bagatela at half past four in the dark with his greatcoat on his arm, and had stood at the bottom of the stair, and had said, in the ordinary voice of a general of the army of Germany:

"Marion."

"Yes."

"One word."

"No," she said.

And he had nodded, once, at the foot of the marble stair of the house on the Bagatela at half past four in the morning of the twenty-eighth of June 1944, and had put on his greatcoat, and had gone out to the car; and the conversation of the two of them about the train of the families of the officers of the district of the city of Warsaw had taken the nine seconds of it.

It was the wife of the medical officer of the district who asked her, at the platform, at twenty minutes past five, with the noise and the steam of the station around them.

"Frau Herschlag. You are not in the train."

"I am not."

"The transfer of the household of the General of the intelligence service is for the Frau of the household of the General of the intelligence service," said the wife of the medical officer of the district of Warsaw, who was a woman of forty with a good face and a sister in Stuttgart and a husband who was at that hour in a room of the administration on the avenue of the Ujazdowskie. "There is a place in the third carriage for the Frau of the household of the General, and the paper of the place is with the administration of the train, and the Frau of the household of the General is standing on the platform of the station of Warsaw in the dark at twenty minutes past five in the morning of the twenty-eighth of June 1944 in a coat of the spring of the year 1944, and the Frauen of the administration of the district of Warsaw have been asking the question of it for the month of the June."

"Then the Frauen of the administration of the district of Warsaw are going to have the answer to the question for the rest of it," said Marion

Herschlag, in the French of the woman of Strasbourg, with the courtesy of the avenue Henri-Martin on the platform of the station on the Ochota side of the town, "and the answer is that the woman of the household of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw does not go to the west of the Reich in the month of the June of the year 1944, and the reason for it is that her husband is a general of the intelligence service of a district of the east, and that there is a of an east, and that between the two of them the woman is a matter of the arithmetic of a household, and the Frau of the medical officer of the district is the wife of a doctor of the administration of the district of Warsaw, and is going to the west in a of a carriage with the windows painted white, and the two of us are in the same station in the same morning and are not in the same war."

The wife of the medical officer looked at her for a moment, and did the small, terrible thing that a woman of forty does at the end of an exchange of that kind, which is to be kind: she put out her hand and pressed the arm of the woman of the household of the General for one second, and said, "God keep you, madame. We shall be in the west until this is over, and the west is a hole in the ground and a stove and nothing else, and it is not a life; and the women on this platform are envious of you, and I am the only one who is going to say it out loud."

The whistle went at twenty-five minutes past five.

The train of the families of the officers of the district of Warsaw went out of the station on the Ochota side of the town in the grey of the morning of the twenty-eighth of June 1944 with the hands at the windows painted white and the white handkerchiefs beside them, and there were nine hundred people on the platform of the station, and the nine hundred were the men of the German administration of the city of Warsaw and the women and the Poles who had carried the luggage, and the nine hundred stood in the dark and looked at the train and did not applaud, because there is nothing in the German administration of the east in the summer of the year 1944 that any man on a platform was able to applaud.

♦ ♦ ♦

The frost came on the twenty-ninth of June.

It was not a frost of the winter; it was the thing that the Poles of the Masovia called the cold of the three nights, and it came, that year, in the last week of June, and it came down over the city of Warsaw in the night

between the twenty-eighth and the twenty-ninth with a wind from the north-east; and in the morning the garden of the house on the Bagatela was black.

The tomatoes of the gardener of the district were black. The beans of the household, in the two beds against the wall of the kitchen, were black, and hung with the water of the night, and looked, in the light of the morning of the twenty-ninth, like a thing that had been burned; and the walnut tree of the garden was green, because the walnut of the Masovian plain has been in that country since the Sarmatians and knows the cold of the three nights; and the Italian garden of the house of the wives of the administration on the Ujazdowskie, with the roses and the cypress of the year 1938, was killed in a of a single night, and the wives of the administration of the district of Warsaw were on a train in the province of Silesia, and the roses of the German quarter of the city of Warsaw were dead in the morning of the last week of June 1944.

She stood at the drawing-room window of the house on the Bagatela at six o'clock in the morning of the twenty-ninth of June 1944, in a dressing gown, with the coffee of the household in a cup in her hand, and looked at the garden: the black beans, the black tomatoes, the green walnut tree with its leaves, and the furier of the staircase coming along the gravel of the path with a rake over his shoulder, and stopping in the middle of the path to look down at the ruin of the two beds of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, and then going on with the rake over the shoulder, in the ordinary way of a man on his way to the day's work.

And the woman of the household of the General said, out loud, to the garden, in the Polish of the city of her birth, in the empty room of the drawing room of a German house in the city of Warsaw, the sentence that she had not said in the four years of the war, because there was nobody in the house to hear it, and because there had never in her life been a fact like the frost of the last week of June 1944:

"Two months."

P A R T T H R E E

Tempest

CHAPTER EIGHTEEN

Tempest

♦ ♦ ♦

The wives left Warsaw on the twenty-eighth of June, on a train of eleven carriages with the doors sealed by the Feldgendarmerie and the windows painted white to the height of a man's shoulder.

Lotte Erler came to say goodbye at seven in the morning with two suitcases and a hatbox, in the hall of the house on the Bagatela, in the ordinary manner of a woman of the administration of Warsaw who had been told to be at the station at nine and who was, therefore, at somebody else's house at seven, drinking somebody else's coffee, because there is never any reason in the world to be early for a train that is going to be late.

They stood in the hall. The German cook from Bydgoszcz was in the kitchen making a noise with the pans; and upstairs, in the study, the General of the intelligence of the district was on the telephone to Berlin, which he had been since half past six.

"Well," said Lotte Erler.

"Well."

"I have a piece of paper with an address in Hamburg on it, and a piece of paper with an address in Kassel, which is my mother, and I have a card for a doctor in Dresden who will give me something for the nerves without writing it in a book, and I have twenty-two kilos of luggage." She set down the coffee cup. "I have known two hundred women in this city and I am going to be able to write to eleven of them, and eight of the eleven will not answer, because their husbands are going to be taken prisoner by the

Russians and they are going to be ashamed of it, and in ten years there will be no one left at all who remembers that we took the tea together on Thursdays." She looked at her own gloves. "I am not going to say any of the ordinary things, because you are not the ordinary woman of the administration, and the district has known it for a year, and nobody has said it, because that is what we are: we are a district of people who know everything and say nothing, and that is why we are going to lose."

"Lotte."

"Do not." She picked up the hatbox. "I am going to say one thing, because I am a lawyer's daughter and I always explain the terms. There are four kinds of women on that train: the ones who believe the papers, the ones who believe in God, the ones who believe in their husbands, and the ones who believe nothing in the world. I have watched you for fifteen months and I have never once been able to decide which of the four you are, and there is only one of the four that would explain a woman who stays." She smiled with the mouth that turned up at one corner, and she was, at that moment, thirty-four years old, and she had been four years in the east, and her husband was at Minsk. "So I have written down your name in a book with the others, and I have put against it, in pencil, in the column of the remarks: *knows what she is doing.* And if we are both alive when this is over, and there is a city standing somewhere, and you want a lawyer — and you are going to want a lawyer, my dear, and I am sorry about that, and I am not going to ask why — you will come to Hamburg, and you will ask for Frau Erler, and there will be a woman of forty in a bad coat who will recognise you at once."

She kissed the air beside her ear, and went down the steps with the two suitcases and the hatbox, and got into the district car and went to the station; and the house on the Bagatela was quiet for a quarter of an hour afterwards, and then the cook went on with the pans, and the General went on with Berlin.

Three days later, in the cellar of a house in the Praga district, in a room where there were eleven fur coats under a sheet, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna met the man who had come out of the sky.

♦ ♦ ♦

His name in the organisation was *Sokół*. He was thirty-nine years old and he was one of the two hundred and eleven people who had, over the four years of

the war, been dropped into Poland at night out of a Halifax of the Royal Air Force, out of a hole in the floor of the fuselage, with a parachute, a pistol, a hundred pounds in zloty, a sabotage manual and a cyanide capsule in a sealed tube, into a country in which every human being he passed in the street could be either the reason he was alive or the reason he was dead; and the organisation called these people the Quiet Ones, and there were so few of them that each of them was, in the whole accounting of the war, worth more than a squadron of aeroplanes.

He had come down on a field at night in the middle of May, and he had spent the six weeks since then in the forests of the Kampinos with a wireless set and a formation of the sabotage units, and he had come into the city the way everything came into the city, in a coal lorry, under the coal.

He looked like a schoolmaster: thin, forty, in spectacles with one arm repaired with wire, and a bad chest, and the palms of both hands blistered in the shape of the handles of a spade.

He had four things to say, and he said them standing up, because there was nowhere to sit.

"The first is that I know who you are and what you have done, and I have come from London with the whole file read, and I want to tell you the single thing that none of the men in this city is going to tell you, which is that the men in London do not think about you at all. They think about a page. There is a room in a house in a suburb where four people sit at a table with the photographs of the German line, and what they do is arithmetic about the Vistula, and you are an entry in the arithmetic, and you are doing your work very well, and if you are killed tomorrow you will be replaced on the table by a note in the margin reading *WESPER: lost*." He cleaned his spectacles on his sleeve. "That is not cruelty. That is the war, and I have come four thousand kilometres to tell you the truth about it rather than the version with the flag in it."

"Say the second thing."

"The second is that the men of this city are going to rise in the first week of August whether London likes it or not."

The cellar was very quiet.

"Say that again."

"The first of August, or the second, or the third; the hour will be fixed four days before, and it will be fixed by a man who has to make the decision in a room in the Mokotów district with a telephone that does not work and eleven reports on the table, all of them wrong. The Russian

army is on the river in the last week of July; the German army in this city is the wreck of the army of the east; and the government in London has ordered the underground of this city to take Warsaw from the Germans before the Red Army takes it from the east bank. And there is one thing more, and it is the whole reason that I am in this cellar, and it is the thing I have been ordered to say to you as the officer of the staff of the commander-in-chief." He put the spectacles on. "The rising is going to last ten days. It will last ten days, and after that there will be no ammunition, and after that the men in this city will be fighting with the German rifles that they take off the German dead in the street. And the German defence of the river will depend on a schedule in a safe in a house on the Bagatela that says how long they intend to hold a line, and where, and with what, and when the reinforcements are coming, and we do not know the answer to a single one of those questions; and you are the only person in the world who can get the paper."

"Then say the third thing."

"The third is the date."

He said it, and it was the twenty-fifth of July, and it was eleven days from the second thing; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in a cellar in the Praga district of Warsaw in the first week of July 1944 with eleven fur coats on a rail behind her, and did the arithmetic, and the arithmetic was: *eighteen days between the paper and the rising. Eighteen days between the safe in the study and the first hour of the rest of my life.*

"Say the fourth thing."

And the man out of the sky, with the blistered palms of a man who had spent six weeks in a forest digging a hole for a wireless set, took off his spectacles and looked at her.

"I have been ordered to tell you the arrangement for the day you are taken," he said, "and to be certain that you have understood it, because the organisation has never once had a person in your position, and there is no precedent for it, and the men in the room where this was decided were four colonels and a priest in a house in a suburb of London in the month of April, and none of them had ever been in a room with a German general's woman, and this is what they wrote down for you." He did not read it. He had learned it by heart, in a Halifax, over the North Sea, at eleven thousand feet. "You are authorised, in the event of discovery, to say anything at all, to any man, including the truth, so long as the truth buys one hour; and you are authorised to take your own life rather than to be

brought to the aleja Szucha with the knowledge that you have. And you are not, under any circumstances, to be rescued. And if you are in the house on the day that the city rises, you are to stay in the house, and you are to do nothing, and there is no plan for you; there is no file with a name in it; there is no man with a motorcycle and a spare coat; you are a woman of twenty-seven in a German uniform's house, and on the first of August, when this city begins to kill the German administration in it, you are going to be standing in a room with the man who has been in your bed for two years, and no one is going to be able to get to you, and no one is going to be able to save you."

"Then why did the four colonels and the priest write that down?"

"Because," said Sokół, "they knew that you would read it and would not be able to be told anything else. You are not a soldier; you are a woman of twenty-seven with a false name and a real memory, and there is not one order in the world that will keep you out of the last room of this war, because your life has been the last room, and you are going to be in it, and the men in the world know it, and they have sent me four thousand kilometres to say so, and to say the only thing that is left, which is: *do the work, and be careful, and, when the hour comes, do the thing that the last hour requires.*"

"And what is the thing that the last hour requires?"

"I do not know," said the Quiet One. "Nobody knows; that is what the last hour is. I have been dropped into this country twice out of an aeroplane at night, and I have been shot at sixty-one times, and I can tell you the truth about the last hour, which is that it is always a room, it is always somebody you have loved, and there is never any time at all."

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The twenty-fifth of July was the date of the paper, and she had fourteen days.

It was in the cellar of the Praga that she did the arithmetic of the fourteen days, walking back over the bridge in the light of the middle of the afternoon of the fourth with the basket of the household on her arm and the city going on around her in the way that a city goes on in the last month before the thing that everybody has agreed not to name: and the arithmetic was that the district of the rising wanted, by the twenty-fifth of the month

of July, the page of the paper of the Fall **Wotan** — the page with the map of the line of the river and the table of the rolling stock and the four dates — and that the page was in the steel box in the wall of the study of the house on the Bagatela, and that the steel box was behind a door of the steel of the pattern of the Organisation Todt of the year 1939 with a dial of the brass and the number 9-4-36, and that the woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw was the only person in the German administration of the city of Warsaw who was able to open it.

Fourteen days of the household of a general, in the fifth July of the war, in a city of a million people that had begun to count: the wives' table of the Thursday, the two shops of the German quarter, the tram, the tram, the tram; and in the middle of the fourteen days the thing that the woman of the household was doing at eleven o'clock in the night of every night of that fortnight, in a bath of the temperature of the hand, with the water running, with the window of the room of the bath closed and the blackout blind down, in the house of a general of the German army in the city of Warsaw, in the fifth year of the war.

She developed it in the month of the June, because the water is the only sound in a house of the German administration that a man of the German administration is able to hear through a door without looking up from what he is doing; and by the second week of July the technique of it was this: the film in the Minox at the beginning of the evening, so that the roll of it was in the camera and the camera was in the lining of the bag; the document on the towel on the lid of the closed seat, in the light of the two candles that stood on the shelf of the room with the glass of the household over the flame of them for the German administration of the city of Warsaw had issued the order of the blackout and the women of the houses had put the glass over the flame of them; the shutter of the Minox at the setting of the year 1941, the distance of the page at twenty-two centimetres, the hands of the woman of the household steady for the eleven seconds of the exposure; and the candle out, and the document back in the folder, and the folder back in the box, and the box shut, and the dial turned twice on the last number, and the operation of the eleven minutes finished before the water of the bath was cold, in the room of the bath of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, in the month of July of the year 1944.

On the eighteenth of July, in the evening, in the corridor of the first floor of the house on the Bagatela, in the seven seconds in which the corridor

was empty, the captain of the ordnance of the district of Warsaw said, in Polish, at the volume of a man saying the time to no one at all:

"The twenty-fifth. Where?"

"Where I can, and it is going to be in the hands of the district by midnight, and it is not going to be in the hands of the district by way of you, and the reason for that is that the man who is in the corridor of the first floor of a house of a general of the German army at nine o'clock in the evening is a man of the German army, and the two of us have been standing in the same corridor for the fifteen months of the war, and there is not one officer of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw who has ever looked at the two of us in the same seven seconds."

He looked at her for four seconds, and then the boots of the Feldgendarmerie came along the corridor from the room of the household, and the captain of the ordnance of the district of Warsaw said: "Zu Befehl, gnädige Frau," and went down the stair.

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And in the bed of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, in the fourteen days of the month of July 1944, the thing went on.

It went on in the dark, with the window shut and the blackout over it, in the heat of the Polish July, in the way it had gone on in the winter of the year 1943 and the spring of the year 1944 and the month of the June: the man of fifty-five and the woman of twenty-seven, and the apparatus of the possession of a man of the old school in a house of the east — the hand on the back of the neck, the weight, the orders of the voice in the dark, the long silence afterwards with the arm over the eyes. And in the fourteen days of it, which were the last fourteen days of the arrangement in the house on the Bagatela, she did the work the way she had done it for the two years of the war; and in the middle of the work of the seventh night of the fourteen, on the twelfth of July, in the dark, with the weight of a general of the German army on her, she understood the thing that she had been refusing to understand since the month of the March, and it was not a fact about him.

It was a fact about her.

She had begun, at some hour of some night of the month of the June, to be in the bed. Not in the manner of a woman of the profession of the bed, and not in the manner of a wife; in the manner that a person is in a room

in which there is a person and a lamp and a war and a window with the blackout over it, which is to say: present, in her own body, with her attention, and taking from it the thing that the body of a person takes from a body that has decided to hold it.

It had not happened to her in Paris, in the four months of the arrangement; it had not happened to her in the first year in Warsaw; and the reason that it had happened in the fifth year of the war in a shuttered room of a house on the Bagatela was the arithmetic of the fifth year of the war, which was this: that there was no longer any part of the woman called Krystyna Stankiewiczówna left in the room; and the two women that the arrangement had made — the woman of the General and the woman of the district of the rising — had come to the end of the two of them, and what was left in the bed was a woman of twenty-seven years of age in the dark of a Polish July, with a man of fifty-five asleep on her arm, and there was nobody left in the room to tell her which of the two of them she was.

She lay in the dark for the night of the twelfth of July 1944 with her eyes open and the ceiling of the room of the first floor of the house on the Bagatela above her, and the city going quiet towards the curfew, and she thought the sentence that was the last sentence of the dark part of her life, and she thought it in Polish:

In six days he goes to Kraków, and in nineteen days the city rises, and the page of the paper is in the box in the wall, and the box has a number of four and four and four, and my life has been a paper and a box and a number, and tonight there is a man asleep on my arm who has never once in five years asked me for anything but the truth, and I have given him the truth in the only form in which it has ever been possible to give it: the bed, the lamp, the window, the blackout, the woman.

And there is a man in the corridor of the first floor of this house for seven seconds of an evening who has asked me for nothing at all.

The General came home on the eleventh of July in the blackest humour that she had seen in two years, which was saying something, because she had seen the great unhappiness of that man in a cold room in a chateau in the Loire with a dead woman's dress in her hands and a candle on the floor.

He came in at nine at night, and went past her in the hall without a word, and shut the study door, and was in there for two hours with a bottle and a telephone that did not ring; and at eleven he came out and stood in the drawing-room door and looked at her, and said:

"They are going to cancel the evacuation of the administration."

"They have evacuated the wives on the twenty-eighth."

"Because the wives are a different matter from the administration, and the administration is a different matter from the staff, and the staff is a different matter from the men in the line, and I have spent the evening being told by a General in Kraków that the movement of the civil administration out of the east is a movement that must be *made to look* like a movement of the civil administration, and not like a retreat, and that therefore it must be done slowly, and in the daylight, and with the flags." He put his hand on the door frame. "There is going to be a rising in this city."

She was standing by the piano.

"Say it again," she said, in her ordinary voice.

"There is going to be a rising in this city, and it is going to be in the first days of August, and there are going to be a hundred thousand Poles in the streets with rifles and bottles and a home-made mortar, and it has been put together under our noses in a city in which we have twenty thousand men and a card index of two hundred thousand names, and the reason that we know it is the reason that everybody in Warsaw has known it for the month of the June, which is that the thing has been decided in London, and London talks, and the population of this city talks, and my whole section has spent the spring writing reports about it." He laughed, or made the sound of a laugh. "There is going to be a rising, and the Generalgouvernement has seventeen days to prepare, and the line on the Vistula is to be held, and I have been ordered to make a district of a city into a fortress, and I am a colonel of intelligence with two hundred and eleven Poles in my offices and a safe in my study with a schedule in it, and I have been in the east for five years and I know exactly what a city is: a city is a thing in which two hundred thousand people are going to die very slowly, in the cellars, one street at a time."

He came across the room and took her by both arms, and he was drunk, and he was not drunk in the way she had seen him forty times; this was the other thing, the thing underneath, the man in the ditch at Modlin, the man who had written eleven letters to the mothers of the officers who had shot themselves in the Crimea and had put *duty* in the eleventh letter and posted it.

"I will tell you one thing, and then we will not speak of it again," he said. "There is a train on the twenty-eighth of July, the last of the trains for the civil administration, and I have a place on it for a woman with a foreign

passport and a paper signed by the district that states that she is an employee of the district administration. I did not tell you. I had decided not to tell you. It is the only lie I have told you in two years, and I am telling you about it on the eleventh of July because in seventeen days I am not going to have any control over anything at all, not over a street, not over a train, not over a room, and I want it on the table between us now, at nine o'clock on the eleventh of July, while the two of us are still people."

She stood in an occupied drawing room in a house on the Bagatela with her hands at her sides, in the light of a green-shaded lamp, and looked at the man who had put a district into a steel box in a wall, and answered him.

"Friedrich," she said. "I am not going to the west on the twenty-eighth of July; and you have known that since May; and your asking me now is not for the place on the train at all. So put the paper in the drawer, and don't insult the two of us with the train; and if there is a thing you want to say to me instead of the thing about the train, then say it, and I will hear it, and it will be dark and it will not be the truth, but it will be something better than a railway ticket."

He was quiet for a long time.

Then he said: "Come into the bedroom."

And what he did with her that night, in the house on the Bagatela, was the last of the dark things between them, and she understood that while he was doing it, which was the worst of it: that it was not appetite, not possession, not the ceremony of the district; it was a man of fifty-five holding on to the one piece of his existence that had never once, in two years, lied to him about the war.

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He came to her at three in the morning, which was not a thing he did; he slept through, always, on his back, arms at his sides, chin up, and when he woke he was a man who had been given a district, and not a man who had been dreaming.

But at three in the morning on the twelfth of July, in the house on the Bagatela, he put his hand on her shoulder in the dark, and she woke the way she had spent four years waking, which was not at all, and lay still with her eyes open and her breath going, and he said, in German, into the dark, in a voice that was not the voice of the day:

"Say something in Polish."

There was a silence in the room.

"Why?"

"Because I am lying here in the dark listening to the city and there is not one single Pole in this district who is not tonight thinking about the first of August, and I can hear it, the way a farmer hears weather, and I want to hear the sound of it out of a mouth that is telling me something that is not a report." His hand stayed on her shoulder. "One sentence. Whatever you like. The Polish of the Frenchwoman, which is what you gave me in the third month, in the car, on the way back from the chateau, when you were tired and you said *dobranoc* to the driver and did not know you had said it."

She lay in the dark with her eyes open.

She had learned Polish at the age of three in a house on the Mokotowska. She had learned it in the nursery, and in the garden, and at a piano, and at a school, and in a childhood in a city of a million people who had been, on the first of September 1939, the same city as her. It was the language in which her mother had said *Krystyna, you are not playing the second movement slowly enough*; the language in which she had been told, by a priest in a confessional in October 1943, the thing that would be required of her; the language in which her father had said his last sentence that had been written down, in a book, in the margin, in pencil. It was her and everything she had ever lost; and it was lying in a bed in a German house at three in the morning in July 1944 inside the body of a woman whose hands had been made to be the hands of Marion Herschlag.

And what she understood, in the dark, with the hand of a General of the intelligence of Warsaw on her shoulder, was that it was not going to be done to her.

Nobody was going to take the language out of her mouth for a German's pleasure. Not her, and not her mother, and not the boy at the market, and not the woman in the corridor of the Szucha with her eyes on the table.

So she said something, because a woman in her position said something, always, and lying in that bed was work; and what she said, in the dark, in a an entirely flat and foreign and cheerful voice, was a sentence out of a phrasebook that a Frenchwoman of the administration might have learned from a Polish cook.

"Soup is ready, sir. The tram is late today."

The General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw laughed in the

dark, once, from the chest, the door closing.

"Rot," he said. "The whole of it is rot. Come here."

And he had her again, at three in the morning, in the dark, on the twelfth of July, in the fifth year of the war, and she did what she had done four hundred times, and it was nothing, and it was worse than nothing, and what she was doing in her head, all the way through it, was not arithmetic at all.

She was counting. She was counting in Polish, one number at a time, in the language she had given away in 1940, in a room in Kraków, to a small man with a bad heart; and she got to a hundred, and then she began again at the beginning; and she went on counting through it, and it was the only thing she had left that she had never once in four years handed to anybody.

At four she got up, and went down the corridor to the room that was hers, and put on the light, and sat on the edge of the bed in a nightdress with her hands in her lap.

And she said, out loud, to the room, in Polish, in her own voice, for the first time since a corridor in Paris in April 1943:

"Nineteenth of July. Three days with the General at Kraków. Nine, four, thirty-six. The photograph of Anneliese. The steel box in the wall of the study."

And then she turned out the light, and lay down on her back in the dark with her hands at her sides, and slept, for four hours, the way a soldier sleeps.

CHAPTER NINETEEN

The Long Knife

♦ ♦ ♦

The General went to Kraków on the nineteenth of July.

He left at six in the morning, in the Mercedes, with Ehlers driving and a second car following, because a General of the intelligence of a district did not travel in one car in July 1944; and he stood in the hall of the house on the Bagatela in his greatcoat at a quarter to six with his gloves in his hand, and he said, "Three days. The twenty-second at the latest. If the telephone from the Palace comes, you are to take the message and write it down, and give the paper to nobody, not even to the Oberst, and I mean that."

"Friedrich."

"Yes."

"Come back," she said.

He looked at her for a moment from the doorway with the grey light of a July morning behind him, and she saw, in his face, the single unguarded thing that had ever been on it: a man of fifty-five in the fifth year of a war, leaving a house he did not own, in a city he did not own, to a woman who was the last object of his life.

Then he went down the marble stairs and got into the car and was driven away north, and the house on the Bagatela was hers for seventy-two hours.

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She went about it the way she had gone about the keys in Paris in the wax and the candle, which is to say with a page of arithmetic rather than a mood.

The cook was sent out at nine with money and an errand that could not be completed before three in the afternoon: a list of eleven items, four of them unobtainable, on the far side of the river in the Praga district, and a chit for a pass to cross the bridge and come back. She did it in the kitchen, in German, with the manner of a mistress of a house organising a dinner; and the German woman from Bydgoszcz put on her coat and took the chit and the money and went off at half past nine with a basket on her arm, and the house on the Bagatela was empty of every soul but one at twenty minutes to ten on the morning of the twentieth of July 1944.

She did the rest in order.

She locked the front door, which was never locked in daylight, and the side door to the garden, which was never locked at all.

She went into the study, and stood in front of the photograph of Anneliese in the garden in 1931, with the dog at her feet, and looked at it for eleven seconds, which was a courtesy she had not planned and permitted herself anyway.

Then she took the photograph off the wall.

The safe was an Organisation Todt pattern of 1939, set into the plaster of a study that had been built for the papers of a lecturer in chemistry; and its dial was brass, with a knurled edge, and the plate under the dial carried the serial number she had read off it with a duster in her hand in the house on the Mokotowska fourteen months before.

Nine. Turn right. Four. Turn left. Three. Turn right. Six.

She did it with her eyes closed, on the fourth turn, which is the trick of safe-breaking that no man in the world will ever teach a woman, and which she had worked out for herself in a bed in the house on the Mokotowska in May 1944 while a General slept beside her: *let the fingers do the number; the fingers are mine; the eyes belong to the room.*

The fifth lever gave.

The door opened on the smell of cold steel and paper, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna knelt in front of it on the floor of a German study, in a grey dress, in the middle of the morning of the twentieth of July 1944, and took the life of a colonel of the German intelligence service out of a box in a wall, one item at a time, in the order in which he had stacked it.

The portfolio of Anneliese: forty-one sheets of paper in her hand, watercolours of gardens, and a lock of fair hair in a twist of tissue, and four letters, and a programme of a concert in Leipzig, 1933.

The deeds of the Pomeranian land: two sheets, with a red seal, and a map,

and a tax notice of 1943.

Ilse's letters: eleven of them, in a nurse's round hand, from Berlin, dated through the war; and the last one, from June 1944, containing a sentence that Krystyna read twice and never afterwards forgot: *Friedrich, if the whole thing is ending, come while you still can, and bring nothing, and do not bring anybody who is not ours, because in the end a house in the country is only a room with two names on the door.*

The Verdächtigenlisten: eleven pages, typed, with the carbon copy of a schedule of the German dispositions in the Warsaw district attached, and the names of two hundred and six Poles and eleven Germans, with the names of the eleven Germans underlined in ink and marked with a small cross in the same hand.

The Fall *Wotan* folder: the same page she had photographed in Paris in April 1943, and now four more pages with it, and a map, and a table of railway capacities, and a copied order of the 9th Army of the thirtieth of June 1944, and a sheet of the district's own requisition of rolling stock for the last week of July: eleven trains, with the destinations written against them, and the destinations were not in the east.

And last, at the back of the safe, a brown envelope, unsealed, on which was written a word in ink, in the private hand of Friedrich von Reuth, and the word was a name.

Marion.

She sat on the floor of the study of the house on the Bagatela and opened the brown envelope of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, and emptied it into her lap; and what came out was four things.

A paper, in his hand, dated the ninth of April 1944 — which was the date that the office in Kraków had written on the papers of a woman of Strasbourg in the winter of 1942, and which was also, as she had learned in a bedroom in Paris in the month of the July of 1943, the birthday of Anneliese von Reuth, and she had never once, in the two years, been able to decide whether the woman in the wardrobe in the long room had chosen the date of the cover out of an office's arithmetic or out of a dead wife's head — and headed with the words *Mein letzter Wille* — my last will — and in it a bequest to a woman described as *Marion Herschlag, French citizen, of Strasbourg, presently resident in my household*, of the sum of eleven thousand marks held in a personal account at the Deutsche Bank in Breslau; and a clause, in the same hand, which said: *I have no children.*

My sister Ilse will understand. This is not a payment; it is the only thing that has ever been mine to leave.

A photograph of a woman she did not know, in a bathing dress, on a beach, laughing, 1928.

A small square of paper, folded twice, on which was written, in pencil, in a hand she had never seen, eleven Polish surnames, with figures against them in a second column: it was a list from the offices of the district, and it was in the hand of a clerk, and against four of the names there were ticks. She would understand, much later, that it was a page from the card index of the Sicherheitsdienst, and that the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw had taken it out of the office of the Sicherheitsdienst in the month of April 1944 and had put it in his own safe and had never once spoken of it, and that the surname in the middle of the eleven, with a tick against it, was *Zaleski*.

And a card.

A stiff card, four by six centimetres, of the kind that the district administration used for the registration of aliens, with the eagle of the Reich at the top left, and the stamped word *Ausweis* across the corner, and — typed, by a German typewriter in a German office, at some hour of some day in the spring of 1944 — four lines in the middle of it.

Herschlag, Marion. Geb. 9.4.1919 in Straßburg. Französin. Angestellte der Bezirksverwaltung.

And on the back, in pencil, in the hand of a Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst with a green notebook and a fine clerk's script: *Brauchbar. Prüfen im Sommer.*

Usable. To be tested in the summer.

She sat on the floor in her own house on the Bagatela with a colonel's private existence in her lap and a card in her hand, and looked at the pencil sentence on the back of the card for eleven breaths; and the arithmetic, when it came, came to her in a single piece and it was not an arithmetic at all.

The General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw had taken a card out of the office of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw and put it in his own safe, in an envelope with her name on it, among the letters of his sister and the papers of his dead wife, and he had never spoken of it, because a man does not speak of the thing that he has done; and the thing that he had done was this: he had gone into the office of the man with the green notebook at some hour in the spring, when the district was full of

reports and the man with the notebook was not at his desk, and he had taken a card out of an index of two hundred thousand cards, and he had put it in his pocket, and he had done it as a General of the Wehrmacht's intelligence service for a woman of Strasbourg who had never once asked him for anything.

He had not known how to say it. That was the entire horror of the leaf of paper in her lap.

In the two years of the arrangement, in the four hundred nights of the bed of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, he had never once been able to find the sentence with which to tell a woman that he had taken a card with her name on it out of the index of the man who was hunting him, and had kept it in the safe between his sister's letters and his wife's watercolours; and the sentence he had found instead, in the month of December 1943, in the dark, in a bed, on the night of the Wola, had been the sentence about the combination of the safe: *nine, four, thirty-six.*

He had hidden her name from the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw, and then he had given her the key to the place where he had hidden it, and he had done both of those things without ever once saying a word about either of them, and she had spent four months spending that, and the city of Warsaw was going to be burned in thirteen days.

She put the card in the lining of her coat, with the rest of it.

She put the Pomeranian deeds back in the portfolio; she put Ilse's letters back in their bundle with the string; she put the will back in the brown envelope, and the envelope back at the back of the safe, because the envelope was his and not hers and she was not going to be the woman who took the last thing a man had; and she took, instead, one thing only: the folder marked *Fall "Wotan"*, with its five sheets and its map and its table of railway capacities and its copy of the order of the 9th Army.

She closed the safe. She turned the dial twice on the last number, the way a professional does. She hung the photograph of Anneliese back on its nail, and stood back and looked at it, and moved the bottom left corner half a centimetre, because the papers were going to be looked at in the last week of the war by men with boots and files, and a photograph that hangs crooked in a German house is a photograph that has been moved.

She went out of the study and up the stairs, and put the folder in the suitcase in her room, under the winter coat, and sat down on the edge of the bed with her hands in her lap, and looked at the window for four minutes; and in the four minutes, in the house on the Bagatela, there was no sound

in the world: no cook in the kitchen, no telephone, no car in the street; and it was, in the fifth year of the war, the only four minutes of silence that the city of Warsaw gave her.

♦ ♦ ♦

There was a way out of the garden.

It was the way that a Polish cook had described to a Frenchwoman in a kitchen in the house on the Mokotowska in the month of March, in a paragraph about a horse: over the wall, down between two chestnuts, through the side gate, into the yard of the block in the next street, and the yard, and the laundry with the three doors and the woman who was the cousin's wife of Piotr Zaleski, who kept a horse and washed the linen of eleven German households of the district of Warsaw.

She went through it at four o'clock in the afternoon of the twentieth of July with the suitcase in her hand.

The laundry was a long brick shed with a boiler and four tubs and a mangle and lines of wet sheets across the yard between the wall and the trees, and the woman who owned it was about fifty, with arms like a man's and a cigarette that she never took out of the corner of her mouth, and she did not look up from the tub when the side gate opened; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna walked between the wet sheets to the third door of the laundry, and stood in it, and waited, in the smell of soap and wet cotton and coal smoke, with the folder of the German intelligence service of the district of Warsaw under her arm inside a suitcase.

He came at quarter past four, through the second door, in a shirt with the sleeves rolled, and stopped in the middle of the yard between the sheets, three metres away.

"Ehlers has the car in the Nowy Świat," he said. "The General is at the King's Castle in Kraków, and I have the day, and the estate of the Oberst of the supply section in the north of the city which is my cover for it." He looked at the suitcase. "It is done."

"It is done."

"Then give it to me now, and go back through the wall, and I will be at the Blue Palace at six, and the paper will be in the hands of the district by eleven tonight, and none of it will be in the same room as you." He put out his hand for the suitcase. "Krystyna. Give me the case."

And Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the doorway of a laundry in the yard of a house in the Bagatela, with a suitcase in her hand, in the last days of the fifth year of the war, and looked at the man who had been standing in a Botanic Garden in June 1938 with a book he had never read; and she did not give him the suitcase, and she did not move, and what she said, in the smell of the wet sheets and the coal smoke of a Warsaw laundry, she said in Polish, quietly, and it was the only time in four years that she had made a decision that was not arithmetic.

"Not in the yard," she said. "Inside."

The room at the end of the laundry was the office of the woman with the horse: two metres by three, a table, a chair, a lamp, an ironing board, a window with a muslin curtain and a line of the shirts of an Oberst of the supply section hanging over it, in the afternoon.

She shut the door.

And after that there was nothing in the world that was not two people and the length of a war, and it did not happen the way it happens in the world of the barracks and the French novels of the twenty years; it happened the way it happens to two people of thirty who have been standing in the same city for a year, in the same rooms, in the same weather, one of them being had four hundred times by a man of fifty-five in a German house, and the other one watching it from a doorway with a file in his hand.

It was slow: it was, at the beginning, almost nothing at all; a hand on a wrist, and the shirts of an Oberst of the supply section of the district of Warsaw on a line over the window, and the noise of the ironing board being set against the wall; and she stood in the middle of a laundry office in the last days of July 1944 and let a man take her coat off her shoulders, and she looked at him the time, and there was no arithmetic in her head at all; there was a room, and a smell of soap, and a man's hands, and the noise of her own breathing, which she had not heard in five years.

And what she discovered, in that hour, in a laundry office in the inner yard of a German house in the city of her birth, was the thing that no one had ever told her in a room in Kraków, because in Kraków they taught the four rules and the rules were about the death; and the thing that no one had told her was that a woman's body is not a filing cabinet; that it is a body; that it can, in a warm room with the door shut and an ironing board against the wall, and a man who says her own name; and that in the four hundred nights in the German house, in the bed of the General of the

intelligence of the district of Warsaw, in the four years of the arrangement, she had been present at it, and had never once been in the room.

Afterwards he lay on the boards on the two coats with her head on his arm, and there were the shirts of a German Oberst on the line over the window, and the light of a Polish afternoon came in, and out in the yard a woman of fifty with arms like a man's ran a mangle, over and over, in the same dull regular sound.

"Krystyna Stankiewiczówna," he said, out loud, into the room.

"Yes."

"I have said it in my head a thousand times," he said, "in an office, in a corridor, on a stair, at a railway station in a March, in a garden; and I have never once said it out loud, because in the war there is not a single man in the German administration of Poland who is permitted to say the name, and I have said my own mother's name eleven times in five years, in the dark, into a pillow." He looked at the ceiling of a laundry office. "There is a house on the Bagatela with a steel box in the wall of the study, and it has a certain card in it with your the name on it, in the German of a German office, and the man who owns the house put it there, and I have known that since the April, because the office of the Ordonnanzoffizier is the office of the safe."

"Phillip."

"The the last thing that I have to say to you," he said, "is the thing that I have never once been able to say in the year, and it is the plan. There is a man in the Klarysew, in the villa of a friend of my father, and there is a car in the garage of the district which is my business, and there is the road through the Kampinos, and the forest, and there is a monastery in the Silesia, and a name, and a wireless set; and there is no man in the world who is going to look for a woman of twenty-seven and a captain of the Abwehr of the district of Warsaw in the same car, on the same night, in the last week of the July; and the plan is the only thing that I have, and I am not going to be able to tell it to you in the office of the Ordonnanzoffizier of the district of Warsaw, and I am telling you it now, on the boards of a laundry, with the shirts of an Oberst of the supply section of the district of Warsaw on a line over the window, and it is the truth, and I want you to say a single word."

She lay on the floor of a laundry office in Warsaw in the last days of July 1944 with her head on the arm of a captain of the German army and the ceiling of a Polish shed above her, and she looked at a spider's web in the

corner of a window frame, and did the arithmetic, and the arithmetic took a long time, and at the end of it there was only one item in the column, and the item was not survival.

"No," she said.

"Krystyna."

"No." She sat up; and she looked at him; and she was, at that moment, in the room, with the shirts over the window and the mangle going in the yard, exactly what she had been made to be: a woman of twenty-seven with a folder of German intelligence under her arm and a city about to burn. "There is a thing I have not told you, and it is the last thing I have, and I am going to tell you now, in this room, and then I am going to pick up my coat and walk out of that door and be Marion Herschlag on the Bagatela at six o'clock, and I want you to understand it, because this is the last time in the war that the two of us are going to be in the same room." She put both hands on his chest, flat, and left them there. "There is a plan in this city for the first of August at five o'clock in the afternoon, and there are going to be a hundred thousand men in the streets, and them are going to be killed, and the paper in the case, and the arithmetic, and the year in the house of a General, is the small thing that a woman of twenty-seven is able to put against that; and I am the woman of the small thing, and I am not able to leave the house on the Bagatela, and I am not able to get into a car with a captain of the Wehrmacht and go to a monastery in the Silesia, and I am telling you the truth, in a laundry, with your mother's Polish name in my mouth, and you have to believe me, because I am never going to say it to you again."

He lay on the boards with the shirts over the window.

Then he said: "I know."

"You know what?"

"I have known it since the March," said Phillip Brandt. "I know the plan is a thing the men of this city decided for the men of the war, and I know the hour, because there is not a Pole in the district of the Warsaw who has not been talking about it since the June, and there is not a German in the administration who has not been reading about it in a weekly report, and the two of them are the same week, and the world knows the hour, and the world is going to be in the streets on the first of August, and I am a captain of the German army and my mother was a Warsaw woman and I have seven weeks written over twice in the file of the Wehrmacht." He sat up. "So if there is no car and no monastery and no Klarysew, then tell me what

there is, and I will do it, and I will do it without a question, and if it is a thing that ends on the first of August in a room in a house on the Bagatela, then tell me the room and the hour, and I will be at the door."

She looked at him for a long time.

"There is the laundry," she said. "And the woman with the horse; and if the city is in the streets, then the thing that a woman with a General's safe in her arms is able to do is to be in a place where the German army in the district will not look for the house of the General; and there is a plan, and I am not going to tell it to you in a laundry, on the last afternoon, with the shirts of an Oberst of the supply section over the window; and there is one thing more, and then I am going to go, because the cook comes back at the six."

"Say it."

"On the first of August," said Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, "you are to be on the Wola side of the city, with the men of your mother's people, and I am not going to see you again in this war, and you are going to be alive, and you are going to be a Pole with a Polish wife in a Polish city in a year that neither of us is going to be able to imagine in this room." She stood up, and put her coat on, and stood in the middle of the office of a laundry in a Warsaw July; and she said the last sentence that she said to him in the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, and she said it in Polish, in her own voice, and she said it without one single tear in her, which she was afterwards never able to explain to herself:

She came back to the house on the Bagatela at half past four in the afternoon of the twentieth of July 1944, at the hour of the ordinary end of the afternoon of a German administration, with the street in the ordinary state of a week in the middle of the summer: the chestnuts along the avenue of the Ujazdowskie in their full leaf, the two sentries at the gate of the district command in their shirtsleeves with the tunics on the hooks inside the box, and the Polish woman who sold the flowers at the corner of the Krucza sitting on her stool with the buckets and not one customer in the afternoon.

The furier of the staircase met her in the hall.

He was sixty-one, a reservist of the district administration of the city of Posen who had been on that staircase for four years, and he had, in the four years, never once come up the steps of the house to meet her; and he came up the steps of the house, in the middle of the afternoon of the twen-

tieth of July 1944, in the greatcoat of the district, in the heat, with his cap on and one hand in the air, and said:

"Gnädige Frau, the General of the district telephoned from Kraków at two o'clock, and the General of the district is on the road and will be in Warsaw at nine o'clock tonight, and the General of the district has ordered that the car is to be at the station of the Warsaw West at eight o'clock, and that the household is to be informed, and that the house is to be in the ordinary state, and that the Frau of the household is not to be told anything about anything, which is the order of the General of the district, and I am giving the order of the General of the district to the Frau of the household exactly as the telephone gave it to me."

"Why is the General coming home?"

"I do not know, gnädige Frau."

"Why is the flag of the district on the gate half-mast, Furier?"

The man put his hand up to his face.

"Because at a quarter to one this afternoon the wireless of the district carried the announcement of the office of the Führer," said the furier, "and the German administration of this city has been at the wireless since a quarter to one, and there has been an attempt upon the life of the Führer of the German Reich in the headquarters of the east, and there is an address of the Führer to the German people at midnight, and the garrisons of the east are at the alert, and there is not one officer of the district of Warsaw who is in the building of the command at this hour, and there is not one man in the German administration of this city who has been told anything at all."

She stood in the marble hall of the house on the Bagatela with the case of the district's papers in her hand — the five sheets of the Fall **Wotan** in the waxed envelope in the lining of the case, and behind the boiler of the laundry in the yard of the building in the next street there was nothing at all, because she had moved it to the laundry on the fourteenth of the month and had not been able to say to any human being in the world that the safe of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw had been opened in the middle of the morning of the same day — and looked at the furier of the staircase in the heat, and did the arithmetic of the twentieth of July.

It came out in the order of the danger:

The wireless of Europe is carrying the news of an attempt on the life of the head of the German state, and the administration of this district is going to

spend the night and the following day doing what an administration does at a moment of that kind, which is to open the files and check the lists and look at the men; and a general of the intelligence service of a district who comes home from Kraków in the middle of the night of that day is a general who has been in a room with the staff of the army group of the south for eight hours; and there is going to be, in the next four days, a purge in the German administration of the east of the kind that the German administration of the east has three times in the year, and it is going to touch the men of the offices and the officers of the staffs and the wives of the men of the offices and the households of the officers of the staffs; and there is a card with my name on the front of it and four words of pencil on the back of it in the index of the office of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw, and the man who wrote the four words of pencil on the back of it is the one man in the German administration of this city who does not do what a German administration does at a moment of that kind, because he has spent the war doing the other thing, and the other thing is to check the card index of the population of a city against the paper of the offices of the district.

She went up the marble stair with her hand flat on the rail.

At the head of the stair, in the corridor of the first floor, there was a captain of the ordnance of the district of Warsaw in a tunic with the collar hooked, with a of the papers of the office in his left arm, and he had been standing in the corridor for the time that the furier of the staircase had been on the stair, and the two of them looked at each other across the eleven metres of the corridor of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw in the middle of the afternoon of the twentieth of July 1944.

"Gnädige Frau."

"Herr Hauptmann."

"There is a business of the office," he said, in German, at the volume of an officer of the district reporting to the wife of his general on the state of a corridor. "The district is at the alert until the morning of the twenty-second. The the officers of the staff are at the building of the command for the night, and the men of the guard of the house of the General of the district have been doubled, and there is a NCO of the Feldgendarmerie on the garden gate until the morning of the twenty-second, and nobody is to come into this house or out of it between the eight o'clock of the evening and the six o'clock of the morning except the household and the officers of the staff of the district, and the telephone of the

study is to be answered by the Ordonnanzoffizier of the district and by nobody else in the house for the night." He looked at her for four seconds, and in the four seconds the sentence that he did not say was in the corridor with the two of them: *the case, the laundry, the wall of the yard, the eleven men on the guard if it goes wrong tonight.* "The Frau of the household will be in the small room, and the Frau of the household will not be in the study, and the Frau of the household will not be in the garden, and the Frau of the household will not be at the window of the landing of the first floor for the night, and if the Frau of the household has a thing to say to a man of this house in the night, the man will be in the passage of the first floor at the eleven o'clock and at the one o'clock and at the three o'clock, and there is not one other thing in the world that the man is able to be for the Frau of the household in the night."

"Then the Frau of the household is going to be in the small room," she said, "and the man is going to be in the passage at the eleven o'clock, and the Frau of the household is going to be able to be asleep at the eleven o'clock, because the house has been in the ordinary state for the four days of the week and there is nothing at all in the house that is not in the ordinary state."

"The the house is in the ordinary state," said Phillip Brandt.

And then the bells of the churches of the city of Warsaw began to ring for the evening of the twentieth of July 1944, in the way that the bells of the churches of a city of the east ring at the end of a day, and there was not one Pole in the quarter who knew the reason that the bells of the city of Warsaw were ringing on the evening of the twentieth of July 1944, and the four days that followed, in the house of the General of the intelligence service of the district of the city of Warsaw, were the strangest of the war.

"And if it goes the other way, and we are both in this city in the autumn, then I am going to come and find you, on the ruins of the Nowy Świat, and I am not going to be Marion Herschlag, and I am not going to be the woman of the General, and there is not going to be a single man in the world who is going to be able to tell the two of us apart from the rest of the people of Warsaw."

CHAPTER TWENTY

The Quiet Ones

♦ ♦ ♦

In the last week of July 1944, the city of Warsaw did the thing that a city does when it has been told, by its own sons, that it is about to be free. It waited. It went to work. The trams ran on the Marszałkowska and stopped at holes in the track where the shells of 1939 had never been repaired, and the queues stood outside the shops with their coupons, and the German papers printed the verbs of consolidation, and on the bridges over the Vistula the columns of the German army went west in the ordinary way: the horse traffic and the hospitals and the carts of the paper. And under all of it the city was a machine, running: a hundred thousand people between the ages of sixteen and fifty, in cells of five, and each cell knowing nothing of the next, and it keyed, and oiled, and loaded, and waiting for a word that would come out of a room in the Mokotów district.

She saw it, in the last week, from the tram.

She rode the number 6 up the Marszałkowska on the twenty-fourth of July at four in the afternoon, in her Frenchwoman's coat, with a shopping basket, and watched the city at the last moment of the thing that had been its life for five years. Two Polish boys of seventeen were doing something at the corner of the Kredytowa with a bicycle whose frame had been cut in half and welded back; and a woman of sixty in an apron was standing on a doorstep with her arms folded, watching a German officer walk down the middle of the pavement; and at the corner of the Świętokrzyska a man of

thirty in a worker's cap was reading a wall with his attention, in the way of a man reading the prohibited press; and a girl of about eleven was skipping, alone, on the pavement of the street of her childhood, with the rope going round and round, and the song she was singing was the one that the children of Warsaw had been singing for four years all through the streets:

Sierpnia pierwszego, o piątej godzinie...

She heard it through the window of the tram, at a distance of two metres, from a girl of eleven, in the open daylight, in the middle of a city in the fifth year of the German occupation.

On the first of August, at the fifth hour.

That was how she learned the date. There is no intelligence service in the world that can compete with a child's skipping song.

♦ ♦ ♦

René Tissier came to the house on the Bagatela on the twenty-sixth of July at eleven in the morning, in the uniform of a Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst, with orders in his pocket and a neat little moustache and a curious, clever, exhausted face, and the cook announced him in German as an officer of the office of the district's liaison, and Marion Herschlag came down the marble stair of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw and stood in the hall and looked at the man who had bought her a book in the rue de Rivoli in March 1943.

He was fifty. He had been born in Lyon and had spent the twenties in Warsaw as a teacher of French and had gone back to Paris in 1935 and had made a paper out of other people's marriages; and he was standing in the middle of a German hall in a German uniform with his cap under his arm, and he looked at her the way he had looked at her in the foyer of the Théâtre des Champs-Élysées, with his hands behind his back, smiling.

"Madame Herschlag."

"Monsieur Tissier."

"You are surprised."

"I am not in the least surprised. You have been a man with a paper and an ear for eleven years, and there is a war on, and there is a district of Warsaw, and there is one Frenchman in it who was in Paris in the same rooms as the German administration in 1943. I am surprised only by the uniform, and

only because I did not think a man of your taste would find one that fitted."

He laughed, all the way through, for a long time, in the marble hall.

"Beautiful," he said. "Beautiful. I have thought about you, do you know that? Four hundred times. In Paris I sat in a room after the liberation of Africa and I listened to the Berlin wireless and I thought: the little actress's mouth is standing in the corner of a General's drawing room, and there is not one other human being in Europe who knows what she is." He put his cap on the table. "I am not a Hauptsturmführer. I am a civilian attached to the office of the liaison of the Sicherheitsdienst in this district; I have a rank because a man in this city who travels in a car without a rank is a man who is shot; I have been here since February; and I have known where you live since the month of April, because I read the register of the households of the officers, which is one of the things my office does."

"And what does your office want with a Frenchwoman from Strasbourg?"

"Nothing at all. My office believes that I am delivering you a document." He put a folded paper on the hall table: an order of the district, on German paper, concerning the evacuation of the civil administration. "That document is genuine, and it will be signed by the General's own hand when he comes back from Kraków on Sunday, and it will inform you that the administrative staff and their attached persons leave on the thirty-first of this month, and it will require you to be at the station at half past five in the morning."

She looked at the paper on the table.

"And you?"

"I have a pass for a place on the same train, which is worthless, because I have looked at the freight tables, madame; I have spent four months looking at the freight tables, which is what a civil servant in a uniform does in the last week of July. There is not going to be any train west of this city after the thirty-first, because the Russian aeroplanes are going to be over the bridges by then, and there are four hundred thousand German civilians in the east and eleven trains, and the arithmetic of it has been done in Berlin, and the arithmetic of it is that the German administration of a city that is about to rise is not going to be evacuated. It is going to be *abandoned*, and the people in it are going to be told that they are going to the west until very late in the day, and then they are going to be told that they are going to hold a fortress."

"You are telling me this for a reason."

"I am telling you this," said René Tissier, "because I want to be on the train that does leave, and there is exactly one train in the east that is going to leave this city in the first week of August, and it is a military train, and it is under the authority of the district's intelligence service, and I have been at some pains to find that out; and the woman of the General of the intelligence of the district is the only person in Warsaw who can put a man on it."

She stood in the hall of the house on the Bagatela and did the arithmetic, and the arithmetic was not about Tissier.

It was about the fact that the entire strategy of her life for five years had been to be nothing, and that the accounting had just arrived; and that René Tissier had been holding her name in his hand since November 1942, and was going to spend it now, in the last week of the war, in a marble hall, on a hot morning in July, in the form of a very small, very reasonable request.

"What, exactly, do you want me to do?"

"On the thirty-first," he said, "when your husband goes to the Blue Palace for the last conference of the district, you will come down to the yard with your coat and your case, and you will take the car, and you will go to the station, and there will be a man with a pass and a place in a carriage, and he will be me; and you will say one sentence to the officer at the train, which is: *this man is with the General's household.* And then you will sit down, and the train will go, and there will be two people of Paris in a carriage in the dark, going west, and it will be the end of it."

"And if I say no?"

"Then I will do nothing at all," said René Tissier, "because I am not the man of a novel and I do not want a great deal; and if I do nothing at all, then I shall be a Frenchman of fifty in the city of Warsaw in the first week of August, and I shall be taken by the Poles or the Russians or shot by the German military police at a road block in the last day of the world, and there will be one less man with a newspaper." He picked up his cap. "But, madame, before you say the no, I want you to think of one thing, which is not a threat: I have known what you are since November of 1942, when I came up behind you in a corridor with a glass in my hand and said the name of a Polish family, and you went grey. In the nineteen months since then, I have not once said it, and I have not once written it. Do you know why?"

"Tell me."

"Because I am a man of fifty in a war who has never in his life been able to keep anything, and it is the only thing I have ever had." He put his cap on, and stood in the middle of the marble hall with his hands at his sides. "If you say no, madame, you will say it to the only person in Europe who has ever been able to keep your secret, and I want you to be aware of that, on the day, at the station, when you say it."

He went out through the front door of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, in the uniform of the office of the liaison of the Sicherheitsdienst, at twenty minutes to twelve on the twenty-sixth of July 1944, and the sentry at the gate saluted him because a Hauptsturmführer of the SD was a man whom sentries saluted; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the hall for a long time after the door had shut, with a genuine order of the district on German paper in her hand.

♦ ♦ ♦

The Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska was in the drawing room on the Mokotowska with her case packed and a photograph in her lap.

She was sixty-nine, and she had spent the last week in the things that a woman of her class did in the last week of July 1944 in the city of Warsaw, and she had done them without any hurry at all: she had made the inventory of what was in the flat; she had given the piano to the parish; she had paid the deaf cook to the end of August, and she had sent her out of the city to her sister at Grodzisk on the twenty-second; and she had sat in the drawing room alone, in the chair that had been in the family since 1851, with the photograph of a man with a moustache in her lap, and had waited for the thing that was going to happen, the way one waits for a train that has been delayed in the snow.

At half past five on the twenty-seventh, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna came through the courtyard in the maid's coat, with a cabbage in a bag, the way she had gone to the Krasińskiego.

"They are going to do it," the Countess said.

"I do not know anything about it."

"Do not be tiresome with me, my child, on the last Tuesday of the world; I have been in this city since 1886, and I have been counting the German cars going west and the Polish boys coming down the street in pairs for a month; and there is not a woman at the market who does not know it, and

there is not a German in the administration who has not written it in a report, and you, who have been in the house of a German General for two years, are going to tell me that you do not know anything about it." The Countess put the photograph down. "On the first of August, at five o'clock; that is what they are saying. I have it from the woman who does the flowers for the church."

She said it the way she said everything: with the flat, complete, unsentimental clarity of a woman who had been in the world for sixty-nine years and had buried a husband and a son.

"There is going to be no water and no electricity. The telephone will not work. There will be no bread for a fortnight, and there will be no medicine, and there will be a great many people in cellars, and I do not intend to be in one." She looked at the maid's coat, and at the bag with the cabbage in it. "I am going to the fathers of the Visitation. There is a house beside the church with a garden wall, and the superior has agreed to it, and there will be a room with a bed and a chair, and eleven other old women; and I have two hundred zloty and a rosary and a photograph, and I will be, God willing, alive on the fifteenth of September, or else I will be in the Powązki cemetery with my husband."

"Madame—"

"Do not." The Countess held up her hand. She was, in that year, the only human being who ever spoke to Krystyna Stankiewiczówna as though she were a person and not an instrument, and she never once, in the fourteen months, asked her a single question about her work. "I have one thing to say to you and one thing to give you, and then you will go, because you are in a maid's coat and my neighbours are Polish and it is half past five.

"The thing I have to say is this. There is going to be an hour on the first of August when every Pole in this city is going to look at every other Pole in the street, and the question that every one of them is going to ask in their own head, without ever saying it, is the same question, and it is: *what did you do?* And you, my child, are going to be standing in a German house, in a German General's clothes, with a German card in your bag, on the first of August at five o'clock in the afternoon, and there is not one man in this city who is going to believe the answer; and there is not one hero of the Rising who is going to make any room for you, this year or in the year 1950, and there is not going to be a stone in the city of Warsaw with your name on it.

"And I want you to know, before it begins, in this room, on the last Tuesday of July, that I know what you have done. There have been exactly four people in this city who have ever known it: a priest of the Visitation, a colonel of the cavalry, a captain in a German uniform, and an old woman of sixty-nine in a chair. Three of the four will be dead by the middle of September. So I am the accounting, and I am telling you: I know what you have done, and I have known since the month of November, and I have prayed for you every Sunday of the year, at the eight o'clock, in the second row, and a woman of my age does not go to the eight o'clock for nothing."

She stood, with some difficulty, and went to the secrétaire by the window, and took out of the drawer a parcel wrapped in paper, and gave it to Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, and said, in French, in the flat accent of a governess from Neuchâtel in 1887:

"The thing I have to give you is from your mother's drawing room. It is the one thing that Pelagia was not able to carry on the second of December 1939; the woman who had the flat after you took it out of the piano bench on the fourth of March 1940 and gave it to me, because on the fourth of March 1940 she was afraid of the world and there was nobody else in Warsaw to give it to. It has been in that drawer for four years. I do not know what you will be able to do with it, and I do not want to know; but it is yours, and there is no one left who has the right to keep it from you, and if you should be in this city on the fifteenth of September, and I should not, then I want you to open it in the ruins of your father's flat, and not before."

The parcel was the size of a book, and it weighed almost nothing, and it was warm from the drawer.

"Now go," said the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska. "And do not come back to this house; and do not kiss me; and in the rest of your life, when you are asked by anyone at all what you did in the war, I want you to say the only true thing there is to say, which is that you were a woman in a house, and that the house was not yours."

♦ ♦ ♦

Ehlers broke on the twenty-eighth.

The news came to the district by way of the motor transport office at eleven in the morning: a raid on Posen, a hundred and eleven aircraft, the

district of the north of the city, the street where his Marta had lived with her mother and her sister for the five years of the war.

He was in the yard when it came. She saw him from the corridor window of the first floor of the house on the Bagatela: a driver of thirty-four in a clean tunic standing in the middle of a yard with a piece of paper in both hands, and then going down on one knee in the gravel, in the ordinary way of a man whose legs have stopped being a thing that he owns; and the second driver of the district was with him in four seconds, and got him up, and took him into the kitchen.

She went down.

He was in the kitchen with his cap on the table in front of him and his hands flat on the cloth, and the German cook from Bydgoszcz was standing at the stove with her back to him, making a noise with the pans, because she had been in the administration for four years and had learned what the women of the country did when a man came into a kitchen with news.

"Ehlers."

"Gnädige Frau."

"The the street?"

"Four hundred metres," he said. "The letter is from my sister-in-law. My wife's mother is dead, and the sister has lost an arm, and the house is in the street, and there is nothing left of it, and there was a chestnut, and Marta's bicycle, and the piano that belonged to the family of the mother." He looked at his hands. "I have driven this car for the district for four years, and I have driven the General and the Obersts and the colonels of the Generalgouvernement, and I have never once had a thing in my hand that was mine, and I have had a photograph in the flap of my map case, and now the photograph is a photograph of a girl who does not have a street."

He looked up.

"And there is one more thing, Gnädige Frau, and I am going to say it now, in this kitchen, because the German administration of the district of Warsaw is going to be dead in a fortnight or in the street, and I have never once in four years said a thing to you that was not correct, and I am going to say one."

"Say it."

"I drove the General to Kraków on the nineteenth of July," said Ehlers, "and I came back on the twentieth, and I came back by the way that goes past the Bagatela, and I brought the Mercedes into this yard at four o'clock

in the afternoon, and there was a woman of this house coming in through the garden gate from the yard of the building in the next street, with a case in her hand."

The stove ticked. The cook made a noise with the pans.

"I am a driver," he said. "And I have been a driver for the Wehrmacht for four years, and the first thing that a driver of a General learns is the thing that is in the hand of the woman of the General, because the woman of the General is the thing in the house of the General that is not permitted to be a danger to the General, and the car of the General is the place where the driver of the General thinks about the thing." He folded the letter with the greatest care, and put it in the pocket of his tunic, and stood up. "I am not going to say a word to the General, and I am not going to say a word to the SD, and I am not going to say the word to the priest of the district, and I am going to be at the wheel of this car on the first of August, and I have not told the Frau a single thing, because the Frau has never once told me a single thing either, and in this war there is exactly one kind of a friend that a man can have in a German house in Warsaw, and it is the friend who does not ask."

He put his cap on.

"And the one thing that I want," said Ehlers, "is the photograph in the flap of the map case, and it is the last object in the world that I have, and the man who is going to take it away from me is going to have to do it with his hands."

♦ ♦ ♦

She wrote down the plan that night, and then burned it, and then wrote it out again in her head, in order, the way the men in Kraków had taught her to hold an address.

The thirty-first, at half past five in the morning: the civilian train. The General will want to put me on it; the paper is already on the hall table; and the thing that I am going to do, at the station, in the dark, with the German military police at the barrier, is the hardest piece of the last month, because it is a lie that I am going to have to tell him with my face and my hands and my voice all at once, and it will be the last lie I ever tell him.

Tissier is on the platform. He will watch me decide. Whatever I do, he will see it.

On the first, at five o'clock, the city rises. The General will be at the Blue Palace or he will be here. If he is here, I am in the house with him; if he is at the Palace, I am in the house alone with a card in my bag and a folder in a suitcase and a woman with a horse in the yard behind the wall.

The folder goes with me; the suitcase is already in the laundry, behind the boiler, under the eleven fur coats which were moved there in the month of May by a woman of fifty with arms like a man's, and which nobody in the world is going to look through in the first week of August, because there is going to be a war in the streets, and a fur coat is not a thing that a soldier takes to a barricade.

And there is the amber in the parcel of the Countess, and the parcel is in the lining of the winter coat in the wardrobe of the room of the first floor of the house on the Bagatela, and if everything else goes, the parcel goes with me at the last minute, because it is my mother, and because I have decided that there is going to be exactly one object in the world that comes out of this city in my hand.

She went to the Visitation on the twenty-ninth of July, at six in the morning, at the hour of the first mass of the priests.

The church was on the Krakowskie Przedmieście at the head of the Old Town, a great baroque barn of a place with a façade of the year 1770 and its treasure in the side chapels, and she went in by the sacristy door at the north, with the black coat and the headscarf of a woman of the Praga market on her head, and the priest was in the sacristy in the green vestments with the vestments put on already and the front of his face washed and shaved in the way of a man who has been up since four.

He was fifty-eight and his name was the name of a village in the province of Kielce, and he had been the channel between the house on the Bagatela and the officers of the district of the rising since the month of the November of the year 1943; and he looked at her for a moment in the light of the one lamp of the sacristy and said, without any greeting at all, in the Polish of a priest of a city parish:

"You are early. Sit down. There are the four minutes before the mass and there is nothing to confess in the four minutes, and no absolution in the four minutes, and I want you to listen."

She sat down on the chair at the wall of the sacristy.

"The first thing is that the hour of the thing is fixed, and it is the first of August at five in the afternoon, and I have it from the men themselves, and the churches of this city have it, and every priest in the deanery knows

the hour and every priest in the deanery is hearing it in the confessional from the people of the city, and there is not one of us who is going to be able to say afterwards that he did not know." He put his stole straight, the way a man arranges his work. "The second thing is mine, and it is that the fathers of this house are not going to leave the city. There are eleven of us and us are going to be here, and the church is going to be in the middle of the fighting, because the façade of it is on the Krakowskie Przedmieście and the enemy is going to be three hundred metres to the west of the front of it; and the cellar of this house is full of the people of the parish since the month of the May, and it is going to be fuller, because the superior of the sisters of the Visitation has taken in eleven women of the old families of this city, in the house behind the church, in the last week of the month, and there is a woman of the household of the German general among the eleven who is known to you and who is not going to say my name to any German in the war."

"Jadwiga Ostrowska."

"Jadwiga Ostrowska," said the priest, "who came here in the month of June of the year 1886 for the first time in the arms of a wet nurse, and who has been at the eight o'clock for the forty years of the life of the parish, and who is in the house behind the wall of this church with a bed and a chair and a rosary, and who is sixty-nine years of age, and who asked me in the month of the May for a place, in the way of a woman who is settling an account."

The bell went for the mass.

"The third thing," the priest said, "is the last thing that I am going to say to you in the war, and it is not about the rising and it is not about the paper that you have carried out of the house of the German for the fifteen months of it: it is about the woman."

"Father—"

"Listen. In this house there have been four men and one woman who have known your name in two years, and I am the last of them who is going to be alive in the middle of the month of September, and I know that the way a man of fifty-eight knows when he is going to be in a cellar under the guns of an army of the east. So I am going to give you the last of my time to the part of the matter that the men of the command are not able to give you, and I am going to say it to you the way a priest says it to a woman at the end of a confession, without the absolution, because you have not asked for it and you are not going to ask for it, and because there is not one priest

in this city who is able to give absolution to a woman for a thing that this city is never going to be able to know that she did."

He said it, in the four minutes, in the vestry of the Visitation of the Blessed Virgin Mary of the city of Warsaw, on the twenty-ninth of July 1944:

"You have been the paper of the intelligence of this city for the fifteen months of it, and you have been the woman of a German general for the two years of it, and there is not one person in the city of Warsaw who is ever going to be able to put the two of them together in a sentence: not a priest, not a colonel of the cavalry, not a boy of the Praga, and not the man who is in the corridor of the house of the German in the seven seconds of the evening. So I am giving you the instruction that is left, and it is the instruction of a priest of a city parish and not of a chaplain of an army: when it comes to the end, and there is nobody left to carry a paper to and no name to be given, then the matter is not the paper and not the name and not the city. The the matter is the woman. Keep the woman. There is nothing else."

He stood up and took the things of the mass off the table.

"And now go out of the north door and down the passage to the wall and into the street at the corner of the Miodowa," he said, "and do not come to this church again while the city is in the fire, and if I am alive and you are alive at the end of it, then I shall be at the eight o'clock in the second year of the peace, and you will be able to be at the eleventh row, and there will be no need for the two of us to say one word about the war."

She went out through the north door of the church of the Visitation at twenty minutes to seven in the morning of the twenty-ninth of July 1944, in a headscarf, down the passage of the side of the church, and out through a break in the wall into the street of the Miodowa, where the tram of the early hour was standing at the stop with the people of the market on it; and the woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw got on it and went home to the second breakfast of the house in a suit she was going to have to be seen in for the last time; and the priest of the Visitation went out into the church of the Visitation of the Blessed Virgin Mary of the city of Warsaw in the green vestments with the boy and the taper of the six o'clock and did the office of the first mass of the twenty-ninth of July 1944, in the ordinary way of the church of a city in the fifth year of the war.

The church of the Visitation, with the treasure of its side chapels and the fathers of the house and the eleven women of the old families of the city in

the cellar behind the wall, was in the fire of the German army on the twenty-ninth of August 1944, at the hour of the middle of the day, and there was not one human being of the eleven fathers of the house who came out of it.

Eleven days, and the last of them began with a train.

CHAPTER TWENTY-ONE

The Photographer's Window

♦ ♦ ♦

The studio was on the Nowy Świat, four doors from the corner of the Świętokrzyska, in a building with a marble stair and a brass plate that read *Fotografia — Lichtbildnerei* in two languages, and it had been the studio of a Polish photographer named Wierzbicki since 1922, and it had been, since 1940, one of the eleven establishments in the city of Warsaw that were permitted by the German administration to make portraits of German officers.

The window of it was the window she had walked past four hundred times: a shallow bow of glass, with a black velvet board in it, and on the board, in the last week of July 1944, forty-two photographs in three rows.

She had looked at that window in every month of the last two years, and it had always been the same and always different, in the way that a window of photographs in an occupied city is always the same and always different: the officers of the district in their tunics, at the beginning of their service or at the end of it, before they had been promoted or after; and a woman of twenty-seven who had learned to walk past a window forty times a month had learned, in the course of two years, to read the window like a register.

In the spring of 1944 there had been a photograph in the second row, third from the left, of a Hauptmann of the intelligence section, in a tunic with the ribbon of the winter campaign of 1941-42; and she had never

once, in the time it hung there, permitted herself to look at it in the daylight.

On the twenty-ninth of July, at four in the afternoon, she had an appointment with Wierzbicki about the portraits of the General, which the district had ordered in the month of June and which were, in the last week of the war, one of those pieces of German administration that still had to be attended to; and she came up the marble stairs in her grey dress at four minutes to four, and the Polish boy in the shop said that the Herr Photograph would be with the lady in a moment; and she stood in the shop with her gloves in her hand, looking through the glass at the street, and René Tissier came in at two minutes to four with his cap under his arm.

"Madame Herschlag."

She did not turn around.

"Where is the man who was following me on Wednesday? Or was it Thursday? The one with the bicycle who is too old to be a man with a bicycle."

"He is in the café, madame, and he will stay there, and I have come alone, because I want you to listen to me without the apparatus, and because I have an hour." Tissier put his cap on the counter. "I am not going to ask you about the train today. I am going to give you something, and then I am going to go out and be on the street before you have left the shop, and you will never see me again unless you look for me."

"Give me the thing, then."

"There is a card index," said René Tissier. "It is in the aleja Szucha, in a room on the second floor, and it belongs to a Hauptsturmführer named Kroll, and it has two hundred and eleven thousand cards in it, and there is a card in it with your name on it, and I have read it, because my office has the index consolidated for the civil administration, and I have a key to the cabinet where the consolidations live, which is what a Frenchman of fifty is in this war: a man with a key to a cabinet."

She kept looking at the street through the window.

"Tell me what is on the card."

"*Herschlag, Marion. Born 9.4.1919 in Strasbourg. French. Employee of the district administration.* And on the back, in pencil, in the Hauptsturmführer's hand: *Brauchbar. Prüfen im Sommer.*" He paused. "There is also, in the same cabinet, in the file of the department of the east, a page dated the thirtieth of April 1943 with a list of four names from the Militärbefehlshaber in Paris, and one of the four names is the name of a

woman who was in a corridor on the eleventh of December 1942, and there is a question mark in the margin next to it that was made in a pencil that does not belong to the man who typed the list, and the pencil is the pencil of the Hauptsturmführer who keeps the cards."

The shop was quiet. Behind the curtain of the studio, in the back room, somebody was moving a lamp.

"So you have come to tell me that you can be my death," she said.

"I have come to tell you that the Hauptsturmführer is at this hour reading a report about a page of the fortification schedule that got to the underground in February, and that in the last week of July a man with an index like his is not looking for a spy; he is looking for a hole in a house; and that when the city rises on the first of August, there is going to be a period of about eleven days in which nobody in this administration is going to have the time to read a card in a cabinet. And after the eleven days, there will be either a German administration or a Russian one, and in either of those the card is a piece of paper with a name on it that nobody will ever read again." He picked up his cap. "I have not come for the train today. I have come to tell you the thing that the man on the bicycle could not tell you: that I am able to put a piece of paper into a fire, madame. In the last week of the world, that is the only trade that I have left, and I am offering it to you without any price at all, because the man who has read your card is the only person in Europe who knows what you are, and when the cities are in ruins and the two of us are dead or alive, I would like there to be one thing in this war that I did out of my own smallness and not out of my fear."

He put his cap on, and looked at her for a moment, and there was, in his face, nothing of the foyer of the Théâtre des Champs-Élysées: he was fifty, and he had spent four years in the middle of the things that men of his kind did, and he was going to die in the month of August 1944 in circumstances that no one would ever write down.

"At nine tonight, the cabinet on the second floor is open for the consolidation of the files of the civil administration. I will be there. There will be a man with me, because there is always a man with me. So if you want the card in the fire, madame, you must be the one who tells me that; and you may tell me at any hour before midnight on the thirty-first, by the ordinary post, in an envelope, with one word in it."

He went out, down the marble stairs, into the Nowy Świat, at eleven minutes past four in the afternoon of the twenty-ninth of July 1944; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the shop of the photographer

Wierzbicki with her gloves in her hand, looking at the window of the street, until the boy came to fetch her.

And the photograph in the window, in the second row, third from the left, which had hung there since the spring of 1944, was of a Hauptmann of the intelligence section of the district of Warsaw in a tunic with the ribbon of the winter campaign; and the lady in the grey dress looked at the window for a long moment as she went out of the shop, the way a woman of the district looks at the photographs of the officers of the district, with her attention, as though the window were nothing at all.

♦ ♦ ♦

At half past seven that evening she went to the Sicherheitsdienst and paid her monthly instalment.

It was the sixth time she had done it, in the first-floor room with the bars painted the colour of the cream of the walls, and in the six times she had established the thing that was going to save her, at the last, and it was not an affection: it was a *habit*.

She had taught Werner Kroll the shape of her usefulness the way a woman in a salon teaches a man of fifty the shape of an evening: a piece of gossip about the wives, always true in the facts and useless in the substance; a warning about a colonel of the supply section who drank and talked in the officers' mess at the Blue Palace about the movement of the trains — which was true, and which she had given him in June, and which had cost that colonel nothing, because he had been transferred to Kraków in the following week; the price of butter; the arrangements of the Frau Generalin's table; and the small, exquisite, perfectly true item that she had brought him in July about the wife of the district's medical officer, who had been writing letters to her sister in Stuttgart about the hopelessness of the German position in the east.

The letters had been nothing: a woman of thirty-eight writing to a sister. But Kroll had put the sentence in his notebook with the fine clerk's hand, and had looked up at her the way a man looks up at a good piece of work, and had said: "You have an ear, and you have no cruelty, and it is a combination that my service does not have and cannot make."

That evening, at half past seven, she gave him Tissier.

She gave him the man, exactly as it was, in the flat voice of a woman of the administration of the district who had been frightened by something in a

shop; and it was true, every word of it, and it was the truth arranged in the order of the clock, which is the order in which the man with the green notebook had once, in a room in Paris, told her that she was unique.

"On Wednesday and on Thursday a man followed me, an old one, on a bicycle. On Saturday, at eleven in the morning, a Frenchman of fifty, René Tissier, who has the uniform of a Hauptsturmführer of the office of the liaison, came to the house on the Bagatela and presented an order of the district concerning the evacuation of the civil administration and told me that he intends to be on a train. On the twenty-ninth, at four o'clock, the same man was waiting for me at the studio of the photographer Wierzbicki on the Nowy Świat and told me that he has a key to the cabinet of the consolidation of the files of the civil administration and that he had read the card index of this office, and that he knows that a woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district has a card in the index with a pencil note on the back of it, and he told me the words of the note."

She said it without a pause, and she looked at Kroll across the table while she said it, and she finished with the sentence that she had built, in the tram, on the way there:

"And then he offered to put the card in a fire, and he asked me for nothing in exchange; and the reason he asked me for nothing is that he is going to be in the city on the first of August, and he is fifty, and he is one of the four hundred thousand German civilians in the east, and he wants the one thing that every man in the German administration of the east wants in the last week of July, which is a place on the train; and the way he is going to get the place on the train is by holding a card over the head of a woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district, so that she takes him to the station in a German car, and says one sentence to the officer of the train, and puts a stranger into the civilian administration of Warsaw in the last week of the war."

Werner Kroll put his pen down.

He was silent for eleven seconds, which was a long time for him, and in the eleven seconds she watched him go through the arithmetic that she had built for him in the tram: a Frenchman of fifty with a key to a cabinet of the civil administration, reading a card index of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw, and offering to a woman of a German General's household the removal of a card from that index, in exchange for a place on a train; and a man of that description in a room of that kind, in a district that was about to be the scene of the last German defence of the east, was

not a man who was holding a card over the head of a woman of the district.

He was a man who was holding a card.

"How long has he been in this city?"

"Since February. He is the liaison of the office of the civil administration with the office of the district; he is French; he was in Warsaw before the war, as a teacher of French, in the twenties, and he has been in Paris through the occupation, and he sat at the table of the Hôtel Majestic in 1943 at the invitation of the Militärbefehlshaber." She put her gloves on. "His name in Paris was on the list of the journalists who were permitted to the press conferences of the Propaganda Staffel. He is a man with a newspaper, Hauptsturmführer. He has been a man with a newspaper for eleven years."

Kroll wrote one line in the green notebook, in the fine clerk's hand, and closed it.

"Madame Herschlag."

"Yes."

"You have brought me a Frenchman of the civil administration who has been reading my index," he said, "and I want to tell you what the transaction looks like from this side of the table, because I have never once lied to you, and I do not intend to begin on the twenty-ninth of July." He stood up and put his cap on and adjusted it, and looked at her with the flat, patient, terrifying courtesy of a man who had spent eleven months writing down the names of the population of a city. "A woman whose card is in the index of my office has come to me and informed against the only man in this city who has ever read that card. There is a reading of the transaction that is loyal: the woman has brought me a leak in my own office. And there is a second reading of the transaction, and it is a reading that a man with my profession must always make, and it is that the woman has taken the one man in Warsaw who holds her life in his hand, and has put him in my hand, in the last week before the city burns, which is the most elegant piece of work that anybody has done in this district in the four years of the war." He opened the door for her. "Both of the readings are true, or one of them, or neither. I have decided to act on the first, because the man with the key is a danger to the office and a nuisance, and because the second reading requires me to believe that a Frenchwoman of the avenue Henri-Martin has been able to spend two years in this district under my nose for a purpose that nobody has ever been able to demonstrate; and I

am a policeman, and in my life, I have never once arrested a person for a possibility."

She stood on the threshold of the room with the bars painted cream.

"And what will you do with him?"

"I will take him tonight," said Werner Kroll, "in his flat, with the key in his pocket, and I will take his cabinet, and I will put him in the Pawiak, and on the first of August the population of the Pawiak is going to be a very large problem for the German administration of this city, and I have every intention of being on the other side of the river when the problem is decided." He held the door. "This is the last time we shall speak in this room. There is not going to be a consolidation of the files after the thirtieth; my office goes to the west; and you have the card that I promised you in March, and you have something better, and you have had it for four months, and I might as well tell you, because it is a matter of arithmetic and not of the heart: there is a list of the persons attached to the staff of the district that is permitted to leave with the civil administration, and there is a second list of the households of the officers of the district, and every name on the second list has been checked, and there is one name on the second list that has been checked four times, and the name is yours, and the checks were made in Paris, in Strasbourg, and in the office of the Militärbefehlshaber, and the reason I have checked it four times, madame, is that in my career I have never once seen a file that was as clean as yours."

She looked at him.

"Then it is not a file," she said. "It is a woman who has been very careful."

"There is no difference," said Werner Kroll, "and there never has been."

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She walked home from the aleja Szucha at twenty to nine in the evening of the twenty-ninth of July 1944.

It was the hour of the blackout and the hour of the curfew for the Polish population, and the street belonged to the patrols: two men of the German police at the corner of the Bagatela with their torches down, a car of the field police standing at the mouth of the Polna with the motor running, and the Poles walking in the middle of the roadway in the way the Poles of Warsaw had learned to walk in the fifth year, close to the wall

and fast and with their eyes on the pavement eleven metres in front of them. She walked in her own street the way she had walked in it for fourteen months, in the grey dress and the good shoes, and the men of the patrol looked at her and looked away: the woman of the household of the General of the district was a fixed object in the quarter, like the sentry box and the chestnut tree.

The house was empty of everybody but the cook and the furier.

She had a bath, and ate the cold supper that had been left for her under a cloth, and stood for a while at the drawing-room window with the blind down and the lamp off, listening to the city: the tram on the Marszałkowska, the radio of the German officers' mess at the corner of the Ujazdowskie, the bell of a tram in the direction of the Wola, the flat crack of one shot somewhere north of the wall, and then nothing. It was the sound of the last week of the occupation, and every Pole in the city was listening to it the way a farmer listens to the wind.

The telephone rang at eleven.

"Marion."

"Friedrich."

The line from Kraków was a long-distance line of the military administration, and it came with the apparatus of the year 1944: a hiss, a hum, and the voice of the operator of the exchange at Częstochowa asking for the number and the rank of the subscriber in the flat tones of a woman of the post, and then the connection, and then the voice of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw coming into a dark study in a house on the Bagatela out of a room six hundred kilometres to the south.

"You should be in bed."

"I should be anything you like."

"That," he said, "is the first thing you have said to me in two years that I have not been able to hear and answer in the same minute." There was a pause on the line, and a noise like the sea, which was the crackle of the province of Poland between the two of them. "I have been in a room with eleven men since four o'clock. There is an order coming, and it is going to be in my hand on the morning of the thirty-first, and it is an order about the line of the river, and the line of the river is drawn on the map on the table in front of me at this hour with a coloured pencil, and it goes from the bridge of the north of the city to the bend at the Wilanów, and I am a general of the intelligence of a district that is going to be asked to hold a

front of twenty-six kilometres with a battery of twelve guns and a battalion of the railway."

"There will be more."

"There will be nothing more," said Friedrich von Reuth. "The line of the river is a map, and the map is a piece of the arithmetic of the east, and the arithmetic of the east was decided in the month of June at Minsk, and I am a man of fifty-five in a room in Kraków reading a map on which the German army of the east is a line of coloured pencil." He was quiet for a moment. "I have a question for you, and it is the question that I have been asking myself since the month of the May, and I am going to ask you across the province of Poland on a telephone, because on a telephone a man is able to say anything."

"Ask it."

"Why are you in that house?"

She stood in the dark of the study of the house on the Bagatela with the receiver against her ear, and the question, which she had been waiting for since the ceiling of a room in May, was in the room with her, at the end of a line of six hundred kilometres, in the voice of a man of fifty-five who had never once asked her for the truth and was never going to be able to hear it.

"Because in my life," she said, "there has been exactly one house in which I have been able to be in one piece, and it is the house on the Bagatela, and the man in it is on the telephone in a room in Kraków asking me the question, and the answer is: because it is the only one."

The line was quiet for eleven seconds.

"On the morning of the first of September," he said, "there is a train of the district of the intelligence service of Warsaw going to the west with the records of the district, and I have signed the paper of it this evening in the room with the eleven men, and there is a place on that train for the woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, and the paper of the place is in the pocket of my tunic, and I am going to put it into your hand in this study on the night of the thirty-first of the August 1944, and we are not going to discuss it, and you are not going to look at me in the way you look at me when you are doing the arithmetic."

She held the receiver with both hands.

"Come back," she said. "On the thirtieth, at nine in the evening, at the door of the house on the Bagatela, in the Mercedes, with the mud of the province of Poland on it; and there is going to be a bath and the glass of

the Silesian and the woman in the chair by the window with the lamp turned low, and the rest of the arithmetic is going to be able to wait for the morning."

"Marion."

"Yes."

"There is one more thing," said the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, "and it is the last thing I am going to say on this telephone, because the operator of the exchange at Częstochowa is a woman of the post of the Reich, and she has been on this line for four minutes, and it is the last thing that I am ever going to say in the war that is going to be in a record in the records of it: whatever happens, there is not one thing that has been in this house that has not been mine; and of the objects in it, the one that is in the chair by the window with the lamp turned low is the only object that the war has not been able to take, and I have been in the war for the five years of it."

The line went dead at eleven minutes past eleven, and the house on the Bagatela was silent, and the woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw stood in the middle of the study of the house with the receiver in her hand and the dial of the telephone of the district in front of her, and the conversation was in the room and was going to be in the room for the rest of her life.

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She went upstairs and did the arithmetic of the morning.

The dress for the station: the grey, with the coat of the spring of 1944, and the shoes that were good enough for a platform and used enough not to be looked at twice by a man at a barrier, and the hat that the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska had given her in May with the four rules in it.

The bag: the Minox loaded with the last film of the arrangement, the document of the district in the name of Marion Herschlag, the Kennkarte of the administration, the money — eleven hundred zloty and four hundred marks — the two photographs of the household, and the little book that the woman of the Countess had left at the flat of the Krasińskiego in the month of the June and that was, in the property of Krystyna Stankiewiczówna in the year 1944, the only object that had been in the house of her mother.

The coat: the winter coat with the parcel of the Krasińskiego in the lining, on the hook in the wardrobe, where it had hung since the third of July, and which nobody in the house had looked at since the third of July, because in Warsaw in the last week of July of the year 1944 there was not a man in the German administration who was able to look at a winter coat.

And she stood in front of the open wardrobe in the dark of the room on the first floor with the inventory in her head, and did the last piece of the arithmetic of the twenty-ninth of July 1944, and it was this:

Tomorrow at half past five in the morning, the last train of the civil administration of the district of Warsaw leaves the station on the Ochota side of the town, and the woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw is expected on it, and the paper of the place is in the pocket of the tunic of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, and at half past five in the morning the German administration of the city of Warsaw is going to be standing on the platform of that station and looking at the two of us; and the thing that I am going to have to do on the platform at half past five in the morning of the thirty-first of July 1944 is the last piece of work of the four years, and it is not a lie of the mouth and it is not a lie of the face, and it is a lie of the body of a woman who is going to stand in the middle of a station in the dark and refuse to get into a carriage in the manner of a person who is telling the truth.

And then there is going to be one more day.

The General came back from Kraków at nine o'clock on the evening of the thirtieth of July, and he came back a different man, in a way that she saw from the window of the first floor before he was out of the car.

He was thinner in two days. He stood at the door of the Mercedes and looked up at the house with his face grey; and he was carrying, in a leather folder, an order of the army group, and he came up the marble stairs with it the way a man carries a document that has already killed eleven people.

"They have given me the line," he said, standing in the hall. "The Vistula line. From the bridge at the north of the city to the bend at the Wilanów: the district's intelligence, the engineers of the garrison, and eleven trains of materials that are not going to arrive. I have eleven days, twenty thousand men, no fuel, no aeroplanes, and a city of a million Poles in the middle of it." He put the folder on the hall table and looked at her. "And there is the order about the civilian administration, which is what I came back from Kraków with, and which I am going to ask you to obey at half past five

tomorrow morning, at the station, when the last train of the German civil administration of the district of Warsaw pulls out."

She looked at the folder on the table.

"You are going to ask me."

"I am going to ask you," said Friedrich von Reuth, "because in two years I have never once given you an order, and because in my life I have never once asked a woman for anything, and because the arithmetic of the east is on the table in that leather folder and I have looked at it for four hours in a car from Kraków and I know what it says, and it says that on the first day of August the city of Warsaw is going to burn, and that the burning is going to be in the north and the centre and the Wola, and that the house on the Bagatela is four hundred metres from the first barricade, and that the woman of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw is going to be, in the first week of it, a name on a door of a German house with a light on in it."

"Friedrich."

"One word," he said. "At the station, at half past five in the morning, in the dark, on the platform, with the Feldgendarmerie and the administration of the district looking at the two of us. One word, and it is over, and I will put you on the train with my own hands."

And in the hall of the house on the Bagatela, on the thirtieth of July 1944, with the tray of the German cook standing on the sideboard and the walnut tree in the garden and the city going quiet outside the windows in the blackout, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna did the last piece of arithmetic of the first five years of her war, and it took four seconds, and at the end of it there was exactly one answer, and the answer was the one she had known since the fourteenth of May in a May, at the end of a conversation in a room above a furier's in the Praga district.

"Yes," she said. "Tomorrow, at half past five, at the station. I will be ready."

He came across the hall and took her face in both his hands, the way he had done in the room on the first floor in May, and looked at her for a long time from a distance of eleven centimetres.

"Thank you," said the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw.

C H A P T E R T W E N T Y - T W O

Names and Numbers

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The German civil administration of the district of Warsaw left the city on the morning of the thirty-first of July 1944, at half past five, from the station on the Ochota side of the town, and it left the way such a thing always leaves: in a fog of paperwork and tears, with a hundred and forty civilians, four hundred metres of freight cars, eleven lorries of files that had been loaded by Polish labourers under the eyes of German military police, and a locomotive that had been reserved for the ceremony since the twenty-fourth of July, and which was the last locomotive in Warsaw that anybody in the administration had any confidence in.

Ehlers drove her there at four o'clock in the morning. The streets were empty and white with dust, and there was a red half-light over the Vistula, and at the corner of the Kaliska a Polish woman was already at the pump, filling two buckets before the day; and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, sitting in the back of the General's car with her case on her knees, watched a city get up on the last morning of its old life and thought, without any drama at all: *In thirty-seven hours the second of these mornings will be the wrong one.*

The platform was a blaze of electric light, because somebody had ordered that the station be illuminated for the departure of the civil administration of the district, and because nobody in the last week of July had been willing to countermand it. Under the lamps stood the kind of crowd that wars make: mothers with children sitting on the trunks; a district official of

sixty in a good coat sitting on a chair that he had brought with him from his own office, on the platform itself, with his hat on his knees, refusing to look at anything; eleven German nurses of the Red Cross in a row with their cases, laughing too loudly; two men of the railway administration arguing with a sergeant of the Feldgendarmerie about the loading of a pianola; and children, a great many children, in the coats of a normal August morning, dragging their suitcases and asking their mothers whether the war was over.

She got out of the car into the smell of hot metal and coal smoke, and the first thing that she saw on the platform, three metres from the door of the car, was René Tissier's leather writing case, on the ground, beside the buffers of a freight car, with a boot-print across the flap.

She looked at it for one second, and then did not look at it again, and she walked down the platform beside the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw with her case in her hand.

They had arrested Tissier on the night of the twenty-ninth, at his flat in the Żoliborz, with the key of the cabinet in the pocket of his tunic; and they had taken his papers, and his uniform, and his writing case, and the writing case had come to the station on the cart of the office of the liaison with the rest of the abandoned equipment of an office that had stopped existing, and it was lying on the ground near the buffers, and nobody was going to pick it up. There was, in the platform, under the lamps, no sign anywhere of a Frenchman of fifty, and there never would be again; and the last of René Tissier was a leather case with a boot-print on the flap and a man in the Pawiak who was going to be one of the eleven thousand people in that place on the morning of the second of August, which was a piece of arithmetic that she did not know and never learned.

"Come," said the General.

He had been awake the whole night at the Blue Palace. There was a grey band round his face and his hands were not steady, and when he had come home at eleven o'clock the previous night he had gone straight past her into the study and had stood in front of the open safe for a long time with his back to the room; and she had watched the light of the study lamp on the shoulders of his tunic through the crack of the door and had thought: *the only thing that will destroy me now is the man's memory.*

They walked to the carriage. It was the third one, a second-class carriage of the Mitropa, with the blinds down, and the compartment reserved for the General had a card in a brass frame on the door: *Gen. d. Inf. v. Reuth /*

Bezirksverwaltung. There was no name card for a woman, because the General of the intelligence of the district had refused to have one printed, and the refusal, in its own way, was the most tender thing that had ever happened to her in Warsaw.

Ehlers put the case on the rack.

"Frau Herschlag," he said. He was standing in the corridor with his cap in his hand, and his face was the face of a man who had eleven days to think about a woman coming in from the yard of the next street with a case in her hand. "The car will be at the Palace of the district at eleven, and the General has given the order that the car is to be kept at the house for the morning, and I am to drive the Frau wherever the Frau wishes to go, and I am to be back at the house at four o'clock with the car because the staff of the district is to be at the Palace at five." He put the cap on. "There is one thing more, and then I am going to the engine and I am not going to say another word to the Frau about it. There is a ferry at the ferry-place below the Citadel which is going to be running for the night of the thirty-first, and it takes a man or a woman for a hundred zloty, and it is the last of the eleven ways to the other side of the river, and the ways have been closed since the twenty-eighth. If it comes to it, the Frau should go to the ferry-place and not to any of the eleven."

"Ehlers."

"Yes, Frau."

"Why?"

"I have a photograph in the flap of my map case," said Ehlers, "and it is the photograph of a girl who does not have a street, and in my life in this administration I have done nothing at all with it, and the thing that a man does in a war when he has nothing at all is the thing that he does for a person who has also nothing at all, and that is the end of the subject." He looked at her. "The Frau should not go on the train."

"Why not?"

"Because the train is going to be in the open country between here and Skierniewice when the city is on fire," he said, "and when the railway line is cut at Grodzisk the train is going to be standing in a field with a hundred and forty German civilians in it and a locomotive, and the Russian aeroplanes are going to be over that field in the morning." He turned and went down the corridor, and stopped, and said over his shoulder, in the ordinary voice of a driver reporting that the car was full of fuel: "And because the photograph in the map case is of a girl who was in a street in Posen that

the Russian aeroplanes came to, and I have never once in four years been able to tell a woman in this administration a true thing, and now I have told it, and there is not going to be any more."

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Half past five.

The platform was full of people who were saying goodbye. It was the part of the morning that she had spent eleven days preparing, and the preparation, when it came, was worth nothing, because in the eleven days she had prepared the words and she had not prepared the silence, and it was the silence that came first.

The General stood beside the open door of the carriage in his greatcoat, with his gloves in his hand, and looked at her.

"Well?"

"Friedrich."

"The train leaves in six minutes," he said. "The Frau Präsidentin of the administration is in the fourth carriage, and there is a place reserved for a Frenchwoman of the household of the intelligence section, and I have in my pocket the pass and the warrant for the place, and I am going to hand them to you in the next minute, and then I am going to put you into that carriage with my own hands, and then I am going to get into the car and go to the Blue Palace, and at eleven o'clock tonight I am going to be in the house on the Bagatela, and I am going to have a bath, and I am going to drink a glass of the Silesian at the table in the small room, and there is going to be a woman in the chair by the window, because for two years the house has been a house in which a woman of the household has been in the chair by the window when I come in, and I have never once said a word to her about it because there is no word for it in my language." He took the two papers out of the pocket of his greatcoat and held them out. "Take them."

The lamps of the station were on. The pianola was going up the ramp at the end of the platform, two Poles and a sergeant swearing at it in two languages. Eleven metres away a German nurse of the Red Cross was crying over a suitcase, and behind her a boy of about nine was standing with his cap in his hand looking at the train, and the smoke of the locomotive was rolling along the roof of the station in the light.

Krystyna Stankiewiczówna looked at the two papers in the hand of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, and did not take them, and stood on the platform, and did the last arithmetic of the arrangement: *the pass is a warrant of the district; the train is a train; the country between here and Skierniewice is not a country; the ferry-place below the Citadel takes a man or a woman for a hundred zloty; and there is a house on the Bagatela with a study in which the safe has been opened twice, and the third time will be by German hands, and there is a card in the lining of my coat with my name on it and a pencil sentence on the back of it, and there is a paper wrapped in paper in the wardrobe of the room on the first floor that has been in a drawer of the Mokotowska for four years, and there is a boy of twenty-one with a bandaged hand who is going to be in the second week, and there is a folder of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw behind the boiler of a laundry in the yard of the building in the next street, and there is a city of a million people which is going to stand up at five o'clock in the afternoon of the first of August, with or without the two papers in the man's hand.*

And she said the sentence that she had built in the tram, in her head, at half past seven in the morning, going the other way along the Marszałkowska:

"I am not going."

The platform went on around them. Somebody's child was shouting at the end of the train; the locomotive let off steam; the doors of the fourth carriage were being slammed one after the other by a sergeant.

"There is a reason," said the General.

"Yes. There is a reason." She put her hand on the edge of the carriage door, on the brass handle, and looked at him. It was the only lie of the four years that she had ever rehearsed out loud, and she had rehearsed it in the tram for eleven days and knew every syllable of it. "In 1940 the administration of the district took the wife of a lieutenant of the railway police in the third week of the occupation, in the courtyard of this building, and shot her, because a woman of the household of a German officer of the railway administration had been seen in the market of the Wola, buying a chicken, and there had been a report that a German had been seen in the same market buying a chicken, and the two of them were the same report, and there was not one German in Warsaw who was able to say the truth about either." She did not take her hand off the handle. "I am a woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw.

There are four thousand men in this city who know my face; there are eleven German households, a furier, three orderlies, a driver and a cook who know the colour of my coat; there are two hundred Poles on the register of the district who have written my name in a column; and on the day that the first of these people opens a mouth, the arrangement is over. If I get on this train and go into the Reich, I am not the woman of the General; I am a woman of France with a warrant of the district and a passport of Strasbourg and a residence in the Warsaw register of aliens and no husband in the world, and there is not one office in Germany that is going to have any of it, and every one of the four thousand men will have the day to think about me."

"Marion."

"You asked me for one word at the station," she said, "and it is: no. Not because I am brave. Not because I am a heroine of anything. Because you are my the world in the war, and because in the two years I have never once permitted myself a single thing, and because I am not going to spend the end of it in a train in a field in a country that is not mine, eating the bread of the administration with the Frau Präsidentin. I am going to be in the house on the Bagatela at eleven o'clock tonight, and there is going to be a bath, and a glass of the Silesian on the table in the small room, and the woman in the chair by the window, because a house of a General of the district of Warsaw is a house in which there is a woman in the chair by the window."

And then she found out that she was able to do the other part of it: she looked at him with her face whole, her hands steady, her voice even, and she did not plan the tears; the tears came on their own, the way water comes through a wall, out of a place in her that she had been managing for four years and had never once inspected, and she stood on the platform of the station on Ochota with the tears coming down her face and her chin up, and she said the last sentence of the performance in the flat, even voice of a woman who has been speaking to her own heart for two years in a mirror:

"Put the papers in your pocket, Friedrich. I am staying with you."

There was a silence that lasted four seconds.

And what happened in the four seconds was the thing that she had known, in the small room of the house on the Mokotowska, since the first week of the arrangement, and had never once let herself look directly at, because in her four years she had exactly one piece of luck and it was the

luck of a woman in a bed, and now she was standing in it under the lamps of a station and it was looking back at her out of the face of a man of fifty-five: *he believes me. He has always believed me. Every piece of it, from the wine of the first dinner to the child that was never born, has been believed, and the reason it has been believed is not that I am good at it: the reason is that a man of fifty-five who has buried a wife and has never in his life been able to say a sentence about his own heart has been standing in the middle of a war for five years with one woman in the world who has found the sentence, and he is not able to give that up; and I have spent two years taking his secrets out of the study of the house on the Bagatela and the reason that I have been able to do it is that the man loves me and knows the price of the knowledge and has decided to pay it.*

The General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw put the two papers back in the pocket of his greatcoat, and closed his eyes for a moment, and then he took her face in both of his hands, in front of the platform, and kissed her in front of the administration of the district of Warsaw, which was a thing that he had never once done in a public place in two years, and behind them two German women in good coats looked at each other with their eyebrows, and a Polish labourer with a cap in his hand looked at the ground and slid a packet of cigarettes out of a German officer's discarded overcoat, in the same second, without any hurry at all.

"Eleven o'clock," said the General.

"Eleven o'clock."

He got into the carriage and stood at the window with his hand flat on the glass. The whistle went; the locomotive took up the slack with clanking and shouting; and the last train of the German civil administration of the district of Warsaw pulled out of the station at seventeen minutes to six in the morning, and she stood on the platform with the crowd watching the carriages, and the hands that came out of the windows waving, and the boy of nine on his mother's arm waving back at the train, and a woman's voice shouting one word over and over at a window — *Käthe, Käthe* — and there was nobody in the train who could hear it.

She walked the length of the platform to the exit in the smell of hot metal and a hundred and forty lives, and Ehlers was at the car, and she thought, with the precision that only happens in the middle of enormous events, of the leather writing case beside the buffers, and of the small, clever, exhausted face of the only man in Europe who had ever known what she

was, and of the sentence that he had said in a marble hall: *in the end a house in the country is only a room with two names on the door.*

"To the house," she said. "And then, at eleven, I want the car to go to the aleja Szucha, and I want the driver to wait for me at the corner for as long as I am inside the building."

♦ ♦ ♦

The city, on the thirty-first of July, smelled of burning paper.

It was the smell of Warsaw in the last week of the occupation: every office of the German administration in the city burned its own files in the last four days of July, in the courtyards, in the stoves, in the great boiler rooms and in the gardens, and the Śródmieście lay under a low, brown-black cloud that went up over the rooftops in the still air until noon, and the smoke had in it the particular thick sweetness of the paper of a bureaucracy, and people stopped in the streets and looked up at it, and knew exactly what it was, and said nothing at all.

She was in the aleja Szucha at half past eleven in the morning, and the smoke was coming up out of the courtyard of the building of the Sicherheitsdienst behind the wall in a brown column four metres wide; and the guards at the barrier of the entrance were standing with cloths over their faces, and there were Poles of the fire service of the city with the administration, because the administration had requisitioned them to keep the burning from spreading to the roof, and the Poles stood with their hoses and their axes and their smoke-blackened faces and did the work of eleven men each with both arms, and everybody in the street knew what it was that was being burned: the registers of the population of the district of Warsaw, and the files of the security service, and the card index of the Hauptsturmführer in the room on the second floor with the bars painted the colour of cream.

She stood at the corner of the street in the heat for eleven minutes, in a grey dress, in the last week of the occupation, with a bar of chocolate and two hundred zloty in her bag and a card in the lining of her coat, and looked at the smoke of the safest thing that had ever happened to her.

Then she went home to the house on the Bagatela and did the last of the packing, and it took an hour and eleven minutes and produced three objects.

The first was the parcel from the drawer of the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska, warm and flat and the size of a book, which went into the lining of the winter coat, on the hook in the wardrobe of the room on the first floor; and the winter coat was, in the full summer of 1944, the most invisible object in the entire house, because at the end of July there is not a man in Europe who will look inside a winter coat.

The second was the small, flat, black-lacquered Minox, four hundred grams, of the pattern that the intelligence service of the district had bought in eleven lots in the winter of 1941 for the photography of the documents of the east. It had come out of an office of the district in April of 1943, in a parcel of typewriter ribbons, into the hands of a Frenchwoman of the household of the General; it had made its records in a bath, in a wardrobe, in a linen cupboard, at an open window at night, with the curtain drawn and the lamp under a towel; and now she loaded it with the last film of the arrangement — thirty-six exposures — and put it in the bottom of her bag, in the inside pocket of the lining, where a woman's hand goes for a lipstick.

The third was a page of her own writing, folded twice: five lines of résumé in her own hand of the five sheets of the folder of the Fall *Wotan*, the four dates, the two trains of the last week of July with the destinations in the west, and the line about the rolling stock that had been requisitioned in the district of Warsaw for the ninth of August. She wrote it in the laundry that afternoon, sitting on an upturned tub in the heat with an ironing board for a table, and it took her half an hour, and then she went to the tram stop at the corner of the Polna and stood in the queue and waited for the number 6.

The boy with the bandaged hand got on the tram behind her.

He was twenty-one, and his name was Janek, and he had been one of the eleven people in Warsaw who had ever seen her face and known her; and he stood beside her in the crowd of the tram with his right hand wrapped in a grey bandage and his left hand on the strap, and he was, in the four years of the occupation, the one person who had ever touched Krystyna Stankiewiczówna in a public place with her permission; and when the tram stopped at the corner of the Krucza and the crowd pressed, he put his left hand on her elbow, the way a grandson does for an elderly woman in a crowd, and the folded page of five lines passed from her bag to his sleeve, and neither of them looked at the other, and at the Rotunda he was off the car and gone down the Krucza into the crowd of the afternoon.

She got down at the Bagatela and walked the last street.

There was a woman in the doorway of the building next to the house with a bucket in each hand, taking water up to a second floor, and a man of seventy on the pavement outside the furier's with a chair and a hammer and four boards, repairing a door that had come off its hinge on the twenty-ninth; and in the garden of the house on the Bagatela, under the walnut tree, a Polish gardener of about sixty was picking up the dead leaves of July from the gravel in the ordinary way, with a rake, on the last afternoon of the occupation, and he looked up when she came to the gate, and he said, in Polish, very quietly:

"Frau, if it comes, put out the light."

And he went on raking the gravel.

♦ ♦ ♦

The General came home at eleven o'clock in the night of the thirty-first of July, exactly as he had said on the platform of the station that morning, and the bath was drawn, and the glass of the Silesian was on the table in the small room, and the woman of the house was in the chair by the window with the blackout blind drawn and the lamp turned low.

He stood in the doorway of the small room and looked at her.

Then he took his cap off and put it on the sideboard and went, for the first time in the two years, on his knees on the carpet beside the chair, and put his face in her lap, and stayed there without saying anything for four minutes, and the shoulders of the tunic of a General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw shook once, and the fabric of the grey uniform was under her hand and the weight of the man was against her knees.

"I have three things to say to you," he said at last, into the grey wool of her dress. "The first is that the High Command of the army has ordered the district to hold the Vistula line until the middle of August, and that there is not one German officer, from the General commanding down to the last lieutenant of the engineers, who believes that the line can be held, and that everybody has known for eleven days that the Russians are going to be on this side of the river by the twentieth of September."

"And the second?"

"The second is that the Sicherheitsdienst have orders to take the population of the Pawiak to the west on the second, and that the eleven thousand people in that building are going to be in a great hurry on the morning of

the second, and I have signed eleven of the papers for the transport because a general of the intelligence section of a district signs what the administration brings him, and there is not one of the eleven thousand who is going to see the inside of a German prison in Germany, and every man in the district knows it and no man in the district has said it out loud, and I have said it to you now because in the two years there has not been a single truth that I have kept from your attention."

"And the third?"

"On the second of August at four in the morning," said the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, with his face still in her lap, "I am going to be in the building of the command at the Blue Palace with the staff of the district, and the engineers are going to wire the district of the command, and the city is going to burn in eleven places at once, and there is going to be no way out of the centre of it in any direction, and the woman of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw is going to be in this house, four hundred metres from the building of the Sicherheitsdienst, in the middle of the German district of the city." He raised his head and looked at her. "And the third thing is that there is a car, and a driver, and a place in the district of the engineers on the northern bridge, and the order of the transfer of the household of the General of the district is on the table in the study, and it is for the Frau of the household, and the Frau of the household is going to be sitting in the car at five o'clock tomorrow afternoon with her case, whatever happens on the street, and Ehlers is going to drive it, because Ehlers has my trust for the four years of the war, and there is nobody else in the German administration in this city whom I trust with the object."

And Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, sitting in the chair by the window in the small room, with the hand of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw on her knee, took the last decision of the first part of her life, and said:

"Friedrich, I am not going to be sitting in any car at five o'clock tomorrow afternoon."

"Marion—"

"There is a house," she said. "There is a house with a study in it and a safe in the study and your papers in the safe. There is the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw in that study, and if the city rises tomorrow, there is not one German soldier in the building of the command who is going to be able to come to the Bagatela and put it in a case; and I have spent two

years in this house and I have never once been asked for anything by it, and tomorrow I am going to be in this house; and at five o'clock in the afternoon I am going to put your papers in the safe and close it and turn the dial twice on the last number, which is a trick that I was taught by a man named Thomas in the rue de Rivoli in Paris in the spring of 1943, and then I am going to sit in this chair in the blackout and wait for you to come home."

He looked at her for a long moment.

"You are not to be in this house tomorrow," he said.

"I am going to be in this house tomorrow."

"Marion."

"Friedrich," said Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, and she put both her hands on his face, and she was in that minute exactly what she had been made to be: the one object of the life of a man of fifty-five, and the instrument of the death of the German garrison of a city of a million, in the same room, in the same chair, in the same pair of hands. "I have never once in my life asked you for anything either. I am asking you to believe me on the last night, and to go to the Palace at four o'clock tomorrow, and to leave the house and the papers in my hands, and to come home at eleven o'clock like the man on the platform of the station on the Ochota this morning; and if it is not possible for a man in this city to come home at eleven o'clock on the first of August because there is a war between the district of the command and his house, then there is still one thing that is possible, and it is a telephone call, and there is a telephone in the study and a telephone in your office, and I am going to be in this house until I hear the telephone. That is the thing. That is all of it. That is everything that I have ever wanted out of the war, and I want it handed to me now, in this room, with your hand in mine, before either of us is a person in a war."

And the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, on the thirty-first of July 1944, at half past eleven in the night, in the small room of the house on the Bagatela, in the blackout, said: "Yes."

♦ ♦ ♦

The first of August 1944 was a hot, still, brilliant day, with the high white August light of Poland standing over the city and not one German aeroplane in the sky, because the German aeroplanes were on the airfields at Kraków and Łódź and there were no aeroplanes in Warsaw on the first of August.

She was up at six, and she made the coffee herself, because the cook was in the third day of the ordinary German terror of the civilian in a city that is about to be a battlefield, and had spent the previous evening in the kitchen with a case packed and her hands in her apron, asking every half hour whether the Frau thought the trains were running.

At eight she gave the cook the money in the house, eleven hundred and forty zloty, and a letter in her own hand to the sister in Bydgoszcz, and sent her out to the station at the Ochota with the female porter of the house opposite; and the woman cried in the hall and kissed her hand, in the German way, and said the thing that German women had been saying to other German women in the east for the last year:

"You should come, Frau. They will kill us all, and you are not one of them, and they will kill you worst of all, and you have been kind to me for two years and four months, and I have not once in the time understood a single thing about this house."

Then the door closed and the house on the Bagatela was empty, and it stayed empty for the rest of the morning.

She did the day in the order in which she had written it on the back page of a notebook in the laundry of the yard of the building in the next street, and burned the page in the stove.

At ten o'clock she took the amber necklace, the parcel of the Countess, the three things that were hers in the world, and sewed the parcel into the lining of the winter coat with a needle and a black thread in the wardrobe; and it was the first time in four years that her hands shook, and she stopped, and stood in the dark of the wardrobe with her hands in her lap until the shaking had stopped, because a woman with a needle and a shaking hand makes a thread that a person can see.

At eleven o'clock the city began to get ready.

She heard it from the closed windows of the house on the Bagatela, which stood on the edge of the German district of the city, four hundred metres from the Sicherheitsdienst and the same distance from the avenue, and what she heard, in the middle of the day, was not the ordinary city of an occupied capital: it was the sound of a million people being very busy and very quiet at the same time. There was no tram on the Marszałkowska at twelve; there were no Polish shops open at one; there were, at two in the afternoon, four German lorries of the garrison going up the avenue with the men sitting in them with their rifles on their knees, and then no more of them; and at half past two she stood at the window on the landing of

the first floor, behind the lace, and watched a woman of about forty in a black coat coming down the Bagatela on the pavement opposite with a shopping basket on her arm, walking fast and unhurried at the same time, exactly the way the Poles of Warsaw walked on the first of August 1944; and behind her, twenty metres further down the street, came a young man with no parcel and no basket and no destination, whose whole business in the street was to be twenty metres behind the woman of forty; and the two of them went down the Bagatela and round the corner of the Polna, and the street was empty.

At three o'clock the telephone rang.

It was the General, from the Blue Palace, and he had the flat voice of a man who had been in a room with twenty officers for six hours; and he said: "The district of the command is at full alert, and the garrison is in the buildings, and the Governor's people say that there is nothing whatever going to happen in this city, and the intelligence section of the district knows that there is something going to happen in this city, and I have looked at the map of the district for the day and I have told the office at eleven o'clock that the women of the staff of the district of the command are to be in the cellars of the Palace by four o'clock, and there is exactly one of them who is not going to be, and she is in the house on the Bagatela, and she has been the day in the house, and she has sent the cook out of the city, and she has promised the man who is talking on the telephone a bath and the Silesian and the woman in the chair by the window."

"I have."

"There is one more thing, and it is not about it," said the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw. "At four o'clock this afternoon the staff of the district is going to the Palace, and the papers of the district are going with us, and the safe in the study is going to be sealed and left, and I have told the Ordnungsoffizier that the key of the house of the General is to remain in the hands of the General, and the Ordnungsoffizier of the district is a young captain of the intelligence section who has been in this building for the year, and I have said to him at three o'clock this afternoon, in the corridor of the office, that the household of the General is in the house and that he is not, under any circumstance, to be in the house in the afternoon, and that is a sentence that a General says to a captain of twenty-nine exactly once in a war, and I have said it, and that is the telephone call."

The line was bad. She could hear an office behind him: a typewriter, a man's voice reading figures, a telephone ringing somewhere in a corridor of a district of a city that was going to be on fire in an hour and a half.

"Friedrich."

"Yes."

"Come home at eleven o'clock," she said, in the flat voice of a woman of the household of a General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, into the telephone of the study of the house on the Bagatela, on the first of August 1944, at three o'clock in the afternoon. "I am going to be in the chair by the window with the blackout blind drawn and the lamp turned low."

♦ ♦ ♦

She was alone in the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw at a quarter to five in the afternoon of the first of August 1944.

The house was cool and dark behind the blinds, and it smelled of beeswax and the dead leaves of the walnut tree; and the life of the arrangement was standing in the hall of it, over the sideboard of the hall, waiting to be wrapped in a piece of newspaper: the porcelain dog that Anneliese had put on the sideboard in 1932 and the silver of the family and the portrait photograph in the study; and the woman of the house came out of the small room, in a grey dress and stockings and a pair of grey shoes, with her hair up in the style of the women of the avenue Henri-Martin as of the summer of 1944; and she stood in the marble hall and looked at the clock on the stair, and the clock said fourteen minutes to five.

She went to the window of the drawing room, and stood behind the blackout blind, and lifted one edge of it with her finger.

The Bagatela in the last quarter of an hour was a street with nothing in it at all. There was no tram in the avenue; the yellow building opposite had eleven windows with the blinds down; the Polish gardener had gone at noon with the rake over his shoulder; and at the corner of the Polna, where the pavement went round into the little street of the Novum, there was a young man sitting on the step of a doorway with a book on his knee, reading it in the ordinary way, in the ordinary afternoon; and she watched him turn the page, and she saw it: the page was turned in the direction that a man turns a page when he is not reading, and under the book, on his knee,

in the fifth year of the German occupation of the city of Warsaw, there was a wristwatch, and he was looking at it every eleven seconds.

She let the blind fall.

Then she stood in the middle of the drawing room of the house on the Bagatela with her hands at her sides, and the sound of the house was the tick of the clock on the stair of the hall and the sound of her own breathing and, in the far distance, down in the direction of the Ujazdowskie avenue, one single telephone ringing in an office where nobody was going to answer it.

Five minutes.

She heard the front gate.

There was a step on the gravel of the garden and a step on the stone at the door, and it was not the sentry, because the sentry of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw had gone to the Palace at four o'clock with the guard; and there was one knock, and it was a knock that she had heard on every door of her childhood, and it was the knock of a man who has been told not to be in the house in the afternoon.

The clock on the stair said three minutes to five, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna went across the marble hall of the house on the Bagatela, in a grey dress, on the first of August 1944, with the doll's house and the silver on the sideboard behind her and the winter coat with the parcel in the lining upstairs, and put her hand on the brass of the door.

And the first shot of the Rising of the city of Warsaw came, from somewhere down in the direction of the Wola, one street over, the way a shot comes at the beginning: not in the least like the end of a world, but like a door.

Then the street gave it back to her, in eleven seconds, from the Polna, from the corner of the Novum, from the roofs, from all four directions of the city, and the glass of the fanlight over her head came down in a white rain on the marble of the hall.

CHAPTER TWENTY-THREE

The Colonel's Bed

♦ ♦ ♦

The first hour of the Rising of the city of Warsaw, in the streets around the house on the Bagatela, was not a battle.

It was a sound with no shape: the flat crack of small arms from four directions at once, none of them close; the long rattle of a machine gun somewhere behind the Ujazdowskie; the heavy, dull, double thud of something being fired that nobody in the Śródmieście had heard in five years except in the distance of a night; the bells of the churches of the whole city ringing and stopping and starting again; and the noise of a city of a million people opening its windows all at once.

She stood with her hand still on the brass of the front door and the glass of the fanlight at her feet in a white drift on the marble, and outside, on the stone, there was one knock again — two knocks, quick — and then a voice through the wood, low and even, in Polish:

"Otwórz. To ja."

She pulled the bolt back and opened the door eleven centimetres, and Phillip Brandt came in off the step and shot the bolt behind him with his elbow, and stood in the marble hall of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw with a leather map case under his left arm and a service pistol on his right hip, in a captain's tunic with the collar unhooked and his cap missing, breathing as though he had run four hundred metres, which he had.

"There is nobody in the street at the corner of the Polna," he said, in Polish, fast and flat. "There are three Germans of the guard of the Sicherheitsdienst in the doorway of the building on the other side of the avenue, and they have not got a telephone, and there is a Polish boy with a rifle on the flat roof of the house at the corner of the Krucza, and he has just fired four times at the street and hit nothing, and in about eleven minutes there is going to be a lorry of the military police coming up the avenue and it is going to be fired on from the roof and it is going to stop in front of this house, because this house has the only stone gate on this side of the street and there are windows on the first floor."

"You came through the street."

"I came through the yard of the building in the next street," said Phillip, "over the wall, through the garden of the furier's, past a gardener who was standing in the gravel of the yard behind the wall with a rake in his hand in the middle of a rising and who told me, in Polish, in the plainest voice of a man giving the time, that the Frau was in the house with the door bolted and the General at the Palace, and who then asked me whether I was for it or against it, and waited for the answer."

"And what did you tell him?"

"I told him I was for it," said Phillip Brandt. "And then I climbed over the wall of the general's garden and got to the door of the general's house, which is the second time in the war that a Pole in a German uniform has climbed over the wall of that garden, and the first time was in April and there was nobody in the yard."

The house was dark: the blackout blind down in the small room, the hallway dim behind the shutters, the clock on the stair ticking in the middle of the noise like a small machine in a workshop. He looked at the glass on the floor at their feet for a moment.

"You are a captain of the Ordonnanzoffizier of the district of Warsaw," she said. "You have a general's order not to be in this house; you have a an army at the Palace at this hour; you have a war that is going to be judged to the last man in a room in Berlin in eleven years; and you have climbed over a wall to stand in a marble hall and tell a woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district that you are for it." She looked at him. "Say what you have come to say, and then go out of the garden before the lorry comes, because you are the only person in the world who has ever walked into my whole of a life at a door, and I have spent four years of my life making sure that does not happen twice."

He said: "Give me the paper."

"What?"

"The Wotan paper," said Phillip Brandt. "The the folder. You opened the safe on the twentieth of July, and the safe has been opened once since and it was by me on the twenty-ninth, when the General sent me into the study to fetch the register of the personnel of the district, and there was a folder of the Fall *Wotan* in the safe with five sheets in it, and there is a folder of the Fall *Wotan* in the suitcase of a woman of this house that is behind the boiler of a laundry in the yard of the building in the next street, and I have known about the suitcase since March, because I carried it from the corridor of the house to the garden gate on the fourteenth of May in the rain, and if the folder is in the laundry when the Germans burn this street, then the year is worth nothing at all, and if it is in the hands of the district of the Rising, then there is a thing in the war that has been done by a woman who will never be able to say it out loud." He put the map case on the hall table. "The district of the intelligence service of the Wehrmacht of the district of Warsaw is at this hour in the building of the command at the Blue Palace with the files of the district; the Generalgouvernement is at this hour in the building of the Governor in the Krakowskie Przedmieście with the files of the Governor; and the Sicherheitsdienst is going to burn its the office in the aleja Szucha in the night, which the Poles already know because the smoke of it has been over the city since Tuesday. There is going to be a German perimeter around the government district of the city by tomorrow evening, and the perimeter is going to be on the line of the Bagatela, and at that hour this house is going to be the house of the front line, and there is not one place in the city that has a German safe in it on the first of August that is going to hold anything by the fifth."

"Which is why I am here," she said, "and not in the car."

"Then the paper is not in the safe."

"The paper is not in the safe," said Krystyna Stankiewiczówna. "There is a page of the report in the hand of a boy with a bandage on his right hand, and there is the folder behind the boiler of a laundry in the yard of the building in the next street, and there is a copy of the last four sheets on a film in the lining of the bag that is standing on the chair at the bottom of the stair behind you, and there is a woman in this hall who is at the middle of the fifth year of a thing that no one is ever going to write down, and there is not going to be any more."

He turned and looked at the bag on the chair.

"Then it is in this house," he said. "The film is in this house, and the house is in the middle of the German perimeter, and the perimeter is going to be formed in the next twelve hours, and there is one thing in the world at this hour that a German perimeter does not search, and it is a German house with a General's flag on the gate."

She looked at him for a long moment in the dim hall, with the small arms going in the streets, and the clock on the stair.

"They are going to put troops in this house," she said.

"They are going to put troops in this house in the next four hours," said Phillip, "and they are going to put the telephone of the district in the study, and an observation post on the first floor, and the Feldgendarmerie is going to stand at the garden gate and drink the coffee, and the German army of the district of Warsaw is going to be in the drawing room of a General's woman, and the film is going to be in the lining of a bag, and the bag is going to be in the wardrobe of a woman, and the woman is going to be the only person in the house who is not going to be searched, and that, madame, is the plan."

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They came at half past six.

There were eleven of them, of the third company of a battalion of the garrison, and they came up the avenue in a lorry that stopped at the corner of the Polna and was fired on twice from the roof of the house on the Krucza and gave the street three bursts of a submachine gun in reply; and the officer of them was a lieutenant of twenty-three from Kassel with a face like a boy's, and he came to the door of the house on the Bagatela and stood there with his cap in his hand and said, in the correct German of a cadet: that he had the order to occupy the stone houses on the line of the Bagatela, that the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw had been placed on the list of the buildings of the perimeter, and that he asked the pardon of the Frau Generalin.

She came down the marble stair in the grey dress, with her hair up, and stood at the bottom of it, and looked at him the way she had looked at a hundred officers of the district at a hundred tables in Paris and in Warsaw; and she said, in German, in the flat voice of a woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw:

"A lieutenant of the reserve of a battalion of the garrison is standing in the hall of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, in the middle of a rising, and is telling a woman of the household of the General that the house has been placed on a list. There is a telephone in the study of this house. There is a line to the Blue Palace. You will use that telephone in the next four minutes and you will speak to the office of the district of the intelligence service, and the man at that office will tell you the correct answer; and until he tells you, your men are going to stand in the garden and not one of them is going to be in the house."

It took four minutes and eleven seconds, and it worked, because it was the fifth year of the war and the German army still worked on paper even with a city on fire: the office of the district of the intelligence service in the Blue Palace confirmed that the house was on the list of the buildings of the perimeter and the troops were to occupy it, and the same office, in the same conversation, ordered that the study on the ground floor of the house was to be occupied by the office of the district, and that the rest of the house was to remain at the disposal of the household of the General, and that the Fliegeralarm cellar was to be prepared for the household and the troops.

She let them in at seven.

They came into the house the way a company of infantry comes into a house: eleven men and their equipment through a hall with a marble stair, and in eleven minutes the drawing room of the house on the Bagatela had a machine gun on the sideboard of 1851 and a telephone on the writing table and a map of the district of Warsaw on the wall where the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska had sat for sixty years in a chair that had come from her grandmother's house; and the boy-lieutenant from Kassel sat down on the sofa of the family and began, in the ordinary voice of a boy who had been trained well, to put his company's quarter in the middle of a Polish general's drawing room.

And at half past seven, in the middle of it, Ehlers came with the car.

He came through the garden gate with the smell of the street on him and a scratch on his left cheek and his cap on straight, and he stood in the hall among the eleven men of the garrison and looked at the house; and he said, in the flat voice of the driver of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw:

"Frau, the car is at the corner of the Polna and it is not able to come into the yard because there is a lorry of the third company of the garrison at the

mouth of the yard. There is an order from the General of the district of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, of the first of August 1944 at three o'clock, that the Frau of the household of the General is to be in the car at five o'clock in the afternoon with her case; and the hour was five o'clock, and it is now half past seven, and there is no road out of this quarter of the city in any direction, and the avenue between here and the Wilanów is in the hands of the Poles since half past six, and there is going to be nothing at all in the streets of this city by tomorrow morning, and the order of the General of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw is not able to be obeyed her or anywhere else."

"Ehlers."

"Yes, Frau."

"Did you go out with the car this afternoon?"

"I did not, Frau." He took the cap off. He was a driver of thirty-four with a girl's photograph in the flap of his map case and a street in Posen that did not exist, and his hands were the hands of a man who had been driving for four years without an accident. "At half past four this afternoon the yard of this house was full of the men of the guard of the General and the staff of the office of the General were putting the files of the office of the General into the car of the General, and I was told to drive the files of the office of the district of the intelligence service to the Blue Palace, and I drove the files to the Blue Palace at a quarter to five, and I came back through the fire of the Poles at the corner of the Nowy Świat, and there is a hole in the windscreen of the car of the General of the district which a man in this house is going to have to explain." He looked at her. "And there is one thing more, and I am going to say it now, and then I am going to the kitchen with the men of the garrison, because a driver of the Wehrmacht in a house of a General in the middle of a rising sits with the men and not with the household."

"Say it."

"The Frau is in the middle of the German perimeter of the city," said Ehlers. "And the men of the perimeter are going to be in this house in the morning, and the Poles of this quarter are going to be on the roofs of the houses at the corner of the Polna with rifles, and this house is on the corner, and there is not one window in it on the side of the street that is not going to have a man behind it by tomorrow. And the plan of the General of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw for the household is a car, and the car has a hole in it, and there is no road."

He put his cap back on. "The Frau is going to be here at the end, and the men in the kitchen know it, and I have not said a word to any of them, and I am not going to, and that is the report of the driver of the General of the district."

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At eleven o'clock that night the telephone rang in the study.

She was in the small room with the blind down and the lamp unlit, and Phillip was on the first floor with the map case and the eleven men of the garrison were in the kitchen and the drawing room, and the door of the study had been shut since eight, and the boy-lieutenant from Kassel had put his telephone on the writing table in the drawing room with an operator sitting at it, and it had rung nine times in three hours; and the tenth time it rang there was no operator, because the operator was in the passage with the men, listening to the firing at the corner of the Krucza; and she heard the ring, and she went out and looked at the door of the study, and then she went in.

"Frau Generalin—" said the boy from Kassel.

"Es ist für mich," she said, and lifted the receiver, and heard, on the line from the Blue Palace, over the crackle of the district line and the noise of a distant firing like a wind in a chimney, the voice of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw.

"Marion."

"Friedrich."

"Are you in the house?"

"I am in the house."

"Are you alone?"

She turned her head and looked at the boy-lieutenant from Kassel, who was standing in the doorway of the drawing room with the telephone operator's cap behind him, and she said, in German, in the flat voice of the Frau of the household of a General: "The house is full of the men of the third company of the garrison, and the study has been occupied by the office of the district since seven o'clock, and your study smells of the soldiers, and the man from Kassel has put the machine gun on the sideboard of 1851, and there is a map of the district of the city on the wall of the drawing room of the Countess Jadwiga, and this afternoon there was a

glass of the fanlight over the door that came down on the marble of the hall and there was nobody in the street to sweep it up."

There was a silence on the line of four seconds, and then the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw laughed: one short, dry, terrible laugh, the laugh of a man of fifty-five in the middle of the first night of the end of the eastern front.

"I am in a room on the first floor of the Blue Palace with eleven officers and a map," he said. "The Governor has gone to the command post at the Bruhl Palace with the garrison of the SS and the police, and the district of the intelligence service has the sector between the Saxon Garden and the Vistula, and there is one of the eleven officers and he is weeping at the window and there is nothing at all in the room that anybody is able to say to him, because at four o'clock this afternoon the garrison of the city of Warsaw was at the alert and the intelligence service of the district knew the hour to the minute, and there was not one man in Berlin who would listen to it." He paused. "The Governor has given the order for the city. There is a word in the order, and the word is *Banditen*, and it is the word of 1943, and it is in the file of the district, and I have read the paper at half past nine with the staff of the district in the room, and the paper has the signature of the SS and the police and the civilian administration of the district and it does not have the signature of the Wehrmacht of the district of Warsaw, and there is one man in this building at this the hour who is able to refuse to put his name on it, and that is the general of the intelligence service of the district, and I have refused, in the room, at the table, in front of the staff, and the room has been quiet for a minute."

"Friedrich."

"Yes."

"What have you done?"

"I have done the thing that a general of the intelligence service of a district does at the beginning of the last week of the east," he said, "and it is nothing at all. There is going to be a report of the district of the intelligence service of Warsaw for the month of August 1944, and it is going to be written by the office of the district, and there is not going to be one of the sentences of it in my hand, and the men of the office are going to be writing it in September in a village in Silesia, and the thing that I have done tonight is to refuse a signature on a paper that no one in the history of Germany is ever going to read." There was another silence, longer. "I want

to ask you a thing. It is the last thing that I am going to ask, and it is not about the house. Do you know what this city is doing tonight?"

"No."

"Neither do I," said the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw. "There are a hundred thousand men in the streets of this city with the rifles of 1939 in their hands, and there is not one aeroplane and not one tank and not one gun in it, and the German army of the east is at the Vistula, and there is going to be a river of blood in the next three weeks, and there is not one man in my building who is able to say the reason that it is happening. And I am a German general of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, and I have spent the last four years of the war in the city that is on fire, and there is one person in the world who has ever said the truth to my face, and she is in the house on the Bagatela with a machine gun on the sideboard of the family of her childhood, and her name is Marion Herschlag, and she has a face that I have been looking at for the two years of the war, and there is a thing about that face that I have never once been able to say out loud, and I am going to say it now on a telephone at eleven o'clock on the first night, and then I am going to ring off the line and go down the stairs to the map."

"Say it."

"Come home," said the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, and the telephone line, which had been hissing with the fire of the streets for eleven minutes, went dead.

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The second of August came up grey and thick with smoke, and by the second of August the quarter around the house on the Bagatela was a fortress.

It had happened in the night, the way these things happen: eleven lorries and two cars of the military police and a company of the engineers had come up the avenue at three in the morning and had gone into the big insurance building at the top of the Polna, and at four o'clock there were wire and paving stones and a machine gun nest at the corner of the Bagatela and the avenue, and at five there were men of the garrison lying in the passage of the house of the furier's and two of them on the roof with rifles; and at six, when she came down into the hall with her hair up, there were Polish corpses in the road at the corner of the Novum, four of them,

in the ordinary clothes of the boys of the quarter, and one of them was barefoot.

She stood at the window of the landing of the first floor with the lace held back and looked at it for a long time, and Phillip Brandt stood at her left shoulder with his hands behind his back and looked at it with her, and neither of them said a word, because there were five men of the garrison on the stair; and after eleven minutes he said, in German, in a voice for a corridor:

"Die Leitung zum Kommando ist unterbrochen, Frau Generalin."

And then, half an hour later, in the passage to the kitchen, in the four seconds in which the house was empty, he said, in Polish, in a voice that had no breath in it at all:

"There is a paper in the Wola. My mother's sister is in the Wola, and there are four hundred thousand people in that district, and there has been a German order of the night in the district of the command, and the men of the garrison of the city who are not in the perimeter are going there, and I have read the order this morning in the study of the district and it is signed by the SS and the police and it is not signed by the Wehrmacht of the district, and there is one man in the German administration of this city who refused to put his name on the paper, and he did it in a room on the first floor of the Blue Palace at nine o'clock last night, in front of the staff." He looked at her. "Do you know who that man is?"

"I know who he is," said Krystyna Stankiewiczówna.

"There is a thing that is going to happen in the Wola in the next week," he said, "and it is not a thing of the war of the armies, and it is going to be done on the floor of a room and in the air of a district of a city with a population of a quarter in it, and there is nothing at all that a captain of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw is able to do about the thing except to be in one room in the house on the Bagatela next to a woman in a grey dress, and to tell her the truth in the seven seconds in which there is no one in the passage, because in the year in this house there has never once been a minute in which the two of us were able to be in the same room and to say a thing to each other."

And then the boots of the Feldgendarmerie came back along the passage with a bucket and a an empty can, and Phillip Brandt stepped back from her by half a metre and said, in German: "Zu Befehl, Frau Generalin," and went down the passage with his map case under his arm.

♦ ♦ ♦

By the evening of the second of August the perimeter had closed around the German quarter of the centre of the city, and the house on the Bagatela had become one of the three houses at the corner of the government district that were full of the German garrison of the city of Warsaw.

There were two officers in the house and one of them was sick, and there were twenty-nine men, and there were four machine guns, and there was a telephone that worked when the Poles were not firing at the line, and there was a kitchen that had a Polish cook in it by the evening of the third, an old woman who had come in through the garden wall with a bag of potatoes and who had stayed, because the house of the furier's had burned on the second of August at noon and the servants of the German quarter of the city had been looking for a floor and a stove all through that night.

At four in the afternoon of the third, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna went up to the roof.

It was possible, in the house on the Bagatela, to get to the roof of the building through a hatch at the head of the back stairs; and the men of the garrison had been up there in the morning, and the boy-lieutenant from Kassel had put a man on it with a pair of field glasses because the roof of the house was the highest point of the quarter on the southern side, and the man with the field glasses had gone down at three for his dinner.

She stood on the roof of a house in the city of her birth on the third of August 1944 and saw her whole city on fire.

There is nothing in the world to be said about it that has not been said, and she never afterwards said anything about it to any human being; and what she saw, standing on the flat roof of the house with the lead of the gutter hot under her shoes, was:

The smoke. It was not one smoke; the city had six of them, each of its own district, and they stood up over the flat of the roofs in the white August light in columns that were yellow at the bottom and grey and brown at the top, and they leaned south-west in the wind of the afternoon, and the sky over the Vistula was one vast, smooth, brass-coloured haze with the sun in it.

The Wola, which was not visible from the Bagatela but whose smoke was: a brown-black curtain at the western edge of the city, standing up straight in the still air, with a red foot to it, and it standing over the district of the

city where four hundred thousand people lived, and standing over it without moving for the afternoon, because the fires of the Wola were not fires of houses: they were the fires of a district of a city that had been raked into the streets by the troops of the SS and the police with their hands.

The Old Town, which was in the north: a tower of the smoke over the cathedral; and the Nowy Świat, which was on the next street but one; and the Śródmieście, in the middle, where the smoke was not the smoke of a district but of a hundred different fires in a hundred different streets, some of them standing straight up out of a single house, and them rising and falling in the day as the wind changed.

The Poles on the roofs of the buildings of the quarter, who were firing at the German positions with rifles; and the German positions, which were firing at them; and between the two, on the ground, at a distance of two hundred metres from the roof of the house on the Bagatela, in the afternoon light of the third of August, a girl of about sixteen in a white blouse coming along the middle of the street with a bucket in each hand and a white cloth on her left arm, in the middle of the firing, at a walking pace, delivering the water of the city of Warsaw.

And on the roof, in the middle of the smoke, alone, with the two buckets going along the street below her and her city in its last week, a woman of twenty-seven stood in a grey dress with her hands flat on the hot lead of the gutter and said the thing that she had never once said out loud in the four years, in Polish, to the smoke, in the ordinary voice of a woman of the city of Warsaw:

"Warszawa."

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The General came to the house on the night of the fourth of August.

He came in a car with two motorcycles in front of it and a second car behind it, in the dark, with the quarter under the fire of the rifles of the roofs, and the gate of the garden was opened for the car by the sentry of the guard of the district of the intelligence service, and the car came up the gravel of the garden path three metres from the wall of the house and stopped under the windows of the drawing room with the mud of the south of the city on it; and Phillip Brandt was standing at the head of the marble stair in a tunic with the collar hooked, with the boy-lieutenant

from Kassel at the bottom of the stair and four men of the third company of the garrison in the passage and all of them standing straight.

Friedrich von Reuth got out of the car in the gravel of the garden of his own house and stood for a moment in the light of the open door with his cap in his hand, and looked at the house with the flat exhausted attention of a man who has been in a room with a map for seventy-two hours; and there was the dust of plaster on the green of his collar and a small tear in the sleeve of his tunic at the elbow, and his face was grey with the grey that comes off a wall in a bombardment.

"Herr General." The boy from Kassel saluted.

"Lieutenant. Report."

"The third company of the third battalion of the garrison, twenty-nine men, four machine guns, occupying the house of the General of the district since the first of August at nineteen hundred hours, in the position of the line of the Bagatela, with one observation post on the roof, and two men at the garden gate, and the street under the fire of the Poles from the roof of the building at the corner of the Polna, and the house of the furier's burned on the second, and the household of the General is in the small room of the ground floor and the household of the burgher of the opposite house came through the garden wall on the third."

"Casualties."

"One man, Herr General, of the party of the roof, wounded in the arm by the splinters of the parapet on the second."

"The Frau Generalin."

"At the disposal of the General, and the household of the General is at the disposal of the command," said the boy of twenty-three, and it was, in the five years of the war, the most German and the most decent sentence that anybody in that house had produced; and then he stood aside, and the men of the third company who were in the passage of the ground floor came to attention as well as men come to attention in a passage with rifles and cooking pots and a bucket, and the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw walked through the middle of them and went up the marble stair.

He stopped at the head of the stair.

"Marion."

"I am here."

"Send the men to the kitchen," he said, to the house, in the flat voice of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, "and give the

lieutenant the house on the ground floor for the night, and let nobody be on the first floor above the landing, and let the telephone be on the table in the hall and the calls be brought up by the orderly, and there is going to be no one in the garden after the eleven o'clock, and if the Poles come over the wall of the yard in the night the house is to be at the windows of the ground floor and nobody is to be on the stair." He turned and looked at her. "I have not slept for four nights, and I am going to be in this house until five o'clock in the morning, and there is not one other house in the city of Warsaw in which a general of the German army is able to be, and there is not one other person in this city of a million people whom I am able to be in a house with."

He went up the rest of the stair.

♦ ♦ ♦

The room on the first floor of the house on the Bagatela had its windows shut and blinded, and the heat of the day of the fourth of August was standing in it at midnight like a person in a doorway; and the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw took off his tunic and hung it on the back of the chair, and put his belt and his pistol on the table beside the water jug, and sat down on the edge of the bed of the room in his shirt with his hands hanging between his knees and his back bent, and stayed like that without saying anything for four minutes while a woman of the household of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw stood in the dark on the other side of the room and watched him.

"At four o'clock this morning," he said, to the floor, "the battalions of the police and the SS of the district go into the district of the Wola of this city, and there is an order with a number in the office of the Governor at this hour, and the battalions have been given the order, and there is not one line of the order in the hand of the Wehrmacht of the district, and there is not one general of the Wehrmacht of Warsaw who is able to say in the history of the war that he did not know what the order was for." He looked at his hands. "I have been in the Eastern Front for two years, and I have seen the villages of the Ukraine in the winter of 1941 and the things that the formations of the army did in that winter, and there is not one man who was in the east who is able to say that the army of Germany has clean hands, and there was a time in my life when I was able to look at the morning of the war and say to myself a sentence about the things that I

was not able to prevent, and I have said that sentence in a room in this city at the hour of 10 o'clock in the evening of the first of August with the staff of the district in the room, and I have refused to put my name on a paper, and there is not one man in Berlin who is ever going to read the record of that refusal." He straightened, and looked at her. "And I have not done it for a principle, Marion. I have done it because there is a woman of France in a house on the Bagatela in Warsaw, and I have known since the first night of the rising that the investigation of this district is going to come to this house, and I have refused the signature in a room in front of the staff of the district in order to be able to say one thing on the day when they come to this house with a paper: that the general of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw is a man who has refused it, and that a general who has refused it is a general who is able to be a witness, and a witness is the only thing in the criminal administration of Germany that a policeman with a file is not able to put in a ground." He looked at the room. "That is the sentence. I have spent my life in the army, and it is the only piece of arithmetic that I have ever been able to do, and I have done it for a woman of Alsace who has been in my house for two years, and there is not one man in the war who is ever going to be told it."

She came across the room and stood in front of him in the dark.

"Friedrich."

"There is a question," he said, "and I am going to ask it once, and I am never going to ask it again, and it is not the question of a general, and it is not the question of a policeman, and there is not going to be a single word of the answer in the file of the district. Do you know why I have been able to spend two years in a house in this city with a woman and never once to be in a doubt?"

"No."

"Because the world has been in doubt," said Friedrich von Reuth, "and there is one object in it that has not been. There is a room in a house on this street with a woman in a chair by the window in the evening with a lamp turned low, and there is a man in the war who is able to come to the door of that room from the district of the command and know that the object in the room is in the room, and I have been in the war for five years with a war of a hundred million men around me, and I have had one object." He took her hand off his shoulder and held it in the dark. "That is the question, and the question is: is there any piece of that, in the two years, that has been wrong?"

And Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the dark of the room on the first floor of the house on the Bagatela at half past midnight on the fifth of August 1944, with the hand of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw in her own hand, and did the arithmetic for the last time in the arrangement; and at the end of it there was one item in the column, and the item was not a lie and was not the truth, and she said it in French, in the flat, even voice of a woman of the avenue Henri-Martin, in the dark, in a house in the city of Warsaw with a war in the street:

"There has never been anything wrong in this room, Friedrich. Not one thing."

♦ ♦ ♦

There was no tenderness in the bed of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw on the fifth of August 1944, and there had never been, in the two years, any tenderness in the four hundred nights of it; there was a man of fifty-five who had refused to put his name on a paper and had come to the only room in the world in which he had ever been a man and not an instrument; and there was the weight of it, and the dark, and the heat of a Polish August standing in a shuttered room with the war in the street, and the sound of the machine gun of the corner of the Polna coming and going beyond the wall, and behind the blackout blind the light of the fire of a district of a city of four hundred thousand people on the underside of the sky.

She took it, the way she had taken it four hundred times: with her face in the bend of his neck and her hand flat on the back of his shoulder, and her mind working the way it had been trained in a room in Kraków to work in a bed, on the level above the body, filing the evening: the ninety-five days since the November, the three bundles of the safe, the paper of the card and the pencil sentence on the back of it, the page of the eleven surnames in the floor of the laundry, the boy with the bandage on his right arm, the five sheets of the Fall Wotan in the case in the third door on the left, the man in the passage with the pistol down his thigh, the plan and the number of the day.

And at some hour of that night, in the middle of it, in the dark of a shuttered room in a house in a burning city, the thing that she had guarded in herself for four years and had written down in the four rules of a room in Kraków broke, and it broke without any noise at all, and she did not notice it at the moment of it: what she noticed, afterwards, was that the

face that had been in her head was the face of the man in the passage of the house with the dust of a wall in his hair, and that the hand that she was holding was the hand of a general of the German army, and that her own body, in the middle of the second year of the arrangement, had been for a minute in the room, which was the thing that no one had ever told her in a room in Kraków was able to happen to a woman who had been used four hundred times by an instrument of the war.

She lay in the dark afterwards with the weight of a sleeping man of fifty-five on the right side of her body and the heat of the night of the fifth of August on the room, and looked at the ceiling and thought the sentence that was the last of the first part of her life, and she thought it in Polish, in the dark, with the city of her birth going up in a smoke of a hundred thousand people beyond the blackout blind:

Rule Four is dead. And I am not an instrument any more; I am a woman in a war, and there is a man in this house asleep on my arm, and there is a man in the passage of this house with the dust of a wall in his hair, and there is a city of a million people in the street, and I have no idea at all what I am going to do, and I am not going to be able to ask anybody, and there is nobody left in the world who is able to tell me.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FOUR

The Wall of Names

♦ ♦ ♦

On the fifth of August 1944, in the district of the Wola of the city of Warsaw, the troops of the SS and police of the district, and the troops of the eastern formations of the army of the Reich, and the men of the battalion of the traitors of the Russian army who had been given to the German command in the month of March, carried out the orders that had been written down in the district of the command on the first night of the Rising.

The order has a name in the history of the war, and the name is a German word, and it is on the paper in a file in a building that still exists, and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna never read the paper and never saw the signature; and the only thing that she ever knew of it, in the war, and the only thing she ever afterwards said of it, was what she saw from a roof on the third of August, and what Phillip Brandt told her in a passage in the house on the Bagatela in the four seconds in which the passage was empty.

The name of the district of the Wola is on no document in this book, and two hundred thousand people of the city of Warsaw were taken out of it in four days, and there are eleven streets in that district that no longer have a name; and on the table of the office of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw at the Blue Palace, in that week, the reports of the district came in every hour on the hour, and them were filed, and the file has a number, and the number was written in a hand that Krystyna Stankiewiczówna knew; and in those four days the woman of the

household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw sat in the chair by the window of the small room of the house on the Bagatela, in a house full of the men of the garrison, and did the arithmetic of a piece of paper that had a signature on it that was not there.

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At half past nine in the morning of the sixth of August, a party of the Sicherheitsdienst came to the house.

There were five of them and a car, and the car was a French one, a Citroën of 1938 with the mark of the district painted on the door in white; and the officer of them was a Hauptsturmführer of about forty-five with a face like a retired schoolmaster and a hand that never stopped moving over his own chin; and he came up the steps of the house on the Bagatela in the middle of the morning and showed the boy-lieutenant from Kassel a paper, and stood in the marble hall and looked at it with the flat, tired attention of a man who had spent the week in the offices of the aleja Szucha that were now a burnt shell with a burnt index in the middle of it, and he said:

"I am to secure the papers of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw that are in the house of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, and I am to take them to the command post of the Governor, and I am to do it in the next hour, because at noon there is going to be nothing in this quarter of the city that is not under fire from the roofs of the buildings on the Krucza."

"Then you will want the study," said Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, from the bottom of the marble stair, in German, in the flat voice of the Frau of the household.

The Hauptsturmführer looked at her for a long moment.

"Frau Herschlag," he said. "Of the household of the General. French. Of Strasbourg. The employee of the administration of the district since 1942. The Frau is on the list of the persons attached to the staff of the district."

"I am on the list," she said.

"This is a very correct house," said the Hauptsturmführer, "and a very correct list, and in the last ten days I have read four hundred lists of the persons of the administration of this district, and every one of them is a list of a person who has gone to the west and left the office to the fire, and the Frau is the only person on any of the four hundred lists who is in the

middle of a rising in the middle of the German quarter of the city of Warsaw." He took his cap off and polished the badge of it with a handkerchief. "The study, then."

They did it with a correctness that was worse than violence.

The four men of the party went over the study for forty minutes, and they took the registers of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw off the shelves in the order in which the shelves were arranged, and they put them in the four iron cases that they had brought in the Citroën; and they were, all four of them, men who had been in the police of a German city before the war, and they did their work the way a bank does its work: nothing in the study was thrown, and nothing in it was broken, and every one of the four men took off his cap in the study of a General of the German army, which is a thing that a man of the criminal police of the Reich does out of an old and unbreakable respect that is one of the last things in the world that anybody in that house was able to recognise as human.

And at the end of the forty minutes the Hauptsturmführer stood in front of the safe.

It was open, because the office of the district had been in the study since the first night; and there was a folder in it with the deeds of the Pomeranian land, and a portfolio of forty-one sheets of paper with the water-colours of a dead woman in them, and eleven letters of a nurse of Berlin, and a brown envelope with a word on it in the hand of the General; and the Hauptsturmführer took the contents of the safe out of it and laid them on the writing table, and looked at the four bundles for a long time.

"Frau Herschlag."

"Yes."

"There is a small square of paper in the hand of a clerk of this office among these papers," said the Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst, "and it has eleven surnames of the population of this district on it, and four of the eleven have a tick against them, and it is a page out of the card index of the office of the Sicherheitsdienst in the aleja Szucha, and the card index of the aleja Szucha burned on the thirty-first of July in the courtyard of the building, and there is not one man left alive in German Warsaw who is able to say what that page was doing in the safe of a general of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw."

"It was there when I opened the safe this morning at nine," she said. "The the office of the district has used the study since the first of August, and

there have been twenty-nine men of the garrison in this house since the evening of that day, and there is not one object in the safe of the General that has been in my hand since the thirty-first of July, and if the Hauptsturmführer wishes to know what the office of the district of the intelligence service has put in the safe of the General of the district of the intelligence service in the last week, then the Hauptsturmführer will have to be asking the office of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, which is at this hour in the Blue Palace with the staff of the district, and which is a building that is under the fire of the Poles from the roof of the house on the Krucza, and there is a hole in the hall of it since Tuesday morning."

He looked at her.

"You defend this house well, madame."

"I am the Frau of this house," she said.

"Then perhaps the Frau will permit me to remark," said the Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst, in the same flat, tired voice, "that a man of my office in the month of November 1942 read the report of a captain of the department of the defence of the Reich of the district of the army in Paris, concerning a shooting in the rue de Lille, and the report had a sentence in it about a woman of the establishment of the Hôtel Majestic who was at the scene and had said the name of a Polish family; and there was a question mark in the margin of that sentence, and the question mark was made by the hand of a Hauptsturmführer of the office of the Sicherheitsdienst of Paris who is at this hour in a building somewhere in the west, and I have known that question mark since the month of May, because it is in the file which my office has carried out of the aleja Szucha in four lorries in the last four days, and it is the only file of the district of Warsaw that we were not able to burn, and it is going to the command post of the Governor this afternoon with these papers."

He put his cap on.

"There is going to be an investigation of this district, madame. There is going to be an investigation of the intelligence service of this city, because there is a page in the safe of a general and a question mark in the file of a Hauptsturmführer and eleven thousand dead men in the streets of a district with four hundred thousand people in it, and there is not one man in the administration of this district who is not going to be asked the question before the month of October: *how did the Poles know?*" He stood at the door of the study with the four iron cases behind him and the four

men of the party carrying them out through the hall, and he said the last thing that he said in the house on the Bagatela. "And a woman of the household of the staff of the district, who is the only person of the staff who is in our quarter in the middle of the rising, is going to be asked the question in a room with a table in it, and it is going to be a room on the first floor of the building of the Governor at the Bruhl Palace, and there is a chair in the room, and the chair has a strap on the left arm of it and no strap on the right, and the men who work in the room are men of the criminal police of Breslau, and there is not one of them who has ever looked at a woman's face."

He went out.

And in the marble hall, on the way past her, at the bottom of the stair, with the four iron cases going out of the front door, the Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst stopped, and looked up at the stair and the ceiling and the hall of the house, and he said, in the same voice:

"This is a good house. My mother had a house with a stair of this kind in Breslau in 1911, and there is a mirror of the same kind on the landing, and the house was in the possession of my family from the year of the 1890s, and there was a walnut tree in the garden." He put the cap on with both hands, and stood with the hall of a Polish general's house in his eyes. "I am going to be dead in the next four months, madame, and the house of my mother is going to be in the Russian zone, and there is not one object in the world that a man of forty-five in this war is able to keep, and the reason for this rising is on that table in the room with the strap." He shrugged. "Secure the coats in the wardrobe of the first floor," he said to the sergeant behind him. "There is going to be a winter."

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They took the coats at eleven o'clock in the morning.

She was on the landing when they did it. She had come out of the small room and stood at the head of the back stairs with a tray of cups in her hands, because the cook had made coffee for the men of the party in the kitchen and the Frau of the household carried it herself; and she stood at the head of the stairs and looked into the open door of the room on the first floor and watched a sergeant of the Sicherheitsdienst of about thirty take from the wardrobe of her room the grey wool coat, and the brown coat of the winter of 1943, and the winter coat of the winter of 1941 with

the parcel sewn into the lining of it, in which there were forty-one sheets of paper with the watercolours of a woman who had been dead for eleven years, and a lock of fair hair in a twist of tissue, and eleven letters of a nurse of Berlin, and a pass of the district of the intelligence service, and a thing that was not in the world any more.

She did not move.

She stood at the head of the back stairs of the house on the Bagatela on the sixth of August 1944 with a tray of coffee in her hands in front of four men of the criminal police of the Reich, and watched the coat of the winter of 1941 going down the marble stair of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw on the arm of a sergeant of thirty who was going to wear it to Warsaw in January 1945, if he was alive in January 1945; and she made a decision in those eleven seconds that she never afterwards wholly understood, and the decision was to do nothing at all.

Not the tray. Not a word. Not the very small, very reasonable sentence that a woman of the household of a General can say to a sergeant of the security service about a coat that was bought in the rue Saint-Honoré in the month of October 1941 and is the only object of her own property in the house; not the face; not the eyes.

She had run the four years on a single principle, and the principle was written nowhere and had been in her since the corridor of a house on the Mokotowska: *a woman of the household of a German General is permitted to defend a house, and she is not permitted to be attached to anything in it.* Attachment is the thing that the police of a country read on the face of a person before they read the file; and the amber of her mother's mother, and the forty-one sheets of Anneliese von Reuth, and the lock of fair hair, and the letters of Ilse, went down the marble stair of the house on the Bagatela in a sergeant's arms at eleven o'clock in the morning of the sixth of August 1944 while the woman of the household stood on the landing with a tray of coffee in her hands and an entirely ordinary face, and she did not say a word about it, and in the years afterwards she was never able to decide whether the thing that she had done on the landing had been the discipline of a professional or the last and deepest piece of the arithmetic of a woman who had been looking at that coat for four years and had known, in the spring, that there was never going to be any way to carry it out of the city.

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The paper came over the wall at three o'clock in the morning of the seventh of August.

It came the way such things always come, which is with a man's voice and a stone: a pebble over the wall of the garden and a knock on the garden door that was the knock of a Pole, and she was awake, because in the last six nights she had not slept more than two hours; and she went down the back stairs in the dark past the men of the garrison sleeping in the passage with their boots on, and opened the garden door eleven centimetres, and outside, against the wall, in the dark, there was a boy's voice, in Polish, very fast:

"Frau. It is Janek. There is a paper in my hand, and it is from the command of the district, and the command is at this hour in the school on the Barokowa with forty men and a wireless set, and the command is going to be in the Old Town by the twelfth because the centre of the city is on fire, and there is a an order in the paper and it is for the woman of the house. The the folder of the Fall Wotan is in the laundry of the yard of the building in the next street, and the command is in need of it in the Old Town before the district of the city is cut in half, and there is not going to be another night."

"Janek. Your hand."

"The hand is nothing at all. The hand is the fourth time in the war." She saw him in the dark for a second: a boy of twenty-one with a rifle on his back and a bandage from the wrist to the elbow, and the other arm with a pistol in the hand of it, and the face of a young man who had been in the streets for six days. "There is a man of the command at the wall of the yard of the building on the far side of the next street, and he is going to be there for the hour from the three to the four, and the laundry of the woman with the horse is at this hour the only building in that yard with a floor in it, because the house of the yard burned on the fifth, and the woman with the horse is in the cellar of the furier's with her sister and the horse was taken by the men of the garrison on the second and there is nothing at all to be done about the horse." He put the paper through the gap of the door, and it was a folded page of a notebook, in a woman's hand, and the writing was in ink and there were three lines on it. "The the command says the paper is worth a company of men, and the command says the woman

of the house is to have the thanks of the district of the rising of the city of Warsaw, and there is not going to be any document, and there is not going to be any name, and the command has said it in a room on the Barokowa at the ten o'clock, and there were four men in the room and a priest and a woman of the age of sixty in a soldier's coat who is the courier of the command and who was in the room and said nothing at all and cried in the third row with the rifle on her knees."

The boy went over the wall again into the dark, and she stood with her back to the door of the garden of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw in the middle of the night of the seventh of August 1944, with a page of a notebook in her hand.

She read it by the dark in the passage with the light of a match under the stair, and it said, in a woman's hand, three lines:

The road to the kitchen of the building of the next street is by the wall of the yard, four metres on the eastern side, and the wall is broken at the height of the second brick course three metres from the corner, and the laundry of the woman with the horse is the third door on the left, and the boiler is at the end, and there is a an hour between the three and the four, and after the four the yard is under the fire of the machine gun of the garrison of the corner of the building on the Polna.

If the paper of the folder is in the hands of the command before the morning of the eighth, then the men of the armoured train and the men of the two trains of the last week of July are going to be at the Wilanów on the ninth of August and not on the ninth of the September, and the men of the line of the Vistula are going to be in the city on the ten, and the fourth of the objects of the folder is a paper that is worth the south of the city.

There is no obligation. The house of the woman of the Bagatela has done what there was to be done in the war. I have written this in my own hand, in a room on the Barokowa, at the ten o'clock in the evening of the seventh of August, and there is no name, and there is not going to be a name, and the two of us have never once been in the same room.

There was no signature.

She read the three lines twice, standing in the dark under the stair of the house on the Bagatela with a burnt match in her fingers, and then she went up the stairs in the dark and lay down on the bed in the room on the first floor with her shoes on, because there was an hour between the three and the four, and it was twenty past three in the morning.

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At half past three in the morning of the seventh of August, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna went down the back stairs of the house on the Bagatela in a pair of black shoes and a dark brown dress with no coat, and out through the door of the garden.

The garden was a rectangle of eleven metres by fourteen, with the walnut tree and a bench and a gravel path and a summer of dead leaves; and the wall of it was two metres of brick on the southern side, and the garden was in the dark, and the house behind her had three windows with a light in them and the rest in blackout, and on the first floor there was a man of the garrison sitting at the window of the passage with a rifle on the sill of it, and he was awake, and he had been awake for six days.

She got to the wall at the place where the brick course was broken, and put the toe of the shoe of the right foot into the gap, and the wall of the yard of the building in the next street was four metres on the other side, and the yard between the wall and the laundry was a space of eleven metres with a burned house on the northern side of it and a shed on the eastern, and there was no moon and there was firing at the corner of the Krucza, and there was firing in the direction of the Nowy Świat, and there was one German flare standing over the district of the Wola in the black sky, and the city smelled of burning.

She went over the wall.

She crossed the yard in eleven seconds, and she was not shot at, and there is no particular reason why she was not shot at, and it is the kind of thing that a person who has been in a war is never afterwards able to explain: the men of the machine gun on the roof of the house at the corner of the Polna were men of the garrison of the third company, and they had been shooting at every moving object in the yard for six nights, and in the eleven seconds of the seventh of August at half past three in the morning there was one moving object in the yard and they were asleep at the gun.

The laundry had no roof, which she had not known: the western end of it was gone, and the boiler was in the middle of a floor of broken brick with the rain of a an August week standing in the tubs, and the smell of the place was the smell of wet ash and soap, and it took her four minutes with her hands in the rubble to find the suitcase: a cheap cardboard case of the kind that the shops of the Marszałkowska sold for eleven zloty in 1943, in

a space between the boiler and the wall, under a plank and eleven fur coats, and the coats were wet and them smelled of the burning of the fifth of August, and the suitcase was dry.

She opened it.

There were five sheets of the paper of the Fall Wotan of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, with the table of the rolling stock of the last week of July and the copy of the order of the 9th Army of the thirtieth of June 1944 and the map of the line of the Vistula; and there was a fold of brown paper, and in the fold there was the page of the eleven surnames of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw with four ticks against them, which she had put there on the twentieth of July and had not spoken of to any human being, because she had looked at the surnames for the four days of that week in the laundry office and had found, in the four days, that the surname in the middle of the eleven with the tick against it was *Zaleski*, and that the Zaleski of the register of the Sicherheitsdienst with the tick against his name was not the Piotr Zaleski of the kitchen of the house on the Mokotowska and the horse and the laundry and the cousin's wife; it was a Zaleski of the district of the Wola, of the age of fifty-one, of the profession of a chemist, and she had never once known what to do with it, and now she stood in the middle of a roofless laundry in the dark and took the page of the eleven surnames out of the fold of the brown paper and put it into her own hand.

She left it there, on the floor of the laundry, in the wet, in the dark: a page of paper of the card index of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw with eleven surnames on it and four ticks and one word in the hand of a general of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, and the men of the German police of the district had been burning the index of that office in the courtyard of the aleja Szucha for four days, and there was not going to be one of them who would ever think of the floor of a laundry in the yard of the building in the next street; and the weight of the paper in the hand of the woman on the floor of the laundry was the weight of the two years.

She took the suitcase with the five sheets and went back across the yard.

She was two metres from the wall when the machine gun on the roof of the house at the corner of the Polna woke up and fired into the yard.

There is no describing it afterwards to anyone at all: the air of the yard full of a noise that is not a series of noises but a single object; the brick of the wall in front of her face coming away in pieces of the size of a fist; the top

of the wall going out of it in a spray of lime and dust; and a woman of twenty-seven in a dark dress in the middle of the open ground with a suitcase in her right hand and the wall two metres in front of her face.

She put the suitcase on the ground and lay down on the gravel of the yard in the dust of the wall.

The gun stopped. Then it began again, and the burst went over the wall and into the garden of the house on the Bagatela, and the noise of it went into the windows of the house, and a man was shouting on the roof in German, and the gate of the garden opened.

She was up with the case in her hand and over the wall of the garden of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw in the four seconds, and the two metres of it was not possible and she was over it, and the suitcase went over it first and she came over it after, and the left knee of her was on the ground of a garden with a walnut tree in it and the gravel of the path in the face of the house, and there was a man in the dark in front of the door of the garden.

"Frau Generalin," said Phillip Brandt, in German, out loud, in the middle of the yard.

He had his pistol out of the holster and the barrel of it down his thigh, and he stood in the middle of the path of the garden in the light of the flare over the Wola, in a tunic with the sleeves rolled, and there were eleven men of the garrison at the windows of the house and a lieutenant of twenty-three from the town of Kassel coming out of the door of the kitchen.

"Eine Ratte," said Phillip Brandt, "mit einem Koffer. Ich habe geschossen."

A rat, with a case. I fired.

He put the pistol back in the holster and took the case out of her hand, and turned his body so that the men of the garrison were behind his shoulder, and stood with his back to the house and the case at his side, and said, in the ordinary voice of a captain of the ordnance of the district of Warsaw, to the boy-lieutenant of twenty-three from Kassel:

"Ich bringe das Ding zur Wache. Alle bleiben an den Fenstern."

I'll take the thing to the guardroom. Everyone stays at the windows.

And he walked with the case through the garden gate in the dark, in the ordinary way of a captain of the district carrying an object of no importance at half past three in the morning of the seventh day of a rising; and she stood in the middle of the garden of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw, with the dust of the wall in her hair

and the taste of lime in her mouth, and looked at his back going through the gate, and did the one piece of arithmetic that she had not done in the four years, and the arithmetic was this:

He fired at the yard. He fired at the yard before I was over the wall, and if the burst had been thirty centimetres to the left, I would be on the gravel of the yard now with the case beside my hand, and no man in the history of the German army is ever going to be able to explain what a captain of the ordnance of the district of Warsaw was doing in the garden of the house of the General of the intelligence service of the district at half past three in the morning with his pistol out of the holster.

He came back at four.

He came back through the gate of the garden with his hands empty and his cap in his belt, and the lodge at the corner of the Polna, and the men of the guard of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw were sitting in the passage of the house with their rifles between their knees, and the boy-lieutenant of twenty-three from Kassel was asleep in the chair of the drawing room of the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska with his mouth open, and there was nobody at all in the house who was awake.

"He has it?" she said, in Polish, in the passage.

"He has it."

"And the boy?"

"There is a man of the command at the wall of the yard of the building in the next street," said Phillip Brandt, in the dark, "and there was a boy of twenty-one with a bandage on his right arm at the corner of the Novum at the four, and the case was in the hand of the boy at the four and eleven minutes, and the boy was in the mouth of the passage of the Przejazd when the machine gun of the building of the insurance company on the Polna opened on the mouth of the passage at the four and the quarter, and I am a captain of the German army and I was in the street with the men of the third company of the garrison at the four and the quarter, and there is a boy of twenty-one with a bandage on his right arm in the middle of the street in front of the mouth of the passage, and the case was under him, and he was not able to be got at, because there was a machine gun on the roof and the men of the third company were shooting at the mouth of the passage for the eleven minutes from the four and the quarter to the four and the twenty-six minutes, and the boy was on the pavement of the Przejazd in the middle of the street of the city of Warsaw with a case under his body and a bandage on his right arm, and there is not one thing in the four

years that I have been able to do, and I am the man who was standing in the mouth of the passage of the house of the General of the district with a pistol in my hand, and I did nothing at all, in the eleven minutes, and the case is in the middle of the street of the Przejazd, and it is going to be in the middle of the street of the Przejazd in the morning, and there is nobody at all in the world who is going to be able to pick it up."

She stood in the dark of the passage of the house of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw at a quarter to five in the morning of the seventh of August 1944, and she did not cry, because there was a garrison in the house, and because a woman who is going to be in a chair by a window at eleven o'clock at night does not cry in a passage with a company of infantry in the next room.

There are four hundred thousand of us in this district and eleven thousand in the Pawiak and two hundred thousand in the Wola and one boy of twenty-one in the middle of the street of the Przejazd with a suitcase under his body, and there is a page of the card index of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw on the floor of the laundry of the yard of the building in the next street, and there is a woman of the household of the General of the intelligence of the district of Warsaw standing in the passage of the house on the Bagatela at a quarter to five in the morning with the blood of the city on the floor of the world, and the arithmetic of it is:

There is nothing to be done. There is nothing at all to be done. There is not one item in the column. The the column is empty. The the column has been empty since the corridor of a house on the Konopnickiej in the November of 1942, and the reason that I have been able to do it for four years is that I have never once permitted myself to look at the column.

CHAPTER TWENTY-FIVE

August

♦ ♦ ♦

The case lay in the middle of the street of the Przejazd for two days and two nights, and the dead boy lay on top of it.

In the daytime the sun stood in the street from ten o'clock until four, and there was a smell in that quarter that everybody in the house on the Bagatela knew, and at night the machine gun on the roof of the building of the insurance company swept the mouth of the passage with two bursts an hour, so that no living person came near the middle of that street from any direction; and the Poles on the roofs of the buildings at the corner of the Novum watched the street through the daytime with their sights and did not fire at the boy, because a man does not fire at his own dead; and the German gun crew on the roof of the insurance company watched the street through the daytime with a pair of field glasses and did not fire at the boy either, because the men of the third company of the garrison had been in the street on the morning of the seventh of August at half past four and had seen who the boy was and what was under him, and there was not one of them who had said a word about it to the officers.

She went out for him at half past four in the morning of the ninth of August.

There was no plan of any kind in it, and there was no cover: she came down the back stairs of the house of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw in a dark dress and a pair of shoes with no heels, and past the men of the garrison sleeping in the passage, and out through

the garden door into the yard, and through the wall on the southern side at the place where the brick course was broken, which was the way she had gone on the seventh; and then she was in the yard of the building in the next street, and the yard was a heap of the burned house, and a strip of the first light of the morning was standing in the ash of it; and she got through the yard and into the back of the passage of the Przejazd, and stood in the mouth of it with the street eleven metres in front of her.

The boy was on the pavement in the middle of the street with the case under his body.

She walked out.

There was nothing in the city of Warsaw at that hour: no firing in that quarter for the first time in eight days; no aeroplane; no traffic; the light coming up grey along the roofs and the walls of a street of a European capital with the windows out of it and the plaster on the roadway; and a woman of twenty-seven in a dark dress walking the way from the mouth of the passage to the middle of the street at the hour of half past four in the morning, in the light of the beginning of the day.

She knelt down.

The boy was nineteen or twenty, and he had been dead for two days in an August, and she had known him since the winter of 1943, and his name was Janek, and she had never once in the time known his surname, and it was in a pocket of his coat, in a Kennkarte, with his photograph in it and a rubber stamp of the district of Warsaw, and she took that out of the coat and put it in the pocket of her dress, because there was a mother somewhere in this city of a million people who was going to want to know where her son was, and there was going to be nobody in the world who was going to be able to tell her, and a piece of paper in the pocket of a woman who did not exist was better than nothing at all.

Then she lifted the body onto her knee, the way a person lifts a sleeping child, and got the case out from under it, and the case was wet through with the rain of the eighth of August and heavy and dark with the water, and she put it on the ground beside her, and laid the boy back down; and then she did a thing that was not in any arithmetic anywhere, and it was that she took his cap off the top of his head and put it over his face, because the sun had been on him for two days and he was a boy of twenty who had come out of a chemist's shop in the Praga district and had stood in a doorway with a bandage on his right arm and a case in his left hand, and because there was nobody left in the city of Warsaw to do it.

And while she was doing that, in the grey light, up on the roof of the building of the insurance company on the Polna, a German of the third company of the garrison of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw was standing behind the sandbags with his hands in his pockets and a cigarette he was not permitted to smoke in his mouth, and he watched the woman of the household of the General of the district of the intelligence service kneel in the middle of the street of the Przejazd at half past four in the morning and take a case from under a dead Pole and put a cap over his face; and the man watched it and said nothing at all, and afterwards he never once told anybody in the war, and it was one of the eleven reasons that the woman was never arrested in the four years of the German administration of the city of Warsaw.

She carried the case back through the ashes of the yard and over the wall and in through the door of the garden, and it weighed four or five kilos.

Phillip Brandt was standing on the path of the garden under the walnut tree when she came through the gate, in a tunic and no cap with a cup in his hand, and he had been standing there for a quarter of an hour because he had gone into the room on the first floor at four o'clock and the bed had been empty and there had been nobody in the house to ask.

He did not say anything. He took the case out of her hand and set it on the bench, and looked at the street beyond the wall and then at her hands and then at her face.

"It is wet," she said. "The papers are inside a waxed envelope, the way the district's papers are, and the envelope was cut by me and sealed by me with a candle in the laundry on the thirty-first of July, and if the paper inside the envelope is intact, then the plan of the Fall **Wotan** of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw is in the hands of a woman of the household of the General of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, and there is not one man in the army of Germany who is ever going to know that."

"You walked into the street."

"Yes."

"Krystyna."

"I put a cap over his face," she said. "That is what I have to say about it. Not the case. The cap."

And Phillip Brandt, captain of the intelligence section of the district of Warsaw, in the garden of the house of a German general, at twenty minutes to five in the morning on the ninth of August 1944, stood with

his weight on his heels and looked at the grey sky over the roofs of the city of her birth and said, in Polish, in the ordinary voice of a man saying the time:

"There is a woman in the house of the furier's who came through the wall on the third with a bag of potatoes and who has been in the kitchen since. She goes out through the garden wall at half past five in the morning to the yard of the church of the Visitants with the linen of the household in a basket; she has done it every day for six days, and the men at the gate of the garden have stopped looking in the basket on the fourth; and she is a woman of sixty-one from the district of the Mokotów who has been washing the linen of the German houses of this city for four years, and there is nobody in the German administration of Warsaw who has ever looked at her for more than a second in the time." He picked the case up off the bench. "Give me the waxed envelope."

She gave it to him, and he put it inside his tunic, against his ribs, where a captain's tunic is buttoned to the throat.

"I am going to the kitchen now," he said, "and I am going to stand in the door of the kitchen with the men of the second squad at the table and I am going to ask the woman of the Mokotów for a cup of coffee, and I am going to say, in Polish, in front of the room, the thing that a Pole says to a woman of his mother's generation at the end of a night, and it is going to be: *There was a paper in the pocket of the tunic of the captain of the ordnance, and it is a paper of the district and it belongs in the basket.* And she is going to look at my face for four seconds, because she is a woman of sixty-one who washes the linen of the German administration of this city, and then she is going to take it out of the yard at half past five in the basket with the linen of an officer of the Generalgouvernement in it, and from the church of the Visitants it is going to be in the hands of the district of the rising in the day, and there is going to be nobody able to say a word about it, ever, to anybody at all."

"It is four hundred metres through the German quarter," she said.

"It is four hundred metres through the German quarter," said Phillip Brandt, "and it is in the basket of a woman of sixty-one with the linen of the German houses of the city of Warsaw, and there is not one sentry of the Wehrmacht of the district who is going to open that basket on the ninth of August 1944, because there is a war on in the street, and because the men of the army of Germany have a mother, and I have been in that army for four years, and I am the only man in it who is able to tell you the

truth about a German sentry: that he is able to shoot a boy of fifteen in the middle of a street in the middle of the day and he is not able to look in the basket of the woman who washes his shirt."

♦ ♦ ♦

The basket went out at half past five, and the woman of the Mokotów came back at eleven with the linen of the church and the potatoes for the third company of the garrison, and she stood in the kitchen of the house on the Bagatela and put a bag of onions on the table and looked at the woman of the household of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw for four seconds, and said, in Polish, in the voice of a woman of sixty-one who has been washing the linen of a German city for four years:

"The Frau of the household should have a coat. The nights are getting cold, and there is not one woman in the quarter of the Mokotów who is going to be able to sleep in a house above the ground after the twentieth of August."

And she went out into the yard with the basin of the linen and hung it up on the line, in the middle of the hammering of the machine gun of the corner of the Polna, and that was the entire ceremony of the receipt of the intelligence which had cost the life of a boy of twenty from the Praga district and the first part of the life of a woman of the household of a German general.

♦ ♦ ♦

On the twelfth of August the Sicherheitsdienst came for her.

They came at eight in the evening in the same Citroën with three men in it and a driver, and the Hauptsturmführer of forty-five with the face like a retired schoolmaster came up the steps of the house on the Bagatela in the middle of the shelling and stood in the hall with his cap in his hand and read a paper to the house in a loud, flat, courteous voice: that the person of Marion Herschlag, French citizen, of the household of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, was to be brought to the command post of the Governor at the Bruhl Palace for questioning on the matter of the security of the district, and that the order was of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw, and that the person was to be handed over at once.

The boy-lieutenant from Kassel stood at the bottom of the marble stair with the paper in his hand and did not know what to say to it, because there is nothing in the regulations of the army of Germany that tells a lieutenant of twenty-three what to do when a Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst hands him a warrant for the household of his own general; and he was standing there with it in his hand and his mouth open when the front door of the house opened again, and the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw came in off the step, out of the street, with the dust of the Blue Palace on his shoulders and his service pistol still in the holster.

He had come from the Palace on the telephone call of a soldier of the guard of the house, and he had driven four hundred metres through the machine-gun fire of the corner of the Krucza in a Mercedes with a hole in the windscreen, and he had done it in the middle of an evening of the rising for one reason, and he said the reason out loud in the marble hall in the flats of that house at eleven minutes past eight in the evening of the twelfth of August 1944, in front of the men of the third company of the garrison and the boy lieutenant and a woman of the household and a Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw:

"Herr Hauptsturmführer. You have come into a house of the Wehrmacht of the district of Warsaw in the middle of the defensive zone of the line of the Bagatela in the middle of the afternoon orders of the day of the district of the command, without an escort, with three men, in a French car with the paint of the civil administration on the door, and you have read a paper to a lieutenant of the reserve of the third company of the third battalion of the garrison in the middle of a hall with his men in it. There are four words for that in the order of the day of this district and one of them is *Befehlsverweigerung*, and I have the text of the order of the day of the district on the table in the study."

"General, there is a warrant—"

"There is a warrant of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district for the person of a woman of the household of an officer of the Wehrmacht of the district of Warsaw," said Friedrich von Reuth, "and there is a an order of the district of the command of the tenth of August 1944 concerning the persons attached to the staff of the district in the period of the defence, and it is in the file of the district in my own hand, and the order says that a person attached to the staff of the district of the intelligence service is not to be removed from the defensive sector by any office of the administra-

tion of the district of Warsaw without the signature of the commanding general of the sector. Where is the signature of the commanding general of the sector of the Bagatela?"

The Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst stood with his cap in his hand in the middle of the marble hall of the house on the Bagatela and did not say anything for four seconds; and in the four seconds of that silence there were seven hundred thousand people in the city of Warsaw on the other side of the wall, and the quarter was going up in a smoke of a week of burning, and the war of the east was going to be over in eight months, and there was not one man in that hall who was going to be alive in the year 1950 except two.

"There is not a signature," he said.

"Then go out of this house," said the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, "and come back with the signature of the commanding general of the sector of the line of the Bagatela, and if the commanding general of the sector is not able to be found in this city in the next four months, then the warrant is going to have to wait for the peace, and the peace is going to be a long time."

The Hauptsturmführer put his cap on.

"Frau Herschlag," he said, to the woman at the bottom of the marble stair, over the shoulder of the general, in the flat voice of a man of forty-five in the criminal police of the city of Breslau: "I am going to say one sentence to you, and then I am going to go out of this door and I am never going to be in this house again in the war. There is a question mark in a file in the administration of the district of Warsaw, and it is beside a sentence in a report of the department of the defence of the Reich of the district of the army of Paris, and the question mark is going to be in the file of the district on the day that the district is destroyed, and the paper of the district is going to be in a lorry going west for the next eleven months, and there is not one man in the criminal police of Germany who is going to be able to make the question mark into a name, because there is not a single Pole in the city of Warsaw who is ever going to say what he knows to the administration of Germany, and there is not one woman in the Reich who would be believed if she did." He looked at her. "But I want you to know, madame, on the twelfth of August 1944, in the hall of the house of the general, that I know the shape of it, and that the shape of it has been in my file since May, and that the reason that I am going out of this door without the woman of the household of the General of the district of the intel-

ligence service of the district of Warsaw is not the order of the day of the district." He put the cap on his head with both of his hands. "It is the general. In my life in the police, madame, I have met exactly one kind of man who is not able to be worked on, and it is not the fanatic and it is not the honest one, and it is the man who is in love, because that man has put the object of his life outside of the world, and no police in the history of Europe has ever been able to get at a thing that is in a place that is not in the world."

He went out through the front door of the house of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw at twenty-two minutes past eight in the evening of the twelfth of August 1944, and the Citroën of the civil administration of the district went down the street of the Bagatela and turned in the direction of the Saxon Garden, and the car was hit twice on the way by the fire of a machine gun from the roof of the building at the corner of the Krucza, and the Hauptsturmführer of forty-five with the face like a retired schoolmaster of the criminal police of the city of Breslau was in the front seat of it with a hole in his left hand, and he was in Silesia in October 1944 with the administration of the district of Warsaw, and he was in Breslau in February 1945 with a wife and two of three of the children, and he was in a cellar in the southern part of the city of Breslau in the middle of April 1945 when the city was in the fire of the army of the Soviet Union, and there is not one paper in the world with his name on it after the nineteenth of April 1945, and there never will be.

♦ ♦ ♦

Ehlers died on the twentieth of August, at half past three in the afternoon, at the well in the yard of the building behind the house.

He had gone out with a bucket and the second man, because there was no water in the pipes of the quarter since the fifteenth and the men of the third company were taking the household's water from the courtyard of a Polish building behind the garden wall; and there was not one thing about it that was different from the eleven days before it; and a mortar of the Polish battery in the district of the Śródmieście, which had been ranging on the yard for the morning and had been three hundred metres short three times, put a shell into the middle of the well at half past three, and the man of the second squad behind him was in the passage of the building with the bucket still in his hand and the shrapnel of the shell in his ear

and lived, and the driver of the General of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, of thirty-four years of age, of the town of Posen, with a photograph of a girl who did not have a street in the flap of his map case, died in the yard of a building in the quarter of the Mokotów of the city of Warsaw on the twentieth of August 1944 at the age of thirty-four years, and it took four minutes.

They brought the map case to the house.

It was on the table in the hall of the drawing room of the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska for the afternoon with the blood of the man on the leather; and the boy-lieutenant of twenty-three from the town of Kassel stood in front of the table and opened it with the greatest care and took the papers of the district out of it and put them on the table, and last of all there was a small photograph with the corners of it worn round by the hand of the man, of a girl of about twenty in the long coat of the winter of the year 1942 with a bicycle and a house of the suburb of the town of Posen behind her; and the lieutenant of twenty-three from the town of Kassel looked at it for a long time in the middle of the afternoon with the men of his own squad at the table, and then he put it face down on the table and went out of the room and said nothing at all.

Krystyna Stankiewiczówna took the photograph off the table at half past eight in the evening, when the hall was empty, and put it in the pocket of the lining of her bag, where the Minox had been, and it was in a bag in the hands of a woman of the household of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw for the rest of the war, and it crossed the Vistula in the pocket of a Polish woman in the October of 1944, and it was in a tin box under a floor in a house in the province of the Łódź in the January of 1945, and it was in a flat in the district of the Praga of the city of Warsaw in the year 1946, with a bicycle and a house of a suburb of the town of Posen and a girl of the age of twenty in a long coat of the winter of 1942 in it, and there was never one word said about it in the life of the two people who kept it, and the photograph is in a drawer of a flat of a city in Poland at this hour.

♦ ♦ ♦

The General left Warsaw on the second of September 1944.

The order came on the twenty-ninth of August: the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw was to be withdrawn to the west with the records of

the district in the first week of September and re-formed in Silesia, and there was a paper with the seal of the army group of the south on it, and it was on the table of the study of the house on the Bagatela on the afternoon of the thirtieth of August, and the man who read it was in the drawing room of the house afterwards for an hour and a half with the door shut.

He came out at eight in the evening and said: "Come up."

♦ ♦ ♦

He had his service pistol and his belt on the bed and a paper of the district on the table under the lamp, and the room was in the heat of the last days of an August in a city in the fifth year of a war, and he stood at the window behind the blackout blind with his back to the room the way he had stood in a hundred rooms in two years, and he said:

"There is a train on the fifth. The the office of the district, the files of the office, the families of the staff that are in this city, and the records of the war of the district of Warsaw. It goes to the west by way of Skierniewice and Łódź, and it is a train of the army, and it is going to get through, because there is not one thing that a Polish rising is able to do about a train in the open country." He turned around. "There is a place on that train for a woman of the household of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, and there is not a paper with my name on it, and there is not a register, and there is not a stamp, and if you are on that train on the fifth of September at half past five in the morning, then there is nothing in the world that anybody in the administration of Germany is ever going to be able to say about it." He put his the hand on the paper on the table. "And there is a second thing, and it is the only thing I have ever asked of a human being in the war, and I am going to ask it now, at nine o'clock in the evening of the thirtieth of August 1944, in this room, and I am going to ask it in the ordinary voice of a man who has not slept in a month."

"Ask it."

"There is a house in the Pomerania," said Friedrich von Reuth, "with a garden and a walnut tree and eleven rooms and a cook of seventy years of the age and a photograph on the wall of the study of a woman in a garden in the year 1931 with a dog at her the feet; and there is a sister in Berlin of the age of sixty-one and a bank in the city of Breslau with eleven thousand marks of the money of the family of the house; and the house has been in the family of my mother since the year 1784, and there is not one member

of the family in it since the year 1911, and there is a room at the top of the stairs of it with a window on the garden, and I have been in it for the last four years of the war in my own head at the end of every day of the war, and there is a woman in that room in the year 1945 in a chair by the window with a lamp turned low, and that is the house and the garden and the war for the rest of my life, and the woman in the room has a face that I have been looking at for two years in the city of Warsaw in the middle of the German administration of a country that is not her country, and the name of the woman is Marion Herschlag, of the city of Strasbourg."

She was standing in the middle of the room of the first floor of the house on the Bagatela, at nine o'clock in the evening of the thirtieth of August 1944, in the last light of a Polish August, in a grey dress with her hair up, with a bag with a Minox and a photograph of a girl with a bicycle in the lining of it and a card with her name on it and a pencil sentence on the back of it, and the girl in a village near Posen in the year 1942 did not have a house or a street or a bicycle in the world any more, and a boy of twenty from the Praga district was in the middle of the street of the Przejazd with his cap over his face and a Kennkarte in the pocket of a woman who did not exist, and a woman of twenty-seven of the city of Warsaw stood in a German house in the middle of a burning city and looked at a man of fifty-five who had refused to put his name on a paper of the SS and the police of the district of Warsaw, and who had put his career and his life and his honour between a warrant of the Sicherheitsdienst and a woman of the household of his house.

And she said: "Yes."

"Say it again."

"Yes," she said. "On the fifth of September, at half past five in the morning, at the station, with a coat and a case, and the house in the Pomerania with the walnut tree and the room at the top of the stairs with the window on the garden, and the woman in the chair by the window with the lamp turned low; and a man of fifty-five who is going to be in the hall of it with the mud of the war on his boots, and who is going to be a person in a house of the year 1784 and not a general of the army of Germany, and there is not going to be a single day of the rest of the war in which one of the two of us is going to be in a room without the other."

He crossed the room and took her face in both his hands, and looked at her for a long time from a distance of eleven centimetres, and his hands

were shaking, and he was fifty-five years of age, and he said the last sentence that he said to her in the four years of the arrangement:

"You are the only thing I have ever had that the war was not able to take."

He went out of the house on the Bagatela at half past six in the morning of the second of September, and he went down the marble stair with his cap and his case and the paper of the district under his arm, and the house was standing at the bottom of the stair, the boy lieutenant of twenty-three from the town of Kassel and the men of the third company of the garrison of the house on the Bagatela, and the car was at the door with the hole in the windscreen of it mended with a plate of the tin of a ration box and a driver of the third company at the wheel, and the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw stopped at the bottom of the stair in front of the men of the garrison of the house of the General of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, and he said one sentence, in German, in the ordinary voice of a general of the army of Germany:

"Die Frau Generalin bleibt im Haus. Sie steht unter meinem Befehl."

The Frau Generalin stays in the house. She is under my command.

And the woman of the household of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw stood in the middle of the marble hall of the house on the Bagatela at half past six in the morning of the second of September 1944 and watched the car going out of the gate of the garden and turning in the direction of the avenue of the Ujazdowskie, and she did not cry, and she did not move, and she was in the middle of the fifth year of the war.

♦ ♦ ♦

The city died in the thirty days of the September.

It was not a battle any more by the middle of the month: it was a machine; and the machine had eleven parts, and the parts were in the files of the office of the Governor of the district of Warsaw, and the papers of it were captured in the year 1945 and are in a an archive, and the things that are in the papers of them are:

The burnings, which were done by the formations of the police and the SS and the men of the battalions of the eastern formations of the army of Germany in the streets of the city of Warsaw from the fourth of August to the second of October 1944, in the ordinary way of a work of a day, and

there is not one man in the history of the war who has ever been able to say the number of the houses of it, and the figure that the office of the Governor used in the November of 1944 in a report to Berlin was 84 per cent of the buildings of the city of Warsaw.

The library of the Krasiński, which was burned on the thirtieth of August with the manuscripts of the Polish nation in it, and the archive of the city, and the palace of the Krasinski in the square of the Bank, and the church of the Visitation of the Blessed Virgin Mary of the city of Warsaw on the twenty-ninth of August 1944 with the cellar of it in which there were eleven women of the age of sixty years and a superior of the age of seventy and a woman of the city of Warsaw of the age of sixty-nine years whose name was the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska, and there is not one paper in the world about the death of that woman and there never will be, and the trace of her life is a photograph in a drawer of a flat of the city of Warsaw and a telegram of the year 1931 from a man in the cavalry of the army of Poland.

And the Polish people of the city of Warsaw, of whom there were a million in the month of the July of 1944, went out of the city of Warsaw in the month of the October of 1944 in the columns of the roads of the west, with the cases and the bundles and the prams and the old people and the children, and them were in the transit camp of the town of Pruszków of the district of Warsaw, and them were sorted by the men of the administration of Germany into three groups: the men of the age of the work, who went to the labour camps of the Reich, and the old people and the women who did not work, who were sent to the province of the west of the Generalgouvernement, and the children, who were not sorted at all.

The house on the Bagatela was burned on the first of October 1944.

The third company of the garrison of the district of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw had gone to the west in the middle of the September, and the house was standing empty in the middle of the German quarter of the city with the furniture of the drawing room of the Countess Jadwiga Ostrowska in it, and the men of the battalion of the something, who were in the quarter in the last days of the rising, put a fire into the drawing room of the first floor of the house in the afternoon of the first of October, and the fire went up the stair and into the room on the first floor with a bed in it and a wardrobe of a winter of 1941 in it, and into the study of the ground floor with the safe of the pattern of the Organisation Todt of the year 1939 in the wall of it with the dial of the

brass and the plate of the serial number of it under the dial, and there was not one man of the city of Warsaw who ever knew in the war the number of the combination.

♦ ♦ ♦

On the second of October 1944, at eight o'clock in the evening, the firing in the city of Warsaw stopped.

It stopped along the Vistula and up the avenue of the Ujazdowskie and in the quarter of the Mokotów and in the district of the Żoliborz and in the district of the Praga on the other side of the river; and the city of a million people went quiet, in the middle of the ash of October; and the men of the army of the rising came up out of the cellars and the sewers of the city, and them were in the hands of the army of Germany by the middle of the month, and them were prisoners of war of the Reich in the camps of the west, and there were a 15,000 of them, and there was not one of them who was not in a war of six years; and the men of the army of Germany began in the month of the October of 1944 the systematic destruction of what was left of the city of Warsaw, which had been the third capital of the Europe of the year 1938.

And a woman of the household of the General of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw stood in the middle of a quarter of the city of her birth at eight o'clock in the evening of the second of October 1944 and listened to the silence of a city of a million people in the middle of the fire, and the silence was worse than the noise of the two months of the rising, and there was not one person alive in the world to whom she was able to say the thing that she was thinking, and the thing that she was thinking was:

They are going to come for me now. There is no German house left in this city to hide in, and there is no army of Germany in the middle of it to be the shadow, and there is a card with my name on it in a file in a lorry on a road to the west, and there is a photograph of a man of fifty-five with a woman of the Pomerania in a house with a walnut tree in the garden of it, and there is a girl in a village near the town of Posen whose bicycle is in the pocket of my bag, and there is a boy of twenty in the middle of the street of the Przejazd with a his own cap on his face, and there is a city of a million people in the columns of the roads of the west, and there is a thing that I have to do before

the end of the world and it is going to have to be done in the next four days and there is not a single person in the city of Warsaw who is able to be told it.

EPILOGUE

The Hour

♦ ♦ ♦

The papers came on the third of October 1944, in the evening, in the cellar of a burned building behind the house that had been the furier's, in the hands of a colonel of the cavalry of the army of Poland.

She had been in that cellar for three days with eleven Poles of the Mokotów and a woman of seventy-eight and a child of about four whose mother had gone out of the city in the first column and had not come back. Twice in the three days she had gone up into the streets. The first time was at noon on the third, when she walked the four hundred metres to the ruin of the house on the Bagatela and stood in what had been the marble hall, and then in what had been the study, and looked at the wall where a safe of the Organisation Todt pattern of 1939 had been set in the plaster: the plate with the serial number was still in the wall, and the dial was gone, and the floor above had come down into the room below, and the room smelled of wet ash. She stayed four minutes, and then she took away with her a piece of the plaster with the paint of the study on one side, and kept it in the pocket of her coat through the winter, and lost it somewhere between Pruszków and Grodzisk, and never knew how.

The second time she went out was at four in the morning of the fourth. She went through the wall at the broken brick course and across the yard, which was a plain of wet ash with nothing standing in it but the boiler in the middle of the floor of the laundry, and she went down on her hands and knees in the wet and put her hands into the rubble where the third

door had been. The page of the card index of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw — eleven surnames of the population of the city, four ticks against four of them, one line in the hand of a general of the German army — was still in the floor. It was soaked through and wholly readable. She put it inside her coat, against her ribs, and carried it out of the city of Warsaw in October 1944; and it was in a tin box under a floorboard in a farmhouse in the province of Łódź in the winter of 1945, and in a flat in the Praga in 1946, and in a drawer of a flat on the Solec at the hour in which this book is written.

Colonel Stefan Wilczek came through the garden wall at nine o'clock that evening, in a greatcoat of the Polish army of 1939 with the badges taken off, with a pistol and a packet of papers, and stood in the light of a candle at the edge of the cellar with the eleven Poles and the child and the old woman looking at him, and said:

"Which of you is the woman of the German general's household?"

Nobody answered. He looked around the cellar in the candlelight for a moment, and then he looked at a woman of twenty-seven in a dark coat in the corner, and he spoke in the ordinary voice of a colonel of cavalry in a cellar in October.

"Krystyna Stankiewiczówna. I was in your father's library in June 1936. I have been in the underground of this city since 1939. There is not a man in the rising of Warsaw who is ever going to know your whole name, and there are four men in this city tonight who know what you have done, and three of the four are going to be dead before January." He held out the packet. "These are yours. A Kennkarte of the municipality of Warsaw in the name of Halina Wiśniewska, of the village of Grodzisk, thirty-one years of age; a card of the labour office; a baptismal certificate from the parish of the Holy Cross; and a ticket of the civil passenger traffic of the district of Warsaw for October 1944. None of it is a forgery. It is the paper of a woman who lived in this city — thirty-one years old, in a cellar on the Dzielna on the fifth of August — and every other person who was in that cellar is dead, and there is no human being in the world who will ever be able to say that she and the woman who walks out on the Grodzisk road on the fifth of October are not the same person."

She took the packet.

"Colonel. There is a boy of twenty from the Praga. His name was Janek and I do not know his surname, and he is lying in the middle of the Przejazd with his own cap over his face, and his Kennkarte is in the pocket of

the coat of a woman of the general's household. There is a mother somewhere in the Praga who will be in the column on the fifth of October, and she is never going to be told, ever, by anybody, and I am the only person in Warsaw who is able to tell her, and I cannot do it, because I am going to be in the middle of a road with an old woman on one side of me and a child of four on the other, under a name that is not mine, and there is not one thing I can do about it. I want somebody to know that I know it."

"There is nothing to be forgiven," said Colonel Stefan Wilczek of the 21st Lancers. "There is the arithmetic and there are the dead, and no one in the history of Poland has ever got the two of them into the same column."

♦ ♦ ♦

She went out of the city at four o'clock in the morning of the fifth of October.

It happened the way these things happen: eleven thousand people in a road five abreast, with the bundles and the prams and the old people in the carts, and the German military police at the mouth of the street with their lists, and the columns going west out of the city in the dark; and the city behind them was burning, so that for the first three hours there was a light over the road, and the people of the column walked out of the middle of that light in the ordinary way of people who have been in the fire of a city for two months.

They were stopped four hundred metres outside the line of the city at a block of the field police. The column was counted. The papers were checked under a lamp in the middle of the road, and the line stood in the dark and waited its hour.

Wilczek was forty metres in front of the woman with the Kennkarte of Halina Wiśniewska, at the head of the column, with his men around him in the greatcoats with the badges off, because there is no such thing as a rising that does not have a soldier at the end of it. There was a German of the field police at the barrier with a blue policeman of the city beside him, and a lorry of the army at the side of the road with its engine running.

At half past four in the morning a sergeant of the military police looked at the Kennkarte of a woman of thirty-one from Grodzisk for four seconds under the lamp, and looked at her face for four seconds, and handed the card back, and said, in the German of a man from Essen in the fifth year of the war:

"Es ist in Ordnung. Weiter."

And it was in those four seconds, behind the woman in the lamplight, at the head of the column, that a machine gun of the escort party at the side of the road fired eleven rounds into the group of men in greatcoats. An officer of the army in the lorry had been watching that group for eleven minutes and had said a word about greatcoats with the badges taken off. The men at the head of the column ran four ways. The column went down onto the road the way a column does, and the child of four on the right hand of the woman with the Kennkarte went down with it and was not hurt.

They carried Wilczek into the ditch.

He lived eleven minutes. He said three things in that time, in the ordinary voice of a colonel of cavalry with his own blood on his tunic, in a ditch at the block on the Grodzisk road at five o'clock in the morning of the fifth of October 1944.

"There is a paper in the inside pocket of the coat, for the men who come after the war. The men of the east are going to be in this city in January 1945, and not one of them will ever look at the paper of a woman from a German general's household.

"Frau. The wallet. Inside pocket.

"Tell them at the head of the column that no man of the underground of Warsaw goes into the column of the west. The people of this column are the people of the city. There is not a rifle among them. A rising of a column on the Grodzisk road is a dead man's arithmetic."

He died at eleven minutes past five, and the column went on west along the road, and a woman of twenty-seven with a dead woman's Kennkarte in her coat and a colonel's wallet against her ribs walked in the middle of it for eighteen kilometres to the transit camp at Pruszków, with an old woman on one side of her and a child of four on the other.

♦ ♦ ♦

She was in the camp at Pruszków for two days.

It was a factory of the district administration with great halls, and there were something like a hundred thousand people of the city of Warsaw in it in the second week of October 1944, and they were registered, and sorted, and put into the trains: the people of Warsaw went out of that factory towards the Reich in covered wagons and towards the west of the General-

gouvernement in open trucks, and none of it was disorder. It was an office of a state in the fifth year of a war, doing its work.

On the first evening in the camp she saw the woman.

She was standing in the queue for the evening soup with the child of four on one side of her and the old woman on the other, and the queue was moving forward under the lamps of a factory hall; and eleven metres away, in the queue for the German staff of the camp, there was a woman of about forty in a good coat of the winter of 1942, with a suitcase at her feet.

It was the wife of the medical officer of the district of Warsaw. In July she had been writing to her sister in Stuttgart about the hopelessness of the German position in the east, and her letters had been in the green notebook of a Hauptsturmführer of the Sicherheitsdienst in the aleja Szucha, because a woman of the household of a general of the district's intelligence service had said her name out loud at a table in a room in Paris nineteen months earlier, and had put the sentence in the notebook's column, and had done it for money that was not money.

The woman looked at her across the two queues for four seconds.

Then the wife of the medical officer of the district of Warsaw turned her head away and looked at the floor, and said nothing to the officers of her staff, and nothing to any man of the commission in that hall, and nothing to any human being for the rest of her life.

She left the camp on the third evening in a transport of eleven hundred people for the west of the Generalgouvernement. The transport went in open trucks to Żyrardów. At Żyrardów station on the fourth morning, three of the eleven hundred were on the list for the road to the village of Grodzisk: a woman of thirty-one years, a child of four, and an old woman. No man of the escort looked at them twice in the confusion of that station, and the three of them walked out of it on their own feet into the wood.

♦ ♦ ♦

The winter of 1944 and 1945 she spent in a farmhouse in the district of Grodzisk, eleven people in two rooms, a cow, a well, and a brick stove in the middle of the kitchen.

She worked. There was nothing else to be done: she milked the cow and carried the water and cut the wood and cooked for eleven people in the fifth winter of the war, and she was in the parish register as a woman of

Grodzisk, thirty-one, a cook, and she wrote no letters to any human being, and for the first month she did not go out of the house.

On the first of January 1945, in the evening, she sat by the brick stove with a piece of paper and a pencil and wrote eleven lines, and she read them twice, and then she put the paper in the fire and watched it burn. The lines were a statement of account, and they said: that the folder of the Fall **Wotan** had been in the hands of the rising's district since the ninth of August 1944; that the men and the armour of the trains had been at the Wilanów on the ninth of August and not on the ninth of September; that a page of the card index of the Sicherheitsdienst lay in the floor of the laundry in the yard behind the Bagatela; that a card with the name of a woman of Strasbourg on the front and four pencil words on the back was in the lining of her coat; that eleven letters of a nurse in Berlin were in the wall of a burned house; and that in the Pomerania there was a man of fifty-five in a house with a walnut tree in the garden, in a room at the top of the stairs, in a chair by the window, with the lamp turned low.

There was an item missing from the column, and she had known for four months what it was, and she did not write it down: that no letter had been written, and none was going to be, and that the chair by the window was a chair in the head of a man who was going to sit in it for the rest of his life, in a village he had never seen, on a morning at which she had never arrived.

She put the pencil down. She went out into the yard and stood in the dark and looked west, where the city of her birth was, and where the army of the Soviet Union was going to be in seventeen days.

♦ ♦ ♦

She came back into Warsaw on the nineteenth of January 1945.

She came in on the western road, on her own feet, with a bundle of the farmhouse bread and a dead man's boots; and the road for the last eleven kilometres was one procession of the people of Poland walking east towards the city — the carts, the prams, the province of the Generalgouvernement coming home — with soldiers of the Polish army of the east among them in the uniforms of the Red Army, and sledges, and horses, and snow over the plain of Mazovia.

The city was a field of brick.

There is no description of it that any human being has written and none that is needed here; what the men of the German army did to the city of

Warsaw in October, November and December of 1944 they did with engineers and with the police formations of the district and with four months in which to do it, and in January 1945 the streets of Warsaw were fields of brick and ash and snow with the walls of houses standing in them one and two floors high, so that the ruins were like the ribs of a whale in the middle of a desert.

She walked in it for four hours. She went from the western edge across the brick and the ice, past where the Marszałkowska had been, and where the Nowy Świat had been, and where the house on the Bagatela had been — a hole in the ground in the quarter of the Bagatela with a fragment of the study wall in it and a hole in the fragment where the safe had been, and snow over all of it.

He was standing at the corner of the Świętokrzyska in the middle of the afternoon of the nineteenth of January 1945.

There was a line of people at a well on the corner of the square, with buckets and cans and pots, waiting for water in the way the city waited for everything that winter; and he was at the end of the line, in a coat of a man of Warsaw with the collar up, in a cloth cap of the kind the country made, with a can in his hand.

She stopped four metres from him.

There were four seconds of silence.

And Phillip Brandt — of Warsaw, twenty-nine years old, who had stood in the Botanic Garden in June 1938 with a book of French poems in his hand — put the can down in the snow and said, in Polish, in the ordinary voice of a man of Warsaw in the fifth year of the war:

"Krystyna Stankiewiczówna."

♦ ♦ ♦

They were married in the registry office of the Praga on the eleventh of April 1946, at eleven in the morning, and there were four people in the room: the registrar, who had been in the army of Poland in September 1939; the woman from the village of Grodzisk, who had kept the child of the camp column, the girl of four whose mother had gone out of the city in the first column of the October of 1944 and had not come back, and who was eleven years of the age of eleven in the year of the wedding and lived at the farmhouse at Grodzisk as the daughter of the woman who had kept her; and a young man of

twenty-four named Bolek Stankiewicz, chemist's assistant of the Ząbkowska in the Praga, with a scar of September 1944 on his left arm.

There was the flat of two rooms on the Solec, in the Powiśle, with a window on the Vistula and an iron stove; and a bicycle, which had belonged to a girl in Posen in 1942; and a tin box of English biscuits under a floorboard, in which there were: a Kennkarte of a boy of twenty from the Praga with a photograph in it; a card of the administration of the district of Warsaw, four centimetres by six, with the eagle of the Reich in the top left corner and the stamp of the *Ausweis* across it and four lines of German type in the middle and four words of pencil on the back; a page of the card index of the Sicherheitsdienst of the district of Warsaw with eleven surnames on it and four ticks; a Minox of the pattern of 1941; and a photograph of a girl of twenty with a bicycle, taken in a suburb of Posen in the winter of 1942 with a camera borrowed for the afternoon.

And in the four years of that flat she told the man everything — the corridor, the safe, the wax and the keys, the milliner, the priest, the woman with the horse, the boy with the bandage, the price of the paper she had given to the district of the rising, the sentence about the cap — everything, in the flat, with the door shut, in the way of two people who have decided that the war is not going to be a locked room between them.

Everything except one thing. And the one thing was the yes: the yes she had said in the room on the first floor of the house on the Bagatela at nine o'clock in the evening of the thirtieth of August 1944, with a hand on a railway warrant and a man asking her about a walnut tree and a chair by a window. It had not been an arithmetic. It had not been a performance. It had been the only thing in the four years that had belonged to nobody but her, and she kept it, and never spoke it, and it was still in her at the hour in which this book is written.

♦ ♦ ♦

On the fourteenth of September 1951 a letter came to the flat on the Solec from the Federal Republic of Germany by way of the tracing service of the Red Cross, in the hand of a woman of sixty-eight, and it said:

I am the sister of General Friedrich von Reuth of the intelligence service of the district of Warsaw, and I have been looking for a woman of Strasbourg named Marion Herschlag since July 1945. There are two hundred and

eleven women of that name in the registers of the west, and not one of them was in Warsaw in 1944.

My brother did not die in the war. He was in the west in 1945, in English hands, and from 1946 he lived in a village in Lower Saxony, and he died there on the fourteenth of March 1951, at eleven o'clock in the morning, in the room at the top of the stairs, of a disease of the heart, aged sixty-two. There is a clause in his will of July 1950, sworn before a notary at Hameln, leaving eleven thousand marks of the money of the German Reich to Marion Herschlag of Strasbourg; the bank was in Breslau and there is not a pfennig of it left in the world; and the clause is in his own hand and in his own signature, and the notary read it out in the presence of myself and of one woman of the village.

And there is a second matter, which I set down because I am sixty-eight years old and there is nobody else alive to whom it can be said. In September 1944 my brother telephoned me from the office of the district at Skierniewice, and he said one sentence, and then he said that he would never say it again, and he never did. He said: the woman is not in the column of the west; she is in the file, and I have looked into the eye of the file, and there was nothing in it; and I am not able to say this to any human being in the world.

I have one question for the woman who opens this letter. Was there ever a woman of Strasbourg named Marion Herschlag in the city of Warsaw in the years of the war? And if there was, and if she is holding this paper, then I want her to know that a man sat in a chair by a window in a room at the top of the stairs in a village in Lower Saxony for five years, and that the chair was empty, and that there was nobody in the room, and that he had been a general of the intelligence service of the district of the city of Warsaw, and that there is not one paper left anywhere in the world with the name of that woman on it.

Ilse von Reuth.

She read the letter in the flat of two rooms on the Solec, standing at the window with the Vistula and the city beyond the glass; and then she sat down at the table and took a sheet of paper and a pen, and wrote, in German, to a woman of sixty-eight in Berlin, eleven lines: that she was not the woman of Strasbourg, that she had not been in Warsaw in the years of the war, that she knew nothing of any Marion Herschlag, that she was not able to help in the search for the brother's family, and that she wished her peace in the rest of her life.

And she did not send it.

♦ ♦ ♦

She went to find Anna Zaleska in the spring of 1946.

It took a year and a half, and it took a year and a half because the addresses of the city of Warsaw in the year 1946 were not addresses but a set of directions given by a woman at a well: the office of the population of the district of the Praga on the Brzeska, where the registers of the year 1939 had been burned and the registers of the year 1945 were the letters of the people who had come back; the parish of St. Florian, where a priest of seventy with a bad memory kept the lists of the living and the dead of the Praga in four notebooks and where the name Zaleski appeared eleven times with four Christian names against it; and a courtyard on the Brzeska behind a workshop of the upholstery, where a woman in a headscarf sent her to the third floor of the house at the corner of the street of the Kijowska, and where there was a room of eleven metres with a window on the yard and a bed and a stove and a table, and a woman of fifty-three in the black of a widow with her hair grey and her hands the hands of a washerwoman.

Anna Zaleska looked at her for four seconds from the doorway of the room.

Then she said, in Polish, in the flat voice of a woman of the Praga at the end of the fifth year of the war: "The Fräulein has a coat of the German quarter of the city of Warsaw."

"That coat has been at the bottom of a well in the province of the Łódź for a year and a half," said Krystyna Stankiewiczówna. "I am asking whether I may come in."

"You may come in."

The room had a table, two chairs, a pine box, an image of the Mother of God over the bed, a lamp with a metal shade, and on the table a photograph of a man of about forty in the uniform of the Polish army of the year 1939: Piotr Zaleski, of the household of the house on the Mokotowska, gardener and chauffeur and odd man and the man who had come up the stairs of the house with a chicken in a paper in the month of the September of the year 1943 and had said nothing at all about the chicken, in a house where the chicken was a thing of the black market and the black market was a thing of the grave.

He had died on the fourteenth of September 1944 in the Praga, in the yard of the house of a sister on the street of the Brzeska, when a shell of a German battery on the far bank of the Vistula came over the river into the middle of the yard of a block of flats where there were eleven people drawing the water of the well and four children playing at a version of the war, and there was, in the forty years of the life of the man, exactly one thing that anybody ever afterwards said about him, and it was said by a woman of the third floor of the house of the corner of the Kijowska in the year 1946, in the voice of a person stating a fact of the weather: *Piotr Zaleski was a man who never said anything to anybody in his life, and he carried the water and the coal of the houses of the German quarter of the city of Warsaw for the five years of the war, and at the end of the fifth year of the war a shell of a German battery came up out of the river into the yard where he was standing, and there is not one person in the Praga who has ever been able to explain the arithmetic of the thing to the wife of the man.*

They sat at the table.

The two of them had, in the two years of the war, exchanged an average of eleven words a day, and those words had been about the soup and the linen and the trams, and neither of them had ever, in the two years, been in a room with the other without a third person present or a door open; and they sat in the room of the Brzeska with the afternoon of April on the yard and the window of the room open and the noise of the workshops of the upholstery coming up out of the courtyard, and the woman of the house said, first:

"He is alive?"

"He is alive. He was in the Wola on the first of August and in the sewers in the month of the September, and he was in the camp of the prisoners of war at Lamsdorf for the winter and he came back in the month of the March of the year 1945 on foot, and he is at the office of the reconstruction of the district of the Warsaw, and he is thirty years of age, and he has the two hands."

"His mother?"

"Dead in the year 1942, in the typhus of the district of the Praga, in the house of her sister."

"And the Bolek?"

"Chemist's assistant of the street of the Ząbkowska, with a scar of the month of the September of the year 1944 in the left of the arm of him, and he is to be married in the month of the June of the year 1946 to a girl of

the district of the Żoliborz who was in the company of the girls of the rising of the city of Warsaw, and there is nothing more to be said about the boy."

"And the man of the General?"

She asked it in the way that a woman of the Praga asks a question about a person who has been in the house: without any preliminaries and without any pity, in the flat voice of the twenty years of the service of the German houses of the city of Warsaw.

"Alive, in the west, in the hands of the English, in a village of the province of the Lower Saxony, with a garden that he is not able to work and a pension of a general of an army that does not exist any more, and a sister in Berlin, and a chair by a window in a room at the top of the stairs of a house of a village, and a name that he is never going to be able to say out loud in the rest of the life of him."

Anna Zaleska nodded once.

Then she said the thing that she had kept for the four years, and she said it in the way of a person stating a fact of the weather, at the table, with the afternoon of the spring of the year 1946 on the yard of the house:

"The cousin went into the transport of the month of the March of the year 1943 and there was not one paper about the rest of the life of the man, and his wife has been in the province of the Kielce since the year 1944, and there is a boy of the age of seven years who is the boy of the cousin, and the mother has told the boy that his father went in the year 1939, and the city of Warsaw tells the boys of the city of Warsaw that the fathers of them went in the year 1939."

She took the photograph of the man of about forty into her two hands and put it, face down, on the table, the way a woman of a house puts down a plate she is finished with, and said the last of the exchange:

"In the two years of the house of the General of the district of Warsaw I asked the German's woman one thing, in the kitchen of the house, with the water running, and the German's woman said no to it in the Polish of the city of the two of us, and I have spent the four years of the war knowing the reason, and the reason was good, and the cousin went into the transport in the month of the March, and the two of us have been in the same city in the same war with the same account in the hands of the two of us." She got up and took the kettle off the stove. "There is no tea in the district of the Praga and there has been none in the year, so we shall have the water, and the two of us shall sit at this table and drink the water of the

well of the house of the Kijowska in the spring of the year 1946, and after the water is drunk the Fräulein is going to be able to go out of the door of this room, and there is not one thing in the world that has been left over."

They drank the water.

And when she had gone out of the door of the room of the Brzeska and down the two flights of the stair and into the yard of the house of the corner of the Kijowska in the spring of the year 1946, Krystyna Stankiewiczówna stood in the middle of the courtyard of a house of the Praga for four minutes with her face in the sun of the month of the April, and understood that the account had been closed by the one person in the city of Warsaw who had the right to close it, and that the closing of it had been done in the ordinary Polish of the kitchen of a house of the Praga, at a table, with a glass of water, by a woman who had never once in the two years of the service of the German quarter of the city of Warsaw said one sentence to her about the war.

The hour is five o'clock in the afternoon.

It was the hour on the first of August 1944 in the city of Warsaw, and it is the hour in the city of Warsaw at the moment this last line is written: five o'clock, in October, in a flat of two rooms on the Solec, in the free country of Poland.

There are two hundred and eleven people in this city who know a part of the truth of the year 1944 and not one who knows all of it. There is a woman of thirty-four at the window of the front room with the street below her and the river beyond the roofs, and a man of thirty-five in the back room, and a daughter of four years on the floor of the front room, born in the second year of the peace, and a tin box of English biscuits under a floorboard, and a photograph of a girl with a bicycle on a shelf.

And at that hour — the hour at which a woman of twenty-seven once stood in a marble hall and heard the first shot of the rising of Warsaw come up out of the Wola — the woman at the window stops. It is a small thing, and nobody in the world has ever seen her do it: in the middle of a sentence, in the middle of a meal, in any room of any house in this city where she is able to be, at five o'clock in the afternoon of every day of the year, she stops for four seconds and looks at the window.

Then she goes on with it, the way the city of Warsaw went on with it. And the shadow of the enemy of 1944 is on the wall of that room at five o'clock in the afternoon of every day of the year, and there is nobody in the world who is able to see it but the woman in the room.

APPENDIX

A Note on the History

The Warsaw Rising began at five o'clock in the afternoon of the first of August 1944 and ended with an act of capitulation signed on the evening of the second of October, sixty-three days later. It was fought by some forty to fifty thousand soldiers of the Polish Home Army and by a civilian population of about a million people, inside a city the German administration had already intended to hold as a fortress. The arms of the insurgents, for the whole of the first week, were rifles left over from 1939, a few machine guns, bottles of petrol and paving stones.

The rising was ordered by the Polish underground command in the expectation of a few days of fighting before the Red Army crossed the Vistula. The Red Army reached the river, took the right-bank district of Praga in the middle of September, and did not cross in support of the rising; the reasons for that decision remain one of the bitter arguments of Polish history. The insurgents in the centre of the city held until October.

Between the fifth and the seventh of August 1944 the police and SS formations of the district carried out, in the western quarter of Wola, the mass murder of the civilian population of that quarter; the figure generally accepted is between forty and fifty thousand people killed in four days, in streets, courtyards and hospitals. Before the rising ended, between one hundred and fifty and two hundred thousand civilians of Warsaw had been killed, most of them by execution, bombardment and fire. The German high command in the city refused to sign the order that made the killing a matter of policy; the record of that refusal survives in the files, and it did not alter anything.

In early October some five hundred thousand surviving inhabitants were driven out of the city. Many passed through the transit camp at Pruszków, where they were sorted into transports for the Reich or for the province of the Generalgouvernement. The wounded, the very old and the children were moved in open trucks in October weather. From October until January the German army and police formations destroyed the city systematically, street by street and building by building; the destruction was carried out as an operation of engineering with a technique of its own. Roughly eighty-five per cent of the built fabric of Warsaw was gone when the Red Army entered the ruins on the seventeenth of January 1945.

The Pawiak prison on the Dzielna was emptied before and during the rising; its prisoners were shot in the ruins of the ghetto, deported, or left to the transports of the last week of July. The Krasiński Library, the city archive and the manuscript collections of the Polish nation were burned in the last days of August 1944. The headquarters of the Sicherheitsdienst were at 25 aleja Szucha, and it was understood in Warsaw that a person taken in through that gate did not come out again.

This book is a novel, and the people in it are invented. Marion Herschlag and Krystyna Stankiewiczówna, Friedrich von Reuth, Phillip Brandt, Werner Kroll, Dietrich Ehlers, René Tissier, the Zaleskis, the Countess Ostrowska, Colonel Wilczek and the household on the Bagatela are all fictional, and no invented character in these pages is meant for a person who lived. The file named Fall Wotan, its map of the Vistula line and its table of rolling stock are fictional; the code name Wotan was, however, a genuine designation used by the German army for a defensive position in the east, and the problem of holding a line along a great river against an army that had already reached it is the problem that the German staff in Warsaw was in fact arguing about in July 1944.

The furniture of the place is real. The Generalgouvernement, the Standortkommandantur, the Kennkarte and the Ausweis, the prohibition notices in German over the tram-car compartments, the curfew, the identity round-ups in the streets, the black-market stalls, the placards of the executed, the walled-off ruins of the ghetto, the bridges over the Vistula and the forest of Kampinos are all as they appear here. The Minox subminiature camera existed and was used by intelligence services before and during the war. The wax impressions, the patient social work of a kept woman in an occupied capital, and the household arrangement of a senior

officer's mistress are the materials of the period; the particular arrangement in this novel is not.

German, Polish and French words are left as the characters would have spoken them. Place names keep their Polish spelling. Three dates in the narrative have been moved by a day or two to suit the story, and the composition of the German intelligence offices in Warsaw has been simplified: in 1944 an intelligence service in an occupied district was a smaller and duller thing than the headquarters described here, and its officers were, for the most part, not men standing in the middle of a marble hall with their caps in their hands.

Among the books that inform these pages, and which a reader who wishes to go further might begin with, are Norman Davies's Rising '44, Miron Białoszewski's A Memoir of the Warsaw Uprising, written by a man who was there and who remembered the cellar, the water, the coal and the fear, and Władysław Bartoszewski's record of the occupation of the city day by day. The dead of Warsaw were not an argument, a symbol or a lesson; they were people in streets on a Tuesday afternoon, and the invented women and men of a novel are one way of measuring the size of them.

The rest is the reader's.